Walk Forward With Me

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32453581.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Additional Tags:
Fluff and Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Idiots in Love, Blood and Injury, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Self-Harm, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Angst with a Happy Ending, Personal Growth, Glimmer ships Catradora, Bow is basically a therapist, Micah is best dad, Everyone Needs A Hug, Hugs are appropriately dispensed don't worry, Lots of hugs :), Eventual Romance

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by mesopphire

Summary

After the defeat of Horde Prime and the collapse of his empire, Etheria is finally free from chaos, and Adora and Catra are finally free from the cold grasp of war. For the first time in history, they can begin to fully explore their love for each other. The path forward isn’t linear, or straightforward, and is clouded by the shadows of their war-torn pasts. But they have the undying support of each other and of the Best Friend Squad. They will brave it together.

A Paradox of Understanding

Chapter Notes

Hello!! Thank you for dropping by, and welcome to my first fic!

Wow, it's actually happening! I started writing this around 5 and a half months ago, and it is finally up!! I am so excited to see how this goes. Feedback and criticism are always appreciated! Kudos as well. ;)

Some info: This fic is pre-written and is currently around 70k words, and will be longer. I will be posting new chapters bi-weekly (Wednesday/Saturday) until completion. Each chapter is around 3,000+ words or so, meaning there will be at least twenty.

With all of that out of the way, I just need to say how excited I am to post this! I such had a blast writing it. So, again, thank you for dropping by. It means so much.

Enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra opens her eyes, blinking as they adjust to the dim light. Around her, she recognizes a disturbingly familiar scene. She is standing on a large, marble-white platform, beyond the edges of which is nothing but abyssal darkness. There are stairs in front of her that lead up to a throne-like chair, which sits importantly in front of a large, complicated electronic display.

The sound of footsteps behind her catches her attention, and she turns to see the outline of a figure approaching in the distance.

Who can *this* be?

As the figure makes its way onto the platform, green light washes across its frame, and Catra recognizes it at once. She knows that blonde hair and red jacket. She knows that face, those steel-blue eyes that make her feel warm inside.

But… What is *she* doing here?

Catra stares incredulously at Adora's face. In a moment of realization, her heart sinks. Isn't Adora supposed to be long gone, away from this horror? Isn't she supposed to be *safe* with her friends?

Before Catra can find an answer, the details of her surroundings, as well as Adora's face, start to become unfocused. The neon green light that she knows all too well creeps into her pupils, clouding her vision, making her want to vomit.

Involuntarily, Catra's entire body goes as rigid as stone and her claws extend. Suddenly, she is itching to fight. She lunges at Adora, looking to tear into flesh, eager to rip her apart.

In Adora's sudden surprise, she is unprepared to dodge, and takes the first claw to the cheek, barely managing to evade the second. But she is slow. Catra knows this, and swiftly sweeps her leg below Adora's knees, knocking her off of her feet. She pounces on her, pinning her to the hard ground. Ignorant to the sounds of her

pleading, Catra slices relentlessly, tearing through her arms, chest, and face.

She only stops once the body below her is no longer struggling. Satisfied, she takes a look down at her enemy.

Adora is her… enemy? No, *no,* that can't be right…

Catra feels a horrible, lurching feeling boil up inside her as she starts to realize what just happened. Adora is hardly recognizable.

"A-Adora?" Catra chokes.

Adora doesn't respond.

No, no, *no…* What has she done?

"Adora!" Tears well up in Catra's eyes, and she collapses forward onto Adora's mangled body.

Why couldn't she stop herself?

The last thing Catra wants in the entire world is for Adora to get hurt. And yet, there she is, clinging to the body she wanted so desperately to protect, but had just mutilated.

"Adora… S-say something…"

Catra is falling. The floor no longer holds her, and she is plummeting downward into the deep void below. She hears the cold, loud, commanding voice of some familiar person, someone who terrifies her. Strong hands enclose around her arms, and sickening green light overwhelms her vision.

I need to get out of here.

Gasping desperately for breath, Catra tries to free herself from whoever is restraining her, but the effort is in vain. She is hurtling downward towards the cold, hard floor, and can do nothing to stop it. Her lungs lack the air to let out a scream, as if that would change anything. This is it; she is about to hit the ground, and her life will surely come to its end.

*****

Four Days Earlier

The end of the war was not as glamorous as Adora would have hoped. It was nothing short of chaos once everyone stopped celebrating their victory and realized that the several hundred clones of Horde Prime, though no longer hostile, were essentially displaced refugees in need of a place to stay while they all worked on sorting out their existential crises.

Not only that, but the post-fight adrenaline high was losing its edge, and the pain and fatigue of the battle-scarred Alliance army was rapidly setting in.

Naturally, Adora was tugged away from Catra and the Best Friend Squad because She-Ra was the best way to go about quickly tending to the more severe wounds within the Alliance. She helped, of course, as much as she could, until her body wouldn't let her, until she no longer had the energy to maintain She-Ra's form for more than a couple of seconds.

And now, she is tired and aching all over, and all she wants to do is flop down on the ground and let sleep take her away, but her work isn't done just yet. She still has to set up her tent.

It's kind of a tonal mess. The world around them is so indescribably gorgeous, so full of magic and teeming with diverse flora and fascinating creatures, more so than ever before, and yet, there she is, having to resort to setting up an emergency tent so she has some semblance of shelter for the night. Pretty much everywhere is destroyed, or at least everywhere that is within reasonable speeder distance, so an actual roof to sleep under is out of the question.

Not that she really minds sleeping in a tent, but right now, her gigantic bed in Bright Moon that she slept in during the war sounds *so* good.

Well… mostly because it's easily big enough for two people and located in a relatively private room, which would be the *perfect* thing for her and Catra if not for the fact that Bright Moon palace is basically ruined. The bed that she's building her tent around is much smaller, but *technically* big enough for two people, if said people were willing to get a little close to each other.

Of course, Adora is *very* okay with the idea of getting close to Catra and sharing this bed with her, but she doesn't know for sure if Catra wants that. This problem could be solved with a bigger bed, but again, her room in Bright Moon might not be intact enough anymore to even be considered a room.

And even if it was, would Adora even be allowed to continue to use it even after the war? It wasn't even her room to begin with; she was just allowed to stay in it because she was part of the Alliance.

Adora shakes her head.

Whatever. A tent will have to suffice for tonight. And probably tomorrow night, and the night after, while everything is sorted out.

Maybe Adora should be focusing on actually putting up her tent correctly, because she's been staring at the same spot in the directions for at least five minutes now, not even taking them in. It doesn't help that she can barely even keep her eyes open, much less get her hands moving for long enough to assemble an entire tent.

Suddenly, she gets an idea. She can ask Catra if she can sleep in her tent under the excuse that she is too tired to put up her own.

With a glance to her left, Adora notices that Catra has almost finished putting up her tent. Perfect.

"Catra?" she asks, trying to sound as casual as possible.

"Wow, Adora, you kind of suck at putting up tents," Catra teases as she hammers a final stake into the ground. "Are you even *close* to being done?"

Adora takes a seat on the ground. "Probably not. I don't even know if I have the energy to finish," she says, leaning back on her hands. "Hey, your tent looks good. I think you might have a hidden talent!" She tries for a bit of flattery, hoping to keep the subject on Catra's tent, not on the fact that Adora is basically procrastinating on building her own.

"Great. Tent building. My *passion* ," Catra deadpans, and she starts towards Adora's tent. "Hey, do you need help? We can

knock this out in like, ten minutes."

"Uh, well- I mean…" Well, so much for Adora's plan. "Sure," she says sheepishly, admitting defeat. Catra *definitely* wouldn't buy it if Adora said she didn't need help. Besides, what else would Catra do besides helping, just stand there and watch?

"Alright, let's do this thing," Catra smiles, offering her hand to Adora.

Adora takes it and allows herself to be pulled into an upright position. Catra's hand feels… *really* nice in hers. *Way* too nice. They hold onto each other's hands for a lot longer than necessary, until Adora realizes that, comes to her senses, and pulls her hand away, blushing slightly.

Was she holding on for too long? What if Catra was just waiting for her to let go, but didn't want to say anything? What if she is making a mental note never to offer her hand to Adora again because it would mean that she would have to hold on for *eternity-*

"What step are you even *on* ?" Catra interrupts Adora's internal freak out and turns away from her to pick up the directions on the ground.

"Uh… step six, I think?" Adora returns. Honestly, she has no idea. She forgot a long time ago.

*****

“Bow, are you *seeing* this??” Glimmer shout-whispers, sounding exasperated. Bow looks to where she is pointing.

“Uh, what?” Bow asks, confused as to why Glimmer seems to be upset at Adora and Catra building a tent together.

“ *That* !” Glimmer bristles, gesturing even more ferociously towards Catra and Adora, as if that clears anything up.

“Ohhhh!” Bow raises his eyebrows importantly, pretending to sound like he’s on board with whatever Glimmer is talking about. “ *Yeah* , they’re… um. They're building a, uh, a *tent*- ”

“Why are they making separate tents??” That question comes out like it is all one word. Glimmer puts her hands on her hips and turns expectantly towards Bow.

“Well,” he starts, but he has absolutely *no* idea how to respond to that. They’re building separate tents because… That’s a normal thing to do for two people? Sure, Bow and Glimmer are sharing a tent for tonight, but that’s because they are basically in a relationship now, and setting up two tents would just be a waste of effort if they are both willing to share one.

“Bow, have you *seen* them lately? How they’ve been acting around each other??” Glimmer asks, again, a *completely* unanswerable question.

“Yeah?” Bow shrugs. Glimmer looks at him in disbelief.

“ *Ugh* , do I have to do *everything* around here?” she huffs, and she starts forward towards Catra and Adora.

What on Etheria is she doing? Bow followers close behind her.

“Hey, Adora!” Glimmer says, clearly trying to sound casual. She’s definitely plotting something.

“Oh, hi, Glimmer!” Adora replies brightly, giving her a smile.

“Hi, I was just wondering… Why are you setting up two seperate tents? Can’t you and Catra just… you know…”

“What are you talking about?” Adora raises an eyebrow.

“Well,” Glimmer smiles. “There’s just really no *reason* to set up two tents when one is enough, right?

“Does somebody else need this tent?” Adora asks worriedly.

“Oh, no, no, it’s nothing like that.” Glimmer waves her hand dismissively. “I just… Don’t you and Catra want to share a tent?”

“U-um…” Adora goes slightly red. She brushes her hair back to hide her face from Catra, who has her arms crossed and hasn’t spoken yet. “W-well, I don’t- I-I don’t know-”

“ *Glimmer* !” Bow says sternly. He knows what’s going on here. He turns towards Adora with a soft smile. “Sorry, Adora. You can sleep *wherever* you want. We’ll leave you and Catra alone, okay?”

“Bow-!” Glimmer starts.

“ *Okay* ??” Bow repeats, facing Glimmer now. He hopes he doesn't have to resort to nudging her on the shoulder to get his point across.

“Ugh. Fine,” Glimmer relents, apparently getting the message, and she turns to walk away. Finally.

Adora looks very uncomfortable now. It’s probably a good idea for Bow to remove himself from the situation as well.

"Night, Adora! Night, Catra!" he says as cheerfully as he can, waving at them both. He turns away before the response.

"Goodnight, guys!" He hears Adora call after them.

*****

Well, that pretty much answers the question that has been on the tip of Catra's tongue for the past hour. From what it sounds like, Adora doesn't want to share a tent with her. Great.

Catra takes a deep breath and reminds herself for the hundredth time to respect Adora's feelings and not do or insist on doing anything that would make her uncomfortable, because that would be *incredibly* selfish.

Even so, she was *really* hoping that Adora would have wanted to share a tent, but in hindsight, Catra should have known that she didn't want to from the get-go. The fact that Adora started setting up a second tent in the *first* place is evidence enough.

"Hey, um… A-about what I said earlier," Adora says cautiously. "About sharing a tent-"

"Yeah, I know," Catra almost-snaps, because she can't bear to hear it from Adora's lips again. Thankfully, she manages to keep her voice relatively level. "It's fine. You can use a separate tent if

you want. I-I don’t mind.” That last part was a flat out lie. Catra almost couldn't bring herself to say it.

“O-okay,” Adora mumbles, her brow furrowing. “Sorry.”

Catra feels a pang of guilt in her chest. Despite her best efforts, her anger must have still bled through to her voice. Who is *she* to get upset at Adora because of her preferences?

“I-It’s okay, Adora,” she replies, trying to give Adora as warm of a smile as she can.

Adora smiles back and turns around to continue working on the tent.

Catra looks at her with longing, so much longing that it *hurts* .

Hey, I’ll… I’ll be right back,” she says. She doesn’t even wait for a response before turning and heading towards her tent. As soon as she gets inside, she flops down on her bed and buries her face in her pillow.

She is *really* screwing this up. Adora probably thinks that Catra is mad at her, which she *isn’t* . No, Catra is mad at *herself* , because she’s not even decent enough to be able to respect Adora’s boundaries.

Adora doesn’t deserve this at all. What she *does* deserve is an apology.

Catra pushes herself upwards off her bed and steps out of her tent, intent on setting things right. But to her dismay, Adora seems to have finished up with her tent and is probably inside, ready to go to sleep.

Catra will just ask to come in for a couple of minutes, so she can apologize, and *nothing* more, and then return to her own tent and sleep alone.

Suddenly, Catra feels her stomach do a horrible lurch.

Her nightmares. Sleeping alone will *not* work.

Her nightmares have been plaguing her ever since Prime’s ship, and as much as she hates to admit it, the only way to avoid them is by sleeping near Adora. Not because she doesn’t *want* to sleep near Adora, but because…

Nightmares are for *kids* .

But there’s a more pressing matter at hand. Adora doesn’t want to share a tent with her, which means that her nightmares…

No, No…

Catr's breathing picks up. Her last nightmare is still fresh on her mind. She's *terrified* of having another one. She doesn't know for sure if she will, but the only way to ensure that she *won't* is by sleeping alongside Adora.

Catra has always slept incredibly well around her. Something about her presence does wonders to keep the nightmares and anything on her mind at bay.

But it's not as simple as it was in the past, as it was in the Fright Zone. Back then, she didn't even think about it when she curled up at the foot of Adora's bed every night. It was just something she *did* , something that she and Adora got used to.

It's ironic. Catra literally kissed Adora just a few hours ago in the Heart of Etheria, and yet, she's unable to simply share a bed with Adora like she used to back *before* they had kissed.

Is it the kiss that is driving a wall between them? Did Catra make a mistake and overstep her bounds?

No, no, *no* , it doesn't make any *sense* ; Adora had kissed her *back* , like she was enjoying it… like she *wanted* it…

“Catra?” Adora, who is now outside of her tent, causes Catra to jolt back into her surroundings.

“Adora!” Catra says breathlessly. “H-Hi…” She gulps.

“Hey, um…” Adora rubs the back of her neck. “My tent is… big. I-I mean- it’s… big *enough* . For us.”

Catra’s eyes widen with hope.

Adora continues. “That 's… um. Only if you *want* to, you don’t-”

“I do,” Catra says without hesitation. “Can I?”

“Sure,” Adora smiles, and she reaches over and pulls one of her tent flaps aside, offering Catra inside. “Come on in.”

Catra’s heart leaps out of her chest, and she starts towards Adora’s tent.

*****

Phew . Adora closes her eyes and breathes a sigh of relief as soon as Catra passes her and enters her tent. Why was that so *hard* ?

She thought that Catra didn't want to share a tent, that it would be a bad idea to ask, because she thought she knew the answer would be no. But of course, she couldn't have known the answer for sure without asking.

And even if Catra *had* said no, at least Adora would have had an answer.

But she *didn't* say no. Adora smiles to herself and enters her tent. Catra is already snugly curled up under the blankets, her head resting on Adora's pillow.

She looks like she belongs there.

As much as Adora wants to curl up right beside her and plop her head down on the same pillow, her judgement is telling her that it probably isn't a good idea. Making Catra uncomfortable in any way is the *last* thing she wants right now, so it's probably best to play it safe and keep her distance.

So, she reaches into her storage chest, grabs an extra pillow, and situates herself on the other side of the bed.

"Hey, Adora," Catra says, giving her a smile.

“Hey,” Adora breathes, her face growing warmer. Catra is so close, well within arm’s reach. Adora could easily reach out, maybe run a hand through her hair and down her cheek…

Snap out of it .

“I’m sorry,” she says to get her mind off of that. And because Catra deserves to hear it.

“For what?” Catra asks, looking concerned. She raises her head off of her pillow.

“For earlier,” Adora whispers, and she drops her gaze. “I thought you didn’t want to share a tent, so I… didn’t ask.”

“Adora, I did,” Catra says, and Adora’s heart drops. “But… I didn’t say anything either, because I thought *you* didn’t want to.”

“Sorry,” Adora whispers. How could she have been such an *idiot* ? All of this confusion could’ve been easily avoided if she’d just asked Catra what she wanted, and not freaked out over what she *thought* Catra wanted.

“No, no, it’s okay! I wasn’t being very… clear,” Catra tells her, which helps her state of mind significantly.

“Well,” Adora smiles. “How about this: I wanna share a tent with you from now on. Do you?”

Catra’s eyes widen before she responds, “Yes, I do.”

“Okay,” Adora giggles, and she suppresses the urge to shout in victory.

“Looks like we set up two tents for nothing, then,” Catra chuckles.

“Yeah, we did, didn’t we?”

Adora feels a comfortable warmth run through her body, the very same warmth that she grew to know and love back in the Fright Zone when Catra curled up at the foot of her bed every night.

That warmth is something that only Catra can give her. Nobody else.

How she’s *missed* this feeling.

*****

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter goes up this Saturday, and I hope to see you all then!!

Lost

Chapter Summary

Catra makes a big mistake.

Chapter Notes

Hello again! Welcome to Chapter 2, and thanks for dropping by! Feedback and criticism is always appreciated. I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Four Days Later

Hordak was surprised at how the people of the camp had come to be able to accept him into their lives. Had he not, weeks prior, been the main threat to their peace? Had he not claimed the lives of so many in the likes of Thaymor and Salineas? Maybe Horde Prime's arrival and the atrocities that he committed had drawn the people's focus away from Hordak. Maybe they see him as the lesser of two evils. Whatever the reason may be, Hordak himself doesn't know. Either way, he doesn't know how to come to terms with what he had done in the past.

He is still bitter that Horde Prime had cast him aside so easily after all he did to return to his side. Apparently to Prime, he was nothing but a menial servant. But, perhaps, Hordak reasons, that is for the best. He should have realized that he never needed Prime to begin with, because after he met Entrapta, he saw that there was more to life than just power and recognition.

He takes a deep breath, taking in the wonderful array of colorful, bright specks of light that fill the night sky above him. His days of leading the Horde to victory seem so far away. It is weird, but he doesn't miss those days of conquest. He doesn't miss those days of subjugation, and his hunger for power, and being in a bad mood all the time. What he has now is so much more valuable than anything he had ever known.

Entrapta's tools sputter and spark, illuminating the fabric of the surrounding tents. "Hordak, hold still!" she pleads.

Hordak suppresses the urge to shout in pain. "This process seems to be inefficient. Perhaps your methods… no. Perhaps my body is beyond repair, and this effort is in vain."

Entrapta raises the lid of her face shield and douses her blow torch.

"Hordak. I am not going to give up on you," she says. "Don't you need your body to work properly? I won't stop until I figure this out. As your friend, I *simply* cannot."

Hordak produces a grin through the aching, and suggests that they continue in the morning, for he is tired and in pain. Entrapta agrees, and reassures him that she won't stop until she fixes him.

Hordak stands, looks around the camp absentmindedly, and his eyes are drawn to the familiar figure of Catra slinking away in the

distance.

"You really should talk to her," Entrapta says, noticing what had caught Hordak's gaze.

Hordak agrees with her; he needs to apologize to Catra for how he treated her in the past. He has already, with Entrapta's aid, apologized to everyone that he could in the camp, and most of them had accepted him. But owning up to somebody he knows, such as Catra, is incredibly difficult for some reason. Hordak makes his way back to his tent, and with more effort than he would have liked to admit, climbs into bed and falls asleep.

*****

Catra jolts upright and frantically scans her surroundings, her breaths coming in short, painful bursts, cold sweat sliding down her forehead and over the contours of her face.

She finds herself sitting upright on her bed, which is inside a large, cubic tent.

A safe place.

Catra forces her muscles to relax, and she starts to focus on gaining control of her breathing.

In, out… In, out…

Repeating the words in her head somewhat prevents other, more disturbing thoughts from creeping into her mind. With her breathing finally under control, she lets out a deep sigh and flops backward onto her mattress, staring at the canvas ceiling.

Trying to sleep alone again was a *horrible* idea.

But, she still did it anyway, and look where *that* got her.

Unfortunately, however, there isn't really a way other than sleeping alone to determine if her nightmares, which have been plaguing her worse than ever since Prime's ship, have decided to leave her alone for once.

But… Why does she need to know if her nightmares are gone yet? Is it so she can feel marginally better about mental state? Is it so she can try to convince herself that she is normal? Is it so she can finally say that she is a big girl and can sleep all on her own?

Pathetic.

She could have just stayed in Adora's tent, like Adora *insisted* , and not have had to worry about her nightmares at *all* .

This was a stupid plan that was doomed from the start.

Suddenly, Catra becomes aware of a cold, wet sensation on the back of her head. She sits up and looks down at her pillow, discovering that it is damp with a deep crimson liquid, which has to be her own blood. Scoffing, she looks at her hands, not at all surprised to find that they are also wet with blood.

She touches the back of her neck with her index finger and feels a twinge of pain. Just as she thought. In her sleep, she must have clawed at the spot on the back of her neck where the control chip used to be.

With an irritated sigh, she pushes herself out of bed.

She walks over to the basin in the corner of the tent and dips her hands in, staining the water with a deep red hue. As soon as the water soaks into the fur on her hands, images of her dream flash through her mind; the sickening green light that flooded her vision, the powerful, commanding grip of Horde Prime forcing her head underwater, Adora laying in front of her, unmoving, her eyes open, but void of their characteristic shine-

"ADORA!" The scream comes out involuntarily.

No, no, no!

Catra's muscles tense up and she recoils violently, sending water flying everywhere. Legs failing her, she loses her balance and tumbles to the ground, curling up into a tight ball, like that will somehow protect her, her muscles spasming uncontrollably.

Suddenly, as if she were slapped in the face, Catra comes to her senses.

What's there to freak out over, you idiot? Some stupid water?

This is a tent, a safe place. Nothing is here to hurt her. That hasn't changed at all in the past four days.

And Adora is alive and well, sleeping soundly in the tent next to hers.

Slowly, Catra begins to relax, and despite how shaky she feels, she manages to stand up. She grabs a towel to dry her hands off, and then presses it to the cuts on the back of her neck.

The adrenaline is starting to wear off, meaning the pain will no doubt set in soon. Kneading wearily at her eyelids, Catra lumbers out of her tent. Maybe a walk will do *something* to make her feel better.

It has been four days since the rebellion defeated Horde Prime. Most everybody who was left after the battle had worked together to create a temporary camp for refugees and soldiers on the edge of the Whispering Woods. Many places, including Bright Moon, are under construction due to the significant damage they sustained in the midst of the conflict with Prime.

Speaking of Bright Moon, Catra wants to live there with Adora and her friends once this is all sorted out. She chuckles softly to herself and shakes her head at the ridiculous prospect of living in the very place she had been trying to raze for so long during her time serving the Horde.

Catra traipses past the various tents in the camp and takes a deep breath. The air here is so different from that of the Fight Zone. It feels more fresh, more clean, more *breathable* . Above her, countless small specks of light dot the night sky. The sight had definitely taken some getting used to, for Catra, as well as the rest of Etheria, had known an empty, black void of a sky for all of their lives. This new world that Adora created is *incredible* .

Catra loses track of time as she walks, taking in the night sky and the crisp air around her. She passes the fading embers of numerous campfires, around which the people of the camp would tell stories, laugh heartily, and share food. Bow has become quite the musician, and regularly plays his guitar into the sunset. Glimmer lays by his side, lost in the melody. Seahawk’s accounts of his daring escapades in battle, as well as his wide arsenal of jokes, earned him the attention and admiration of many young children.

And Adora will be there, wearing that dumb smile that Catra won't give up for the world.

This is happiness; this is something she sorely missed. How long has it been since she felt this good? And… What did she do to deserve this feeling?

Catra suddenly realizes that she has arrived back at her tent. She doesn't go in. Instead, she slinks into Adora's tent next door.

Adora looks so peaceful, nestled snugly into her bedsheets, her chest rising and falling in a gentle rhythm. If Catra wakes her up, she will probably get super stressed out and bombard Catra with questions. The last thing Catra wants is to worry her, so she decides that it would be best to wait until morning.

Since Catra's nightmares seem to be showing no signs of leaving, she will have to seek out Adora'a company for the next couple of weeks, or months, or however long it takes. No problem; that is what she prefers anyway. With a contented smile, she steps out of Adora's tent.

Catra is certain that if she goes back to sleep, she will see horrible things again. The disturbing images from her nightmare still swim nauseatingly around in her head, growing more and more vivid by the second.

Just a second ago, Catra had managed to gain some control over her breathing, her pulse, her anxiety. But what little control she *did* have is now gone, and she is rapidly relapsing into her state of panic.

" *N-no…* " she begs, and she starts to lose her balance, the features of the camp around her sliding in and out of focus. She drops to her knees.

She is desperate for a distraction, something to get her mind off the gruesome images drowning her mind.

She shakes her head violently.

Get ahold of yourself. What are your options?

It is either wake up Adora and make her worried sick, which is out of the question, or grit her teeth and handle this herself. That means she will have to resort to an old method, one she hasn't used in a while.

Her body shakes as she extends a single one of her claws and places it carefully on her left forearm. After steadying herself with a deep, shaky breath, she grits her teeth and rakes her hand downward, slicing into her own flesh. Immediately, she feels as if a searing, white hot metal wire has been pressed to her skin, and gasps in pain.

Think about the pain, think about how it burns…

Pain is something Catra is well acquainted with. It is, or *was* , back when she was in the Horde, always the best way to distract herself from something troubling her mind. Consequently, it was one of the few things that had given her a sense of control in her life.

Catra stares at her throbbing forearm, at the blood seeping out of her fresh wound. One of the downsides of using this method is having to deal with the blood, but she is used to it.

She presses the towel she had used on her neck to the wound. Applying pressure is a great way to stop bleeding. Her many trials have taught her that much, and more. In the Horde, her squad mates used to ask how she knew so much about first aid, and she would always say that she read about it in the library. That seemed to be good enough for them.

Another downside to using this method is having to deal with the marks that it leaves behind. It was easy to come up with excuses for her squad mates at first (they were soldiers, after all), but eventually, her scars started to raise a few too many questions, so she learned to cut herself in places that nobody would see.

Back then, Catra sometimes found herself with her claws hovering over the places that had the potential to *permanently* end the

pain, but always stopped herself when she thought about how that would mean never being able to see Adora again.

Suddenly, Catra's stomach does a horrible turn. What was she *thinking* ? Was Adora's insistence that Catra wake her up if she needs anything, no matter how small, for *nothing* ?

This isn't what Adora would have wanted at *all* .

Catra should have woken her up. She should have *listened to her* .

But now, it is too late. The damage is done, and Catra has to hide her wound. If Adora found out Catra cut herself instead of coming to her, it would be…

Catra pushes that thought and the inevitable explosion of anxiety that would follow it out of her mind.

Focus on the present, on what you can do *right now* .

She runs into her tent and tears the blanket off her bed, throwing it around her body, making triple sure that her arm doesn't bleed through the fabric.

This will have to work. And- a blanket will be easy to explain, considering how chilly it is outside.

Catra steps outside. It is only a couple of hours until sunrise. She takes a seat under a tree outside her tent, staring blankly at the ground in front of her. It's only a few hours; she's stayed awake for longer.

She can manage.

Unfortunately, however, staying awake means that she will be *super* tired in the morning, and most likely next to useless during the hard day of manual labor ahead of her. Catra (and everyone else in the camp) is still working to rebuild all the towns and cities that Prime had leveled.

Well, not *just* Prime. Catra herself had also played a hand in the destruction of several towns in her time serving the Horde.

And she's not proud of it.

Sometimes she thinks her dumb past self was deliberately *trying* to screw her present self over.

*****

Adora wakes up early, as always. She rises from her bed, stretches, and yawns deeply while she draws her hair back into a ponytail. She throws on her favorite jacket and steps outside into the cool morning. It is still relatively dark outside, and the sunrise is just visible over the Whispering Woods.

Immediately, Adora notices Catra sitting by herself under a tree beside the extra tent, wrapped up in a blanket. She runs over and sits on the ground beside her.

"You're finally up," Catra says.

"Finally? It's still dark out," Adora points out, and she throws a glance at Catra. In the dim light, she notices the prominent signs of stress and fatigue on her face. Adora's smile fades. "...How long have you been out here?"

"A while," Catra replies simply.

"What? Why? Did you not sleep?"

"No, not really." Catra shrugs her blanket closer to her body, not removing her gaze from the ground in front of her. "I still can't get him out of my head. I… I'm scared. To sleep alone. I can't believe I thought the nightmares would stop." She pauses, looking into Adora's anxious face. "Adora, you're the only person who can keep them away. I-I don't know what I'd do without you…"

Adora gives her a warm smile, hoping that it will help in some way.

Catra continues. "...In my dream I… I saw you. And the stuff I did-" Her mismatched eyes start to water.

Adora instinctively pulls Catra into a gentle embrace, placing her hand carefully on the back of her head. "Catra, it's okay," she soothes. "It was just a dream. None of it was real."

Catra begins to cry softly into her shoulder, her muffled breaths coming in uneven sobs.

Though Adora is curious about what happened in the nightmare, she doesn't want to ask and make Catra relive it.

Regardless, she is grateful that she can support Catra in these kinds of moments, and that she is willing to share her insecurities with her. More than anything, Adora wants to destroy all of the terrible images plaguing Catra's mind, but she knows that's impossible. For now, all she can really do is try to distract her, and keep her mind off the past.

Adora holds on to Catra until she calms down and stops crying. Feeling it's safe to let her go, she returns to her spot, giving Catra some space.

“You should’ve woken me up,” she says.

“Sorry…” Catra mumbles. She still looks downcast.

“Hey, it’s alright,” Adora replies warmly. “I’m just worried about you. Sleep in my tent tonight, okay?”

Catra gives Adora a weak smile. “I was planning on it.”

“Good.” It is nice to see Catra smiling again. When she is happy, Adora is happy.

Adora shivers at the thought of Catra lying alone, surrounded by darkness, writhing in her sleep, unable to escape the terrible images clouding her mind.

It’s not *fair* .

“Hey, Adora?” Catra’s voice brings Adora out of her thoughts.

“Yeah?” she says.

“You look cold.”

“Nah, I’m fine.” Adora throws Catra a glance. She looks… determined about something.

Catra scoots over and places her hand on the ground beside her. “Are you sure?”

Adora’s heart does a little leap. “Ohhh. Yeah. I’m pretty cold,” she says, shifting herself into the spot right next to Catra, who wraps the blanket around her.

“Do you have to do anything this morning?” Catra asks.

“I don’t think so,” Adora responds. Even if she *did* have something to do, she wouldn’t say. She needs to be here for Catra right now, and would gladly skip over any of her duties or morning routines to do so.

“Good,” Catra purrs, laying her head on Adora’s shoulder.

Adora feels a warm sensation take over her body, and not because she is under the blanket. “Yeah, you were right, I *was* cold.”

“See? I told you.”

“I guess you know me better than I know myself.”

“Come on. That’s not even possible.”

Adora smiles to herself, but it fades as her mind reminds her that they have to go and help with post-war reconstruction work in a couple of hours. If only she could just melt away indefinitely under this tree, maybe even reach over, wrap her arms around the girl next to her, and pull her close, but… she can’t. Something in the back of her mind is keeping her hesitant.

As long as Catra is comfortable, it shouldn’t matter what I want.

With that thought, Adora is able to push her desires out of her mind.

“Catra, when did you wanna get breakfast?” she asks softly.

Catra doesn’t respond.

Adora turns her head downward and discovers that Catra’s eyes are closed and her mouth is slightly open. She has fallen asleep. A low, rumbling purr escapes her chest with each time it rises and falls.

Adora remains as still as she can. It will probably be best to skip out on breakfast and stay under this tree with Catra to let her get as much sleep as possible. She will wake her up before they have to leave for reconstruction work.

Adora smiles contentedly and leans her head back on the tree. With Catra by her side, this is going to be *easy*.

*****

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter comes Wednesday! Thanks for reading!!

Breathing Room

Chapter Summary

The Best Friend Squad is put to work. There is a lot to get done.

Chapter Notes

Hello!

I'd like to say thank you to everyone who read, left comments, and/or left kudos! It's so nice to see feedback from the community, and to hear all of your kind words. It really gives me motivation to continue in the future. I have no intention to stop writing when this story is complete. In fact, I already have an AU in the works. ;)

With that being said, I hope you enjoy chapter 3.

Again; thanks for reading!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"...tra? Time to get up."

Catra doesn't open her eyes immediately, but she does recognize Adora's voice right next to her. She feels a hand shaking her shoulder.

"C'mon, we've gotta go," Adora says.

"Ughhh," Catra groans, yawning deeply and slouching into the warmth next to her, her hand finding a place on what feels like

Adora's upper arm.

"U-um… W-we'll be late." Adora stands up suddenly, causing Catra to lose her means of support and fall to the ground.

"Hey-!" Catra protests, and she finally opens her eyes to the sight of Adora standing over her. Her face looks slightly red.

"We've got a new assignment," Adora tells her, avoiding eye contact. "Elberon. Glimmer told me. We won't be working at Bright Moon today."

"Why?" Catra asks, pushing herself upward and stretching her arms.

"Well, Glimmer says that her dad told her that they have too many workers in Bright Moon, and that some other places could use the help. So, he moved us."

"Fine by me," Catra shrugs. As long as she's with Adora, she doesn't care where she works during reconstruction. Ideally, they wouldn't be working to *begin* with, but of course, the end of the war doesn't mean the end of their troubles.

Adora gives her a smile. "Alright, are you ready to go?"

“Let’s get breakfast first,” Catra suggests.

“Well, it’ll have to be quick,” Adora responds. “ *Really* quick.”

“I’ll just grab an apple, or something.”

*****

“No, it’s that one, I think,” Adora says, pointing to one of the speeders on the left side of the lineup.

“Alright, why don’t we just ask?” Catra responds, and they make their way over to the group of people surrounding the speeder in question. Catra can’t spot anyone she knows in the new group, and she can’t decide if that’s a good thing or a bad thing. Either way, it’s not like she’ll be lonely with Adora working by her side.

“Name?” the organizer asks when Adora and Catra reach him.

“Adora,” Adora tells him, stepping forward.

The organizer adjusts his spectacles and flips through the pages on his clipboard, his pencil hovering over the paper.

“Ah, yes,” he says, marking a spot on the page. “Please continue forward, Miss.”

“Thank you!” Adora says brightly, and she moves past him towards the group waiting for departure.

“And you?” the organizer asks, pointing the butt of his pencil at Catra.

“Catra,” Catra says, and the organizer flips through his pages again. He furrows his brow and adjusts his spectacles quizzically.

“What did you say it was again, miss?” he asks, and Catra’s heart drops.

“Catra,” she repeats, throwing a glance in the direction of Adora, who starts to walk back towards them.

“I’m terribly sorry, but I think you are at the wrong location, miss Catra,” the organizer tells her. “It says here that you are with the group stationed at Thaymor.”

Catra’s heart twists at that name.

...Thaymor. The city she burned to the ground.

Adora reaches the organizer and asks, “What’s wrong?”

“And who are you again?” he responds, peering at her over his spectacles.

“I’m her… her friend,” Adora says, throwing a glance at Catra.

Friend. Yup. Catra doesn’t know exactly what feeling she’s experiencing right now, but it’s *definitely* a weird one.

“I’m sorry, Miss, friend or not, this matter is none of your concern,” the organizer asserts, and he turns back to face Catra. “Now, Miss Catra, you will be able to find the shuttle to Thaymor three rows to the right of here.”

“T-there *has* to be some sort of mistake,” Catra says, stepping forward. “I-I’m sure I was assigned to Elberon, I-”

“And who told you that, exactly?” the organizer asks.

Catra drops her head.

“I’m sorry, Miss,” the organizer continues. “But I don’t have the authority to change assignments. If you are unhappy with yours, you will have to take a complaint to the head of this operation,

King Micah. Now, please be on your way. You're holding up the line."

" *But-* " Catra starts, and she cuts herself off and heaves a sigh of disappointment. She throws Adora a look of longing.

"I'll… I'll think of something," Adora calls out to her, giving a smile of encouragement.

Catra returns her smile, gives the organizer a nasty look, and turns to walk away, feeling completely dejected.

Great. So much for *that* .

Now the *one* person that made reconstruction work bearable is gone. And Catra will be all alone once again.

" *Ugh* …" she scoffs, kicking a rock with her bare foot as she walks.

It feels as though the already incredibly limited time that Catra has had with Adora lately keeps slipping away from her like sand through her fingers. For the past four days, it's been a gruelling cycle of work and sleep, with little to no space in between.

Even still, at least she could be *around* Adora during construction work when they were both working at Bright Moon, but now that she's assigned to Thaymor, she can't even have *that* . Maybe she shouldn't have taken it for granted.

And as far as one-on-one time goes, it's short, and it only really happens in the evenings when everyone is winding down and getting ready for bed.

If that's all the time Catra is going to get with Adora from now on, then she'll just have to make the most of it.

"Catra?" Bow's voice comes from Catra's left. "You're over here, I think."

Great. Just who she needed in her new work group. *Arrow Boy* . At least Sparkles doesn't seem to be with him.

"Hold on," Catra tells him, and she approaches the organizer of this group.

"Name?" she asks when Catra reaches her.

"Catra."

“Catra? Hmm… Catra… Catra…” The organizer runs her finger down the page, pausing at a certain point and grabbing a pencil from behind her ear to mark Catra’s name off. “Alright, you’re all set!”

“ *Wonderful* ,” Catra snaps, and she storms forward, trying her best to avoid eye contact with Arrow Boy.

“Hey, where’s Adora?” Bow asks her. “Wasn’t she with-”

“Why do *you* care?” Catra hisses, crossing her arms.

Bow steps backward, looking hurt. “W-well, you know, I was just… wondering.”

Catra breathes a slow sigh to calm herself. “Sorry, Bow. I’m just… in a bad mood right now. You didn’t deserve that.”

“It’s alright,” Bow responds, giving her a smile.

Catra is glad she was able to get that out. The word ‘sorry’ doesn’t exactly come easy to her. Because she’s never really used it before, she really has to concentrate on her enunciation every time she says it, like it’s a word in a completely different language.

"To answer your question, Adora's with another group," she explains, getting back on topic. "She's going to *Elberon* for some reason. And I… I just wanna go with her."

Catra and Bow step onto the speeder with a few others and take a seat. The driver tugs on the steering rod, sending them hovering forward.

"I feel you. I wish we could have all just stayed at Bright Moon," Bow says solemnly. "Glimmer is the only one still working there out of the Best Friend Squad."

"Yeah…" Catra hugs her knees and drops her head. Her tail wraps around her ankles.

"Maybe," Bow says after a moment, pointing an index upward, "you could ask King Micah to reassign you?"

"I was planning on it," Catra replies. Hopefully Micah obliges; hopefully there isn't some *random* reason that Catra needs to stay assigned to *Thaymor* , of all places.

She shudders at the thought of visiting Thaymor, the city she helped destroy so long ago.

*****

Adora doesn't speak as she works. She keeps her head down, her mind completely focused on the task at hand.

Every time she stops, whether it be to take a quick breather, or to take a brief water break, something in the back of her mind reminds her to get back to work, reminds her that there is no time to waste, that the job needs to be done perfectly, for the sake of the people of Etheria.

Maybe it's because she's She-Ra that she finds herself unable to stop working as hard as she can, so much so that by midday, her hands are bruised and calloused like they would be if she had just completed *five* days of work.

But, she keeps going regardless, for there is no time for indolence.

If only Catra were here. It seems counterintuitive, but having Catra around actually makes Adora, in her opinion, *leagues* more productive. There is something about being able to talk with someone that you enjoy the company of during manual labor that makes it a lot more manageable, a lot more bearable.

Not only that, but just being around Catra makes Adora *indescribably* happy, reconstruction work or not.

Adora just wishes that the two of them could be… *alone* more often. Sure, having Catra around during reconstruction is very enjoyable, but it could be so much better if they weren't exclusively around each other while carrying out menial work.

Well, of course, being around just about *anyone* is better when it's not during a day of hard labor, but still.

Being alone with Catra is something that Adora never really got to do, even in the Horde. There was always someone around, whether it be Shadow Weaver or a member of their squad. Always someone watching or listening. The Horde didn't exactly know the definition of the word *privacy* .

So, in every rare instance that Adora *was* alone with Catra, she was at her happiest. No wars or drills or lectures to worry about, no predetermined fate or whatever to carry out, just Adora with Catra, her best friend in the entire world.

The only time they were ever consistently 'alone' was at night when everyone else around them was asleep. Adora and Catra would use that time to stay up late whispering about anything and everything. Thankfully, everyone in Adora's barracks eventually got used to Catra sharing her bed, so they never really got in trouble for it (sharing a bed was probably against *some* rule in the Horde).

Adora suddenly realizes that she's smiling. And she can't stop, even as she uses She-Ra's mighty strength to relocate boulders and clear countless piles of rubble over and over and over again.

*****

As soon as the speeder returns to the camp, Adora hops off, peeling her eyes for any sign of Glimmer. There's a slim chance that she'll be in the crowd of people returning from reconstruction work, considering she doesn't even need to ride a shuttle back to camp with access to her teleportation abilities.

Regardless, Adora searches, standing on her tip-toes as she cranes her neck to look over the sea of heads surrounding her.

She does a double take as she spots a familiar head of purple hair close by.

"Glimmer!" she calls out, moving through the crowd towards her friend.

"Adora?" Glimmer responds, turning to face her. "Hey! How was it today?"

"Pretty dull," Adora tells her, trying to manage a lighthearted smile. "What about you? How is Bright Moon coming along?"

"Oh, Adora." Glimmer puts her hands on Adora's shoulders. "It's coming along *so* well. I asked my dad to reassign Bow to Bright

Moon so he can help me work on the- *ahem* . S-so we can work together on my… project.”

“Really? Where is he assigned right now?”

“Thaymor. I think he and Catra are both there.”

“T-Thaymor?” Adora’s heart drops. “Catra- she’s there?”

Thaymor, the place where… Adora left Catra. Catra’s memories of that place are *horrible* …

“Adora,” Glimmer says, furrowing her brow. “What’s wrong?”

“Oh, it’s…” Adora sighs. “I was just wondering… if you could ask your dad to reassign Catra to Elberon? I-I really want to… to see Catra more. I just feel like we've been apart a lot recently, you know?”

“Yeah, I get you. I feel the same way with Bow. I know I said that I asked for him to be reassigned so he can help me with my project. That’s *partly* true, but I mostly just want him to be reassigned so I can be around him more.”

What project could Glimmer be talking about?

No, that doesn't matter right now. *Focus, Adora* .

"So… Will you ask King Micah for me, Glimmer?" she asks, trying to keep Glimmer on topic.

"Oh- yeah. I can totally do that. What was it? Elberon?"

"Yup."

"Okay! I'm sure my dad will be fine with that," Glimmer smiles. "Oh, hey, Bow! Over here!" She waves at someone behind Adora.

Adora turns and spots Bow's smiling face heading towards them through the sea of people, accompanied by Catra.

"Good evening," Bow says brightly as he reaches Glimmer and Adora. Catra, who seemingly subconsciously followed Bow over to them, hasn't raised her head. She looks to be in deep thought, her gaze fixated on the ground.

"Hi, Bow!" Glimmer beams, and she moves forward to hug him.

"Hey, Glim," Bow replies. "And Adora! How're you doing?"

At the mention of Adora's name, Catra raises her head. She meets Adora's eyes and gives her a very strained-looking smile, like she's stressed out about something and trying to hide it.

Adora's heart drops. "I'm doing… fine," she replies. "Um… I'm pretty tired, though, and I think I'm gonna head back to my tent." She glances at Catra, hoping she got the message. Catra nods ever so slightly.

"Alright! Good seeing you!" Bow says, giving Adora a smile.

"Goodnight, Adora!" Glimmer waves at her.

Adora puts on a smile that she hopes doesn't look fake, and turns on her heel to start towards her tent, double checking that Catra is coming.

When she reaches her tent, she opens the flaps and steps inside.

"You can sit down, if you want," Adora offers, taking a seat on the foot of her bed.

Catra doesn't reply, but she does settle herself down in the spot next to Adora. Adora knows that when Catra's shoulders and ears are drooped and her tail is motionless like this, she's feeling

troubled about something. But Adora isn't sure if she should ask Catra about it or wait to see what she says.

"I'm tired," Catra mumbles after a moment.

Adora waits for a bit before replying, just in case Catra has something else to say. It doesn't seem like she does. "Me too."

Catra remains silent.

"What's wrong?" Adora asks after a moment. "Are you… are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Catra replies almost immediately, and she sighs. "Well, kind of. I… didn't really… Thaymor. It was… it was *destroyed* …"

"Hey," Adora says, speaking in the most soothing tone she can muster. "It's alright. It wasn't your fault, remember? It was *Prime* who destroyed it this time."

"I know, I know… It's just…" Catra visibly shudders. "Seeing it like that reminds me of… t-the past. Of *me* ."

"Well," Adora says, feeling defeated, and she figures that changing the subject is probably a good idea right now. "I put in a request for you to get reassigned to Elberon."

“You did?” Catra raises her head and her ears perk up.

“Yeah,” Adora replies, shifting herself closer. “I did. Are you… okay with that?”

Catra smiles. “ *Yes* . I was going to ask Sparkles earlier when I had the chance, but I wasn’t really…” She lets out another sigh. “Today was… kind of rough.”

Adora gulps and nods.

“It’s been, what, four days since we started reconstruction, and I *still* haven’t gotten used to working with the clones,” Catra says. “Have you?”

“Definitely not.” Adora grimaces. Working alongside the people who were on the opposite side of the war to repair the damages of said war is *certainly* going to take some getting used to. Yes, when they were fighting them, the clones were controlled by a hive mind and acting against their will. Now, they are free from that control, but… That doesn’t make working with them any less unnerving.

“You know,” Catra continues, “if Arrow Boy hadn’t been there to tell me a bunch of stupid jokes, I think yesterday would’ve been a lot worse for me. I think he knew I was upset, and that was his way of distracting me.”

“That’s sweet of him,” Adora says, her already deep fondness of Bow growing even stronger. “Did you… did the… *images* come up? You know, the ones-”

“From my nightmare?” Catra takes a deep breath. “No. They didn’t.”

Adora feels relief wash over her.

“Between the endless busywork and the constant stream of terrible jokes, I don’t think I had *time* to think about my nightmare,” Catra chuckles.

“That’s good to hear,” Adora says, her voice stronger now, and she feels as though a weight was suddenly lifted off of her chest.

“So, Adora? How was the repair work on your end?” Catra asks.

“It was boring,” Adora responds in monotone.

“Figured,” Catra replies, her mouth forming into a flat line. “Did you take any breaks?”

Adora's stomach lurches. "Uh, y-yes. I did. *Two* , in fact," she says as triumphantly as she can.

"Yeah?" Catra raises an eyebrow like she knows exactly where this conversation is going, which she probably does. "And how long were they?"

"W-well, the first one was… it was kind of…" Adora gulps, her shallow sense of victory fading. "They were both... two minutes."

Catra's expression darkens. "Adora, you *really* need to-"

"Yeah, I know, I know. I-I'm sorry, it's just-"

"You're *overworking* yourself," Catra tells her sternly. "I thought we talked about this."

"We *did* , I'm just…" Adora stutters. "I…"

There is no point in arguing anymore. No matter what Adora says, it won't change Catra's mind on this matter. In Catra's eyes, Adora is working too hard. Sure, she skips out on lunch, and the breaks she *does* take can hardly be considered 'breaks,' but… She doesn't have time to waste. She needs to work as hard as she can. And besides, the sooner they complete their work, the sooner she and Catra will be *free* -

“You didn’t eat lunch today, did you?” Catra asks, but it’s more of an accusation than a question.

Adora sighs. She swears Catra can read her mind sometimes. “No, I-I didn’t.”

“ *Adora* …”

“I’m sorry,” Adora says, dropping her head. “I’ll… I’ll take a lunch break tomorrow, I promise.”

To her dismay, Catra doesn’t seem to be satisfied with this.

“You need at *least* three breaks, including lunch,” Catra replies. “And they need to be *reasonable* , not just two minutes each.”

Adora feels a twinge of annoyance.“Catra, I’m *fine* ,” she snaps. Immediately, she feels a strong urge to apologize.

“Adora.” Catra furrows her brow. “You look *exhausted* . I haven’t seen you like this since…” She shakes her head. “Just… please. Can you do this? For me?”

...Catra is right. As much as Adora is trying to ignore it, there's no denying that she feels *incredibly* tired right now, not to mention as hungry as ever. Her hands are freezing even though it's hot outside and in this tent, which can't be a good sign.

"Alright," she says. "I'll do it."

"Thank you," Catra smiles. "Do you want to get something to eat before bed?"

"Yeah," Adora replies, her stomach rumbling. "Good idea."

*****

As she steps into Adora's tent after dinner and slips under the bedsheets, Catra can't help but smile, just like she does every night when she is sleeping in here.

And the sound of Adora climbing into bed right next to her makes her heart jump without fail each time she hears it.

Maybe she's just being selfish, but recently, Catra has found herself wanting more. She wants Adora to be *closer* , even though they are literally in the same bed. And it's not like it's a large bed, either.

"Adora?" Catra says suddenly, even surprising herself.

“Yeah?” Adora responds, turning to face her.

Catra has to bite her tongue to prevent the words ‘can I come closer’ from escaping her lips, so instead she just says, “good night.”

“Good night, Catra,” Adora says, her face forming into the smile Catra loves so much.

Resorting to her tongue-biting method again, Catra manages to force herself to remain quiet. When Adora speaks to her again, she isn’t expecting it at all, and her heart does a full on somersault.

“Hey, um… Thanks for looking out for me,” Adora says. “And… I’m sorry for not taking breaks today. You were right; I completely wore myself out.”

“Told you so,” Catra teases.

“Yeah, yeah,” Adora yawns.

“Just… take care of yourself, alright?”

“I will,” Adora assures her. “I promise.” With that, she closes her eyes.

Catra doesn’t close hers, however. And then she realizes that her hand is inches from Adora’s face (when did it *get* there??), and she catches herself just in time, right before she makes contact. She stays like that for a while, frozen in place, unable to move her hand forward, but also unable to pull it away.

Suddenly, however, she comes to her senses and quickly returns her hand to her side. What if Adora were to open her eyes to the sight of Catra hovering her hand awkwardly in front of her face? Her face grows hot with embarrassment at the mere thought.

Her heart is pounding like she is carrying out a heist, despite the fact that she is simply lying in place. She forces herself to close her eyes, but that doesn’t last long. In just a few seconds, she has them wide open again, staring at Adora.

Eventually, Catra has to completely flip herself over so that she’s not facing Adora anymore, and that seems to do the trick. And while listening to Adora’s soft, soothing breathing and fighting the urge to turn back over to face her, she drifts off into a deep sleep, her nightmares kept at bay by the subconscious reminder of absolute safety by her side.

*****

Chapter End Notes

In the next chapter, the past continues to catch up with the Best Friend Squad.

As always, thank you for reading!! See you on Saturday!

Damages

Chapter Summary

The war, though long over, continues to take its toll.

Chapter Notes

Today's chapter is by far the shortest of the entire fic. But don't worry; there are plenty of stacked chapters coming! ;)

I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Ughhhh…" Adora groans, flinging her arm over to her nightstand and slapping her alarm clock to silence it. She double checks that her alarm is working properly, because it *definitely* feels like she slept for about two minutes and her alarm went off several hours early. But the time on the display, as well as the reddish glow shining through the fabric of the tent, tells her that it is indeed morning.

She pushes herself up into a sitting position, feeling betrayed by the passage of time during her slumber. With a glance to her right, she sees Catra, or rather the outline of Catra, underneath a mess of blankets.

As she reaches over to rouse her, Catra pokes her head out from under the covers, her short hair spiking out wildly in all directions, looking completely disappointed with the idea of being vertical.

"No *way* it's morning," she growls, her already raspy voice sounding extra gravelly like it normally does right when she wakes up.

"I'm still in disbelief," Adora responds, standing up, and her fingers find her hair tie. As she draws her hair back into a ponytail, she spots some sort of paper object next to the entrance to the tent. She moves closer and discovers that it is a letter, one that it seems somebody slid under the tent flaps while she was sleeping.

She collects the letter and reads the address:

To: Adora (mostly) and Catra

From: Micah

"What's that?" Catra asks. Adora turns to discover that Catra has managed to rise out of bed on her own without Adora having to drag her into a standing position.

"It's from King Micah," Adora replies, holding the letter out in front of her. "Can you open it for me?"

"Sure." Catra takes the letter, slices the top open with one of her claws, and hands it back to Adora.

“Adora,” Adora reads. “Hello! King Micah here. I’m writing to inform you that you have been hereby transferred to Thaymor for reconstruction work as to be alongside Catra.”

“Yes!” Catra cheers, clenching her fists in front of her. “Wait, *what* ??”

“I received your request from my daughter, Glimmer,” Adora continues. “She told me that you wished to work in the same location Catra, and that you wanted her to be reassigned to Elberon. However, upon consideration, I felt it would be more beneficial to assign you to Thaymor instead, for that location requires more personnel at the moment. This way, it is the best of both worlds. Please, if you have any concerns with this reassignment, let me know immediately, and I will sort them out as quickly as I can. Also, I wanted to let both you and Catra know that I am sorry for assigning you in two separate locations (really, what was I thinking?). Can you tell her? I would’ve written two letters, but I figured that would just be a waste of paper. Anyway, thank you, and I hope you have a good rest of your week.”

Adora finishes reading, but her eyes remain glued to the page as if staring at it would magically change the words.

“Um… we’re both at Thaymor now?” Catra asks, sounding apprehensive.

“Apparently,” Adora responds, furrowing her brow. “...Do you wanna ask for a reassignment?”

Catra sighs, running her hand through her hair. “No, I’ll… give it another shot. It wasn’t *that* bad, but…You know.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yeah. If it doesn’t work out, I’ll just ask for a reassignment tomorrow.”

“O-okay…”

“Let’s just… go get breakfast,” Catra offers, stepping out of the tent.

*****

“Hey, you promised, remember?” Catra says, playfully pushing Adora on the shoulder. “Just fifteen minutes, nothing fancy.”

“Fiiiine, if you *insist* ,” Adora replies sarcastically. Again, Catra is right in this situation. If Adora takes a break, she will be energized and therefore able to complete her job more easily and effectively. Not only that, but a break does *wonders* to relieve stress. Taking a break is important, and something that Adora should have been doing more consistently throughout her entire life.

“What’s next; am I gonna have to convince you that *breathing* is a health benefit, or something?” Catra teases, her eyes glinting mischievously.

“Breathing? Never heard of it.”

“You know, I wouldn’t be surprised if you were actually serious right now.”

Adora is too busy laughing to come up with a clever comeback. Catra joins in her laughter, poking her ribs, chanting, “in, out, in, out! Come on, you can do it, Adora!”

“ *Hey* ,” Adora says with mock-indignancy, doing her best to deflect Catra’s poking onslaught. “I thought I was supposed to be on break!”

“Too bad!” Catra finally relents, and she fills two paper cups with water and hands one to Adora.

“Thanks, I *guess* ,” Adora smiles, toasting Catra’s paper cup and taking a sip.

“Adora, I’m *so* glad you’re here,” Catra says after a moment’s pause. “Really. Thanks for- well. Thanks for everything.”

“You’re welcome,” Adora responds, and she feels a warmth spreading through her chest. She fights the urge to reach over and pull Catra into a tight hug, and distracts herself by asking, “do you wanna take a walk?”

“Where to?” Catra asks her.

“Oh, I don’t know. Just… around?”

“Sure.” Catra throws her head back, downs the last of her water, and discards the cup.

The question doesn’t come easily, and it takes Adora a good minute of walking in silence to get it out. “So, how’ve you been holding up?”

“I’m actually doing pretty well,” Catra responds, and Adora feels significantly relieved. “A *lot* better than I was yesterday.”

“Good! I’m glad.”

“You know, I…” Catra sighs. “I’ve been thinking about this whole thing, about Thaymor. And… It’s actually pretty- I don’t know… *comforting* for me to work here. For me to help rebuild the place I once worked to destroy. It feels almost like… closure.”

“It does?” Adora raises an eyebrow.

“Yeah. It’s kind of a mindset thing. I know I’m not erasing what I did in the past, because I can *never* do that, but it feels like I’m making progress towards… I don’t know, acceptance, or something.”

“Catra,” Adora says, furrowing her brow. “You *are* accepted. There’s not a single person that thinks otherwise.”

“Actually... there is.”

Adora’s heart drops.

“It’s… someone I didn’t even know,” Catra continues. “Yesterday, they told me that I’m a monster, that I destroyed their home. And… they were right about one of those things.”

“W-which one?” Adora asks.

“They were probably right that I destroyed their home. And I can’t deny it. I *won’t* deny it. But they were wrong about the other thing. Adora, I’m *not* a monster. I might’ve been in the past, but I’m not anymore. And I might not be able to make that person or the others who think the same change their mind about me, but

that's not what's important. What matters is that I focus on myself, on what *I* can do, and try to make an effort to move away from my… my past."

"Catra, that's… I'm *so* glad," Adora says, her heart brimming with warmth. "You've come such a long way."

It's so *wonderful* to hear Catra being hopeful about her future, to hear her validating herself, *respecting* herself. Adora knows that she has been trapped in a cycle of self-hatred for the longest time, and it looks like she's making great strides to escape it.

Of course, it's not over yet, and Adora knows that Catra may very well relapse into her self-destructive mindset in the future, which makes it *all* the more important that Adora be there for her when she needs it, to remind Catra that she is worth something, that she's changed for the better, that Adora *loves* her, and that she always will.

"Thanks, Adora," Catra says. "I'm glad you're my f… m-my friend…"

Technically, yes, they are friends, but in Adora's opinion, that word doesn't really do their relationship justice. Before she can pursue this train of thought any further, however, Catra suddenly stops in her tracks, staring forward at a location that they both know all too well.

Adora stops as well, standing next to Catra in complete silence, the implication of this place causing the hairs on the back of her neck to stand on end.

This is the place where I left Catra.

Adora hangs her head.

"Hey, we should… probably get back," Catra says, her voice small. "I think our break is almost over."

"Yeah," Adora breathes, swallowing the lump in her throat and turning away from the spot where it all began, the spot where she abandoned her best friend all those years ago.

*****

"Oh, *no* ! What *ever* shall we do? This large boulder is going to be *impossible* to move!" Bow says, gesturing dramatically to a particularly sizable chunk of rubble blocking a doorway in front of him.

"Alright, you can drop the act," Glimmer sighs, and she places a hand on the boulder's weathered surface and disappears in a flash of purple light. Seconds later, she's back, and the boulder is nowhere to be found.

“Seriously, though,” Bow continues. “That’s amazing! Is there even a limit to how much weight you can teleport??”

“I really don’t know,” Glimmer replies. “I’ve never really found something that I *couldn’t* teleport, so who knows?”

“I wonder if you could teleport an entire building? Ooh, imagine going on vacation, or something, and just being able to bring your entire *house* !”

“I don’t think I’d be able to move something so big that far.”

“Not with that attitude!”

Glimmer picks up a pebble by her foot and throws it out of a nearby window. “Bow, can we focus? We need to clear this room even if we’re not gonna use it.”

“Sure! I can do that,” Bow says brightly, moving past Glimmer into the previously boulder-blocked room.

It’s a fairly large room, the perfect size to house two people. Across the room on the opposite wall is a doorway leading out to a balcony area with a great view of Bright Moon Valley below.

There are numerous pieces of rubble of various sizes strewn across the floor, but as far as damage, the room seems to be relatively fine. Luckily, the fourth floor was pretty heavily prioritized in Bright Moon's reconstruction process, meaning in third floor rooms such as these, the ceilings are repaired and intact. That'll make their job easier.

"So, what do you think?" Glimmer asks.

"You know," Bow smiles. "I think this is the one. It looks *perfect* !"

"I have to agree." Glimmer travels the perimeter of the room, poking her head into the two doors on the right side and nodding in approval. "I like this one. We should've claimed it."

"We already chose," Bow points out. "I like our room, though."

"Yeah, me too. I'm mostly just jealous of that balcony. Just look at that *view* !"

"Right??" Bow picks up a handful of rocks and rubble and deposits them into a large bag. "It's like I'm on top of the *world* !"

Glimmer starts filling a rubble-bag of her own, and a half hour and nine-and-a-quarter bags later, the room is mostly cleared.

“Heads up,” Glimmer warns, throwing a broom and dustpan to Bow. “Alright, you get that side of the room, and I’ll get this one?”

“No complaints here,” Bow replies. He begins to sweep.

A couple of minutes pass where the only sound in the air is the brush of their brooms on the floor and the sound of the waterfalls cascading over the walls of the valley in the distance.

After a while, Glimmer says, “We’re really coming along, Bow. Look at how much progress we’ve made!”

“I know, right?” Bow beams. “This room will look brand new in *no* time.”

“It’s kind of hard to believe that this place was practically destroyed a couple of days ago.” Glimmer stops sweeping and her expression darkens. “You know, I um… I visited my mom’s statue today. Well, I do *every* day, but… I just… Today, I realized something.”

“Yeah?” Bow gulps in anticipation and he stops sweeping as well. “W-what did you realize?”

“My mom’s statue, the one on the first floor, is in perfect condition. Not a scratch on it. And you know how messed up the first floor was from the war, Bow.”

“Yeah…” Bow breathes out. “It was… It was pretty bad.”

“Anyway,” Glimmer continues, “I just thought that it’s kind of ironic that the *one* thing that *wasn’t* damaged by the war is the statue of my mom. Even though the war is what… took her away… in the first place…” She drops her head.

“That’s- um…” Bow tries, but he’s unsure of how to respond. He leans his broom against the nearest wall and moves forward, reaching out and taking one of Glimmer’s hands between his own. “Do you wanna take a break?”

“No,” Glimmer responds after a sigh. “Let’s just… keep working. We’ve got a lot to get done…”

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Chapter End Notes

Next chapter, some stuff is set in motion. That's all I'll say.

As always, thank you so much for reading, and feedback is highly appreciated!!

Past and Present

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora hang out after repair work. Some unexpected things occur.

Chapter Notes

Hello again! We're back to normal-length chapters today. If I remember correctly, they only get longer from here! :0

This was a fun one to write. I hope you enjoy!

“Glimmer, check out this new feature of my tracker pad!” Bow’s enthusiastic voice is very recognizable among the chatter of the people around the fire pits. “You just press this button, and then-" Bow points the back of the device into the air, and from it springs a small, triangular object. The object rises up and starts hovering in place. “It’s a drone that can be controlled through the pad! And look, it also has a camera!”

The pad’s display perfectly recreates the landscape that the drone is facing.

“Bow, that is amazing! How’d you *do* that?” Glimmer beams.

“I got some help from Entrapta; she’s been helping me learn more about tech and how to really use it,” Bow says proudly.

Two voices speak in unison from behind them. “Wonderful, Bow!”

Bow spins around. “Dads! You came to visit! How are the repairs going in Erlandia?”

“Ah, you know. They’ve been slow. But, they’re coming along! We both could use a change of pace, which is why we are here. Also, we wanted to see you!” says Lance.

“It’s great to see you!” Bow says, hugging them both. “We’ve been pretty busy around here as well. But, we have She-Ra and Glimmer’s *amazing* powers to help things move more smoothly!”

“Ah, She-Ra! Wonderful! And you too, of course, Glimmer,” George adds, chortling.

The evening is cool, the slight breeze in the air flowing gently over Adora’s body. She smiles complacently as she watches everyone socialize. The world is this way because of *her* . Of course, everyone had played a part, especially Catra, Bow, and Glimmer, but *Adora* had been the one to return the magic to the world. She had been the one to finish off Horde Prime, ridding the universe of his tyranny.

It’s a nice feeling. She tilts her head back and closes her eyes, taking a deep breath through her nose.

“Adora,” she hears from behind her.

She immediately recognizes the voice and turns around. “Hey!”

“Who is this ‘She-Ra’ person I keep hearing about?” Catra asks, smiling slyly as she saunters forward. “Everyone seems to *love* her. Can you introduce me, Adora? She seems *way* cooler than you.”

“Heh. Yeah,” Adora scoffs. She stands up confidently and points her thumb at her chest. “I happen to know her *pretty* well myself. Want to meet her? Here, I can arrange that.” She lunges forward and bear-hugs Catra, rustling her hair playfully. “Be warned; once the mighty She-Ra has something in her grasp, it can never escape!”

“Yeah, we’ll see about that!” Catra retorts, wrestling against Adora’s grip.

They tumble to the ground, rolling over each other and giggling hysterically, just like they did when they were younger.

At some point in their wrestling match, Catra finds an opening and breaks free, grabbing Adora’s wrists, pinning them to the ground, and sitting on her legs, trapping her in place.

“See? All too easy,” she says triumphantly.

“Pfft. I let you win,” Adora replies, giving her a smile.

“Yeah, right,” Catra huffs, and suddenly, the look of smug accomplishment fades from her face and her eyes widen. She probably isn’t aware of the fact that she is staring, and that her tail is flicking back and forth rhythmically behind her. She looks to be in a trance of some sort.

Adora throws her hand up to her mouth and yawns sarcastically to hide her blush. “Catra, are you planning on letting me go any time soon?”

Catra also goes red. “Uhm-” She tears her eyes away from Adora’s, dropping her head in embarrassment. “Yeah…”

She rolls off of Adora and lays beside her, looking up into the sky.

The sun has almost completely disappeared behind the trees and the stars are starting to become visible. Around them are the distant sounds of the evening winding down and everyone getting ready for bed.

Adora clasps her hands below her head, her heart still beating quickly from Catra’s intense stare.

“I think even after that ‘win,’ you’re still down 3 points,” she says.

Catra looks over at her, raising her eyebrows in disbelief. “What?! Have you been keeping *score* ?”

“Nah, I completely made that number up. You believed me, didn’t you?”

“Pfft. *No* . I knew you weren’t serious.”

Adora turns to face Catra. “Actually, I bet you’re down by a *lot* more than 3 points.”

Catra scoffs derisively. “There’s no *way* that’s true.”

“Yeah? Where’s your proof?”

“I don’t know, where’s *your* proof??”

Adora returns her gaze to the night sky. “Come on, you know I’m right.”

“It doesn’t look like I can convince you otherwise,” Catra replies.

"Then I guess we'll just have to wait and *see* who's right."

"Is that a challenge?" Catra smiles mischievously, as if she is coming up with several devious plans to prove Adora wrong. "Alright *Adora* , you'd better stay on your guard from now on."

"Don't worry, I'll be ready," Adora assures her. She has a trick up her sleeve for next time. Nothing Catra can devise will be able to stop her from losing *spectacularly* .

Well, hopefully.

"Good. I'd like a challenge for once," Catra says, nudging Adora's arm with her elbow.

"Okay, suit yourself."

As they lay staring up into the night sky, Adora finds the silence that has fallen between them to be extremely uncomfortable, entirely due to the fact that her mind can't seem to find anything to think about other than her almost irresistible desire to reach over, put her arms around Catra, and cuddle tight into her body.

Almost irresistible. She can manage.

She *has* to manage. Catra might not be okay with a sudden move like that. Adora reminds herself to prioritize thinking about what will make Catra happy, and not to let her own petty wishes make things weird between them.

Yeah, that's what it is. A petty wish, and nothing more.

"I wonder when we're going to be done with all this dumb repair work," Catra says.

Adora sighs, somehow both disappointed and relieved that she doesn't have to think about her deep desires anymore. "I have no idea."

"I thought our job was done when we, you know, saved the *universe* and everything, but I guess not."

"Hey, I'm getting tired of this as well. I wish we could just relax for once."

Catra extends her arms and legs outward, stretching thoroughly against the grass. "Relax? That sure sounds nice."

"Yeah, it does," Adora replies. She steals a glance at Catra, and finds herself unable to look away.

Catra is gazing pensively up into the night sky, her freckled face lit softly by the moonlight. She is so beautiful.

Well, *obviously* . Adora has known that for a long time. But… Is this the first time she's actually *really* put thought into it?

Catra turns to match her gaze, and Adora feels her face getting warm. Her eyes- those brilliant, gem-like blue and yellow eyes- are so alluring.

Catra breaks the silence. "Adora, I…"

Adora's heart jumps as she feels Catra shift herself closer.

"CATRA."

Both Catra and Adora jolt upward, sitting up and scanning for the source of the voice.

Hordak's figure emerges from behind the two of them. "Er- I mean, Catra," he says more politely. "There you are."

"Hordak," Catra says, and it sounds like not even trying to hide the disdain in her tone. Adora notices she is shaking slightly,

perhaps because Hordak shares the same voice as Horde Prime. "What do *you* want?"

"I wish to speak with you," Hordak commands, and Catra's eyes narrow. "Only if you are able," he quickly adds.

Catra turns to give Adora a look of longing, to which Adora responds, "It's all right. You guys… go talk. I'll be in my tent, okay?"

Catra winks at her and disappears into the darkness.

Great. Thanks for nothing, Hordak.

On the way back, Adora lets out a sigh of disappointment. As simple as it was, she already misses laying by Catra's side under the night sky. Catra was going to say something to her, and Adora has a feeling that it was probably something important.

What can Hordak *possibly* have to say that's more important than that?

She opens up her tent and steps inside. After hanging up her jacket, she removes her hair tie and slumps down onto her bed.

*****

It is Catra that breaks the awkward silence. “Hordak, what is your deal? In case you didn’t *notice,* I was in the middle of something.”

Hordak takes a deep breath. “You may be correct, but I have something I need to say.”

Catra raises an eyebrow dangerously, and Hordak takes a deep breath.

“Let me rephrase what I just said,” he says. “Catra, I am sorry for interrupting your evening with my selfish request.”

“Yeah, yeah, get to the point. What do you *want* ?” Catra snaps.

“I have been thinking about my time in the Horde, and lately, I have not been able to dispel my feelings of guilt. I treated you poorly, and I am here to apologize for my misconduct.”

Catra lets out a mirthless bark of a laugh. “Seriously?! After everything you did, you think a single apology will fix everything? Why are you even *trying* this?”

Hordak drops his head. “I am not trying to fix this, for it is far too broken to repair. However, I felt that this was necessary in order to-”

He stops abruptly as a web of electricity sparks over his body. He lets out a grunt and collapses to the ground.

“Hordak? What are you-?” Catra crouches down beside him to get a better look.

Hordak strains, turning his head upward. “Catra, I know I have no right to ask anything of you, but I am not in a fit condition at the moment. Please, I need to see Entrapta. She will be able to help me.”

Hordak just asked for help. *Hordak* . Catra never thought she’d see the day.

“I’ll be back. You stay there,” she says, and runs off in the opposite direction. “Not like you have any choice,” she adds, once out of earshot.

Once Catra gets to Entrapta’s tent, she bursts inside. “Entrapta! It’s Hordak, he’s-! Uh, What are you doing?”

Entrapta turns around and beams widely. “Oh, hello Catra, I was just reviewing and compiling the *incredible* footage that Bow

captured on his new remote-”

“Wait, never mind,” Catra interrupts. “You need to come with me. Hordak is in trouble.”

Entrapta’s eyes widen significantly and her smile is instantly gone. “Hordak?? What’s wrong? Where is he?”

No time to explain. Catra pushes her out of the tent. “Follow me, he’s over here.”

Entrapta manages to reach back into the tent with her hair and grab her toolbox, and the two are off. Once they reach Hordak, Entrapta immediately pulls out multiple complicated looking tools and starts to work. Catra lingers awkwardly by their side, watching the process.

Entrapta breathes a sigh of relief. “That was close, Hordak. If you had been in this state any longer, the damage to both your armor and body would have been catastrophic, and possibly irreversible! Good thing I was nearby to help,” she adds happily.

“How embarrassing. The state of my body right now is simply pathetic,” Hordak says. “Thank you for your assistance, Entrapta.” He turns his head towards Catra. “And you, Catra. I truly appreciate your help as well. Because of you, Entrapta will be able to help me. Now, I am sure Adora is looking forward to your

return. You've done all that you can here, so please enjoy the rest of your evening."

Catra stands over him, absolutely thunderstruck.

"Sure thing," she replies simply, and spins around on her heel, striding away hastily.

Hordak has definitely come a long way as far as emotional depth goes, Catra thinks to herself, smirking. She never thought the day would come that Hordak, of all people, would apologize to her, or to *anyone* for that matter.

Though she isn't ready to forgive Hordak, and though the scars that he carved into her will probably never disappear, she feels a bit better knowing that he is at least *trying* to change for the better. It was a good thing that Catra helped him. In the past, perhaps things would have been different.

With a satisfied grin, Catra breaks into a run. Adora is waiting for her.

*****

Adora can't sit still. She had to force herself to lay down after pacing frantically around her tent for a good ten minutes. Now, she's unable to stop fidgeting with her hands, and she keeps

throwing *way* too many looks towards the entrance, as if that would make Catra magically appear.

Sleeping alone last night made Adora realize how much she really appreciates Catra's company, and how hard it is to imagine a day without her.

Is that normal?

She has never experienced feelings like these around anybody else in the entire world. Of course, her other friends, like Bow and Glimmer, are amazing people, and they also make her happy. But, for some reason, they just aren't able to bring out the same feelings hiding within her that Catra can. No one else can make her entire body warm with just one simple look into her eyes.

Adora's glance shoots towards the entrance yet again, but this time it is for good reason; the tent flaps were just thrown open. "Catra!"

"Hey Adora," Catra says playfully. She jumps onto the bed into a sitting position, her tail pointing upward and swaying rhythmically behind her.

Adora props her head up on her head. "What did Hordak want with you?"

“You won’t believe this. He tried to apologize to me. After all he did!”

Adora’s eyes widen. “What?? Hordak apologized? To *you* ? I didn’t think he had it in him.”

“Right? I couldn’t take him seriously. It felt like I was dreaming!”

“Maybe he finally got a taste of his own medicine when he was on Prime’s ship,” Adora snickers.

Catra goes completely silent, and then she starts to breathe heavily, her eyes sliding out of focus.

Adora immediately realizes her mistake.

She sits up feverishly and puts her hands on Catra’s, which are closed tightly, digging into the bedsheets. She is having another panic attack.

How could Adora have been so *careless* ?

“Catra? It’s alright!” she pleads, but it isn’t getting through to Catra. She tries again. “Hey, look at me. He’s gone. I’m here for

you. You won't have nightmares again." Though she doesn't know that for sure, she feels it has to be said.

Finally, Catra replies, her voice a shaky mumble. "Yeah, you're right. You're right… I won't have them again…"

Adora knows what she has to do. She shifts towards Catra and pulls her into her chest, and gradually, *thankfully* , she feels Catra's shaking subside and her body relax.

"I knew I made a mistake letting you sleep alone," she says. "I won't ever do it again. No matter what happens, I'll be here for you."

Catra doesn't respond, but since she isn't shaking anymore, Adora feels it is safe to let go of her, and she returns to her side of the bed.

"Thanks," Catra sighs. She sounds irritated. "It feels so pathetic. I'm scared of dreaming, and I need somebody to sleep with. I feel like a *child* ."

Adora feels her blood boiling. Prime did this. *Prime* is the reason Catra is in this state.

She takes a deep breath to calm herself. "Catra, we *will* overcome this. I will never leave you, ever." She pauses. With a smile, she

adds, “How could I? I love you too much.”

Catra’s face lights up. Thank *goodness* . “I know. I was gonna say that earlier before Hordak came and screwed things up.”

They both share a gentle laugh, and their eyes meet. Catra’s tail starts to move again.

Adora feels her face getting warmer. She can’t really help it when Catra looks at her like she is.

She drops her gaze and distracts herself by extinguishing the lamps in their tent.

“Alright, lights out. I’m super tired after today,” she says. That is true, she *is* exhausted from all of the heavy lifting that they had to do. But it is also an excuse. In the dark, she won’t have to worry about going red simply by looking into Catra’s eyes.

“Alright, sleepyhead,” Catra sighs.

As Adora turns off the last lamp and climbs back in bed, she feels the familiar burning desire that overtakes her every night, the desire to put her arms around Catra and pull her into her body. She has to physically shake her head to get the idea out, reminding herself not to make Catra uncomfortable in any way. She has already been through enough already.

Perhaps Adora should just give it more time.

On the other side of the bed, Catra is curled up into a cute little ball, which doesn't exactly help Adora's state of mind right now. She gives in a little, reaching over and placing her hand on Catra's forearm. For now, this much will have to be enough. As long as Catra is comfortable and doesn't have any nightmares, it shouldn't matter what Adora wants.

Catra's heart does a little backflip following Adora's unexpected touch. This isn't normal. Adora almost never initiates contact between the two of them.

But, Catra isn't complaining. In fact, she wishes Adora would do it more, and not just when Catra is freaking out.

"Um, Catra?" Adora suddenly asks.

"Mm?

“What’s on your arm?”

Catra’s blood turns to ice. She immediately pulls her arm away.

“Oh, that’s… N-nothing! I- I scraped it up during repairs,” she stutters.

Adora just hums in response, and she gets out of bed to relight a lamp. Catra uses this opportunity to hide her entire body and the majority of her face underneath the bed sheets.

“Hey, come here. I can heal you,” Adora says as she turns back around, and she extends a hand cautiously, like she is trying to calm a wounded animal.

“N-no, I- I’m fine, it’s just a scratch.”

“Um, Catra, are you okay? You look… uncomfortable.”

It is just a matter of time before Adora sees her cut, and trying to hide it will just make Catra look more suspicious. Maybe it doesn’t look too bad; maybe she can pass it off as an accident-

“Hey.” Adora is now sitting down on the bed. “Let me *heal* you.”

Catra's stomach does a horrible lurch. She reluctantly pulls her left arm out from under the bed sheet and gives Adora a weak smile.

"See? It's not bad," she lies.

Adora's eyebrows furrow. "Catra, this isn't *just a scratch* . Look at how deep it is."

Catra's heart is pounding. She tries to respond, to say *something* to diffuse the situation, but she can't; the knot in her chest won't let her.

Adora moves her face closer to the wound.

"Hey, what did you even *do* ?" she asks. "This looks like it was-"

Suddenly, she cuts off, and the color drains from her face. She looks terrified, on the verge of tears.

"C-Catra?" she chokes. "Y-you didn't d-do this to yourself, did you?"

*****

Consequences

Chapter Summary

Adora takes charge. She and Catra talk.

Chapter Notes

There's nothing much to say today; I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra messed up. Badly. She is terrified of what's about to happen.

Adora takes a deep breath and extends her arm outwards. A sword materializes right in front of her hand, and she grasps its hilt. In a flash of light, she transforms into She-Ra. She grabs onto Catra's arm, and in a surge of magical energy, the wound is healed.

"Catra, tell me the truth. What happened??" Adora commands, and she returns to her normal form.

"I…" There is no getting out of this one. Catra has to tell Adora what she did, or she will just make things worse. "I d-did it to myself."

" *What* ?"

"I- I'm sorry…" Catra shrinks into the bed. The look that Adora has in her eyes is one of abject horror. And it is *all* Catra's fault. If she had just woken up Adora instead of deciding that it was a good idea to *cut herself* , none of this would be happening.

"Catra, talk to me, *now* . What did you do??" Adora's voice is powerful.

Catra gulps. "I… Even when I was awake, I saw things from my nightmare. I didn't know how to stop it, so I- I panicked, and…"

"W-was it an accident?" Adora says those words like they are what she wants to believe. Catra can take advantage of this and say yes, playing her wound off as something that happened on accident as a result of her freak out.

But she is *done* lying, and should have never hid the truth to begin with. Adora doesn't deserve that.

"No. I did it on purpose," Catra admits.

Adora staggers backward, her eyes brimming with tears. It hurts to see. "But- *why* ?"

"I… I did it to distract myself. F-from my nightmare. I didn't want to wake you up."

“Catra, you should’ve! I told you it was okay!” Adora’s voice breaks on the last word. Tears are now rolling down her cheeks. She throws her hands onto her head, clenching her fists into her hair. “I’m such an idiot- I *knew* I shouldn’t have let you sleep alone- What was I *thinking* ??”

“Hey-!” Catra’s heart wrenches. It’s painful to see Adora in this state.

And… it’s Catra’s fault. It’s *all* her fault. Adora is in agony because of *her.*

Suddenly, Adora catches her in a tight hug, clinging onto her body as if her life depends on it.

“A-Adora?” Catra says, her eyes widening.

“P-please, Catra,” Adora chokes. “Please, never do that ever again. It… it *hurts* me.”

“I’m sorry, I- I didn’t-” Catra can’t finish her sentence, as she feels as though a knife has been jabbed into her chest.

“Promise me,” Adora pleads. “ *Please* .”

“I promise,” Catra says firmly. “I’ll never do it again.”

Adora lets go of Catra and returns to her side of the bed. She takes several deep breaths to calm herself down, and when she speaks again, her voice is small, almost timid.

“Why didn’t you wake me up?” she asks.

“I- I didn’t wanna be a burden,” Catra responds weakly.

“You… you’re not.”

“I know…” Catra’s ears droop. “I’m so sorry, Adora…”

“Catra.” Adora places her hand on Catra’s forearm where the cut was. “You’re not alone. You can come talk to me about *anything* . It doesn’t matter how small or dumb it may seem. Because… you’re important to me, and I wanna help.”

“Adora, I’m sorry,” Catra repeats, but it isn’t enough. Adora deserves so much more.

“It’s okay,” Adora says, but Catra knows that she’s lying.

Adora keeps her hand on her arm and leans back against her pillow.

"Are you gonna stay in here tonight?" she asks.

"Yeah. I will from now on."

"Good. Wake me up if you need something, okay?" Adora manages a weak smile, which Catra returns.

"I will. I *swear* ."

Adora closes her eyes and turns away, her hand and the warmth it provided leaving Catra's forearm.

Catra's heart drops at the sight of Adora turning away. Adora hasn't done this before; they always sleep facing each other.

Catra breathes a slow sigh of frustration at herself. She knows this isn't over yet, and that she definitely needs to apologize again in the morning to assure Adora that she won't ever hurt herself again, but she's done all she can tonight.

So, she eventually drifts off to a deep sleep free of nightmares.

*****

Catra wakes up first and silently slinks out of bed, careful not to rouse Adora. After today's day of reconstruction, they will have a free day, one that she plans to use to spend some *much* needed time with Adora.

She lets out a yawn, dresses quickly, and slides out of the tent. Once Adora wakes up, she will apologize again.

Her stomach lurches at the thought. Last night, Adora was *very* upset with her…

Catra *will* make this right. But for now, she will have to wait.

She lets out a sigh and starts towards the treeline of the Whispering woods.

Dawn has not yet broken on the horizon. The trees on the edge of the forest will allow for a good view of the first light of the new day. Catra moves over to the tallest tree she can spot, climbs up it, and perches herself on one of the uppermost branches. Her mind wanders as she basks in the rays of light that begin to creep over the treeline.

She thinks about her past, about Adora, about the Fright Zone…

It is hard for her to imagine being back *there* . The Fright Zone was the very place Catra grew up in, lived almost her entire life in, and yet she cannot bring herself to imagine herself being back there in any way.

And that's probably a good thing.

Well, for one thing, the constant stress and abuse that she had been subjected to there, that she had come to accept as a natural part of life, is *definitely* not something she misses.

Of course, there are a plethora of other things that she doesn't miss as well. Really, the one and only thing she *doesn't* miss about the Horde is Adora.

Come to think of it, Adora was really the only reason that Catra kept going in the Horde. So when she left, well…

Catra's heart sinks as she thinks about how a lot of… *things* could have been avoided if she had just defected from the Horde when Adora did.

Back then, she was too stubborn, and she forced herself to believe that everything was all Adora's fault. She couldn't understand why Adora left her behind. Had she found a new, better place that she belonged in? Was she content with her new friends?

Was Catra not good enough for her?

But Adora wasn't leaving her; she was escaping from the atrocities of the Horde. It wasn't until Catra was saved from Prime's ship that she finally realized the painfully obvious truth: Adora really did care for her, and had since the beginning.

And she still does. *Very* much.

With that comforting thought, Catra can't help but smile.

The loud sound of several objects crashing down to the ground below her causes her to almost jump out of her tree. As she is smoothing out her newly fluffed up tail, she hears a voice.

"Oh man. This is *not* good."

Catra immediately recognizes the voice. She jumps gracefully downward from branch to branch and lands softly on the ground. Looking around, she spots a large, familiar figure.

“Scorpia??” she says in disbelief.

Scorpia turns around and her face lights up. “Oh, hey Wildcat!”

“Um… What happened here?” Catra beckons to the numerous logs strewn around Scorpia’s feet.

“Oh, these?” Scorpia chuckles. “Earlier this morning, I noticed the camp was running low on firewood, so I went to gather some up, and… Yeah, I think I may have tried to carry a bit too many. Whoops. Not the best move on my part.”

“Here, let me help you,” Catra offers, and she bends down to start gathering up some logs.

Scorpia grins widely at her. “Really? Ah, you’re the best. Come here, it’s been a while!”

She reaches out and hugs Catra with her massive pincers, lifting her completely off the ground.

Catra tenses up, and without thinking, she starts straining to escape Scorpia’s grasp. In a moment of realization, she quickly comes to her senses and is able to relax.

Scorpia isn't trying to hurt her; this is just her way of being friendly, Catra reminds herself.

"You haven't changed one bit," Catra says, her voice muffled by Scorpia's shoulder. "Are you ever going to stop hugging people?"

"Probably not. Yeah. *Definitely* not. I give great hugs! And- I don't know what I'd do without them! Give out head pats, maybe?" Scorpia comtemplates, placing Catra back on the ground.

"On second thought, maybe you should stick with the hugs," Catra laughs, imagining how destructive a pat on the head would be from someone as strong and spiky as Scorpia.

"Yeah. I think you're right," Scorpia agrees.

The two gather up the logs and start to walk back to camp.

"Anyway, I really appreciate your help, Wildcat!" Scorpia says cheerfully.

"Any time," Catra smiles.

She feels a lump form in her chest as she remembers how poorly she used to treat Scorpia. But, despite that, Scorpia had thanked her for simply helping her carry some logs. She is acting as if nothing had ever happened.

"Where have you been, Scorpia? I haven't seen you around camp lately," Catra asks, distracting herself with this new train of thought.

"Oh yeah," Scorpia responds. "I've been staying behind every day and helping with repairs for as long as I can, and then coming back here to hit the hay. Usually, by the time I'm back, everyone is already asleep. It's been a lot of work, but I'm glad that I can help!"

"Do you always get up this early as well?"

"Yeah, I find that I have more energy if I wake up and get the day going early, you know?"

The two arrive at the storage area for the logs, set them down, and take their respective seats in view of the camp. People are beginning to wake up and exit their tents. The warm yellow light from the rising sun makes the yellow tents look like they are made of gold.

"You seem to have quite the routine," Catra says, smiling.

“Well, as I say, an early start builds a strong heart!” Scorpia lets out a hearty laugh and pats Catra on the back with a tad more force than is necessary. Catra surges forward and falls off her seat, but manages to keep her balance.

“Ooh, ouch, my bad. Did I hurt you?” Scorpia shakes her head. “Sorry, I need to stop doing that…”

“Yeah, I think you just broke my spine.” Catra straightens herself, laughing. She is happy to see that Scorpia gives her a laugh in return. Catra doesn’t feel like she deserves to share laughter with Scorpia.

A minute of silence follows.

“Hey, Scorpia?” Catra asks cautiously.

“Hmm? What’s up?”

Catra pauses. She can’t bring herself to look at Scorpia’s face, so she finds a spot on the ground to stare at. She can practically feel a pair of eyes burning into her.

“I… Um. I just wanted to, you know, say something about… how I treated you.” She steals a quick glance at Scorpia, who has her

pincers together below her chin. She looks timid. Catra can't bear to look, and quickly returns her gaze to the ground.

"Oh. That," Scorpia says it like she is admitting to something *she* did. "Hey, you don't have to say it. That's all in the past! What matters now is that we look out for each other moving forward, right?"

"Yeah…" Catra says, feeling a little relieved. She's right; all of that is in the past.

She turns to face Scorpia and finally meets her eyes. She looks satisfied.

That whole process was a lot easier than Catra had imagined. She knew Scorpia would be understanding, but not *that* understanding.

And yet… something in the back of Catra's mind is still nagging her. Scorpia is beaming contentedly, overlooking the picturesque camp and all of the people starting their mornings. Is that *really* it? Is Catra really off the hook that easily? The feeling in the back of her mind is growing stronger. It is telling her that this situation is completely wrong.

"No. This isn't right," she says, and Scorpia turns to face her, wearing a look of surprise on her face. "Scorpia." Catra takes a breath. "I treated you like trash in the Horde. It wasn't fair. You

were completely right to leave because you didn't deserve *any* of it. I was a bad person, and a horrible friend. So, I'm- I'm sorry."

"Catra…" Scorpia starts, looking thoroughly astounded, and then her face breaks into a smile. "It's okay. I always knew you were a good person, deep down."

Catra doesn't deserve this at all. She finds it incredibly hard to maintain eye contact, but perseveres.

"Seriously," Scorpia continues. "If you are a bad person, then explain why you are apologizing right now. The fact that you are shows that you care!"

"Y-yeah," Catra sighs. "I guess."

"That's the spirit! Come on, let's go get breakfast," Scorpia suggests. "I don't know about you, but I am *starving* ." She stands up and starts to walk toward the tents, waving at Catra to follow. "Ooh, I think I smell some berry pie, wanna go grab a slice?"

"Wait!" Catra reaches out and grabs Scorpia's arm. Scorpia stops and turns her head quizzically.

Catra takes a deep breath and lets go of her arm. "You've been gone a lot lately, and- I-I've missed you. Wanna hang out this

weekend?”

Scorpia smiles from ear to ear. “Oh, I would love to! What do you wanna do? Maybe we could fish, or learn how to bake, or go hike in the mountains. Have you ever been to the mountains? They’re *gorgeous* ! Or- Ooh, maybe we could climb trees together! ...Wait, I don’t think I’ve ever done that before… Oh, I know! You could *teach* me how to climb trees!”

Catra can’t help but smile as well. This is the kind of person that Scorpia is. She’s confident, strong, optimistic, forgiving, and kind to everybody she meets. Catra should strive to be more like her.

Following her apology, Catra feels refreshed and as though a weight has been lifted from her chest. She considers herself fortunate that Scorpia is willing to be friends with her even after all that she had done to her in the past.

*****

“Adora? Are you in there?” Catra calls.

The sound of a bed creaking as weight is lifted off of it reaches Catra’s ears, and a few seconds later, Adora pushes open the flaps of her tent.

“Hey… can I come in?” Catra asks.

“Of course,” Adora responds, furrowing her brow. “Are you okay?”

“Oh yeah, I’m… I’m fine. I just…” Catra clenches her jaw and moves past Adora, taking a seat on the edge of the bed, and Adora sits next to her.

“I’m… going to Dryl tomorrow with Scorpia,” Catra continues. “We’re going to the mountains.”

“You are?” Adora says, her expression unreadable.

“Yes,” Catra replies sheepishly, dropping her shoulders. “I-I’m sorry. I wasn’t- I know this is our first day off, and…”

“Our first day off?” Adora asks.

“Yeah. You know, since the war, and all,” Catra explains. “Listen, I apologized to Scorpia for how I treated her back when we were Horde soldiers, and I asked her to hang out to… I don’t know, *repay* her, I guess. Even though it’s… Anyway. We agreed to go tomorrow, and I should have thought about you when I made those plans. I should have tried to work out another time, or… or something.”

Adora looks slightly taken aback at first, but then her face softens and she breaks into a warm smile. “Catra, it’s fine. You haven’t seen Scorpia in a while. Go hang out with her, okay? I don’t mind, I *promise* ,” she says, and Catra can tell that she’s being completely honest. “Besides, we’ll have an entire day next week to hang, i-if you want.”

“I do,” Catra says without hesitation. “I wanna spend that *whole* day with you. W-will that be okay?”

“That’ll be *more* than okay, Catra. I love being around you.”

“O-okay,” Catra stammers, her heart doing a little leap. She feels her face growing warmer.

“So, when are you and Scorpia leaving?”

“Oh. I think first thing tomorrow morning.”

“Mountains, huh?” Adora says, her eyes sparkling. “You’ll have to tell me how *amazing* they are!”

“Deal.”

A moment of silence passes, one in which Catra feels her stomach lurch uncomfortably.

Thanks for the encouragement.

"Adora?" she finally says, wringing her hands nervously. "I need to talk to you about... something else."

"Anything, Catra. You can talk to me about *anything* ," Adora assures her.

"Right…" Catra takes a deep breath. "I-I'm sorry, Adora. For hurting myself the other day. I- um. I know it was on purpose, but I will *never* do it again. You have my word." She swallows down the lump in her throat.

Adora places her hand gently on Catra's forearm. "Thank you. I needed that."

"Yeah," Catra breathes out, nodding curtly. "S-sorry."

"I know, Catra. I know. It's okay." Adora gives her a warm smile.

"Thanks, Adora. For always… being there for me."

"I'll always be here for you, okay?" Adora responds, and she squeezes Catra's arm. " *Always* ."

Catra breaks into a smile, and she makes eye contact with Adora for the first time today. It feels *so* good, being able to look into the eyes of the woman she loves without shame.

She feels *significantly* better now. And it looks like Adora does, as well. Catra definitely made the right choice in apologizing again.

"We'd better get going," Adora says after a few seconds, and she stands up. "We're going to be late for reconstruction."

"Good thinking."

As Catra starts to walk with Adora towards the speeders, Adora's words from earlier echo in her ears.

You can talk to me about anything .

Can Catra really talk to her about *anything* ? Can she reveal how much she wants Adora to reach over and pull her into an embrace every time they go to sleep and hold her there forever? Can she confess her desire to feel Adora's body and her warmth, to drift away comfortably in her arms every night?

Well, her face doesn’t seem to think so, because it is now burning in embarrassment. She quickly dismisses her thoughts.

Besides, when Adora said to talk to her about anything, she probably meant the important stuff.

Yeah. *Important* stuff.

*****

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter is titled "A Second Opinion." Little teaser ;)

Thank you for reading!

A Second Opinion

Chapter Summary

Bow and Glimmer surprise Adora. Catra and Scorpia hang out together.

Chapter Notes

Today's chapter is comparatively lengthy. Yay!

It's kind of egotistical to say this, but who cares- this is one of my favorite chapters. I hope you enjoy reading it as much as I did writing it!

P.S., There aren't any warnings for this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Glimmer, where does this one go?” Bow’s voice comes from outside the room.

Glimmer tilts her head out of the large doorway and spots Bow among several piles of boxes in the hallway.

“That? Here, I’ll get it,” she replies, teleporting to Bow and grabbing the wooden drawer he is holding. She teleports back into the room to put the drawer in its proper place.

Bow and Glimmer are in the palace at Bright Moon, helping with the final steps of the reconstruction process. After several days of constant work, the place is finally looking fixed up and better than ever.

“I can’t believe how far this has come along,” Bow says to Glimmer, who had just teleported back into the hallway.

“I know, right? It goes by quickly when we work together,” Glimmer replies, stepping carefully over some empty boxes. “I’m glad to see Bright Moon back in good shape. Maybe things can finally be normal around here again.”

Bow resurfaces from underneath a particularly large pile of boxes looking delighted. “Hey Glimmer, guess what? That was the last box! I think we’re done!”

“Ugh, *Finally* ! I think this is going to be well worth our effort, Bow,” Glimmer says, hugging him.

“It’s gonna be awesome,” Bow agrees, rubbing her back. “Here, let’s clear these boxes out. I can’t *wait* !”

The two grab all of the empty boxes they can carry, and make their way to the first floor. It takes a couple of trips to get all of the boxes moved out, and Glimmer is practically bouncing on her heels when they finish.

“Let’s go already!” she says, extending her hand.

“Alright, take us away!” Bow gives her a smile, grasps her hand, and they disappear in a flash of purple light.

When they rematerialize, they are in the camp on the edge of the Whispering Woods.

“We’re here,” Glimmer says. The sun is setting; they have to find Adora quickly. “Where do you think she is?”

“I don’t see her around here… Let’s check her tent,” Bow suggests. They teleport to the entrance of Adora’s tent and call her name.

Thankfully, Adora is there, and emerges from the tent with a broad smile on her face.

“Bow! Glimmer!” she says happily, pulling both of her friends into a hug. “I heard you guys teleport here. Where’ve you been?”

“Adora! You’ve got to come with us, quick!” Glimmer says.

Adora pulls away from the hug with a sudden curiosity. “Why? What’s up?”

“We can’t tell you yet,” Glimmer replies, grinning widely.

Bow peeks over Adora's shoulder and into her tent. "Hey, Adora? Where's Catra? Is she in there?"

"No, she's with Scorpia. They said they were going to the mountains in Dryl. They took a speeder and left this morning."

Glimmer and Bow exchange looks.

"That's fine, you can show Catra later, Adora," Glimmer says.

"Show her what?" Adora asks, raising an eyebrow.

"Are you doing anything important right now?" Bow asks her.

" *No* ?" She is now thoroughly confused.

"Great! Come on, let's go already! We're losing daylight!" Bow says, grabbing both Adora and Glimmer's hands.

Before Adora can open her mouth to ask another question, she is suddenly in front of Bright Moon palace, and *wow* , it looks good. The place had been basically ruined just a couple of days ago

when she was working on it, but now it stands before her, looking as good as new.

"This place looks amazing!" she exclaims.

Glimmer is not doing a very good job of containing her excitement. "I know, right? Come on, let's go inside."

Once again, the trio grasp onto each other's hands and disappear in a purple flash. They reappear in a long hallway on the third floor of the palace.

"Woah-!" Before Adora can even react, Glimmer is pulling her hand down the hallway.

"Right this way, Adora!" she says, as if Adora has a choice in this matter.

"She's going to *love* it!" Bow whispers to Glimmer.

Adora almost runs into Glimmer when she stops abruptly in front of a very heavy looking set of double doors.

Bow and Glimmer stand on each side of the door, grab a knob each, and open it outward.

“After you,” Bow says, bowing politely downward and gesturing Adora into the room.

Adora enters, and is immediately mesmerized.

The opposite wall has another doorway. Two gorgeous layered glass doors stand ajar, revealing a balcony overlooking the huge waterfalls cascading over the towering rock formations in the distance. The balcony features a simple stone fountain in the middle of it, and is surrounded by matching stone walls that are decorated with numerous different potted plants and winding vines.

Lined up on the left wall is what looks like a king sized bed with two pillows. It is flanked by matching nightstands, both of which are complete with lamps. At the foot of the bed is a soft-looking rug, which brings Adora’s attention to the floor. It is made of a beautifully polished maple-colored material that has to be wood.

On the right side of the room are two matching dressers, each with an oval-shaped mirror hanging on the wall above them. To the left of the dressers is a doorway that leads to what looks like a large walk-in closet. To the right of the dressers is another door that leads to a shiny washroom.

“This is *amazing*!” Adora turns around to face Bow and Glimmer, who are both beaming from ear to ear. “That view is spectacular, and the bed looks so *big*!”

“You can go try it out, Adora,” Bow says. “After all, it *is* your room.”

Adora’s eyes widen. She flings herself forward and pulls Bow and Glimmer into a hug. “It’s *perfect* . I love it!”

“It’s the least we could do,” Glimmer says. “Honestly, I don’t really think this room is even fit for the *savior of Etheria* .”

“You guys…” Adora hugs them tighter. “Thank you.”

“Actually, we lied to you. This room isn’t for you,” Bow says suddenly.

Adora pulls away from the hug and cocks an eyebrow in confusion.

Bow continues. “Let me rephrase that. This room isn’t *just* for you. If it was, we would have designed it with only one person in mind.” He smiles at Glimmer.

Adora gasps. “Catra!”

“Come on, Adora,” Bow says. “We couldn’t forget about her! We know how much she means to you.”

“Aw, you guys are so thoughtful!” Adora can feel tears welling up in her eyes as the realization hits her. She is going to *live* with Catra, with the love of her life.

It’s finally *happening* .

“When Catra gets back, you should be the one to show her. I think she will like this room just as much as you do,” Glimmer says. “Anyway, our work here is done, so we will leave you to it. Our room is just down the hall to the right if you need anything. Let’s go, Bow!” With that, they turn and start to leave the room.

Bow skids on his heels and turns around, clapping his hand to his forehead. “Oh, I almost forgot! Adora, take these.”

He reaches into his pocket and pulls out two small, golden keys.

One of the keys features a small, silly engraved image of Adora’s face, and the other Catra’s. Bow dumps them into Adora’s hands.

“There,” he says. “One for you, and one for Catra.”

“Bow, they’re adorable!” Adora pulls him into yet another hug.

"I know, right? It was hard to get the faces right, but I think it's good enough."

"I think you did great. Catra's gonna *love* this!"

"I hope so," Bow smiles, turning towards the door again. "Alright, we're leaving for real this time. See you later!"

Glimmer waves at Adora on her way out of the room. "Have fun, Adora!"

"Thank you, guys! You are the best friends *ever* !" Adora calls after them. She puts the two keys in the pocket of her jacket and wastes no time doing a belly flop onto the bed. It is firm, just as she likes it.

She gets up, runs out to the balcony, and takes in the magnificence of the grand valley below her, which is lit up by the evening sun with a breathtaking golden hue. The breeze is cool, and there is a relaxing rushing sound coming from the massive waterfalls in the distance.

This place is perfect. And Bow and Glimmer had been working on it secretly for the past few days. For her… and for Catra.

Adora wipes a tear from the corner of her eye.

She *could* stay in her new room, but she remembers that Catra is going to be back at camp tonight. She wants to be there with Catra and sleep next to her so she can prevent her nightmares.

Well, *that* , and… for other reasons.

But then, Adora realizes that she doesn't even know where the camp is relative to Bright Moon, or how far away it is. She figures she should find Glimmer and ask her to teleport her back.

As she steps out of her room, she notices another double door a ways down the hallway on the opposite side. She fast-walks over to it and knocks.

After a couple of seconds, Glimmer opens the door and steps out. "Adora! How are you liking the room?"

"Oh, Glimmer, I love it!" That is an understatement, of course. The room is more than she could have ever wanted.

"Great! We figured you would," Glimmer beams.

Bow emerges from the room. “Glimmer and I were so excited to show you. Isn’t the balcony amazing?”

“I *love* the balcony!” Adora exclaims. “That view is the best!”

“When are you going to show Catra?” Bow asks her.

“I’ll show her first thing tomorrow. I would totally stay here tonight, but I need to be back at camp for… something. Glimmer, can you teleport me back real quick?”

“Yeah, sure!” Glimmer offers her hand.

When they arrive back at the camp, Adora gives her friend another hug and bids her farewell, and then heads back to her tent. She peeks in, expecting to find Catra waiting for her inside, but she isn’t there.

She quickly checks the extra tent next door, just in case Catra is using it for some reason, but it is also empty.

Maybe she is still out with Scorpia.

As Adora leaves the extra tent, she spots Perfuma, Seahawk, and Mermista sitting around a nearby fire pit. Seahawk is talking

animatedly to the two princesses.

"...And just when I was about to lose all hope, I saw a seagull perched on the topmost sail to my left." Seahawk points upward, posing theatrically. "At that *exact* moment, I knew that all of my time studying the language of those fabulous feathered friends was not in vain!" he narrates dramatically.

"You have told this story like fifteen times, Seahawk," Mermista says lazily.

Perfuma shifts eagerly forward in her seat and props her chin up on her palm. "I don't think I've heard this one before; what happens next?"

Adora reaches the fire and takes a seat on a log next to Perfuma.

"Oh, hi, Adora!" Perfuma says cheerily. "What are you up to?"

"Hi, Perfuma, have you seen Scorpia?"

"This morning she told me that she was going to the mountains with Catra, and I don't think they've returned yet," Perfuma says.

"...Did she say when she was going to be back?"

“Yeah, I think she said that they were going to be back before sundown.”

Adora’s brow furrows. It is only a few minutes until sundown. Perhaps Catra and Scorpia are running a little late?

*****

Scorpia was right, Catra thinks as she cranes her head upward to fully immerse herself in the incredible sight of vast mountains towering over her. These mountains *are* a sight to behold. Definitely worth the hour-long speeder trip, which mainly consisted of navigating slowly through the winding trees of the Whispering Woods.

Some of the mountains feature impossible rock formations that look like they would collapse at the slightest touch. A few of them have gaps tall enough for even Scorpia to fit under.

“You think we can get onto that peak?” Scorpia asks at one point, pointing to the tallest mountain.

“Pfft. Give me a challenge. That’ll be nothing!” Catra replies confidently.

The climb *isn't* nothing, after all. In fact, it's quite challenging.

Thankfully, however, there was only one mishap, which consisted of Scorpia accidentally stepping between a gap in some rocks and getting her foot stuck. It took a solid couple of minutes of Scorpia trying, and failing, to carefully pull her leg out until she finally gave up and resorted to lifting the large rocks off of her foot with her massive pincers, a method that worked wonderfully, and that she should have used to begin with.

The rest of the climb is accident free, and after a final challenging climb up a steep, boulder-filled path, they reach the small plateau on the peak. Scorpia takes a seat, breathes a sigh, and leans back on her pincers.

"Oh man, what a climb. I am feeling it right now!" she says, letting out a puff of air. "And this *view* , huh? It's like I can see all of Etheria up here!"

"It is a nice view," Catra agrees, and she points over the woods. "Is that the Fright Zone over there?"

Scorpia's eyes widen. "You know, I think it is! *Woah* ! It looks so small from up here!"

"And green," Catra says. "Weird."

"Right? I never thought I'd see trees growing in the Fright Zone, of all places."

That is probably due to the fact that there are no longer thick pollution clouds hanging overhead that block any and all sunlight, Catra reasons.

"Man, what a *dump* that place was," Scorpia says.

"No kidding," Catra grimaces. "I can't believe we once called it home."

Scorpia lets out a deep sigh. "Yeah, it was a pretty lame excuse for a living space if you ask me."

"When we were younger, Adora and I used to talk about our plans for if we ever got the chance to leave."

"Yeah? And what was your grand plan, Wildcat?"

Catra smiles softly. "Well, it was more of a fantasy than anything, but… We wanted to conquer Etheria. That was before we really knew what war was, and what it did to people, though. I think what we *really* wanted to do was just… get out, and take on the world. Walk down our *own* path."

"You know, I actually thought about doing the exact same thing! You know, leaving. Well, I eventually *did* leave, but that was because- well-" Scorpia cuts herself off.

Because I was a monster. The guilt hasn't quite worn off yet, and Catra can't say for sure that it ever will. Thankfully, Scorpia changes the subject with a bright smile.

"So, speaking of Adora, how is she doing? I haven't really seen her after she saved the world and all," she asks.

"Adora's doing great!" Catra replies.

"I'm so glad to hear that!" Scorpia beams.

"But… we've all been pretty busy lately, with repairs and stuff." Catra's ears droop, and her gaze drops to the ground. "I wish I could see her more. I mean, I *do* see her, but I just wanna be… alone more, you know? Just the two of us…" She looks longingly into the distance and hugs her knees. Her tail curls around her ankles.

"You two seem like you're super good friends," Scorpia responds after a moment.

Friends. Maybe Catra and Scorpia aren't on the same page. "Scorpia, I don't think I've told you this, but-"

Scorpia gives her a curious look.

Catra takes a deep breath. "I'm in love with Adora."

That is an extreme understatement, of course, but to be fair, there really aren't any words that can *truly* describe her feelings for Adora.

Scorpia's eyes widen significantly. " *What* ?! You *love* her??"

"Yeah, I do. And I have for a really long time. I- I don't even remember when it started. I guess it was just… something I realized at some point."

Well, maybe Catra *does* remember when she realized she loved Adora. Back when she was much younger, and she had just finished a long, arduous day of training in the Fright Zone, Shadow Weaver was lecturing her over something stupid, as always. And, for some reason, Catra thought it would be a good idea to talk back, perhaps was more fed up with Shadow Weaver than usual and wanted to make her mad, to get under her skin.

But Catra made her a little *too* mad. She wasn't ready for what came next, for such a violent reaction. Shadow Weaver hit her. A lot. And when Catra tried to run away, she was frozen in place by dark magic.

Catra remembered feeling so beat up when Shadow Weaver finally let her go that when she finally reached the barracks, she didn't have the energy to climb up to her bed on the top bunk. Instead, she flopped down at the foot of Adora's bed. She buried her face in the sheets to muffle the sound of her crying. Crying was definitely a sign of weakness, so she couldn't have let anyone know.

Catra jumped at the sound of the door sliding open and forced herself into silence. She tried to pretend to be asleep so that whoever was in the room wouldn't ask questions.

"Catra?"

Catra knew that voice. She raised her head and saw Adora looking down at her.

"Um, what are you doing in my-" Adora cut herself off with a gasp. "A-are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Catra told her.

Adora sat down next to her. "No, you're not."

"Then why'd you *ask* ?"

“I- um…” Adora looked hurt. “I don’t like seeing you like this.”

A warm feeling started to well up inside Catra’s chest. Adora truly sounded like she cared.

“What happened?” Adora’s voice was just louder than a whisper.

“...Shadow Weaver. Again.”

“Oh, Catra…” Adora put her arms around her. “I’m sorry…”

Catra buried her face in Adora’s shoulder. She felt the warmth in her chest spread to her entire body, as far as her fingertips. And, as if it was magic, the pain seemed to fade away. As Adora let go, Catra couldn’t help but smile.

And Adora returned her smile, a warm, kind, and admittedly dorky smile. It gave Catra butterflies in her stomach for some reason. And suddenly, the terrible day she had just endured didn’t seem so bad.

“Hey, wanna have a sleepover tonight?” Adora asked.

"Sure," Catra responded almost immediately.

After that day, Catra and Adora continued to have regular sleepovers. Well, 'sleepovers' in the sense that they would, instead of sleeping five vertical feet from each other in separate beds, they would both share the bottom bunk. Eventually, their sleepovers became such a normal part of their lives that at one point, Catra stopped bothering to ask to sleep in Adora's bed, and would just curl up at the foot of it every night out of habit.

And maybe that day was the one that Catra realized that Adora was someone who was truly special, someone who, unlike anyone else on the planet, could bring out a strange, intense feeling within Catra that she couldn't comprehend.

Or, maybe that's when Catra realized that the intense feeling within her towards Adora, that she now knows was love, powerful, unconditional love, had *always* been there, had always been one with her mind and soul, a fundamental constant through every twist and turn in her life, through everything she had to endure as a child and as a young adult.

And the fact that Adora returns her feelings of love is the best thing in the *world* .

Catra snaps back to reality. *Oh, right. I am talking with Scorpia right now.*

“Anyway-” she continues, hoping she didn’t space out for too long, “I told Adora that I love her. But it was really recent, like on the day that she saved the universe. I probably… should have told her sooner.”

“Wait!” Scorpia leans forward attentively. “Does she love you back?”

Catra smiles contentedly, and a familiar warmth blossoms in her chest. “Yes, she does.”

Scorpia’s jaw drops. “That’s amazing, Catra! I never knew! I am *so* happy for you guys!”

“Thanks, Scorpia.” She is so supportive.

Suddenly, Scorpia gasps and throws her pincers up to her cheeks. “Wait, am I taking away your time with her? Y-you should have told me! I would have cancelled this trip! This was your first free day in a week, and I’m *ruining* it!” She speaks frantically, as if she is blaming herself for something. Catra needs to set this right.

“Hey- Scorpia, listen. You’re not ruining *anything* . I have a whole day next week to be with Adora. Right now, I want to be here with you.”

Scorpia’s eyes sparkle. “You mean it?”

"I mean it."

Scorpia's smile gets somehow broader. "Aw, Catra, thank you! Hanging out with you is so much fun," she says, pulling Catra into a half-hug.

"Any time," Catra replies. Scorpia lets go of her, and they return their gazes to the horizon.

Speaking of Adora… Catra has something in the back of her mind that she just *has* to talk about with somebody, and she hasn't gotten the chance to.

"Hey, Scorpia? This might sound weird, but-" she pauses.

"Hmm? What's up?" Scorpia says curiously.

Catra realizes that putting her thoughts into words is going to be much harder than she anticipated. "When me and Adora are together, I want her to…" She sighs. "Sometimes I wanna feel her touch. Well- w-we do touch, but I mean it's- it's not enough."

Wow , that sounded pathetic. Scorpia is probably going to laugh at her. Catra throws a glance in her direction, and to her surprise,

her friend is not laughing, rather she is wearing a slightly confused expression on her face.

"Why don't you just ask her?" Scorpia asks, making it sound like it is the most obvious thing in the world.

Catra gives her an incredulous look. Is it really that simple? Why *doesn't* she ask? She feels like answering that question is both the easiest and hardest thing to do in the world.

"Scorpia, do you have any idea how weird that sounds?" she settles on saying. Apparently Scorpia doesn't, because her expression is completely serious.

"Hm? What's weird?"

"How am I supposed to ask Adora *that* ??" Catra says in disbelief, throwing her hands outward.

Scorpia puts her pincer on her chin, looking profoundly perplexed. "Uh, I don't know, I figured you could just, you know, go up to her, and tell her what you told me? How would she know what you wanted if you kept *quiet* about it all the time?"

Catra stares at her. That is a very good point. But, *still* …

Scorpia scratches her head. "Um, maybe we're thinking too broadly. What kind of touch-related things do you enjoy? Maybe a back scratch, head rub, or… some kind of massage? Ooh! I give some *mean* massages!" she says, clicking her pincers. "But- that's beside the point."

Catra ponders. What *does* she enjoy? As far as she remembers, there were only a few times that people had touched her in her entire life. There was Shadow Weaver, but Catra prefers not to think about her, for she brings back painful memories. There was Scorpia, but that was a given, considering she had forcefully hugged just about everyone on the planet.

And then there was Adora. She recalls Adora patting her on the head when they were just kids. She doesn't remember why Adora did it, or even where they were at the time, or what they were supposed to be doing. That simple head pat is so vivid in her mind.

"Yeah, I think you're onto something, Scorpia," Catra says. Simply asking Adora to touch her would, for one, just be weird, and two, leave way too much room for interpretation.

Well, not that she'd be *opposed* to the idea of a little creative interpretation…

"Right? I think you can do it, Catra! Here, I'll show you a trick that helps me when I can't work up the courage to do something. Okay, repeat after me: 'I can do this,'" Scorpia chants.

Catra throws back her head in laughter. “Don’t be ridiculous. I don’t need to give myself a pep talk.”

“Yeah, you’re probably right. I think you’ve got this, easy,” Scorpia says reassuringly, and they both fall silent again.

Catra feels a little bit better now that she actually has a plan. How hard can it be? She will just have to ask Adora for something specific. She doesn’t know what it will be yet, as it will probably depend on the situation.

Suddenly, Catra’s heart drops like an anchor. Does she really deserve Adora’s affection after all she had done to her? Is she being too selfish?

Realistically speaking, there is absolutely nothing that Catra has done to deserve any sort of kindness from *anyone* .

Catra is brought back to the present by the sound of Scorpia’s slightly worried voice. “You know, I just realized that we should probably be heading back to camp now. I told Perfuma that I would be back before dark.”

“Before dark?” Catra says, standing up. “We’d better hurry.”

The hike down the mountain is much faster than the climb. When they reach the bottom, they hop on their speeder and set off for the camp. It is almost sundown when they reach the edge of the Whispering Woods. Scorpia suggests that they take a shortcut through the center of the woods, and Catra agrees, for they are cutting it *pretty* close.

*****

Chapter End Notes

I'm still imagining how a massage from Scorpia would feel. Either really awesome or completely terrible. Perhaps possibly lethal...

Anyway. Thanks for reading!

I Could Get Used to This

Chapter Summary

Catra puts Scorpia's advice to use.

Chapter Notes

Hello! I just wanted to take a quick sec to say that I truly appreciate the feedback I've received on this story. I mean, we're only eight chapters in, not even halfway, and it's already gained more traction than I ever imagined it would. So, thanks to everyone who reads, comments, leaves kudos, etc. It's really nice :)

'Nuff of that; enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Adora, it’ll be alright. Just breathe, okay? It really helps,” Perfuma says, placing a gentle hand on Adora’s shoulder.

Adora lets out the puff of air she was holding and allows her shoulders to relax somewhat. “Right. Y-yeah,” she breathes. “Sorry, I don’t know what’s gotten into me.”

“You’re simply worried, my friend!” Seahawk states. “I would be too, if my cardinal companion were lost and alone in the forest!”

“ *Seahawk* !” Perfuma hisses through gritted teeth, and she turns to Adora with a smile. “She’s not lost, Adora. And,” she turns back to Seahawk with an accusatory expression, “she’s not *alone* !”

“My apologies, Perfuma, Adora. I misspoke!”

“Read the room, Seahawk,” Mermista drawls. “Or- the atmosphere, or whatever, since we’re outside…”

“Listen, Adora,” Perfuma continues, facing her again. “Catra is with Scorpia, so even if something was wrong, which it *isn’t* , she’s in good hands. Or- pincers. Not hands.”

Adora manages a smile, and is about to reply when she hears a familiar voice to her right.

“Who’s in good pincers?”

“Catra!” Adora exclaims, standing up immediately.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra says, in that voice she does that’s just Adora’s *favorite* .

“Where’s Scorpia?” Adora asks, scanning the area for her. “Wasn’t she with you?”

“ *Wow* , I see how it is,” Catra teases, strutting forward, her tail flicking back and forth behind her. “Not even a ‘welcome back?’

‘How was your trip?’ *Ouch* , Adora.” She places her hands dramatically on her torso, miming some sort of rib cage injury.

“She was *worried* about you and Scorpia,” Perfuma says sternly, putting her hands on her hips.

“I was just kidding…” Catra says, her ears flattening against her head. “Scorpia went back to her tent. She was looking for you.”

“Really??” Perfuma clasps her hands together and Adora swears she can actively see her eyes sparkling.

“Uh… Yeah?” Catra says, throwing Adora a sideways look.

“Eeeee!” Perfuma squeals, and she strides off without another word.

“What’s with her?” Catra asks Adora, who simply shrugs and turns to Seahawk and Mermista questioningly.

“Oh, it’s nothing, just… Scorpia and Perfuma are *really* close now,” Mermista explains. “Like, I’m pretty sure Perfuma even used the word *'girlfriend'* a couple of times.”

"Really? Good for them," Adora says, and she throws another glance in Catra's direction. Catra has an unreadable expression on her face.

Girlfriend…

"Indeed!!" Seahawk asserts, planting his boot firmly on top of a tree stump and clenching his fist in front of his face. "It is *wonderful* , my dear, isn't it? *Love* ??"

"Ugh, you are *so* sappy," Mermista says, and she interlaces her fingers with Seahawk's, looking dreamily up at his confident countenance.

Adora and Catra exchange awkward looks and kind of back out of the situation before it can get any more *interesting* than it already is.

"Tent?" Catra whispers.

"Yeah," Adora agrees, and they steal away in the direction of their tent.

*****

“So, how was it? Your trip?” Adora asks.

“It was *very* nice,” Catra responds. “The mountains are pretty great. And Scorpia, she talked with me about a lot of stuff, and-”

She can feel her face getting warmer at the thought of her admittedly embarrassing conversation with Scorpia about Adora.

Adora breaks the silence. “Like what?”

“W-well, you know…” Catra lets out a puff of air. “The mountain we climbed was so tall that we could see the Fright Zone from the top. It was *green* , Adora. *Trees* were growing. How weird is that?”

“Trees?” Adora’s eyes widen. “In the *Fright Zone* ?”

“Right?? Scorpia and I couldn’t believe our eyes!”

“It sounds like you two had a blast,” Adora says.

“Yeah, we did. She’s such a good friend.”

A comfortable silence falls between them.

Catra is glad she spent the day with Scorpia. She learned a lot about herself and how to go about asking for Adora's touch. Catra never realized just how much she needed someone to talk with about that. A second opinion *really* does wonders.

Suddenly, Catra feels Adora's hand brush ever so slightly against hers as they are walking. It doesn't seem like an accident, though. It's a request.

As if in a silent agreement, they grasp each other's hands, interlacing their fingers together.

A warm, pleasant tingling sensation runs up Catra's arm. The feeling of Adora's fingers laced between hers is one that is very new to her, and one she doesn't see herself ever growing tired of.

The sun slips below the treeline as they reach their tent and step inside. They stand holding onto each other's hands, not saying anything, just feeling. But after a minute, Adora lets go and slides wordlessly into bed.

Catra feels another sensation run up her arm, but this time it's an uncomfortable cold one, as if the sudden lack of Adora's touch is chilling her entire body. She climbs into bed and buries herself under the blanket, looking to replace the missing warmth.

But of course, a blanket just isn't the same.

"Catra?" Adora asks, and Catra feels her heart leap.

"Yeah?" she responds. Adora's face is red, and she looks like she really wants to say something.

"Um, n-never mind. Good night."

"Wait-!" Catra says, grabbing onto her arm.

Adora looks at her curiously.

Catra freezes up. Isn't she prepared for this moment? Scorpia had made it seem so easy to ask…

She does her best to collect herself, and speaks after a moment.

"Can you… Can you hold my hand again?"

Adora appears to be taken aback by this sudden request. She blinks a couple of times before responding, “did you seriously just ask me to hold your hand?”

Catra’s face flushes. “ *No*- s-shut up!” She turns her head away to hide her embarrassment.

“Hey, I'm just messing with you, dummy,” Adora snickers.

Catra feels Adora’s hand find hers, and their fingers interlock again.

The tingling sensation returns to Catra’s arm as Adora starts to stroke her hand with her thumb. Catra’s embarrassment is replaced by warmth, and she would probably be smiling right now if she wasn’t freaking out over the fact that Adora is holding her hand after Catra *asked her to*.

“Hey, are you going to stay over there *forever* ?” she hears Adora ask.

Catra turns to face her, and is met with that dumb, soft smile that makes her melt inside. She moves herself closer, putting her head right beside Adora’s, on the same pillow as her.

“There, that’s better,” Adora says.

Catra agrees *completely* . Nothing in the world can beat being close to Adora and holding her hand and feeling her warmth.

Well, nothing except being even *closer* to her, but… Catra isn't quite sure she's ready to work up the courage to ask for that much just yet.

"Adora… you jerk," she says, hoping her tone is playful enough to come across as loving. The laugh she hears from Adora following this warms her heart.

"I learn from the best," Adora says.

Well… That isn't exactly *wrong* . Catra had been a terrible person for the longest time, constantly putting down people around her, yelling at them, dehumanizing them. She had gotten really good at it. The fact that she was that way for so long makes her feel disgusting inside.

"Hey, Catra? I'm sorry, that was… I-I didn't mean it in that way," Adora says, as if she just read Catra's mind.

Catra gives her a smile. "Adora, I know you didn't, but I… I'm not proud of my past. I hurt so many people, caused so much pain. If I could just… go *back* , I would change so much. But I can't."

"You… you're not that person anymore, Catra," Adora replies solemnly.

"Yeah, I know…"

But that doesn't make it any less difficult to come to terms with. The only thing Catra can do about it now, and in the future, is show as much kindness as she can to everyone around her, to let them know, no, to *show* them that she has changed for the better through her actions and words.

"Well… Good night, Catra. Sleep well, okay?" Adora says, running her thumb affectionately over Catra's hand again.

"I will, Adora. I will."

There is no doubt in Catra's mind about that.

*****

Another day of reconstruction in the books. Catra is so tired that she feels like she might just fall asleep on the spot if she isn't careful.

Today, they got off early because of how demanding the work was. This is a prime opportunity to spend some time with Adora, but Adora seems to be on the same page as Catra in that they both *really* need a nap.

Catra feels a pang of guilt. She used the entire free day yesterday to spend time with Scorpia, and not Adora. Of course, she's glad she *did* end up hanging out with Scorpia, but still… She should've tried moving their hangout day to next week. She really feels like she hasn't had a chance to be around Adora much at all lately.

"Catra, what's wrong?" The sound of Adora's voice from across the fire pit brings Catra out of her contemplative state.

"Nothing, It's just…" Her ears droop. She sighs and drops her gaze to the ground. "Adora, I feel like I haven't been around you much lately. You know, with

reconstruction and all. And yesterday, we had a free day, but I… Well, I spent it with someone else."

"It's alright, Catra. I *promise* ." Adora assures her, and she moves herself onto the log Catra is sitting on. "And, I feel the same way. I just want this all to be over, and for you and me to…" She pauses, and Catra feels her hand find her knee. She flicks her tail upward to run it along the back of Adora's hand.

"Catra," Adora continues. "I… want to live with you."

Catra feels her heart leap out of her chest at these words. She meets Adora's eyes, and she can feel herself blushing. "You- you do?"

Adora returns her gaze with an incredible intensity. "Yes. Even though the war is over, I still feel *trapped* by it. I… don't wanna be She-Ra anymore. I'd like to just be able to live as myself for once. With… with you!"

Catra feels warmth overcome her entire body. It is truly refreshing to hear Adora talking about what *she* wants for once, and not what other people expect from her. And… What she wants is to *live with Catra*.

Catra's heart flutters. The woman she loves more than anything in the universe wants to *live* with her.

"Adora, I-I wanna live with you as well," she says, almost unable to contain her excitement. "Let's leave this camp when this is all over and- a-and go somewhere together!"

"Yeah, let's do that," Adora says, giving her a warm smile. And in what looks like a subconscious move, she reaches down into the pocket of her jacket, as if she is checking that something is still there. This catches Catra's curiosity.

"What do you have in there?" she asks.

“U-Um… It’s a… It’s nothing. Nothing’s in there,” Adora stutters.

She’s obviously nervous about something. Catra raises an eyebrow to let her know she’s on to her.

Adora gives a little *ahem* before continuing, akin to one let out before a change of subject. “Listen, uh- I’ve been wanting to do this for a while, but-”

“Do what?” Catra asks.

Adora reaches down and her hand finds her belt. She removes the small, golden single-winged pin attached to it. Her face turns red and she holds it outward in the palm of her hand.

“I wanted you to have this, Catra.”

Catra is overflowed with emotion again, and for some reason, she feels tears welling up in her eyes.

“Before I joined the rebellion, I always wore a Horde emblem on my belt,” Adora says. “I replaced it with this pin after I left the Horde, and I’ve worn it every day since. I feel like… I feel like it has become a part of me.” She shifts closer and her hand tightens

on Catra's knee. "I don't know why, but I just… I want you to have it."

Adora's pin. The one that, despite being so small and seemingly insignificant, obviously *really* means a lot to her.

"I… t-thank you, Adora," Catra says, blinking away her tears and accepting the pin.

"It's not much, but…" Adora smiles and chuckles softly. "You know, I never let anyone touch that pin. You're the only other person in the world who has touched it since I've had it."

"R-really?"

"Yes."

"Adora, this means so *much* to me," Catra sniffles. "Thank you. I'm gonna wear it *every* day."

As Catra clips the small golden pin to her own belt, Adora wipes away a tear of her own.

Catra reaches down to grasp her hand. She wants to say something to her, to make her feel good inside. Because Adora

deserves the *world* .

And then, something comes to her, clear as day. It's a phrase she hasn't said since the Heart of Etheria, something that Adora deserves to hear every day.

Perfect. She squeezes Adora's hand tighter.

"Adora, I love you."

To Catra's surprise, Adora's mouth forms into a smirk.

"Come on," Adora says. "I already know that, you dummy."

"Hey, that's my line!" Catra protests, standing and pushing her playfully on the shoulder.

"Are we doing this *again* ?"Adora responds, standing up as well and stretching her arms menacingly.

"I hope you're ready to lose," Catra taunts, her tail flicking back and forth mischievously. "You'd better become She-Ra if you don't wanna eat dirt."

“I’m not going to lose,” Adora assures her, crossing her arms confidently.

“Yeah, we’ll see about that.”

Catra swiftly lunges forward, multiple different plans of attack and corresponding contingency plans playing out in her head simultaneously.

However, her confidence is completely challenged when she notices a bright blue glow in Adora’s eyes.

Is she *actually* going to transform? Catra was *joking* !

Adora takes advantage of Catra’s hesitation. She moves to the side and sweeps Catra’s feet with her leg, knocking her off balance. As Catra is regaining her footing, Adora reaches out and grabs her by the waist, spinning her around and pulling her into her body.

Out of reaction, Catra puts her hands on Adora’s shoulders, ready to push her away, but quickly realizes what is happening. Her eyes go wide as she looks into Adora’s face, into her brilliant steel-blue eyes.

“I think that was a record time,” Adora says smugly.

Wow. Adora is… quite close. Catra feels her face growing hotter by the second.

"No fair, you cheater!" she huffs, hoping that putting up an indignant front will hide her most likely super obvious blush.

"Who said there were any rules?" Adora responds, the corner of her mouth curling into a tenuous smile.

"That's- u-uhm-" Catra falters. At a loss for words, she gives in and wraps her arms above Adora's shoulders, staring into her face as it slowly closes in.

Slowly, but surely.

Slowly…

Suddenly, Glimmer appears out of nowhere in a bright flash beside them. Catra and Adora jump out of their skins, quickly letting go of each other and standing at attention, as if they are still in Fright Zone boot camp, both blushing furiously.

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "Why are you guys so tense?"

Adora and Catra look sideways at each other.

"Well…" Adora trails off.

Catra sighs impatiently. Of course Sparkles just *had* to show up right at this moment and *completely* kill the mood, just when she was about to kiss Adora for the second time ever. She tries not to let her disappointment show on her face.

Glimmer's voice breaks the awkward silence. "Um, are you guys… okay?

"Y-yeah! You just- you *startled* us, that's all," Adora sputters, wringing her hands. "Teleporting. Heh. You know!"

"Right…" Glimmer says skeptically. She doesn't look convinced, but thankfully, she doesn't pry any further. " *Anyway* , Adora, can I talk to you for a second? Um… alone?"

And of *course* Sparkles wants to speak with Adora in private *right this second* . Just *typical* .

"Sure, about what?" Adora asks, looking slightly confused.

"Well…" Glimmer nods her head towards Catra in a *not-while-she's-here* sort of way.

"Alright, I'll just go back to my *tent* ," Catra huffs.

*****

"Were you guys in the middle of something?" Glimmer asks. "Sorry, I didn't mean to interrupt-"

"No, we weren't," Adora says quickly. "W-we were just- um… *ahem* . What did you want to talk about?" She doesn't really have the brain power right now to attempt to explain to Glimmer that she was about to kiss Catra for the second time in history, and that *yes* , Glimmer had *very much* interrupted them. Besides, it would be rude to tell her all of that after agreeing to talk with her.

"Well," Glimmer says. "I just wanted to ask when you were planning on showing Catra the room."

"The room?" Adora wasn't really expecting that. "Oh, well- I was going to, but… Because of reconstruction and all, I just haven't really gotten the opportunity-"

"Can you show her tonight?" Glimmer interrupts. "Like, in three and a half hours?"

“What? Why?” Adora cocks an eyebrow.

“Well,” Glimmer nervously jabs the front of her boot into the ground. “Something important is happening tonight, and well… I-It’ll just make a lot more sense if Catra knows about the room. It’s kind of hard to explain.”

Adora was sorta planning on holding off until after reconstruction to surprise Catra with their new room because it would be kind of pointless to show her a room that they basically can’t even live in yet. It would just be more convenient to stay at camp in order to catch the shuttles in the morning.

However, reconstruction does seem like it is going to be over soon, so maybe it isn't such a bad idea to show Catra tonight. And besides, Adora has been so excited to show her that she isn’t sure that she would’ve been able to wait until after reconstruction *anyway* .

“Alright,” she agrees. “I’ll show Catra tonight. Three and a half hours, you said?”

“Yeah, preferably sometime before seven.”

Adora makes a mental note to set her alarm just in case her nap goes past seven, which very well could happen given how tired

she feels right now.

"Okay, will do," she says.

"Great!" Glimmer beams. "I've gotta go, I've got a lot of stuff to do. See you later!"

"See you!" Adora smiles, and Glimmer teleports away.

*****

"Catra?" Adora's voice sounds from somewhere over by the entrance to the tent. Catra pokes her head out of the blankets she buried herself under.

"Adora," she says flatly. "Hey."

"Hey, I'm sorry about that, I know we were, well… Before Glimmer- *um* ." Adora goes red and drops her gaze. "I-I just finished talking with her."

"It's alright." Catra sits up and gives Adora a warm smile. "What did she say?"

“Well, I… I can’t really tell you.” Adora drops her voice to a whisper and leans in closer. “It’s a surprise.”

This piques Catra’s interest. Her ears perk upwards. “A surprise, huh?”

“Yeah, I’ll show you… later, alright?”

“Okay!” Catra resists the urge to ask ‘why not now?’ She flops back down on the bed and turns up the covers, inviting Adora next to her.

Adora’s face brightens and she slips into bed next to Catra, causing Catra’s heart to jump, as always.

“Hey,” Adora says after a bit. “Do you wanna… hold hands again?”

“Yes,” Catra responds immediately, and her heart starts to race. She is one *hundred* percent fine with this becoming a normal thing between her and Adora. As she reaches over and interlaces her fingers with Adora’s, the wonderful tingling sensation that she loves *so* much, that she just can’t get enough of, travels up her arm and down her entire body.

Adora lets out a sigh of satisfaction. “Good night, Catra. Or- good day? Good afternoon?”

“Adora,” Catra purrs, stroking her hand with her thumb. “I have no idea.”

“Then sleep well, I guess,” Adora chuckles.

There is no doubt in Catra’s mind that she will sleep *wonderfully* .

*****

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter, best dad Micah makes his debut! Yeah!!

Welcome Home

Chapter Summary

Adora surprises Catra and gets surprised in the process.

Chapter Notes

Welcome to another chapter! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"…Catra? It's time to get up."

Catra feels somebody pushing lightly on her shoulder. She opens her eyes to the sight of Adora standing over her, smiling warmly.

"Hey, Adora," she says, returning her smile.

"Good morning- or evening. How was your nap?" Adora tucks a lock of Catra's hair behind her ear.

"Mmm… five more minutes," Catra purrs, closing her eyes and leaning into Adora's hand.

She feels Adora's hand slide gently off her face, stroking along her chin as she goes.

“Alright, I guess this will just have to wait, then…” Adora says with mock-disappointment.

Catra opens her eyes curiously. She catches a glimpse of Adora tucking a small, brown paper bag into her pocket. Is that what she’s talking about?

“Wait, what do you mean?” she asks.

Adora starts towards the tent flaps, waving her hand dismissively.

“Oh, don’t worry. I’ll let you sleep,” she replies, and she steps outside.

“Adora!” Catra calls after her, now wide awake.

Her heart leaps. She springs out of bed and throws open the tent flaps to the sight of Adora greatly exaggerating a yawn.

“ *Alright* , I’m up,” Catra says.

“ *Finally* ,” Adora drawls, turning to face her.

“Um, what is a speeder doing outside our tent?” Catra gestures to the speeder in question, parked mere feet from where they are standing.

“I put it there,” Adora says matter-of-factly, lifting herself on to the speeder. “If you come with me,” she reaches into her pocket, pulls out the small paper bag, and shakes it enticingly, “I’ll show you what’s in here.”

“Deal,” Catra grins, and she hops onto the speeder. “Where are we going?”

“Bright Moon. I have some business to take care of first. I hope you don’t mind.” Adora turns on the speeder and tugs on the steering rod, sending them hovering towards the Whispering Woods.

“What business?” Catra asks.

“Oh, nothing *too* bad,” Adora dismisses. “Don’t worry, I’ll be done in like, five seconds.”

“Alright…?” Catra furrows her brow.

Adora is acting really weird right now. Since when did she have business in Bright Moon? And what is in that paper bag that she has?

Well, there's only one way to find out.

The journey from camp to Bright Moon palace isn't a long one to begin with, but it seems to go by three times as fast for Catra when she's around Adora, talking about everything there is to talk about.

"Remember when you almost crashed a speeder in this forest?" Adora says at one point.

"What?! That wasn't me!" Catra protests.

"Uh, you were the one who was driving," Adora points out.

Catra rolls her eyes. "Yeah, I was *trying* to drive, but then *you* decided to grab on."

" *I* was just trying to make sure you didn't hit a tree."

"Yeah, mission accomplished. Didn't you fall off the speeder right after that? That was *so* graceful," Catra teases.

"Oh yeah. Whoops," Adora chuckles, going slightly red.

“Hey, eyes forward, knucklehead. You’re gonna hit a tree for *real* this time.”

“Uh. Do *you* wanna drive, Catra?”

“Nah, you could use the experience.”

“Are you sure? What if I *crash* ?” With that last word, Adora jostles the steering rod, causing Catra to flail her arms around wildly to maintain her balance.

“Adora, you-!” Catra starts, but she can’t help but break out into laughter following Adora. Her laugh is just too contagious.

As they are giggling stupidly at each other, Adora snorting and pushing Catra on the shoulder, the speeder breaks through the treeline, and the magnificent palace of Bright Moon comes into view, completely grabbing Catra’s attention.

She raises her eyebrows. “Hey, this place doesn’t look half bad, Adora!”

There are few things in this world that she would call ‘pretty,’ but this palace is definitely one of them, especially in the state it is in right now compared to the start of reconstruction.

Adora parks the speeder just outside the double doors of the front entrance and hops off. A small cloud of dust rises from where her boots hit the ground.

"Yeah, everyone did such a great job with repairs," she says, opening the door and offering Catra inside.

"Woah," is all Catra can manage as she steps across the threshold and into the main hall. Between the grand chandeliers hanging from the ceiling and the huge, detailed statues lining the walls, this place looks like something out of a fantasy.

"Alright, let's go!" Adora says excitedly, apparently not interested in the architecture. Without a second of pause, she grabs Catra's hand and tugs her into a stairwell.

"What're you so excited about, Adora?" Catra asks her as they ascend the stairs in a time that *has* to be some sort of record.

"Come on, up here!"

Adora didn't even bother to answer Catra's question. As soon as they reach the third floor, Adora practically kicks the door down and runs out into a long hallway, still grasping Catra's hand.

“Adora-!” Catra starts, but Adora doesn’t seem to be interested in travelling at any speed slower than a sprint.

Suddenly, Adora stops in her tracks in front of a large wooden set of double doors. Catra almost collides with her following this sudden drop in speed.

“Alright. After you, Catra!” Adora steps backwards and beckons Catra forward.

Catra stands in front of the very fancy, heavy-looking doors. She pulls one open, crosses over the threshold, and her eyes widen immediately.

It is the most beautiful room she has ever seen in her life. She never thought she would ever be calling something as simple as a room *beautiful* , but after living in the bare-minimum barracks of the Fright Zone for so long, she just can’t help it. She walks forward slowly, mesmerized by the glass doors on either side of the archway in front of her, the fountain, the breathtaking view…

Catra turns to face Adora when she feels a hand on her shoulder. “Adora, this is-!”

“I believe this is yours,” Adora says, holding out the small paper bag.

Catra's heart leaps, and she accepts the bag. Slowly, she reaches inside and pulls out a small, golden key that is engraved with an amusing depiction of her own face.

"Catra?" Adora says with a warm smile. "Will you live here with me?"

"You-" Catra's eyes widen, and her heart does a full-on backflip. "O-of course! *Yes* !"

Adora steps forward and catches her in a tight hug.

Catra feels completely elated. She puts her arms around Adora and buries her face in her shoulder, her eyes brimming with tears. This is happening for real; they are going to *live* with each other!

Adora lets go of Catra, still grinning from ear to ear. She reaches into her pocket and pulls out a matching key of her own.

"Welcome home, Catra," she says.

"Adora…" Catra runs forward and tugs Adora into another hug, squeezing her tight to her body. "I love you!"

"I love you too," Adora says, running her hand along Catra's back.

“Mmm…” Catra purrs.

“ *Oh* , I almost forgot,” Adora says suddenly, removing herself from the embrace and placing her hands on Catra’s shoulders. “Make sure to thank Bow and Glimmer for this room. “They put it together in secret and completely surprised me with it!”

“They did?”

“Yeah. Aren’t they amazing??”

“Hmm. Since when did they become interior designers?”

“I have no idea,” Adora laughs.

Suddenly, there is a knock on their door. Adora wheels around to open it, and Micah lunges inside, hands on his hips and a scowl on his face.

“Y-your Majesty!” Adora quickly kneels and bows her head.

“What are you two doing here?!” Micah booms. “By order of the King of Bright Moon, I hereby declare that both of you-!”

Catra stares wide-eyed at Micah. What did they do wrong? Did they barge into this room without his permission, or something?

"Shall attend a *mandatory* -" Suddenly, Micah's face softens and his voice drops to a more pleasant volume. "Dinner. With me, tonight."

Adora and Catra are both left thunderstruck.

Micah breaks out into a fit of laughter, clutching at his sides. "Oh, you guys! You should have seen the looks on your faces! They were *priceless* !"

"King Micah-!" Adora starts.

The King waves his hand dismissively. "Oh, drop the petty formalities, Adora. Just call me Micah. And don't worry about kneeling around me, or anything."

"Oh- okay." Adora stands up awkwardly and clasps her hands together.

Catra steps forward. "Um, Your maj- I mean- Micah?"

“Yes, Catra?”

“Are we allowed to- to stay here? In this room?”

Micah raises an eyebrow. “Yes, who else would?”

“Um- I don’t-”

“What’s wrong? Do you not like it? Please, let me know what I can do to-”

“No, it’s not that, it’s just-” Catra pauses. Micah is staring at her with a concerned look on his face. She gives him a smile. “No, I love this room. It’s perfect.”

Micah swoops forward and cups one of Catra’s hands between his. “Catra, I should have been more clear. This room belongs to you and Adora, and nobody else. You can stay here for as long as you like.” He gives her a firm handshake and a satisfied smile. “In any case, I want you girls down in the banquet hall in half an hour! Dress nice; this one is going to be *extravagant* !” he declares, doing an about-face and striding boldly towards the door.

“Micah, wait!” Catra exclaims, extending her arm.

Micah freezes in place and wheels around, a perplexed look on his face.

"Um- thank you. For letting us stay here, Your Highness." Catra kneels down and bows her head in respect.

A wide smile breaks out on Micah's face. "Oh, don't sweat it, Catra. It's the least I could do!" With that, he turns, opens the door, and steps out into the hallway. "Thirty minutes! Dress formally!!"

Adora and Catra exchange looks of excitement.

"Was this part of your plan, Adora?" Catra says.

"No, I had no idea there was gonna be *dinner* tonight! Ooh, I know exactly what I wanna wear!"

Catra smirks as a certain outfit that Adora *really* seemed to enjoy the last time she saw Catra wearing it coming to mind. "Yeah, I think I have a good idea of what I-" She pauses suddenly, her eyes widening as the realization hits her. "Oh no, Adora! I don't have a change of clothes!"

"Um, actually…" Adora moves across the room, stopping in front of the left dresser. "I moved all of your stuff here from the camp." She opens the top drawer, revealing several neatly-folded pairs of

pants. “Are you okay with having the left- *oh* !” She is cut off by Catra catching her in a tight hug.

Catra didn’t even notice that her clothes were gone. Did Adora move them earlier while she was asleep? In any case, that was so *thoughtful* of her.

“You really thought of everything, Adora. Thank you,” she says.

“No problem, Catra,” Adora replies. “I’m glad you’re here.”

“I wouldn’t wanna be anywhere else in the *world* .”

After a while, Adora pulls away from Catra’s hug. “We really need to start getting ready,” she says. “Come on, lemme show you the closet. It’s huge!”

Catra follows Adora into the *very* spacious closet. It has plenty of clothing racks, so many that they will probably never manage to fill them all, and a tall full-body mirror in the corner.

Adora picks a scarlet dress from one of the many racks. She turns to Catra, crossing one leg over the other and holding the dress up to her chest. “Remember when I wore this at Princess Prom?”

“Yeah, I do. You should wear it again; it looks good on you,” Catra says. Memories flood through her mind. Princess Prom was so long ago, but she remembers it like it was yesterday. It was one of the few times in her life that she had managed to have fun, even if she was only there to crash the party. She feels a pang of guilt.

“What were you wearing that night, anyway? Wasn’t it a suit?” Adora says pensively, finding her bottom lip with the tip of her index finger.

“I think so,” Catra replies. She turns to face the vast rack of clothing in front of her. She flicks through the various tops (since when did she own so much clothing?), pausing when she sees the dark, purple-red coat and matching shirt. She pulls both of them off the rack.

“Yeah, that’s it!” Adora says, her eyes sparkling.

“I remember this thing. Lots of memories, huh…” Catra’s ears droop.

Adora quickly changes the subject. “H-here, let’s get changed. We’re gonna be late.”

Catra opens her mouth to respond, but immediately forgets what she was going to say as Adora turns around, unclips her belt, shrugs off her jacket, and pulls off her top, revealing the back

strap of her bra. Catra finds herself unable to pull her gaze away from the prominent definition in Adora's arms and shoulders, the striations in her back, and-

Her scars. Catra gasps and drops her suit.

"Catra?" Adora spins around. "What's wrong?"

"You- your scars- I-" Catra swallows dryly.

"What? What are you talking about?"

"Your *back* , it's-"

"My back?" Adora says, sounding genuinely confused. She steps in front of the mirror, turning her head to look over her shoulder. Her eyes widen as they find five long, thin streaks spanning diagonally downward across her shoulder blades. "Huh. I never noticed those…"

Catra drops her head and stares at the floor. There is no doubt in her mind that those five marks were made by her hand. And that isn't the only thing she has done to Adora. Catra has hurt her in so many ways, both physically and emotionally, too many ways to count.

In the back of her mind, Catra hears a voice.

You don't deserve her affection.

"H-hey, Catra?" Adora says worriedly.

"Adora… I'm sorry."

"It's alright!" Adora gives her an encouraging smile. "I think these are from when you were chip- *uhm* . Y-you didn't mean it. You weren't yourself. Besides, I think scars are *cool* !"

"No…" Catra says, meeting Adora's eyes. "I'm sorry… for *everything* ."

Adora's eyebrows raise. "Catra…" she whispers. "I'm sorry too."

"W-what?"

Adora's shoulders droop. "I *never* should have left you. I caused you so much pain…"

“Adora, you didn’t leave me, you left the *Horde* !” Catra says defiantly. “I- I should have gone with you! It’s all my fault!” Her voice breaks and she drops to the ground and slumps over her knees.

“Catra?” Adora breathes, walking forward carefully.

“I’m sorry, I’m *so* sorry, I really- I…” Catra raises her head and sees Adora standing over her, offering a hand. She takes it and slowly stands up.

“Hey, listen,” Adora says. “This goes both ways. I hurt you in the past as well. But, we *have* to be willing to accept each other as who we are right now, not who we once were. People change, Catra. Remember?”

Catra nods solemnly and drops her head.

Adora puts a hand on her cheek, raising her head back upward, and gives her a warm smile. “Will you walk forward with me, Catra? Into the future?”

Catra sniffles back a tear and stands up to wrap her arms around Adora, burying her face in her shoulder.

“I’ll take that as a yes,” Adora says, holding the back of Catra’s head tight to her body. “I love you, Catra. Don’t ever forget it.”

Catra won't forget it. *Ever.*

"I love you too, Adora," she replies. "So *much* ."

Adora is right. If Catra spends all of her time dwelling on the past, it will make for a miserable existence. Adora is willing to accept her into her life, even after all she did. Not only that, but she loves her, and wants to *live* with her.

And that's because Catra has changed for the better.

A warm feeling fills Catra's body, and she can't help but smile as she pulls away from the embrace.

Suddenly, she notices, because she somehow *forgot* , that Adora is standing there in nothing but her underwear, and *wow* , she is breathtaking. Her entire body is toned, and she is compellingly curved in all of the right places. Catra gives herself a mental slap and tears her gaze away.

"Oh, s-sorry. This is… awkward," Adora blushes.

"No, it's *not*- It's- I mean-" Catra's tail flicks wildly around behind her as she steals another glance at Adora. "It's fine," she finally says, regaining her ability to speak.

“Are you sure?” Adora asks.

Catra stares. Of course it’s fine. It is actually a lot *more* than fine. She undoes her top, pulls it over her head, and steps out of her leggings.

“Yes, Adora,” she says. “I’m *sure* .”

Adora’s eyes widen, seemingly involuntarily, and her mouth opens slightly. Catra is completely aware that her own body has changed, and that Adora is, judging by her expression, probably pretty stoked about it.

In the week-and-a-half or so since the defeat of Horde Prime and the end of the war, Catra has noticed that, despite still retaining her slender body type, she has filled out more; her arms and shoulders are noticeably bigger, her legs are more defined, she’s a bit taller (not as tall as Adora yet, but that might never happen), and she just feels more *whole* . Between consistent days of intensive reconstruction work and an actually reasonable diet that doesn’t just consist of nutritionally deficient ration bars, there’s no wonder she’s made such progress. Catra has found herself loving her own body more and more each day. And, apparently, Adora does too, which is a *very* nice feeling.

Even still, that doesn’t stop her from blushing *completely* from head to toe when she’s standing in front of Adora and they are both wearing almost nothing.

“Um, we should probably be getting ready,” Catra suggests, and Adora’s trance is lifted.

“R-right, yeah…” she gulps, dropping her gaze and picking up the dress at her feet.

Catra shrugs on her undershirt and steps into her slacks, which she notices are slightly tighter around her thighs than they were the last time she wore them, no doubt a result of the muscle she’s gained.

She throws her bowtie around her collar. Adora has already pulled on her dress, which of course, she looks absolutely *stunning* in. The way it shows off her arms, the way it perfectly hugs her curved frame, the way the scarlet hue of the dress somehow makes her bright eyes shine even more-

“Any day now, Catra,” Adora teases. Because she has finished dressing, she is just standing there, watching Catra smugly with her hands on her hips.

Catra huffs indignantly. “My outfit is like 300 pieces. Gimme a second.” She tugs a belt around her slacks and buckles it into place. She reaches down for her coat, and almost starts to put her arm through the sleeve, but pauses when she notices that Adora is standing right in front of her. Catra rises slowly to match her gaze.

“Here, lemme get this,” Adora says softly, reaching down and slowly buttoning the lowest button on Catra’s undershirt.

Her hands travel delicately upward, brushing softly against Catra’s body as she moves. Catra watches her in silence, wonderful chills surging through her body with every gentle movement Adora makes, until Adora passes over her chest and reaches the last button.

“You like to keep this one unbuttoned, right?” Adora says, *way* too nonchalantly given the current situation.

Catra swallows. “Yeah.”

Adora gently straightens the collar of Catra’s shirt and grasps her unfastened bow tie.

“And this…” she purrs, looking up to meet Catra’s eyes. “Stays just like that."

Catra’s chest starts to heat up. Adora’s brilliant steel-blue eyes are now inches away from her own. She feels a gentle tug on her bow tie; Adora is pulling them closer together, pulling her closer to her face-

Suddenly, there is a loud knocking sound on the door, startling them both.

Catra frantically throws on her coat. Adora fast-walks out of the closet and over to the door. Upon opening it, she sees Micah standing outside. He is wearing a charming dark-grey suit with a light blue undershirt and a matching striped royal blue tie. A small handkerchief pokes out of his chest pocket.

“Adora, dinner is about to start. I know I gave you two a very short notice, but please hurry. Everyone is waiting,” the King says.

Adora’s eyebrows arch. “Everyone? Who’s here?”

“Oh, you know. Just a couple of friends.” Micah winks at her. “By the way, Adora, you look very nice! Red suits you well.”

“Oh- thanks! You look nice as well,” Adora says. “Um- we just finished getting ready. We’ll be down in a few.”

Micah gave her a thumbs-up and a bright smile. “Awesome. Gotta go!” He turns and fast-walks away.

Adora closes the door and turns around. Catra is carefully rolling up her cuffs in front of a mirror. “Catra, you ready?”

Catra turns to face her and holds up a pair of fingerless gloves. “Hey, do you think I should wear these again?”

Adora shrugs. “Yeah, why not?”

Catra crosses the room towards her. “Well, you know, I figured that-” she reaches down and grasps Adora’s hand, interlocking their fingers together, “I’d just be better off without them.”

“Yeah, good call.” Adora smiles and strokes Catra’s thumb.

“Alright. Let’s go,” Catra says excitedly.

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Chapter End Notes

I wish we got to see more of Micah in the show :(He was one of my favorites, and I feel as though his screentime was severely limited in S5 (referring to non-chipped Micah ofc). Good thing he appears a lot in this fic! Yeah!!

Second Dance

Chapter Summary

Micah hosts a dance.

Chapter Notes

This chapter is absolutely ginormous; the longest yet

Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Oh man, this is going to be pretty hard, with my pincers, and all," Scorpia says, looking down apprehensively at her tiny silverware.

"I'm sure you'll get the hang of it, dear!" Perfuma says encouragingly, placing a hand on Scorpia's arm.

"Yeah, you're right!" Scorpia replies, smiling brightly at her. "This'll be *nothing* !"

"Perfuma, I love your dress!" Glimmer compliments, smiling at the flower princess from further down the table.

"Oh, thanks!" Perfuma beams happily.

"And yours too, Scorpia!" Bow claps his hands to the sides of his face. "Aw, you guys are so *cute* in matching outfits!"

Scorpia puts a pincer behind her head, blushing. “Thanks, Bow. You know, at first, I wasn’t so sure about the color green. I’m more of a *red* type of person. But, I really think it’s growing on me.”

“Yeah, green’s totally like *my* color, but I have to say; you’re really pulling it off,” Mermista says. “You make me proud.”

“Well spoken, my dear,” Seahawk agrees. “As you well know, I have quite the eye for beauty myself, and I can assure you that those outfits are simply perfect!”

Micah bursts through the doors at the end of the hall, drawing everyone’s attention. “Good news, everybody! Dinner will be commencing shortly. We’re still waiting on two more, but they should be down here in a heartbeat.” He walks the length of the long rectangular table, sitting down in the fancy chair furthest from the door.

“Dad! You didn’t tell them about the dance, did you?” Glimmer asks.

“Nope! Don’t worry though, I made sure that they dressed for the occasion,” Micah says proudly.

Bow rubs his hands together excitedly. “Ooh, I can’t wait!”

The doors at the end of the hall open again, and this time Adora and Catra step in.

"We're here, your maj-!" Adora starts, but then her eyes widen. Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, Perfuma, Seahawk, Mermista, and Frosta are all sitting at the table with Micah, beaming broadly at her and Catra.

"Adora! Catra! Come sit down; I saved you guys seats!" Glimmer beckons to the two chairs across from where she and Bow were sitting.

"Is *this* why you wanted me to show Catra the room so badly?" Adora says indignantly as she sits down in her chair. "I was *going* to, you know!"

"I had to get you over here *somehow* , Adora," Glimmer responds. "And I figured that was the best way to do it without outright telling you there was going to be dinner."

"You made me wake Catra up."

Glimmer raises her eyebrows. "Oh, s-sorry, Catra, I-"

“It’s fine,” Catra responds. Being woken up to Adora’s gentle touch is *definitely* not something she can complain about. Especially when the reason is a grand feast like this. She eyes the various heaping dishes of food in front of her. “This looks… appetizing.”

Micah stands up, his powerful voice commanding the attention of the room. “Alright everybody, now that every guest is present and accounted for, I believe it is time to… *not* dig in just yet. I have a couple of words to say. Firstly, I would like to thank all of you for your hard work during reconstruction. The progress that we’ve made is incredible! And that is why I would like to inform every person in this room that you are no longer required to attend reconstruction, effective immediately. We have more than enough personnel to-”

Micah’s voice is drowned out by cheers from everyone else in the room.

Catra’s heart leaps. She won’t have to wait until next week to have a free day with Adora! She’ll have one *tomorrow* ! And the day after, and for the rest of the week, and the rest of the *month* -

“Yes, I know, I know,” Micah continues. “Wonderful, right? I just figured, since all of you were heavily involved in the war effort, that you should be let off the ol’ reconstruction hook a little early. Now, with that being said, I would like to invite you all to commence consumption, because you *deserve it* !”

“Yes!” Frosta says happily. “Dibs on the pudding!”

“Now Frosta, make sure you eat some vegetables first,” Micah says while he sits down.

Frosta scoffs. “Yeah, okay *dad* .”

Catra doesn’t know where to start; everything looks so delicious. She ends up piling a little bit of everything onto her plate.

“So… good!” Bow gushes through a mouthful of mashed potatoes.

“Bow, manners!” Glimmer scolds.

“Sorry!”

Glimmer opens her mouth to say something in response, but is distracted by King Micah, who had just stood up again. He readies himself with a wide stance, throws a grape into the air, and catches it spectacularly in his mouth. Perfuma, Scorpia, and Frosta cheer and clap enthusiastically as he takes a theatrical bow.

“Wonderful! A perfect ten!” Seahawk exclaimes, pumping his fist into the air.

“Thank you, thank you!” Micah says, sitting back down.

“Yeah, Sparkles? I think ‘manners’ are out of the window on this one,” Catra snickers.

“Ugh. *Dad…* ” Glimmer puts her palm on her forehead out of embarrassment.

Adora, Catra, and Bow burst into laughter, and a red-faced Glimmer can’t help but join them.

“Oh, man. We should have dinner like this every night,” Bow says, and he takes another bite.

“Yeah, that’d be nice,” Glimmer agrees. “But sadly, not every night is a special occasion.”

Adora puts down her cup. “Wait, Glimmer, what even *is* the occasion? Is it a festival, or something?”

“No, Adora, there is nothing special about today. My dad just wanted to host a dinner out of *nowhere* for all of us as a thank you for our help during reconstruction. Honestly, though? I’m not complaining.”

“That sounds… like Micah,” Adora chuckles. “Why so *fancy* , though?” She pinches the fabric of her dress.

“Oh, um…” Glimmer looks flustered for a split second. “W-well, it’s not every day you get to pull out the ol’ formal wear, is it?”

“That is true,” Catra reasons. “It’s a bit excessive, but I don’t mind.”

“I don’t know, Catra. I could get used to this!” Bow breaks into a pompous smile and perks up his bowtie. “Bowtie Bow is always ready to go!”

“Oh, Bow. You dolt,” Glimmer laughs, nudging him with her elbow.

“Yeah,” Adora says. Under the table, Catra feels a hand rest on her knee. Their eyes meet. “I could get used to this, too.”

“Ugh. You’re worthless, Adora,” Catra teases.

“ *I’m* worthless?” Adora protests. “Uh, which one of us was dressed and ready to go first? Oh yeah. Me.”

“I wasn’t aware that it was a competition,” Catra retorts.

“Really?” Adora smirks. “For you, that should be common sense.”

“Alright, fine, I’ll give you this one. I can afford to, considering you’re about a hundred points behind.”

“Pfft, yeah *right* .” Adora takes a swig of water. Under the table, Catra takes her hand, interlocks their fingers together, and starts to stroke her palm.

But before she can respond, the door is thrown open and the room goes silent. Wrong Hordak and another clone step in, both dressed in all white. Wrong Hordak has an apron over his front and a chef’s hat perched on his head. On the palm of his hand, he is balancing a large platter full of a variety of pitchers and glass bottles.

“Good evening, all!” he says brightly, crossing the room with several lunge-like strides. “I come bearing refills!”

Adora and Catra stare awe-struck at Wrong Hordak as he places the platter down expertly on the corner of the table. The other clone takes a spot in the corner of the room, standing completely still, a handkerchief draped over one of his wrists in front of his body.

“For you, miss?” Wrong Hordak says to Mermista, whipping a small notepad and pencil out of his back pocket.

“Ooh, what’s that bubbly green one?” Mermista asks, pointing at a pitcher on the platter.

“This is a simple carbonated beverage infused with a hint of lime,” Wrong Hordak explains, holding up the beverage in question. “You can refer to this page-” he puts the pitcher down and flicks to the next page in his notepad, “-if you would like a list of all beverages that are currently available.”

“Uhhhh… I’ll just take some of the lime stuff,” Mermista says.

“Lime stuff it is, then!” Wrong Hordak winks enthusiastically, and he turns back to the previous page in his notepad, scribbling something down. When he is done, he moves on to Bow.

“Wrong Hordak has become quite the chef,” Glimmer explains to a wide-eyed Adora. “He loves cooking for other people. He’s so good at it that my dad appointed him as the executive chef of Bright Moon’s kitchen!”

“Woah, that’s impressive,” Adora says.

Glimmer takes the notepad that Wrong Hordak had just offered her. “Hmm… I’ll take some lemonade,” she says, and Wrong

Hordak jots that down and continues moving along the table.

"Lemonade? What's that?" Adora asks.

Glimmer actually gasps. " *What* ? You've never had lemonade? Adora, you have to try it!"

"Why, what's so good about it?"

"I've never had it either," Catra says. Whatever it is, it sounds… interesting. "I'll try it if you do, Adora." She squeezes Adora's hand under the table.

Adora meets Catra's eyes and with a determined smile. "Alright, let's do it."

"For you, miss?" Wrong Hordak queries, suddenly appearing beside Adora.

"Oh- um, her and I are both going to have the lemonade."

"Oh my, that particular beverage is quite popular tonight! Good thing; it's custom-made! By *me* !" Wrong Hordak chortles heartily and slides over to Seahawk, who is the last one to take a drink order from.

“I think I will have…” Seahawk squints at the paper. “But of course. The Ginger Ale!!” he announces dramatically, throwing his pointer finger in the air.

“Wonderful!” Wrong Hordak cheers, clapping his hands together. “I will get to it right away!” He swiftly produces nine cups, fills them with incredible speed, and moves energetically around the room as he passes them out. “Lemonades for you two, and… Finally, the Ginger Ale! Wonderful. Enjoy, everybody!”

Wrong Hordak winks, throws up a peace sign, and exits the room, followed closely by the assistant clone.

After a moment of awkward silence, Seahawk raises his glass. “To adventure!!”

Micah follows suit, suggesting a toast of his own. “To an era of prosperity!”

“To Adora and Catra, newest residents of Bright Moon!” Glimmer says.

“Yeah, what she said!” Bow agrees, and he takes a large gulp of his drink.

“After you, Adora,” Catra offers. She wants to see Adora’s reaction first.

“What, are you scared to try it?” Adora says confidently, clinking her glass against Catra’s. She takes a sip of lemonade and almost spits it out. With what appears to be great difficulty, she manages to get it down, her face contorted in disgust. “Eeeughh! What *is* that?”

“Is it really *that* bad?” Catra asks, going for a cautious sip. But the second the liquid touches her lips, she raises her eyebrows in delight. “Mm! Not bad, Sparkles. Not bad at all.”

“You *like* it?!” Adora exclaims, staring at Catra in disbelief.

“How do you *not* like it?” Glimmer says, taking a drink of her own.

Adora sets her glass down and visibly shudders. “This might be the worst thing I’ve ever tasted in my entire life.” She washes out her mouth with a large gulp of water. “ *Ew* , I can still taste it!”

“So… I assume you’re not gonna finish, then?” Catra says, eying Adora’s glass.

“Yeah, I don’t think so.” Adora slides her drink over to Catra. “It’s all yours.”

“I think you’ve found my new favorite drink, Sparkles,” Catra says, taking another sip.

“Good!” Glimmer beams. “I’m glad at least *one* of you liked it!”

“You guys are crazy,” Adora says, shaking her head.

“Maybe you’re the crazy one, Adora,” Glimmer smirks. “Even *Bow* likes it.”

Bow, who is busy drinking deeply from his glass, raises his eyebrows. “Woah, woah. Hold on, Glimmer. I’ll have you know, my palette is *quite* refined.” He straightens his bowtie yet again.

“Okay, Mister Mashed Potatoes,” Glimmer teases.

Micah stands up to clear his throat, and once again the room falls silent. “Alright, everybody. Now that we’re all well fed, I believe it is time for tonight’s special occasion. For all who wish to participate, start heading to the ballroom. This will be a night to remember!” He meets eyes with Catra, and Catra swears she sees him give her a wink.

...What?

“What’s the ‘special occasion?’” Adora asks, getting up from her chair and following Bow and Glimmer as everyone shuffles out of the banquet hall.

“I don’t know, probably some stupid ceremony,” Catra replies, the image of Micah’s wink still clearly vivid in her mind. “If so, wake me up when it’s over.” She fakes a yawn.

Adora takes Catra’s hand. “Maybe it’s… Micah’s birthday today, or something?”

“Why would that matter?” Catra raises an eyebrow. What does someone’s birth date have to do with any of this?

“Glimmer told me that people all around Etheria celebrate each year on the day that they were born,” Adora explains. “Apparently it’s a pretty big deal.”

“Why?”

“I don’t know, it seems weird to celebrate over something small like that.”

“Yeah, it does.”

“Well, I don’t see anyone carrying around gifts, or anything,” Adora reasons.

“And… What would that mean?”

“Oh, yeah. Part of the tradition is giving a gift to the person who is having the birthday.”

“That’s… interesting,” Catra says. “Hey, um, unrelated, but… Can you give me a moment? I wanna ask Micah something.”

She doesn’t know exactly *what* she wants to ask, or what she wants to say. She just feels like she needs to talk to Micah.

“Sure!” Adora replies brightly. “What for?”

“Well…” Catra furrows her brow. “I don’t really know.”

“Okay. I’ll wait for you!” With that, Adora gives Catra a wave and turns around to continue down the hallway.

Catra feels warmth towards Adora for not prying any further, for simply agreeing without hesitation, for understanding what Catra

needed.

Catra turns on her heel and heads back into the banquet hall.

Micah raises his head at Catra's entrance and stops writing whatever he is writing. "Catra! You're missing all of the fun!" he says, extending his hands palm-up in her direction.

"King Micah," Catra replies, bowing her head before moving closer. "I needed to ask you something."

"Sure! Hit me!" Micah puts his writing utensil behind his ear and laces his fingers together on the table in front of him. He's… giving Catra his undivided attention.

For *what* ? Why does *she* deserve this?

"Why am I here?" Catra blurts, her words coming out before she really thinks about them.

Micah raises his eyebrows, looking taken aback. Of course he would. What Catra just said was completely out of nowhere.

"I mean… Why was I invited?" Catra clarifies, and against her better judgement, she asks her burning question. She *needs* to

know, though. “Why are you being so nice to me? I’m… I was a Horde soldier.”

Is it because she knows Glimmer? Is it because Micah didn’t *know* she used to be a Horde soldier? He was confined to Beast Island for the majority of the war, so maybe he just-

“I know you were,” Micah says matter-of-factly. “But you aren’t anymore, right?”

Catra’s breathing picks up. “I… I did *terrible* things! I-I was-”

“Catra, let me ask you something,” Micah interrupts firmly. “Are you planning to cause harm to the people of this kingdom any time in the future?”

Catra swallows. “N-no.”

“Well, there you go!” Micah smiles, as if that settles everything. How… Is it really that easy? How can he accept the word of an ex-Horde soldier so *readily* ? “I’m being nice to you because I like you,” he continues. “You’re part of the *family* now.”

Catra actually takes a step backward.

...The *family…*

"I need to go," she says, her brain and body working on autopilot. Without even waiting for a response, she turns to fast-walk away, out of the Banquet Hall, away from what she can't understand.

She picks up her pace without even realizing it. Was that worth it? Did she get the answers to the questions that have been sitting dormant in the back of her mind since the end of the war?

She doesn't even know what she's running from anymore, she just can't *understand-*

"Catra! Hey!" The sound of Adora's voice brings Catra to her senses. It calms her down almost instantly, like a *miracle* . She lets out the breath she was holding and feels the tension in her body evaporate.

"Hey," she says, giving Adora a warm smile and taking her hand again.

"You ready?" Adora asks, nodding her head towards the entrance to the ballroom.

"You bet," Catra replies, and she leads the way inside.

She can mull over what Micah said to her later. But for now, she'll just…

Catra shakes her head and enters the ballroom.

Immediately, she is met with the sight of what has to be over 100 people scattered throughout the room, dancing and mingling together. A string quartet is playing in the corner, and on the opposite wall is a table full of various snacks and refreshments.

"This is…" Catra says, and she raises her eyebrows, at a loss for words. Her heart starts thumping with excitement. This is… a *dance* !

Looking around, she spots Entrapta, Hordak (who invited *him* ?), Netossa, Spinarella, Castaspella, and many other familiar faces in the crowd.

"Wow!" Adora breathes, and she turns to face Bow and Glimmer, who must have been waiting at the entrance for Catra and Adora's arrival. "Glimmer, you didn't tell me there was gonna be a *dance* !"

"Sorry Adora. I wanted it to be a surprise," Glimmer says. "Care for a dance?" She extends her hand.

Adora looks over at Catra, who gives her a nod of encouragement.

“Go ahead, Adora. I’ll catch up with you later,” Catra says, and she watches as Adora gives her a smile, takes Glimmer’s hand, and disappears into the crowd.

“So, Catra, what do you think?” Bow asks.

“I was *definitely* not expecting this,” Catra replies, smiling.

“Yeah, I really wasn’t either. Micah really outdid himself this time.”

“You can say that again.” All of this… for them. And for Catra.

“So, do you… wanna dance?” Bow asks, and he offers his arm.

“Yeah, sure,” Catra says. It will probably be a good idea to re-acquaint herself with dancing before trying it with Adora, anyway, so she doesn’t make a fool of herself. She feels her heart rate increase at the thought of holding on to Adora, swaying softly to a slow melody, lost in her arms, melting in her embrace.

“Great, let’s go!” Bow smiles.

Catra takes his arm and he leads the way towards the dance floor. The string quartet is playing a medium waltz.

"Okay, you know how to do three step, right?" Bow asks.

"Yeah. Believe it or not, I'm actually pretty good at this," Catra says proudly. She takes Bow's hand in hers and places the other behind his back.

"Woah," Bow says, putting a hand on her waist. "Where'd you learn to dance?"

Back in the Horde, Shadow Weaver loved making Catra do menial grunt work, and one day, she had her on trash duty (even though it was *definitely* Kyle's day to do it, but whatever). Catra had no choice but to oblige; disobeying Shadow Weaver, though fun to do sometimes, always ended up being way more trouble than it was worth. When she arrived at the trash bins, however, there was something that caught her eye. A book, perhaps one from the library? It looked like somebody had tried to throw it away, but didn't care enough to bother making it in the bin.

Catra never really liked reading, but the cover of this particular volume caught her eye. Upon opening it, she discovered why it was cast aside as trash. Why would anybody in the Horde ever need to know about *dancing* ?

Apparently, dancing was something that two people could do together, and it looked like it involved a lot of physical contact. Naturally, this grabbed her attention, as 'physical contact' with Adora really only happened when they were sparring and play-fighting. She took the book, hid it under her shirt, and stashed it in a ceiling vent in a room next to the barracks.

She remembers stealing away to that room and retrieving the book on multiple different occasions. Thankfully, that room wasn't used very often, so Catra would, nine times out of ten, have the space to herself. She would carefully read through the directions, studying the diagrams and practicing by herself when nobody was around to see, all in preparation for the day that she would take Adora's hand, look into her eyes, and ask her to dance.

Of course, that day never came. The Horde wasn't concerned with such trivialities (which was probably why the book was thrown away in the first place), and kept them busy, focusing instead on raising them to be soldiers in a war they barely knew a thing about. As Catra grew up, she started losing hope that the opportunity to dance with Adora would ever arise, but she kept what she had learned from the book in the back of her mind, just in case.

"Um… am I making you uncomfortable?" Bow says.

Catra snaps back to the present. "Oh- um… no. I-It's not you. I was just thinking about… the past." She feels her face growing warm at the ridiculous memory of dancing alone in that extra room, desperately preparing for a day that, in the back of her mind, she knew would never arrive. Anyway. "To answer your question, I actually taught myself how to dance."

“Woah, really?” Bow says, clearly impressed. “You’re good!”

“Thanks Bow, but I’m not as good as you.”

“Well, for someone of your backgr- I- I mean-” Bow gulps.

Catra gives him a smile, lightening the mood. “I know. You wouldn’t think an ex-Horde soldier would know how to dance at all.”

“Yeah, it’s pretty surprising,” Bow says, returning her smile.

The string quartet finishes playing the waltz piece and moves on to a lively four-beat rondo. Bow and Catra seamlessly change their step pattern to match.

“So, where did you learn to dance, Bow?” Catra asks.

“Glimmer taught me. She was probably required to know how, given that she was royalty, and all. I thought it was the most useless thing in the world at first, but eventually, I started to really enjoy it. It came in handy because she would always invite me to Bright Moon’s festivals and stuff, and we’d have to dance there.”

“That sounds like fun,” Catra says. Adora must’ve learned how to dance from Bow and Glimmer. At Princess Prom, she was surprisingly good, and there was no way she learned in the Horde, because Catra never showed anybody the book about dancing, not even her.

“It was always a blast. Glimmer and I would always teleport to the top of the palace after festivals and hang out up there, away from everyone else. It was like our own little secret.” Bow’s face forms into a nostalgic smile. “If I stayed for too long, though, my dads would start to worry, so I’d have to leave before it got too late. Honestly, I could have stayed up there with Glimmer *forever* .”

“I know the feeling,” Catra says, a particular set of steel-blue eyes popping into her head. “You guys are pretty close.”

“Yeah. We always have been.”

“How long have you known her?”

“Oh, forever. Ever since we were kids. Like you and Adora!”

Catra gives him a smile.

“You know Catra, Adora *really* likes you,” Bow says. “It’s actually pretty funny. Sometimes I feel like you’re all she can talk about these days.”

“R-really?” Catra’s heart leaps.

“Yeah! She’s told me… a *lot* about you. I uh… *may* or may not know your favorite color, which nicknames you two used to call each other when you were younger, the way that you would- *ahem* . Never mind. Sorry, I’ll stop,” Bow says, apparently noticing the embarrassed look on Catra’s face.

“Oh, it’s fine,” Catra assures him. “But, now that you know my secrets,” Catra takes her hand off Bow’s back and extends her claws menacingly, “I’ll have to kill you.”

“Oh *no* , is this how I meet my end??” Bow places the back of his hand on his forehead dramatically. “Please, make it quick!”

“Bow. I can’t do it in front of all of these people,” Catra laughs.

“Thank goodness, I’m saved!”

Catra returns her hand to Bow’s back and gives him a smile. “Don’t push your luck.”

"Well, in any case, I guess what I'm trying to say is… Adora's kind of crazy about you."

"Yeah; I'm also crazy about her," Catra admits. "And- sometimes, I-I just don't feel like I'm *enough* . I want to be perfect for her. She deserves the world, and… w-what if I'm not good for her?"

Bow stops dancing and places his hand firmly on Catra's shoulder.

"Catra. Let me tell you something," he says. "Glimmer means so much to me. I love her with *all* of my heart. Sure, she messes up sometimes, and I get upset with her, but that doesn't mean that I will *ever* love her any less. Nobody's perfect. Not me, not you, not Adora. But… that's fine, because we're *Etherian* . Imagine how boring the world would be if everyone was completely perfect and never made any mistakes! I think that our ability to learn and *grow* from mistakes is the reason we're all so unique."

"I've… never really thought about it like that," Catra says, raising her eyebrows.

"Right?" Bow continues. "Listen, Catra, you mean the *world* to Adora. When you're around, I've never seen her happier. *Really* . You bring this… *passion* in her that no one else can. And, if that's not enough, then I don't know what is."

"Wow, Bow," Catra says, giving him a warm smile. "That was very… sophisticated."

“Thank you! I think it’s the bowtie, if I’m being honest” Bow flicks his bowtie and removes his hand from Catra’s shoulder.

Catra can’t help but laugh. She would have never thought that she would end up pouring her heart out to *Bow* , of all people. And yet… Doing so made her feel a lot better. He is surprisingly very easy to talk to.

“Hey, I think this would be a good time for you to find Adora,” Bow says encouragingly. “Go ask her to dance, and make sure to tell her that you love her.”

Catra’s heart leaps. “Good idea.”

“Go get her, Catra!”

Catra starts to walk away, but pauses when she realizes she forgot something. “Hey, Bow?”

“Yeah, what’s up?”

Catra’s face breaks into yet another smile. “Thanks. For the dance, and for talking with me. It was fun.”

"You're welcome, Catra," Bow replies, returning her smile. "Any time."

"And…" Catra continues," I also wanted to thank you for the room. I… I really don't know what to say. I *love* it."

"Good! I'm glad," Bow tells her. "We really had fun putting it together. Did you thank Glimmer?"

"No, not yet. But, I will, I promise."

"Good, she deserves it," Bow beams. "Now hurry and find Adora! I think the *slow piece* is coming up soon."

"Yeah," Catra says, her heart leaping. "Will do, Bow. Thanks again!"

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"Okay, Adora, you ready?" Glimmer asks, and she places a hand on Adora's waist.

"Uhh… yeah?" Adora runs through the steps in her mind and she begins to dance. Step, match, side. Back, match, side. Repeat, shifting weight accordingly.

“Yeah, there you go! You’ve got it!”

“What, were you doubting my abilities?” Adora teases.

“What?” Glimmer scoffs. “No, of course not.”

“Good to hear, because I was.”

“Why?” Glimmer raises an eyebrow. “You’re doing just fine.”

Adora accidentally stubs her toe into the ground and stumbles forward, but manages to catch herself on Glimmer’s shoulder. “Yeah, *just* fine,” she says after regaining her balance.

“Okay, maybe you’re just a *bit* rusty,” Glimmer laughs.

“I think I just need to warm up.”

“For Catra?” Glimmer says, smirking.

“Well, I…” Adora feels her face getting warm. “...Yeah.”

“Sooo… How is she, Adora?”

“Catra? Uh, she’s great, why?”

“Have you guys gone on a date yet?”

“A- a date?” Adora furrows her brow.

Glimmer gasps dramatically. “You *haven’t* ??”

“I… *What* ?”

Alright, now Adora is *thoroughly* confused.

“Okay, you *do* know what a date is, right?”

“Um, no?”

“Oh my-! Adora! You *have* to take Catra out somewhere, just the two of you! On a *date* !”

“But- where?”

“Somewhere romantic, obviously!” Glimmer says in disbelief, like this is common knowledge. “ *Wow* , you are terrible at this.”

“Wow, thanks,” Adora scoffs. It’s not her fault that she’s hearing about this alien concept for the first time in her entire life.

There are so many *possibilities* . She and Catra can go anywhere in the world, so how is Adora supposed to choose?

Suddenly, she remembers the time that Glimmer and Bow took her to Mystacor to relax in the hot springs. If she wasn’t so paranoid about Shadow Weaver showing up at any given moment, she probably would have really enjoyed it. The water was so warm, so soothing… “Glimmer, I think you’re onto something. I think I might know where to take Catra.”

“Ooh, where??” Glimmer asks, her eyes sparkling.

“Mystacor,” Adora tells her. “To the hot springs.”

“Adora, that’s a great idea!”

"You think so?" Adora's heart races at the thought of Catra laying by her side, melting away in the warmth of the spring, melting away in her arms…

Yeah. It is a good idea.

"When are you gonna ask her? You should do it tonight!" Glimmer says excitedly.

"T-tonight? Okay…?"

Easier said than done.

"Then, it's settled! Ooh, I am *so* excited for you, Adora!"

"Thanks, Glimmer, for the idea."

Glimmer beams at her. "You're welcome."

As Adora continues to dance with Glimmer, she tries to come up with a plan to ask Catra on a date. What is the best way? Should she wait until the night ends, and ask her then? Should she wait until tomorrow? No and no; it will probably be best to ask her as soon as possible. If Adora keeps overthinking this, she'll never get it done.

Alright, I'm gonna ask Catra on a date as soon as I see her next.

But where *is* she? What if she is busy dancing with somebody? Will it be rude to interrupt them?

Yeah, it definitely would. The idea of awkwardly watching Catra from a distance while waiting for her to finish dancing isn't exactly appealing, either. What could she do in the meantime? If she started dancing with someone else, and then Catra stopped dancing, she wouldn't want to have to abandon who she was with, because that would *also* be rude.

"Adora," Glimmer says in her Queen-of-Bright-Moon tone.

"Y-yeah?"

"It's okay. You've *got* this. Just go up to her and ask. She'll *definitely* say yes."

"Right…" Glimmer makes it sound so easy. "Maybe I shouldn't wait any longer. I feel like I need to ask her right now, while I'm thinking about it."

"There you go, that's the spirit!"

“Do you mind if I go find her real fast?”

Glimmer waves her hand dismissively, just like Micah does. “Oh, not at all. Besides, I was thinking of finding Bow for a dance, anyway.”

“Oh, good,” Adora breathes out. “Thanks, Glimmer!”

“No problem, Adora! You’ve *got* this!”

Adora lets out a nervous sigh as she turns around to scan the dancefloor. There is no sign of Catra, but then again, the place is packed. She moves over to the refreshments table and pours herself a cup of water as she continues to look.

She concocts a plan to start walking around the perimeter of the ballroom, gradually moving inward until she spots Catra. Once she does, she will go up to her and ask, unless Catra is dancing with somebody, in which case Adora will complete her perimeter and return to the refreshments table. Then, she will wait five minutes and try again.

It is a solid plan. Foolproof.

Adora takes a sip of water and is just about to begin her first perimeter sweep when Catra emerges from the crowd, heading in her direction.

"Hey, Adora," she says.

Adora's heart flutters at the sound of her voice. "Hey, Catra."

Catra extends her hand and meets Adora's eyes with an intense, unrelenting gaze. "You wanna dance?"

"Yeah, I do," Adora replies, and she steps forward and takes Catra's hand.

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Chapter End Notes

It's my HC that Adora is a very analytical person, and often ends up overthinking stuff in pursuit of what is optimal XD

Thanks for reading!

Bridging the Gap

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora dance. Adora works up some courage.

Chapter Notes

This chapter is very fluffy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Alright, follow me,” Catra says excitedly.

“Woah, Catra- slow down! Where are you going?” Adora asks as Catra tugs her towards the stairs leading up to the second floor, which are blocked off by a series of stanchions.

“Over here!” Catra whisper-shouts, and she lets go of Adora’s hand and ducks under the velvet ropes.

“Wait- what are you *doing* ?”

“Going upstairs, obviously.”

“Uh, It’s blocked off??” Adora gestures towards the barrier.

“What’re they gonna do, kick us out?” Catra smirks. “Just- c’mon already!”

“Alright, I’m coming!” Adora pulls her dress up, steps over the barrier, and follows Catra up the stairs.

At the top is a simple overlook that extends around the perimeter of the dancefloor. Directly to their right is what looks like a door to a balcony, one that opens up to an incredible view of the valley outside. Brilliant moonlight is shining through the opening, casting a gleaming silver rectangle onto the floor below.

“Over here,” Catra says, and she pulls Adora into the moonlight. Perfect; just as she had predicted, the second floor is completely deserted. It will just be her and Adora, alone, with no distractions…

“Woah…” Adora’s eyes widen as she looks down into the valley below them.

“I know, right?”

“This is beautiful! How did you know it was up here?”

“Well- I kind of didn’t,” Catra admits. That is true; she simply saw how empty the upstairs area looked, and thought it would be a great place to take Adora for a dance, as the dancefloor is *way*

too crowded. The impeccable view and gleaming moonlight the balcony provides is a *wonderful* coincidence.

"We are *definitely* breaking some rules right now," Adora says, smiling.

"Yeah, but that's what makes it fun," Catra replies. She steps forward and takes Adora's hand.

"You're not wrong," Adora agrees, and she puts her free hand around Catra's waist. Catra does the same.

The voices coming from downstairs sound so distant, but the sound of the string quartet, which is playing a lively waltz, resonates beautifully off the walls, dominating the ambience. Adora and Catra start to dance.

Every time they turn to the beat, the moonlight washes over Adora's face, illuminating her steel-blue eyes in a way that makes Catra's heart race.

"Catra, I need to ask you something," Adora says after a while, noticeably blushing.

"Ask away, Adora."

“Would you like to… go out somewhere? Just the two of us? I mean- not right now, but after this?”

Just the two of them… Catra’s heart beats somehow faster.

“Y-yes! When?”

“I was thinking… tomorrow? Would that work?”

Tomorrow. Catra would have said yes to right this second. “Of *course* ! W-where do you wanna go?”

“Do you remember Mystacor?” Adora asks.

“No?” Catra raises an eyebrow. She’s never heard that name before. If she has, she doesn't remember. “What’s that?”

Adora’s eyes sparkle. “We've been there. It’s a floating city.”

“A floating city,” Catra repeats in disbelief. She doesn't ever recall visiting such a place. Strange.

“Yeah! You probably don't know this, but it has these *awesome* hot springs! You wouldn’t believe how relaxing the water is.”

Immediately following the mention of water, a dreadful chill passes down Catra’s spine.

She shudders at the thought of the horrible images that flashed through her mind the last time she came into contact with water…

But… How hard can it be? It’s just some stupid water. She isn’t going to say no to Adora and ruin their day together just because she’s a little *scared* .

Well, she is a *lot* scared.

No , that’s probably just nerves.

Besides, being alone with Adora in a steamy hot spring sounds absolutely *wonderful* . It will provide a perfect opportunity to get… *close* to her. Catra definitely isn’t going to let her dumb fear of water ruin this chance.

“How does that sound, Catra?” Adora asks.

“U-um…” Catra’s eyes widen. This should be an easy yes, so what is holding her back? Something in her stomach does an uncomfortable lurch. Is she really *that* scared? “Yeah, I-I’ll go.”

Adora’s brow furrows. “Catra, what’s wrong?”

“Wrong? It’s- n-nothing’s wrong. I’m just… excited.” Catra manages a smile. “We’ve never done this before.”

“Yeah, me too!” Adora catches Catra in a hug. “I can’t wait…”

Immediately, Catra feels her worries melt away. Adora is *really* good at doing that.

“So, when do you wanna go tomorrow?” Adora asks as she pulls away from the hug.

“Uh… how about first thing in the morning?”

“Okay!” Adora beams widely. “You’d better not sleep in.”

“Adora, if you get up first, just wake me up.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes, I’m sure.”

“Alright. You said it, not me,” Adora teases.

“Yeah, yeah,” Catra grumbles. She wraps her hands around Adora’s nape and pulls her close. The string quartet had just finished up the waltz and is now playing a slower, more intimate movement.

Adora places her hands on Catra’s waist and touches their foreheads together. She closes her eyes, swaying softly to the beat.

“Adora…” Catra breathes, her heart pounding in excitement. All she has to do is tilt her head slightly upward, and her lips would be touching Adora’s…

They stay like that for a while, holding each other gently, swaying silently under the soft silver light surrounding them. On the dancefloor below them, the evening is winding down, the crowd is thinning out, and the string quartet has stopped playing, not that either of them had noticed any of those things.

Suddenly, Adora moves her head back, away from Catra’s.

“Hey…” she says.

“Hm?” Catra is taken aback by the sudden movement.

“Um…”

Catra’s heart rate speeds up again. Adora has a certain look in her eyes, almost like desperation, or *hunger* …

Adora inches forward.

A relentless flurry of powerful emotions run through Catra’s mind, rendering her unable to do anything but stare wide-eyed at Adora, whose face is now so close that it is out of focus.

Adora closes her eyes, tilts her head sideways, and kisses Catra. Immediately, an intense fiery sensation erupts inside Catra’s chest, and she tightens her grip around Adora’s waist, holding her even closer to her body.

Her heart pounding with excitement, Catra’s eyes flutter shut, and she moves her hands upward, finding the sides of Adora’s head, kissing her back. Her entire body feels like it is going to melt, and it is *incredible* . But the feeling vanishes as soon as it came when Adora’s embrace slackens and she pulls her head away.

Catra let out a breath that she didn't even realize she was holding. It has been so long since their first kiss that she almost forgot the feeling, that incredible, indescribable, *irresistible* feeling. She wants more.

"Hey, um, I think the dance just ended," Adora says, blushing. "The ballroom is empty."

"O-oh, right…"

"Do you… wanna go back to our room?"

Catra fights the urge to yell 'yes, please!' and manages to keep her voice at a reasonable volume when she replies, "yeah, sure."

They find each other's hands and interlace their fingers together as they start to head back to their room.

Catra is slightly disappointed that Adora pulled away as quickly as she did. Any longer, however, and her chest would have combusted, so maybe that was for the best.

That is the second time they had ever kissed. Catra wants to go back in for another, to experience the wonderful sensation of Adora's soft lips against hers again, but thinks better of it.

“Hey, Catra, do you wanna dance together again sometime?” Adora says, and Catra is pulled out of her thoughts.

“I’d love to, Adora,” she smiles.

“Great! I don’t know when the next dance is going to be, but…”

“We don’t have to wait for another dance,” Catra reasons. “We can just make our own.”

“Oh, yeah. I guess you’re right. I mean- that’s basically what Micah did tonight,” Adora chuckles.

The only sound in the entire dance hall is the *clack clack* of Adora and Catra’s shoes on the marble steps as they make their way down the forbidden staircase.

“Hey, Adora?” Catra asks, once they reach the bottom.

“Yeah?”

“Tonight…” Catra pauses and squeezes Adora’s hand. “Was the best night of my life.”

“Really?” Adora says, her eyes widening.

“Yes. I mean it.”

“W-woah! I’m glad to hear that,” Adora beams.

“Yeah. I had a great time,” Catra replies. And Adora kissing her had made everything ten, no, a *hundred* times better.

Tomorrow, they are going to spend the day together, away from all of their responsibilities and worries, alone in the hot springs together. Catra is still unsure of how her body will react to the water, or what images might decide to flash through her mind, but perhaps she can busy herself with Adora’s lips when the time comes so she doesn’t have to think about that…

“Wow, I just realized how *tired* I am,” Adora yawns as they reach the top of the first flight of stairs to the third floor.

“That makes two of us,” Catra says. It has been a *long* week, and these stairs are proving to be quite the task at the moment.

“...They weren’t in there when we left. Why would they be there now?” Bow’s voice echoes from the top of the stairwell.

“I don’t know, but they’re not in their room. They have to be *somewhere,* ” Glimmer responds.

Adora and Catra exchange looks as they hear Bow and Glimmer’s approaching footsteps.

“Oh,” Glimmer says as she and Bow reach them. “Adora, Catra, we’ve been looking for you two. Where’ve you *been* ?”

“Hey, Glimmer! We were just coming back from the dance,” Adora says.

Bow raises an eyebrow. “You know the dance ended half an hour ago, right?”

“Yeah, we kind of… lost track of time,” Adora mumbles.

“Oh?” Glimmer smirks. “And what were you doing for so long?”

“Shut up, Sparkles,” Catra says, attempting to hide her blush, but failing miserably.

"Hey, I didn't say anything." Glimmer throws her up her hands innocently. "Anyway, Catra, I have something I need to talk to you about."

"M-me?" Catra stammers. Maybe it's just her imagination, but that request sounded oddly threatening.

"No, the *other* Catra in the stairwell," Glimmer teases. "But, seriously. Are you free tomorrow? It won't take long."

"Um, actually… I'm going to Mystacor first thing tomorrow. With Adora."

Glimmer's face lights up. "You're going on a date? Adora, congratulations!"

"Wait- a *date* ?" Catra asks.

"Oh. You too?" Glimmer says, sounding slightly disappointed.

Catra raises her eyebrows in confusion. "Uh, what?"

Adora chimes in. "Catra, what we're doing tomorrow is technically called a date. I can't *believe* I didn't know that until tonight."

"I can," Catra teases. "Knowing you."

"Oh, please," Adora starts. She makes that face where she raises an eyebrow and tilts her head upward in a cocky, 'I hope you know what you just got yourself into' sort of way.

"Wait!" Bow says excitedly, before Adora can retort. "You guys are going to Mystacor?? Ooh, I'm jealous. That's gonna be so much *fun* !"

"Yup, that's the plan," Adora smiles.

"Well, in that case," Glimmer says. "Catra, what I need to say can wait. A date is *way* more important. I can just tell you after."

"Sounds good," Catra replies. She is curious about what Sparkles has to talk about, but Sparkles is right. The date takes priority here.

"Oh, I'm so *excited* for you guys!" Glimmer beams. "Adora, I wanna hear *all* about it when you get back."

"Okay," Adora agrees.

“Alright, we’re gonna head to bed now. Have fun tomorrow!” Glimmer says.

“Night, Adora! Night, Catra!” Bow waves at both of them.

“Good night!” Adora and Catra say in unison, waving back as Bow and Glimmer teleport away.

“I wonder what Glimmer needs to talk to me about,” Catra says after a moment.

“I… really don’t know,” Adora replies, furrowing her brow.

“Maybe she’s gonna lay down some ground rules, or something, to make sure I don’t burn this palace down.”

“C’mon, Catra,” Adora chuckles. “Glimmer trusts you, and so does Bow. They wouldn’t have put this room together for both of us if they didn’t.”

“Yeah,” Catra agrees, a smile softening her face. “I know.”

“In any case,” Adora announces, arriving at the door to their room and pulling it open, “we should be getting to sleep. We’ve got a big day tomorrow.”

“Alright, sleepyhead,” Catra responds. She heads into the closet to hang up her suit and change into something more comfortable. The sooner they get to bed, the sooner it will be time for their *date* .

So that’s what that word means. She’s heard Scorpia use it before, a long time ago, but Catra had no idea what it meant at the time.

Just her and Adora, alone together, where they won’t have to worry about a random interruption or some stupid repair work. For the first time in her life, Catra is actually looking forward to waking up.

Adora follows Catra into the closet, changes into some shorts and a t-shirt, and climbs into bed. Shortly afterward, Catra emerges from the closet, shuts the balcony doors, and joins her.

“Hey, Catra?”Adora says, her voice soft.

“Yeah?”

“Good night, I love you.”

Catra gives her a warm smile. “I love you too, Adora.” She makes a mental note to tell Adora that every day from now on.

Adora closes her eyes, and Catra just stares at her, at the way her flowing hair has fallen naturally around the flawless contours of her face. She is just… perfect. Catra can’t seem to tear her gaze away. Her heart beats rapidly in her chest as she enjoys the view in silence, until-

“Adora?”

“Yeah?”

“Can I… come closer?”

“Sure,” Adora whispers.

It *worked* .

Catra is tired of holding back. She wants to be as close as physically possible to Adora. She crosses the bed, and when she reaches Adora, she curls in tight, pressing their bodies together and nuzzling her face affectionately into her neck.

“Mmnh…” Adora breathes a soft moan.

A wonderful shiver travels down Catra's entire body. She has never heard *that* sound before.

The hot sensation in Adora's chest returns following Catra's unexpected maneuver. They have been close together before, but never *this* close. The way that Catra's lips are brushing softly against her neck makes her spine tingle.

Carefully, Adora wraps her arm around Catra's lower back and slides her hand up the length of her body to the back of her head. She strokes her hair and then rests her hand on her nape, holding her tight to her chest. She never wants to let go.

"Adora?" Catra asks for the second time.

"Hmm?" Adora breathes.

"Could you do that again?"

Adora immediately understands. She slides her hand back up to Catra's hair and starts gently running her fingers through it. She experiments, tenderly moving her hand behind Catra's ears, around her neck, and over her shoulders. Catra's breaths turn into soft purrs, and Adora feels her shift somehow closer into her body. Their thighs are now crossed over each other.

As Adora strokes Catra's hair, she feels Catra shiver against her body, and she can tell that it was the good kind of shiver. The kind of shiver that Adora has only had the fortune to experience a select few times in her entire life, all of which in situations involving Catra giving her back rubs late at night in the bunks of the Horde barracks back when they were young.

She didn't know how much she missed this until now.

It isn't long before the sound of Catra's purrs grow into deeper, rumbling vibrations, and Adora knows that she's fallen asleep. Adora lets that incredibly comforting sound steal her away into a deep slumber.

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When Adora opens her eyes, Catra is still curled up snugly into her body, every soft breath she takes flowing over Adora's collarbone. Adora raises her arm from its position around Catra's back, shifts backwards, and starts to stroke the bangs out of Catra's face.

“Mm…” Catra mumbles, opening her eyes and blinking her sleep away. “Hey, Adora,” she says gently.

“Good morning,” Adora says sleepily, moving over the length of Catra's eyebrow with her thumb. To her surprise, Catra reaches out and cups Adora’s jaw in her hand, caressing her in return.

“I like your hair like that,” Catra says dreamily, her eyes half-lidded. “Can you keep it down?”

“Yeah, sure,” Adora smiles, her skin tingling pleasantly from Catra’s touch. “All day?”

“How about *every* day?”

“Oh, okay.”

Catra gives her a warm smile, and Adora can feel her face growing warmer as Catra stares into her eyes.

“When do you wanna go?” she asks, giving her brain something else to think about other than how red her face probably is.

“Um…” Catra yawns, her pointed fangs shining brilliantly in the morning sunlight. “I don’t know, I’m pretty comfortable right

now.”

“Yeah, me too,” Adora agrees. She moves her hand over Catra’s shoulder and starts to run it along the length of her back.

“Mmm…” Catra closes her eyes. “Great, now I’m *never* gonna get up.”

“Alright, guess I’ll just have to cancel our date, then,” Adora says with faux disappointment.

“Uh, *no* ,” Catra protests. “Not happening.”

“Alright,” Adora says, sitting up. “Then you’re gonna have to get up.”

“Ugh, fine…” Catra pouts, rolling lazily out of bed.

“Okay, get dressed! We’re leaving in 20 minutes!” Adora tells her, crossing the room to her dresser.

“...Dressed? What do you mean?” Catra’s question is answered when a conglomerate of white garments hits her in the face. “What are *these* ?”

“It’s swimwear, Catra. C’mon, put it on.” Adora steps into the washroom and closes the door behind her.

“What…?” she hears Catra mumble from the other side of the door.

Adora pulls on her swimwear and slips on some shorts and a t-shirt, as well as her jacket. “Catra, are you done?” she calls through the door.

“Yeah, I… I think.”

Adora opens the door. “How does it feel?”

“Uh…” Catra raises her arms, examining herself. “Feels pretty nice, actually.”

“Okay, good. I was worried that they weren’t going to fit,” Adora says, and she feels her face getting warmer yet again. The swimwear fits Catra perfectly, complimenting the features of her slender body *beautifully* . “Hey… you look good.”

“Oh- t-thanks, Adora,” Catra replies, blushing slightly. “Um- did you change yet?”

“Huh?” Adora snaps out of her trance, raising an eyebrow. “ *Oh* . Yeah, I did.” She lifts her undershirt to expose the white cloth of her swimwear beneath it. “You should probably put something on over that. I mean- unless you *want* everyone to see you walking around Bright Moon in nothing but swimwear. You might get some weird looks.”

“Oh, like the one you were just giving me, with your eyes wide and mouth half-open?” Catra teases.

“N-no,” Adora bristles, blushing furiously. “Y-you know what I mean.”

“Whatever you say, Adora.” Catra rolls her eyes as she pulls on her shorts and t-shirt.

“Okay, are you *finally* ready to go?” Adora asks her.

“Um, lemme think.” Catra feigns an expression of deep thought. “Yeah, I’m ready. Obviously.”

Adora is *way* too excited to attempt to come up with a clever comeback. “Let’s go, then!”

“Lead the way, Adora,” Catra says, taking her hand.

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Chapter End Notes

Fluff overload? I think not. There's plenty more where that came from.

Thanks for reading!

Vow

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra venture to Mystacor.

Chapter Notes

Hello again, and welcome to massive fluff :>

Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You've *got* to be kidding me."

Catra stares reluctantly down over the literal cliff face before her. Out of all of the numerous date-scenarios that ran through her head, this one *definitely* didn't pop up. She was not at *all* expecting Adora to park their speeder on the edge of a cliff face in the middle of nowhere. They are so high up that she can see the tops of clouds below them.

"I'm not. I'm being serious," Adora responds.

"Yeah, look me in the eye and tell me that you're *really* about to jump off a cliff."

"I'm about to jump off a cliff," Adora says, and Catra almost believes her before she notices the slightest curl of a smile playing at the corner of Adora's mouth.

"I *knew* you were joking, Adora," she laughs, pushing her arm. "I see that smile!"

"No!" Adora insists. "I just… I can't help but smile when you look at me like that."

"Like what?"

"Like… ugh. I don't know." She blushes.

"Okay, but seriously," Catra presses. "Where is this 'floating city,' anyway?" She scans the vast, empty, cloudy expanse in front of them for the fourth time. And still finds absolutely nothing.

"Come with me, and I'll show you," Adora says, grasping Catra's hand and leading her towards the edge of the cliff.

"Where's there to go?" Catra asks. "There's nothing here."

"Yes there is! You just can't see it yet."

"And you can?"

"No; it's protected by a magical barrier so evil can't find it," Adora explains, and Catra can tell that she's telling the truth, because there is *no* way Adora would be able to say that with a straight face if it were a joke.

"Okay…" Catra raises an eyebrow. "This is getting weirder by the minute."

"Good to hear. I'm gonna jump off the cliff now."

"Yeah, right. I thought we were done-" Catra stops herself when Adora steps dangerously close to the cliff face, claps her hands together, and dives headfirst off the side. "A-Adora!! What-!?"

Adora lets out a whoop of excitement as she passes through the clouds.

"Adora!" Catra repeats, and she grits her teeth and jumps off after her. As she accelerates downward, her stomach rises to her chest, and she has to suppress the urge to scream. The second she passes through the clouds, her body is overcome with an odd floating sensation. Her feet make soft contact with sturdy ground. She stands up shakily and spots Adora in front of her.

"Ah, there you are," Adora says matter-of-factly, apparently completely unfazed by the fact that they had just plunged off of

the side of a cliff.

"That…" Catra huffs. "That was… *terrifying* ."

"Good, I'm glad to hear it!"

"Phew… Ok, I am *never* doing that again." Catra stabilizes herself by putting her hands on her knees.

"Why not? It's even more fun the second time around."

" *That's* your idea of fun??"

"Yeah, basically."

"Oh, *great* ."

Adora smiles devilishly. "Just wait. The next cliff is even bigger."

"T-there's another?!"

"Nah," Adora chuckles. "I'm just messing with you."

Catra scoffs, but can't stop herself from smiling at the sight of the big, stupid grin that Adora has plastered on her face.

"Adora… you dummy."

Adora raises an eyebrow. Cute. "Oh, really?"

"Yeah, really. But…" Catra steps forward and gently takes her hand. "I don't mind."

"Wow, rude," Adora smirks. "That's not a very nice thing to say to your *date* ."

"I'm just *kidding* , Adora."

At that moment, the chunk of rock they are standing on breaks through a magical barrier, sending ripples across its surface, and the city of Mystacor comes into view.

"We're here!" Adora says happily.

"This," Catra raises her eyebrows, "is Mystacor?"

“What do you think?”

“It’s…” Catra eyes the several waterfalls spilling down the sides of the steep, terraced landscape, as well as the ornate gold-tipped spires surrounding numerous differently-sized domed buildings and winding archways. “ *Big* .”

“I know, right?” Adora says excitedly.

“How is it *floating* ?”

“Uhh, I don’t know, magic? This place *is* home to tons of sorcerers, after all.”

“Oh, that would make sense.”

“So, do you wanna hit the hot springs?” Adora asks excitedly, apparently too giddy to stay on the boring subject of crusty old wizards.

Catra feels an anxious pang in her chest when she remembers what they are here for. What if her reaction to the water is more than she can handle?

No, that won't happen. Besides, she's handled worse in the past. Catra does her best to push the lingering doubt out of her mind.

"Y-yeah! Let's go!" she manages. A smile for good measure.

"Yes! C'mon!" Adora cheers, tugging Catra up the grassy path that leads to the entrance of the palace. But as she enters, she passes the entrance to the hot springs, and Catra throws her a glance. Just a minute ago, she was so excited, but now, she looks… *worried* about something. Weird.

"Adora, I think the hot springs are that way," Catra says carefully, pointing to the hallway they just passed.

Adora appears to regain her focus. "Oh, y-yeah. They are. Wait- how'd you know that?"

Catra raises an eyebrow. "There's a sign."

"Oh." Adora's face flushes in embarrassment. "Right. Let's go."

What is she so *distracted* about?

As they continue down the long hallway, a sense of uneasy familiarity falls over Catra. This place- she recognizes it.

"Adora, isn't this... where the *failsafe* was?"

"Yeah. We've been here before. Don't you remember?"

"Well, I do *now*." Catra glances around at the gigantic statues lining the walls. "I had no idea this place was a floating city, though."

"Hmm," Adora mumbles. "Oh yeah! We teleported straight inside last time. That's probably why you don't remember the outside."

"Makes sense," Catra concurs, and she gives a chuckle. "So, the failsafe was sitting below some random hot springs all this time, huh?"

Adora scoffs. "Catra, they're not just some *random* hot springs. They're world class healing springs!"

"You sure are hyping this place up. It better be worth it."

"Oh, it will be. Don't worry."

The first thing Catra notices about the room with the hot springs is how *steamy* it is. Every smooth, stony surface around them is covered in a layer of condensation, and every breath she takes fills her lungs with pleasantly warm, moist air.

Suddenly, her eyes snap to Adora, who is pulling off her top and shorts.

Adora turns to face her and raises an eyebrow. "Hey, uh, what's with the weird face?"

"Sorry, Adora, I just can't stop… looking at you."

Catra is completely aware of how stupid that sounded, but it's true; she is completely engrossed by Adora's body. The swimwear provides a wonderful view of her muscular shoulders and arms, her defined collarbone, her toned core…

Catra is also fully aware of the fact that her heart rate is increasing and that her face is probably currently assuming the color of Adora's favorite jacket.

"Oh, uhm…" Adora blushes. "Well, are you just gonna *stand* there?" She turns and steps into the nearest spring, drawing a sharp intake of breath as the hot water creeps up her body and past her chest. With a sigh of satisfaction, she eases backward, leaning against the wall of the spring. "Catra, you coming? This water feels so *good* !"

“Yeah, I’m just… hold on.” Catra pulls off her own shirt and shorts and moves over to the edge spring.

It’s just some stupid water, she convinces herself. *There’s nothing to be scared of.*

She raises her leg over the wall, dips her foot into the water, and recoils almost immediately with a gasp.

“It’s hot, I know,” Adora laughs. “You get used to it once your entire body is in.”

“Y-yeah. It’s pretty… pretty hot.”

Yeah. Hot. Not terrifying in any way, just… hot.

Catra takes a deep breath, trying to relax her face as much as possible to conceal her reluctance. She holds her breath and steps completely over the wall, submerging herself up to her shoulders in searing water. Her whole body goes rigid, and she starts to shiver, despite the heat.

“Adora, I-I’m-” she stammers, panic flooding her mind and choking out her words.

“Catra? W-what’s wrong?” Adora frantically wades forward and finds Catra’s shoulder with her hand.

“I-I’m okay,” Catra quavers through ragged breaths. “I’m- I…”

Gradually, she gains control of her breathing. Maybe it is Adora’s touch, or merely her *presence* , but thankfully, no disturbing images flashed through Catra’s mind. If that were the case, she would have reacted more… violently.

“W-what happened?” Adora asks.

“Sorry, Adora.” Catra drops her head in shame. “It’s just…”

Catra braces herself. The last thing she wants right now is for Adora to be worrying about her on their *date* , on the day that they are supposed to be spending happily together. But, Adora deserves to know. She deserves *everything* , and Catra should have never hid her fear of water from her in the first place.

“I’m…” she says sheepishly. “I’m scared of water.”

Adora furrows her brow. “You- you are?”

Catra nods solemnly, drooping her ears. "Ever since… since *Prime* , he… the water was…" She shudders.

"...W-why didn't you *tell* me?"

"I… I'm sorry," Catra laments. "I didn't mean to hide it from you. I just wanted our date to be… perfect."

"Catra, you can talk to me," Adora says. She looks… *hurt…*

A pang of guilt surges through Catra's chest. "I know, Adora, I know. I should've."

"Hey. I will *always* listen to what you need to say. No more hiding things, okay?"

"Okay. I promise."

Adora gives Catra a warm smile. "And I promise not to hide anything from you, either."

"Thanks," Catra says, returning her smile.

How could she have been so *stupid* ? How could she have forgotten how important it is to be open with Adora? Every pang of guilt that returns to Catra's chest pleads with her to never again hold back her inner thoughts, to talk to Adora about *everything* , no matter how small.

Because Adora deserves that, not to be left in the dark, forced to guess and hope she is doing the right thing. Catra knows that Adora wants the best for her, but how is she supposed to know what 'the best' is if Catra won't tell her?

And who is Catra to put Adora through the stress of *guesswork* ? She's already put her through enough already.

"Catra? How are you feeling?" Adora asks, and the compassion in her voice reaches so deep into the fabric of Catra's being that she makes a vow in that moment to never hide anything from the woman she loves *ever again* .

And, maybe it's because Adora is with her, but the water doesn't seem so bad anymore. In fact, it is actually starting to feel pretty nice.

"I think I'm okay, Adora," Catra says, moving closer. "Sorry about that."

"It's okay, Catra." Adora removes her hand from her shoulder and settles back down against the wall. "Thanks for being honest with

me.”

Catra gives her a smile and takes a seat next to her. “You know, now that I’m not freaking out, this is… *very* relaxing.”

“Right? It feels so good…” Adora sighs, relishing in the pleasant warm, weightless feeling that the water gives her.

Although, there is no doubt in her mind that it would feel ten times better if Catra were in her arms. Perhaps Adora could wrap her arms around her, pull her into her body, and melt away in the warm, relaxing liquid of the spring…

Then again, she *has* been through this scenario in her mind about a thousand times since she asked Catra on this date, and each time, she just can’t see herself realistically working up the courage to do it, to put her arm around Catra.

But now that it’s the real deal, it is *twenty* times more intimidating. She’ll *never* pull this off.

But then- the promise. The one she made just a couple of seconds ago to never hide anything from Catra. But… does this count as *hiding something* ?

Yeah… it probably does.

But, even still, something is bugging her. Something deep in the back of her mind that she can't pinpoint. What if Catra doesn't want-

No. Adora has gone down that path of thought *way* too many times now. She's tired of treading this endless cycle of hesitancy. Perhaps she should just *try* for once, or *ask* to try, instead of freaking out internally about it like she always does.

"Hey, Catra?" Adora asks cautiously, unsure of where to start.

"Yeah?" Catra's ears perk up curiously.

"Can I… um." Adora swallows before continuing. "...Can I- put my arms around you?" Her face starts to heat up, and she prepares herself for Catra to laugh at her for how ridiculous that request just sounded.

She shouldn't have asked. She *knew* this was a bad idea… Her brain was telling her that it was for a reason; she should have *listened* -

“Sure,” is the reply, and Adora is completely taken aback.

“O-oh, okay,” she stutters.

“Adora. Thanks for making sure, but… You really don’t have to ask to hug me.”

“I- I don’t?”

Catra chuckles. “No, of course not. What makes you think that?”

“I guess I didn’t know if-” Adora blushes and sweeps her hair behind her ear, “...if you’d be okay with it.”

Catra raises an eyebrow. “Are you kidding? I’m *more* than okay with it.”

“Y-you are?” Adora says, instantly filled with relief.

“Yes.” Catra gives her a look, something between determination and hope.

"Sorry, Catra. I don't know why, but I've just been hesitant about... Touching you. And asking. You know."

"Adora." Catra moves her face closer to Adora's and speaks into her ear, her tone low and soft, almost a growl. "I would do *anything* you asked."

Adora feels her heart skip, like *really* skip, as if she had just missed an entire flight of stairs.

Woah.

"Now," Catra declares, pulling her head back. "Where were we?"

"O-oh, right…" Adora reaches out and offers her hand, Catra's words still echoing in her mind.

Catra accepts her hand and moves closer.

She's moving closer!

Adora interlocks their fingers together and wraps her arm around Catra's shoulder, pulling her in tight to her body.

“That’s more like it,” Catra purrs, laying her head on Adora’s shoulder.

“Y-yeah…” Adora’s heart is still pounding, but she can’t help it.

‘*I would do* anything *you asked.’*

And Catra had said it in such a way, such a sultry, *chill-inducing* way that Adora isn’t sure that she will ever be able to speak again.

“Is everything okay?” Catra asks suddenly.

“Erm- W-what do you mean?” Adora stammers.

“Adora, you’re tense.” Catra takes her head off of her shoulder. “Am I making you uncomfortable?”

Adora’s eyes widen. “No, i-it’s nothing like that. I’m just… not used to this.” What a weak excuse. She curses her brain for it’s sudden inability to form logical thought.

“Oh,” Catra says, her voice uncertain. “Do you want to stop? I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to-”

“N-no, *don’t*- I mean- it’s not you, Catra.” Adora reaches up to wipe sweat from her brow, but is apparently too distracted to account for the fact that her hand had just been submerged in a spring, and ends up flinging water all over her face.

“Adora.” Catra removes herself completely from Adora’s hold and turns to face her. “What is going on?”

“Nothing, s-sorry about that.” Great. Now she’s *really* messing this up. And it was going so *well* -

“Why are you apologizing?” Catra asks. “Are you sure you’re okay?”

“Yes.”

“Then, *relax*, you dummy.”

“Catra-!” Adora blurts, unable to stop herself.

Catra simply furrows her brow in response.

Adora takes a deep breath. It is now or never.

“Kiss me,” she demands. “Please,” she adds, for that just sounded very commanding.

“O- *oh* .” Catra’s eyes widen in understanding and she goes completely red. She stares at Adora in disbelief.

Adora smirks. She feels her confidence returning.

Catra regains control of her senses. Adora has got this smug look on her face, as if she doesn’t believe that Catra will be able to kiss her, as if she is *daring* her to.

Of course I will.

Catra forms a smirk of her own. She moves back towards Adora, straddles her lap, and wraps her arms around her nape, staring into her beautiful steel-blue eyes.

“You could’ve just *said* something, Adora,” she purrs.

"Uh, I *did* ."

"Yeah, after a millennium."

"Shut up."

Unable to hold back any longer, Catra closes the gap and presses her lips to Adora's, and immediately, a flaming sensation ignites in her chest. Adora's lips are so soft, so warm against her own, and every inch of Catra's body is telling her never to stop, never to let up.

A soft moan suddenly escapes Adora's throat, causing the flame in Catra's chest to flare up into a raging inferno. Her fingers splay across Adora's shoulders and neck as she arches her back into her body, pushing her against the wall, kissing her hungrily, relentlessly.

Adora's hands snake around Catra's waist, holding her in place. In return, Catra runs her hands down Adora's back, pressing their bodies closer together, feeling the intense heat radiating from her skin, drinking in her scent, her taste.

All Catra can think about is how she never wants to separate from Adora's lips, how *incredible* this feels.

But despite this, she pulls her head back, her chest heaving and her heart pounding. She can feel warm sweat running down the side of her face, mixing with the slick condensation already covering her entire body.

"Why'd you stop?" Adora asks, looking understandably surprised.

"I was just…" Catra pants. "Breathing."

But before Catra can fully catch her breath, Adora stands up and catches her in another kiss, grabbing her by the shoulders and pressing her back against the wall. She feels Adora's hands moving down her body and over her hips, stopping at her legs.

Catra's heart skips several beats as she feels her legs being raised up around Adora's waist, and suddenly, she's suspended against the wall behind her back. This maneuver sends her mind into a whole new level of excitement that she never knew was possible.

"*Nn…* " she pleads.

She wraps her arms around Adora's body, digging into her skin with her fingers, holding onto her as if the world would end the moment they separated. Adora kisses her with a newfound intensity, as if something just awoke within her, something that Catra just can't get enough of.

Catra's chest is going to catch fire, but she doesn't care. She tightens her grip around Adora's back, running her hands over her nape and through her hair, holding her head in place. She isn't going to make the mistake of pausing again.

But this time, it's Adora that separates. With a final, breathless moan, she releases Catra and pulls her head away.

"That was…" Catra manages through heavy breaths. There are not enough words to describe exactly what is going on in her head right now. "I-I don't know what to say."

"What, you think it's over?" Adora says, her chest also heaving.

"I never said *that* ."

"Good. Get over here."

Catra can *definitely* get used to this side of Adora. She smirks and moves forward to meet her lips again.

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Adora loses track of time as she closes her eyes and leans her head back against the edge of the hot spring. Catra is sitting in

her lap, leaning back into her body, her head resting on her chest and her tail wrapped tight around her thigh.

She can *absolutely* get used to this.

"Hey, Adora?" Catra asks.

"Hmm?" Adora breathes, opening one eye.

"Thank you for taking me here. It's been, well, you know. *Amazing* ."

"You're welcome, Catra," Adora says warmly, moving her hand from its place on Catra's belly to her head to stroke a pointed ear.

"Mmm…" Catra purrs, leaning into the touch. "I love you."

"I love you more."

Catra turns her head to place a soft kiss on Adora's neck. "That's not possible."

Adora’s heart jumps, and she seizes an opportunity. “Oh yeah? Prove it.”

Catra unfurls herself from Adora’s arms, turning to face her, fully prepared to accept that trivial challenge. However, Adora beats her to the punch and pulls her into a kiss before she has a chance to react.

“Too late,” she says against Catra’s lips.

“Mm. Cheater,” Catra mumbles in return, wrapping her arms around Adora’s neck.

It is so strange, Adora thinks as she pulls away, giggling. Just earlier today, she was tentative about the idea of simply putting her arm around Catra’s shoulder. Cut to the present, and she can now go in for a *kiss* with full confidence that Catra will gladly return it. It’s *incredibly* refreshing.

Why on *Etheria* had she not talked with Catra about her feelings sooner? Why was she so scared to express her desires? The worst that could have happened was Catra saying ‘no, I’m not ready for that yet,’ or something. But, so what? Adora would rather know that Catra *doesn’t* want her touch than have to constantly go through the stress of trying to *guess* what she wants.

“What are you laughing about?” Catra smirks.

“I don’t know,” Adora says, and she can’t stop beaming. “I’m just… *happy* .”

“Yeah, I know. Me too,” Catra returns, her blue and yellow eyes sparkling. “And… I think I may have gotten used to the water. I feel like I could stay in here forever.”

“I don’t think I could. I’m actually getting pretty hot,” Adora admits, and she gets a wonderful idea. “Do you wanna head back to Bright Moon, and maybe…” She subconsciously brushes some of her hair behind her ear. “Continue this in our room?”

Catra’s tail flicks back and forth and she bites her lip, exposing a pointed fang. “I would *love* to,” she says, placing a quick kiss on the corner of Adora’s mouth before stepping out of the spring. “But let’s get something to eat first. I’m starving.”

“Yeah, good idea,” Adora agrees, suddenly aware of how empty her stomach feels. She raises herself out of the water.

Once they are dry and dressed, Catra and Adora step out of the palace into the dark, cloudy evening. The wind is chilly and unpredictable, a stark contrast from the calm, clear weather when they arrived.

It feels ominous out here.

As they hop on the speeder and set off for Bright Moon, small drops of rain begin to fall from the sky. The drops are so insignificant that they almost tickle, but they, as well as the angry-looking clouds in the distance, seem to be a telling sign of what's to come.

"Ugh. I *just* dried off," Catra huffs, folding her arms.

"This could be worse," Adora points out. "It's only sprinkling. At least it's not-"

At that moment, a blinding white light fills the air, punctuated by a bone-rattling roar of thunder.

Catra and Adora stare wide-eyed at each other for a good three seconds as the thunder dissipates before breaking out in a fit of giggles.

"Um, I'm gonna… speed up now," Catra says, her voice higher pitched than usual.

"Good idea," Adora returns, her heart still pounding in exhilaration from the incredible volume of the thunder.

This kind of weather is Adora's favorite. The kind just before a storm that fills the sky with dark, turbulent clouds, unpredictable wind patterns that shake the trees, and an almost *electric* taste in the air that foreshadows something powerful. Oh, and the occasional strike of lightning that shakes the ground.

But as much as she loves this kind of weather, it's not *exactly* the best time for it right now.

Thankfully, they don't get struck by lightning on their journey back, and the rain never really picks up. As they hop off of the speeder and cross the threshold into Bright Moon palace, they are only *slightly* damp with water.

"It's a good thing we left when we did," Catra says, running her hand over her tail to squeeze the moisture out.

"No kidding," Adora responds, turning her head for a look back outside. The trees on the edge of the Whispering Woods are whipping around violently in the wind, threatening to snap at any moment.

As they enter the dining hall, another ear splitting crack of thunder explodes outside. Heavy rain starts to splatter violently on the windows, vibrating the entire building.

"Woah," Adora says, raising her voice to accommodate for the loud sounds of rain. " *Really* good thing we left."

Catra grimaces. “Yeah, I think we would have been stranded in Mystacor. Ugh, I can’t imagine being stranded with *you* ,” she teases, biting a chunk out of the apple she just picked up.

Adora scoffs, reaching for a bowl of reddish soup. “Next time we go to Mystacor, I am throwing you off a cliff.”

To Adora’s surprise, Catra’s ears perk up, and her face loses its smug confidence.

“N-next time?”

“Oh. D-do you want there to be a next time?” Adora asks. “It doesn’t have to be Mystacor again, if you want. Just, um. Yeah. Do you-”

“Hold on, Adora,” Catra interjects, pressing her pointer finger to Adora’s lips. “Don’t you think it’s *my* turn to ask you on a date?”

Adora throws up her hands in surrender. “Ask away, Catra.”

“Um… Okay, but- later. I wanna ask when you aren’t expecting it.”

"Well, *now* I'm gonna be expecting it."

"Oh, shut up," Catra huffs. "And- you know food is supposed to go *in* your mouth, right?"

Adora's face flushes. In her infinite grace, she missed her mouth with her spoon, causing soup to splash over her lower lip. Her face burns in embarrassment as she reaches for a napkin. This is Catra's fault. Her face is *way* too distracting.

"Wait!" Catra says, extending her hand, pausing inches from Adora's face. "Lemme get it."

"O-oh-kay," Adora stutters, freezing in place.

Catra shifts closer and moves her thumb forward, her tongue poking out of her mouth in concentration. Adora feels a shiver run down her spine as Catra's thumb makes contact and brushes gently over her lips.

And without breaking eye contact, Catra brings her now soup-covered thumb slowly up to her own mouth and licks it.

"Mm. Good soup choice, Adora," she says.

Wuh- Adora's brain auto-pilots out a response. "T-thanks."

"Wait, hold on, I think I missed a spot." Catra moves closer again, but this time she doesn't extend her thumb. Instead, it's her lips that make contact with Adora's.

And suddenly, Adora has melted. Her arms are around Catra, her hands running over her back and through her hair, holding her head in place-

The door to the dining hall swings open, and Bow and Glimmer step inside.

"Yeah, there's already a leak in the-" The sound of Glimmer's voice cuts off.

Adora's heart jumps out of her chest and she removes herself from Catra way more frantically than she probably should have. Bow and Glimmer are standing petrified in the doorway, as if they just stumbled across the scene of a murder.

"Oh, uhm. H-hey, guys, you're back," Bow says, clearly trying to play innocent.

"Did we *interrupt* something?" Glimmer smirks, *way* too suggestively, apparently not getting the message.

“W-well, we- um. I-” Adora stammers. Technically, yes, they *did* interrupt something, but it would be rude to say that. She can’t say ‘no,’ either, because that would be a flat-out lie. Her two friends in the doorway most *definitely* saw what just went down between her and Catra.

“Nope,” Catra says nonchalantly, before Adora can respond. *What*? “You guys here for some food?”

Bow cocks an eyebrow upward. “Yeah, uhm. W-we can come back later.” He points his thumb over his shoulder towards the door.

“Nah, you’re fine. C’mon, take a seat!” Catra replies, smiling mischievously, the way she does when she’s up to something.

“Alright, if you say so,” Bow says, turning awkwardly to Glimmer for approval, who nods. They take their places in two chairs directly across from Adora and Catra.

A distant rumble of thunder rings through the thick patter of rain on the windows.

Bow lets out a puff of air, breaking an unbearable bout of silence. “Quite the storm, huh?”

“Yeah. We’re lucky we didn’t get caught up in it on our way back from Mystacor,” Catra says conversationally.

“Ooh, how’d that go?” Glimmer asks excitedly, her eyes sparkling.

“It was *perfect* . Your friend here really knows how to treat a girl,” Catra replies, giving Adora a punch on the shoulder.

Adora’s face burns, and she looks anywhere that isn’t a pair of eyes. She can practically feel Glimmer’s smirk from across the table. This must have been what Catra was planning.

Well played.

“I’m glad you two had fun,” Bow says brightly, but his attempt to ease the tension fails miserably, and silence falls across the room.

With every second that passes, Adora swears her face only gets hotter.

“So, Sparkles, what did you want to talk about?” Catra finally asks. Thank goodness; a subject change.

“Um, I actually wanted to speak to you in private,” Glimmer responds. “Is that okay?”

“Right now?”

“Oh, no, It can wait. I can always ask tomorrow.”

“No, I said I’d talk to you after my date. How about after we’re done eating?” Catra offers.

“Yeah, sure!” Glimmer beams. “It won’t take long at *all* .”

Adora furrows her brow. What could Glimmer possibly have to say to *Catra* ? They barely even know each other. And- why does their conversation need to be in private?

A faint rumble of thunder echoes in the distance.

*****

Chapter End Notes

Glimmer ships Catradora, it's canon

Thunder

Chapter Summary

Catra and Glimmer talk.

Chapter Notes

Hey y'all!! I changed my username :0
It was previously JT5963, and is now mesopphire. Sorry if that's confusing lol

Anyway, enjoy the chapter!

Perfect.

Catra smiles to herself. Sparkles' timing is impeccable.

Their conversation will allow some more time to pass between now and her night with Adora. And that means Adora will no doubt grow even more eager to return to their room than she already obviously is.

Besides, it's not even night time yet, and it's *storming* outside. Not exactly the best mood. By the time Catra is done talking with Sparkles, about whatever she needs to talk about, perhaps the storm will have passed, and it will be a little bit darker…

Catra's heart leaps. Tonight is going to be *incredible* .

With a sufficient plan in place, she zones back into the conversation that is taking place before her.

"Adora, tell me *everything* ," Glimmer says.

"Everything?" Adora replies, her face uncertain.

"Yes."

Adora breathes a sigh, and what she says comes out as if it is one word. "Okay, so first, we woke up, and I made sure to-"

"Adora," Glimmer interrupts. "The date."

"R-right. Uh, yeah. The date," Adora says, blushing. "Well, it was… it was *hot* . T-the water, I mean! We went to the hot springs. Y-you knew that."

Catra's heart flutters. Adora is flustered because of *her* . It's a nice feeling.

"Anyway," Adora continues. "Well. We kind of just… relaxed in the springs for a while. Pretty nice. Yeah."

“That sounds pretty uneventful,” Glimmer says, but Catra knows she doesn’t mean it. She’s laying a trap, one that Adora walks right into.

“It wasn’t *uneventful* ! We ended up-” Adora cuts herself off, blushing furiously.

Glimmer smirks. “Go on?”

Catra knows how to make the room explode, but she has to wait for the right opportunity. There isn’t enough tension just yet.

“Oh, come on Glimmer,” Bow interjects. “It’s not fair for you to decide if they had fun or not.”

“ *Booow* ,” Glimmer sighs. “Fine, Adora, you can keep your secrets.”

“I-I’m not keeping *secrets* !”

“Then you should have no problems with me asking Catra about it, right?”

“ *Ugh*- you- I-” Adora sputters, and she gives an indignant huff. “ *No* .”

“Great!” Glimmer beams. “Then I’ll do just that!”

“Oh?” Catra raises an eyebrow. This is the moment to strike. “Well, I’m not telling you either,” she jeers. “What happens in Mystacor stays in Mystacor.”

“Lame,” Glimmer groans, rolling her eyes.

Catra throws a discreet glance to her right. Adora looks relieved.

Not for long.

She swoops over and pecks a quick kiss onto Adora’s cheek.

“Right, Adora?” she says.

Adora turns and looks at Catra like she had just performed ten consecutive backflips. “R-right…”

For a moment, the only sound in the room is the rain splashing onto the windows.

"You guys are…" Bow starts, breaking the silence. Then, he claps his hands to his cheeks and his voice jumps up an octave. "So *cute!* It's like you were destined for each other!"

Catra cocks an eyebrow. That is not quite the reaction she was expecting. But then again, it is *Bow…*

"I second that," Glimmer declares with a wide smile.

"I third that," Adora says, breaking into a grin of her own. Catra feels fingers interlock with hers under the table.

"It's a majority vote! Yes!" Bow cheers, throwing a fist into the air, and Catra can't help but smile as well, despite the fact that her plan had failed miserably.

The sound of the rain is drowned out by hearty laughter from all four members of the Best Friend Squad.

"Whew. I'm stuffed," Glimmer says, after everyone has calmed down.

The other three murmur in agreement.

As Catra stands up and stretches, she figures this is a good time to get her talk with Sparkles over with.

Well, she should probably take her time, because every minute she spends talking is another Adora has to wait.

I am evil, Catra smirks to herself.

"Sparkles?" she asks. "Ready to chat?"

Glimmer stands up purposefully. "Yeah, sure, wanna go outside?"

"No, not really. I'd prefer to talk somewhere that isn't *raining* ," Catra teases.

"Ugh. You know what I mean," Glimmer scoffs. "Just- c'mon. Let's go."

"Alright, lead the way."

Catra is actually pretty curious as to what Sparkles has to say. Maybe it's something about…

Nope. she can't even *begin* to imagine what Sparkles could possibly have to say to her.

As she steps out of the dining hall and into the hallway, she turns her head to throw a wink at Adora.

*****

Adora follows Catra out with her eyes. Her heart jumps when Catra's blue eye flicks closed in a quick wink. And then, the door swings shut and she's gone; off to talk about *something* with Glimmer. Something that better not interfere with their… evening.

Glimmer had said it wouldn't take very long, but Adora doesn't feel like she can wait anymore. She needs to be alone with Catra right this second, away from everyone else, wrapped up in her arms.

"Adora, I'm sorry."

Bows voice. An apology? That is the last thing Adora is expecting to hear right now.

"Bow? What's there to be sorry about?" she asks, furrowing her brow.

“I know Glimmer was making you feel uncomfortable earlier when she was prying about your date and everything.”

“But- why are *you* apologizing?”

Bow lets out a sigh. “It’s just… I was kind of uncomfortable as well, so I can only imagine how you felt. I’m sorry because I empathize with you. ”

Adora gives him a smile.

“Glim just… really wants to see you two happy together,” Bow continues. “And sometimes I think she gets a little too excited.”

That’s a good way to put it. Adora knows that Glimmer never meant to cause any discomfort; she was just being a bit overzealous. But, then again, that’s classic Glimmer.

“How do you feel about this, Bow? About… me and Catra?”

Bow smiles. “I meant what I said earlier. You two were destined for each other. I’ve never seen two people who just *work* like you guys do.”

“Thanks, Bow. That really means a lot.” That warms Adora’s heart. Bow is such a kind soul.

“It’s the truth, Adora,” Bow assures her.

He’s right, as well. Catra is so much to Adora , and she wouldn’t give her up for the world.

*****

“Where are we going?” Catra asks as Glimmer leads her up several flights of stairs.

“To my room,” is the reply. Catra must have made a weird face because Glimmer adds, “Don’t worry; you’re not in trouble, or anything. I just wanna talk.”

Well, as reassuring as that is, it doesn’t sound any less intimidating.

“About what?”

Glimmer leads Catra out of the stairwell and into a long, familiar hallway on the third floor. “I kind of… wanna get to know you. Become better friends, you know? We’ve never really just *caught*

up before. We only really know each other through Adora, and I think it's time that we talked to each other without her for once. Get closer, you know?"

Catra simply raises an eyebrow.

"N-not in a weird way!" Glimmer insists. "Just… as friends. Bow says that he's gotten pretty close to you, and honestly? I'm kind of jealous."

"You *are* ?"

What could Catra possibly have to offer that would warrant any jealousy?

"Yeah. I am," Glimmer says, opening the door to her room and inviting Catra inside. "But, if you don't wanna talk, just let me know."

Sparkles is right; they haven't really interacted at all outside of the war and Prime's ship. It would be nice to become better friends.

"No, it's okay. I can talk." Catra steps into the room, taking a seat on the sofa.

"Great!" Glimmer beams, seating herself opposite of Catra. "I wanted to start by saying… that I'd like to hang out with you

sometime. Just the two of us."

Woah. Not what Catra was expecting at *all* . She had already mentally prepared herself for some awkward, banal small talk, but not a request to hang out *.*

"Hang out? Um, when?"

Oh, I don't know, sometime this week, maybe? Whatever works best for you."

"Um… sure."

How odd. Sparkles is asking *Catra* to hang out, of all people. A year ago, Catra basically *hated* her, and now, she's acting like they're friends. Which… they're not exactly *not* friends, but-

"It's alright if you don't want to," Glimmer says. "Just let me know. I know it's kind of a weird request and all-

"No, it's- it's fine. I'd like to hang out," Catra smiles. "I just… wasn't really expecting that. Anytime this week works for me, unless Adora and I are-'" She blushes slightly, for she was about to say 'busy,' which would've sounded a bit more suggestive than she would've intended. And, if dinner earlier were any indication, Sparkles would've *run* with it. Give her an inch, she takes a whole planet.

"Yeah, yeah, you two have plenty of *catching up* to do," Glimmer smirks.

"Well, that's… *one* way to put it, yeah," Catra mumbles, her face growing warmer.

"Anyway." Thankfully, Glimmer doesn't linger on the subject. "Just let me know when you're free. There's this breakfast place in Seaworthy that Bow and I *really* love. I think you'd like it, too!"

"Sure. I'll let you know."

"Good!"

This is followed by a weird silence, one in which Catra isn't really sure what to say.

For some reason, maintaining a conversation with Sparkles isn't as easy as doing so with Bow or Adora. Maybe they just need to spend a bit more time together and get to know each other better, and it will become easier.

Well, now they *will* be spending time together, just the two of them, probably sometime this week. It's a good thing that reconstruction is over, because if that were still going on, Catra

wouldn’t have set aside any room in her busy schedule for anyone other than Adora.

“Alright! With *that* out of the way,” Glimmer announces suddenly. “Let’s talk.”

“About what?” Catra asks.

“I don’t know, what do you wanna talk about?”

Catra’s mind goes somehow even more blank. There’s absolutely nothing she can think of that would be interesting to talk about.

Well, actually… There are *plenty* of things to talk about, but they all involve Adora. But of course, bringing her up would defeat the purpose of this meeting. This is about Catra and Sparkles.

Maybe she can ask about Sparkles’ childhood? Her friends, her family? Yeah, that might be a good starting point.

Although… In return, Catra would probably get questions about her own childhood, ones that she doesn’t have answers to. She never knew her parents, never had any friends, never had anyone who cared about her.

Except Adora, of course, but *then again* -

"Catra? Is everything okay?" Glimmer asks.

"Oh- y-yeah. I was just… Sorry. I don't really know where to start."

"That's okay! I can start, if you'd like."

Suddenly, Catra gets a wonderful idea. At the dance, she had thanked Bow for her room, but not Sparkles. That will probably be a good starting point.

"No, I'll start," she says.

Glimmer's eyes widen for a moment, as if she is surprised that Catra actually has something to say, and then her face forms into a warm smile.

"Okay, go ahead!"

"Alright, um." Catra wrings her hands awkwardly as she tries to put her words together. "I've been meaning to thank you for my- um. Me and Adora's- t-the *room* . It's… I appreciate it."

That could have been a lot better. Again, Catra finds herself unable to relax around Sparkles, unable to speak her mind without sounding stressed out.

Glimmer's smile widens into a broad grin. "You're welcome, Catra! I'm so glad you like it!"

Catra doesn't really know how to respond to that, so she just gives her a smile that she hopes doesn't look strained.

"Did you thank Bow?" Glimmer continues. "He was the mastermind behind most of the design choices. I *really* couldn't have done it without him."

"Yeah, I thanked him. At the dance."

"Good. He deserves it."

"Why?" Catra asks, unable to stop herself.

Glimmer gives her a weird look, something between surprise and confusion. "Um. Because he did a lot of work on the room, and he-"

“No, I mean, why did you-” Catra starts.

Since when does Catra deserve anything? All she ever did to Bow and Glimmer was hurt them, and hurt their friends. So, why’d they go out of their way to do something so incredibly generous for her?

“Why’d you… do this? F-for me?” she asks.

Glimmer bites the inside of her cheek in a contemplative expression. She looks like she is choosing her next words very carefully.

“Well, to be completely honest, I don’t know. It just felt right. I mean… you’ve changed.”

Catra raises her eyebrows.

“I- I just wanna be your friend, alright?” Glimmer blurts, and she goes slightly red.

“O-okay,” Catra says, feeling it would be pointless to ask why she deserves friendship. “I can do that.”

“Really?” Glimmer says, her face lighting up.

“Yeah, Sparkles. Really.”

“Yes! The Best Friend Squad is now complete!”

Catra can’t help but laugh. “Was that really what you brought me up here to tell me?”

“Well, *kind* of. I also wanna hear about your life,” Glimmer says. “I- If you want to talk about it, I mean,” she quickly adds. “You don’t have to.”

Here we go. Exactly what Catra was dreading.

“There’s not much to talk about, Sparkles. My life was pretty…” Horrible. Terrible. Painful. Just a few words that come to mind right now. “Um. It wasn't all that special.”

“I- I’m sorry. I shouldn’t have asked. Just… Forget it.”

“It’s okay. There’s just… not really much else to say. I never knew my parents, and I don’t remember anything before the Horde,” Catra explains. “If there *was* anything before the Horde. I don’t even know how I ended up there.”

Glimmer furrows her brow. “I’m sorry, Catra.”

“It’s fine,” Catra flatlines, and she changes the subject. “What about you? How was your childhood?”

“Me? Oh, it was very… different. From yours, I mean. I grew up as the successor to the throne of one of the largest kingdoms in Etheria, so as you can probably imagine, I was pretty spoiled as a child,” Glimmer chuckles. “I didn’t really know my dad growing up because we- we lost him. In a battle with the Horde. We thought they killed him, but they sent him to Beast Island to die instead. Not like that’s any better.”

Catra’s ears droop.

“W-well, you didn’t have anything to do with that, Catra,” Glimmer stammers. “It happened when I was really young, and you and I are around the same age, so you were a child as well.”

“Yeah…” Catra shudders as she remembers that she too has given the order to send someone to Beast Island before. Someone she knew. Someone who didn’t deserve it.

“Anyway,” Glimmer says, her voice brighter now. “My dad survived, and he made it back to Bright Moon in one piece. I am *very* grateful for that,” she smiles. “But… I wish I could’ve known him more when I was younger.”

If the *Horde* didn't exist, maybe Glimmer would have been able to grow up happily with her father. Catra feels her blood boiling from anger at the Horde, and at herself.

"I-I'm sorry, Sparkles," she says. "I know what that's like, to grow up without a father. I never knew mine either. Well- I don't even know if I ever *had* a father. Or a mother. The closest thing I had to a 'parent' was Shadow Weaver, but…" Catra swallows dryly.

"Yeah, hardly 'mother' material, I imagine." Glimmer gives her a slight grimace.

"That's *one* way to put it," Catra grumbles. "Sometimes, I wish I knew my real parents. But… I have a feeling it's better that I didn't, because I think they abandoned me as a child. Adora… she found me in a box somewhere." She chuckles softly.

" *Really* ?? She's never told me that!" Glimmer laughs.

"Yeah, well," Catra grins. "She might not even remember. But, I do. In fact, I think my earliest memory is Adora's face when she found me. She was… pretty surprised, to say the least."

"Oh my goodness. That is *adorable* ."

“I will claw you, Sparkles.”

“Ugh, Fine,” Glimmer scoffs. “That is terrible, and my day was going great until you told me.”

“Wow, were you *always* this sassy, Sparkles?”

“Oh, you think *I’m* sassy?” Glimmer says, raising an eyebrow. “Wait ‘till you meet my mo-”

She cuts off, as if a knife had sliced through her words, and her face morphs into an unreadable expression.

“Y-your mom?” Catra asks, unsure of why Sparkles just randomly froze in place. “Yeah, I’d like to meet her, i-if that’s okay with you.”

“You can’t,” Glimmer says, her voice eerily calm. Catra shivers.

“Uh, why not?”

“She’s gone.”

Catra feels her heart drop out of her chest.

Judging by Glimmer's tone, she must've been very close to her mother, and the memory of losing her might still be fresh on her mind.

That might mean it happened recently. In that case, it's probably best not to ask about it.

"I- I'm sorry. I didn't know," Catra breathes.

Glimmer actually manages to smile, but a tear is glistening in the corner of her eye. "It's okay, Catra. It's not your faul-"

But then, her smile disappears, her eyes widen, and she gives Catra a look, something between fear, regret, and… anger?

Catra's stomach does an uncomfortable lurch. Could it be that…

No.

If it *was* her fault, Glimmer would not be speaking with her right now.

But… Why did she falter?

“I-it’s not?” Catra breathes, dreading the answer to that question.

“You… I mean… it was- the *portal* was-” Glimmer pauses again, this time clapping her hand over her mouth. A tear slides down her face.

The world stops.

Catra’s veins turn to ice.

As if in a trance, she stands up and starts to back away, her head filled with the sound of her thundering pulse.

“ *No* , Catra, wait!” Glimmer yells, extending her hand, but her voice sounds murky and muffled, as if she were underwater.

Catra runs. She turns on her heels and tears through the door in front of her, deaf to the sounds of Glimmer’s pleas, of the thunder ringing through the hallway, of her own ragged hyperventilation.

*****

'What could they possibly be talking about?' is the question that keeps popping up in Adora's mind as she fiddles with her spoon and empty bowl, but each time it is met with the same answer.

I have no idea.

She probably shouldn't be worrying about it as much as she is, given that Catra will most likely tell her all about her conversation with Glimmer when they finish.

Why *is* she worrying about it, anyway? It's none of her business. This is a conversation between her two friends, and Adora isn't a part of it.

Then again, when is the phrase 'I want to speak with you in private' ever followed up by something insignificant?

Adora pushes those thoughts out of her mind. She knows that if she keeps overthinking this, she won't be able to stop herself from coming up with increasingly terrible situations that will inevitably make her fret more than she already is.

But… it's *natural* to be worried right now, right? For her friend?

Her… friend. Adora has been thinking about this for a while now, but for some reason, that word just doesn't sound right. Catra is *way* more than a friend to Adora. She still has kiss marks on her

neck from earlier today to prove that. And all over her collarbone area. It's a good thing she is wearing a jacket that has a poppable collar.

"Adora, are you alright?" Bow asks, and Adora jolts back into her surroundings.

"Yeah, I'm fine. S-sorry, just… thinking."

Bow looks contemplative for a moment, and then says, "It's about Catra, isn't it?"

Adora is convinced that Bow can see into her soul. That's not fair.

"Y-yeah, how'd you know?"

"Uh, your face is *bright* red, and unless you somehow suddenly got a sunburn indoors *and* in the middle of a thunderstorm, then I think it's pretty obvious what you're thinking about."

If Adora's face wasn't flushed enough already, it *definitely* is now.

"You can talk to me, Adora," Bow continues. "I'm no Catra expert myself, but I'm also not a brick wall."

“What is she?” Adora blurts before she can stop herself.

Bow, looking aptly dumbfounded, simply blinks in response.

“I-I mean- what is Catra to me, Bow?” Adora stammers. “What do you think?”

“Um…” Bow says, bringing his pointer finger and thumb up to rub his chin. “I can’t *decide* that for you, Adora.”

“I- I mean, she’s not my friend- well, she *is,* but not *really* -” Adora cuts herself off before she can say something even dumber than that.

“Right,” Bow agrees, to Adora’s surprise. “I understand. She’s *more* than a friend to you.”

“Yes,” Adora responds, a newfound clarity behind her words. “That’s *exactly* right.”

“Well, what do *you* want to call her, then?”

That's the problem. Adora isn't really sure just *what* she can call Catra, but 'friend' definitely isn't going to cut it.

Well she knows what she *wants* to call her, but Catra might not be okay with that-

"Hey," Bow says. "I think it would be a good idea for you to talk with Catra about this. Be honest with her, and tell her that you see her as something more than a friend. I'm sure she does, too, Adora."

Bow's right. Adora should have an honest, open conversation about her feelings. She shouldn't hide anything from Catra, no, she *promised* not to hide anything from Catra.

And Catra promised, too.

"Thanks, Bow," Adora smiles. "Your advice is the *best* ."

"Oh, I don't know about that," Bow says, going slightly red. "But, thank you. I try my best."

Adora makes a mental note to talk to Catra about this tomorrow, and not tonight, because they… well. They have more *important* things to do tonight.

Speaking of, it's probably a good idea to start heading back up to her room. Catra may be done with her conversation with Glimmer already. If that's the case, Adora is *definitely* going to get teased for being late.

"I think I'm gonna head back to my room. Thanks again for talking with me, Bow," she says.

Bow gives her a wide smile. "No problem, Adora! I really enjoyed it. We should do it again sometime!"

"Sure! I'd love to!" Adora says.

"Good to hear. You have a good rest of your night, okay?"

"You too, Bow!" Adora throws him a grin, and she steps out of the dining hall into the dark hallway.

Her heart leaps at the thought of seeing Catra, and she picks up her pace up the stairs, taking them two at a time, eager to get back to her room.

But when she finally reaches the door and yanks it open, her heart drops.

No Catra here.

She slumps down onto the bed.

Glimmer and Catra sure are taking their time with… *whatever* they're talking about. Adora knows she shouldn't be complaining, and that what Glimmer has to say is probably super important, but that doesn't stop her from feeling a *little* cheated.

This was supposed to be her and Catra's night.

But… then again, they *did* just come back from spending an entire day together on a date. And, it's not like Glimmer had randomly stolen Catra away without notice. She had asked beforehand, and Catra had agreed.

And it's not like the night's close to being over any time soon. They have plenty of time.

Is Adora just being too selfish right now?

But, before she can find an answer to that question, she is distracted by a resounding *bang* .

Thunder? No; too quiet, and it sounded like it came from down the hall. That was the sound of… a door?

Adora hops curiously out of bed and steps outside into the hallway. As she does, a much louder *bang* , this time *definitely* of thunder, rips through the hallway, and a bright flash of light illuminates a sight that makes her heart clench.

In front of her is Catra, but she looks… petrified. Confused, angry, *desperate* .

“Catra? What’re you-” Adora says, but before she can finish, Catra meets her eyes and freezes in her tracks, looking completely terrified, as if Adora were a manifestation of her deepest, most piercing fear. Then, she turns on her heel and tears away in the opposite direction.

“Catra, *wait* !” Adora screams, not even thinking twice before sprinting after her.

*****

Consequences Part 2

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora talk.

Chapter Notes

Mornin y'all, or afternoon, or whatever it is for you, and welcome to another chapter!!

Thank you guys so much for the continued support. Seeing all the kudos, comments, hits, etc that this fic gets actually makes me so happy and makes me totally wanna write more and more. Thank you. Truly.

Enjoy today's chapter!

Catra doesn't look back. Fueled by adrenaline and piercing fear, she sprints through whatever openings appear before her, not even remotely aware of where she is going, not *caring* where she is going, as long as it is as far away as possible from the people she hurt.

Her feet somehow carry her into some sort of storage closet, and she scrambles inside, shutting the door behind her, retreating into a dark corner and curling up into a ball behind a pile of old mops and buckets.

She killed Glimmer's mother. She *killed* her.

The truth rips through Catra's chest like millions of broken shards of glass, and she collapses onto the floor, her body convulsing

with each strangled cry that escapes her throat, the tears coming in torrential waves, spilling down over her face and soaking into the fur on her hands.

I hurt people. It's all I've ever been good at.

She doesn't deserve Adora or her friends. She never did. That is a delusion, a false reality that Catra was never destined for.

She cries until there are no more tears, until her sobs are dry and her throat is raw and she no longer has the will to move.

And she lays in silence, barely breathing, alone, more alone than she has ever been in her entire life.

She isn't aware of the passage of time, of the fact that she has been silently weeping for almost an hour, alone on the floor of the small, dark closet. Like a broken recording in an endless loop, her mind keeps reminding her of why she is alone, and why she deserves to be for the rest of her life.

You killed her.

You monster.

You never deserved love.

You murderer.

You

Deserve

Nothing.

*****

The hollow silence is broken by a small creaking sound, and Catra's cycle of self torment snaps in two, replaced immediately by a gripping anxiety. She flinches upward, locking her gaze on the closet entrance, trying to make herself as small as possible to avoid detection.

Slowly, the door opens, filling the pitch-black space with a blinding light from the hallway. Adora steps inside.

"There you are, Catra," she says softly, a warm smile on her face.

Catra's blood turns to ice, and she panics, reacting purely on desperation, the desperation to protect Adora from her own claws, to protect her from the truth.

"GET AWAY FROM ME!" she yells, scrambling backwards until her back slams into the wall.

Adora's face contorts into a pained expression, as if those four words tore directly into her heart, but she doesn't back off. She takes a slow step forward, holding her hands up cautiously in front of her.

"No, *NO* , please, Adora!" Catra cries, retreating as far as possible into the corner, her feet slipping in puddles of water leftover from the cleaning equipment.

"Hey." Adora's voice comes out calm and composed. She doesn't halt her advance. "It's okay, Catra. It's okay."

"N-no, it's not okay, I *can't*- I'm gonna-" Catra chokes on the dry lump in her throat.

I'm gonna hurt you, I'm gonna hurt you like I always do… Like I hurt everyone…

Adora stops in front of Catra and extends a hand in a slow, careful movement, as if the slightest twitch will set off something in

Catra, cause her to snap out of her state of paralysis and lash out with her claws.

After what seems like forever, her hand makes contact with Catra's shoulder.

"It's okay," Adora repeats as soothingly as possible. "I'm here, Catra."

"A-Adora…" Catra chokes. She feels Adora's arms wrap around her, and against her better judgement, she accepts the touch. Her hands drop limply to the ground beside her.

Adora is so warm…

As Adora runs a hand gently through her hair, Catra feels her body relax and her claws retract. She buries her face in Adora's shoulder, succumbing to the touch, surrendering herself entirely to the embrace.

The embrace reminds her that she has moved on from her past self, that Adora is showing her love because of who Catra really is, and who she really *was*, underneath the facade of a desperate attempt at control over a life that was broken, a life that was shattered into thousands of pieces, a crumbling existence perpetuated by an endless cycle of torment and abuse.

Where burning anger and paralyzing fear once were is now an empty sadness, and Catra lets new tears come, lets them soak into the fabric of Adora’s jacket. Her arms move upward and lock around Adora’s body, clinging onto her like she’s a lifeline.

Catra’s wailing gets quieter with each tender pass of Adora’s hand through her hair, and after a while, they fade into nothing, replaced by complete silence.

They are silent for a long time. Adora continues to gently cradle Catra's body in her arms, continues caressing her hair to remind Catra that she's here, that she will always be, no matter what.

*****

“I’m gonna let go, okay?” Adora breathes after a while.

Catra lets out a small whine.

“I’m not going anywhere,” Adora assures her. “I’m staying right here.”

Reluctantly, Catra loosens her grip on Adora’s body and lets her move backward. She shudders violently at the jarring loss of warmth.

Adora takes a deep breath, closing her eyes and furrowing her brow, and when she opens them again, they are filled with deep sorrow, complete empathy and understanding.

"Catra," she says. "I talked to Glimmer. She's-"

At these words, Catra feels the panic rising within her again, and her eyes widen in terror. She tries to retreat backward again when Adora grabs her wrist, freezing her in place.

"Listen to me, please," Adora says, her voice commanding yet compassionate. "I need you to listen."

Catra manages to nod.

"Thank you." Adora takes another deep breath before speaking again. Her words come slowly and carefully. "I talked to Glimmer. She wants you to know that she's sorry."

"W-what? No, s-she's-"

Catra is at a loss for words. Glimmer is… sorry? To the person who killed her mother? *How* ?

“Catra,” Adora continues. “She knows about what happened in the portal, because… I-I told her. She’s known for a long time. A-and I have, as well.”

What??

“Y-you knew, Adora?”

Adora nods, tears now brimming in her eyes.

“For… for how long?” Catra says, her breathing picking up.

“Ever since it happened. We-” Adora swallows down the lump in her throat. “W-we never told you. I- I’m sorry.”

Catra’s heart rate starts to pick up. She feels her body start to shake again.

“You… never told me?” she breathes.

“We j-just… It never r-really came up,” Adora stammers, fighting to hold back tears. “I’m sorry, Catra, *really* , I’m… I’m sorry...

Adora and Glimmer knew this whole time. They knew the portal was the reason Glimmer's mother is no longer in this world. And they didn't tell her. *Why* ?

Is it because they didn't want her to know the truth?

What *is* the truth??

"Adora," Catra says after managing to gain control of her breathing. "W-what happened in that portal? What did I *do* to her? To... to Glimmer's mother?"

"Well… someone had to stay behind. To stop the portal." Adora drops her head. "And… that was Angella."

"Stay behind? W-what do you mean?"

Adora draws a shaky breath. "M-my sword was the power source. Whoever removed it from the portal could shut it down, but… Entrapta said that whoever did would get trapped between dimensions, and not be able to return." A tear escapes her eye, sliding down her face and dropping from her chin. "That's… that's what Angella did. She…"

"Trapped between dimensions?" That small detail sends Catra's mind into hyper-focus. If Angella is still trapped, that means there is a chance that- "I-is she still in there? Is she still *alive* , Adora?"

"I-I don't-" Adora pauses abruptly. Her eyes widen and she shoots her gaze upward to match Catra's. "She… she might be!" She stands up, her chest heaving rapidly. "Catra, Angella might still be alive!" Her shoulders droop. "And I… I abandoned her…"

"Can we go back for her??" Catra demands, also standing up.

"I don't know," Adora responds.

"We *have* to! Where's Entrapta? Maybe she can think of something, or open the portal again, or- *anything* !"

"I…" Adora says, looking crestfallen. "I *left* her. It might be too late…"

"But what if it *isn't* ?!" Catra yells. She isn't going to rest until she knows for *sure* if Angella is alive or not. If Adora says she doesn't know, then that means there's a *chance* . A chance that is worth risking.

"She… she's…"

"Adora, we *have* to try."

Adora swallows. “You’re right. I can’t just give up on Angella.”

Catra feels a newfound determination growing inside her, a determination to set things right, to do something *good* for once.

They can’t waste another second. Angella could still be out there, *somewhere* out there, possibly slipping further from reach with every moment they spend in this tiny closet.

“Where’s Entrapta?” she repeats, grabbing Adora’s hand and pulling her out of the closet. “We need to talk to her *right now* .”

“She might be back at camp. We should check there.”

“We need to hurry. C’mon!”

*****

Of *course* , the rain hasn’t let up yet, and Adora is drenched from head to toe before she even manages to start up the speeder. But that doesn’t matter. They have to get back to camp as soon as possible, so they can find Entrapta and ask her about the possibility of saving Angella.

The *slim* possibility.

But, Catra's right. As long as there is a chance, they should at least *try* to find her.

Had Adora seriously given up? What if Angella is still out there? Glimmer had always said that her mom is immortal, and if that's true…

What *really* happened to Angella after she flew into the center of the portal?

What if… she *was* out there, but it's too late to save her because Adora let herself believe she was gone and *abandoned* her? What if they could have saved her if they had acted sooner?

No. She can't know that. Not yet.

What she *does* know is that there is no way to control what she did in the past. She *can* control what she does right now, and she can put her all into finding Glimmer's mother. For that reason, it is *imperative* that they talk to Entrapta as soon as possible.

As the speeder shoots out of the treeline, going faster than it ever has, Catra is forced to weave through several tents as she slows down.

“I hope she’s not asleep,” Catra says, and the speeder finally lurches to a halt outside of Entrapta’s bright purple tent.

“I think that’s the least of our worries right now,” Adora responds, and she steps through the flaps. Thankfully, Entrapta isn’t asleep (does she *ever* sleep?), and turns around curiously at the sound of visitors, flipping up her visor.

“Entrapta!” Catra asserts, before Entrapta even has the chance to speak.

“I swear it wasn’t me!” Entrapta says, throwing both her hands and her pigtails up in surrender.

“No, w-we- um,” Catra stammers.

“We need your help,” Adora says, stepping forward. “It’s about the portal. Do you remember?”

Entrapta’s eyes light up passionately, and Adora braces herself for a long, rambling speech about the science behind the portal machine.

“Yes, I do!” Entrapta chirps. “What do you wanna know?”

Ok, good start. That *definitely* could have been worse.

"Do you…" Adora says, but then she realizes that she doesn't even know where to *begin* . There are so many things she has to ask Entrapta, about Angella, about the alternate reality, about the possibility of re-accessing said alternate reality…

"How do we save someone who's trapped between dimensions?" Catra asks.

Thankfully, Entrapta seems to understand, as if asking her this question is as simple as asking her about her favorite color. Which is probably purple.

"That's easy," she replies, not missing a beat. "In order to enter or leave the space between dimensions, there first must be two or more dimensions active, meaning you are going to need to open up a second dimension, and the easiest way to accomplish that, at least that *I've* found, is through Hordak's portal machine."

"R-really?" Adora says, her heart leaping. "It's that simple?"

"Well, not *really* . A portal requires the sword of She-Ra to function, but unfortunately, that's gone now. Destroyed."

Adora raises her hand into the air and summons her sword out of thin air.

“We have She-Ra’s sword,” she says.

Entrapta’s eyes widen to the size of dinner plates. “Woooah, where did *that* come from?? Are you breaching the barrier between dimensions *without* a portal machine? Where’d you learn to do *that* ?”

“ *No* , I’m not-” Adora huffs.

She has no idea how she summons her sword, it just kind of *happens* . But they can’t waste time discussing that right now.

“Focus, Entrapta, *please* ,” she says. “Will this work?”

“Hmm…” Entrapta narrows her eyes in concentration and flips her visor back down over her face. “Well, there’s only one way to find out! Time for an *experiment* !”

She turns and starts to type something into her keyboard. Adora and Catra exchange uncertain looks.

“All-right! A new experiment log has been created! I can’t *wait* to get started!” Entrapta says.

“Entrapta?” Catra asks. “Where exactly are we going to build this portal? We can’t just do it in the camp.”

“Already ahead of you there,” Entrapta responds. “We’ll have to travel back to the ruins of the Fright Zone and to Hordak’s old Sanctum, for two reasons. One: The pre-existing portal device is still there, I think, and we can repair it instead of having to start from scratch. And two: The last portal was highly destructive, to say the least, so we are going to need a site that is isolated from any surrounding civilization. The Fright Zone is the perfect location! Well, not *perfect* , because ideally, a perfect location would be one in which zero outside variables are present that could potentially influence the outcome of the experiment, but no such place exists in any-”

“ *Okay* ,” Catra interrupts. “We can go to the Fright Zone. But, we need to *hurry* . When are you able to go?”

Entrapta gives her a tsk of annoyance in response. “ *Hurrying* means rushing, and rushing an experiment is *never* a good idea. Results take time, you know!”

“This isn’t about *results* !” Catra yells, and Entrapta shrinks backward, crossing her arms over her body. “S-sorry, Entrapta. It’s just… We *really* need your help…”

“Yes, I understand,” Entrapta says after a moment. “I *am* very knowledgeable on these sorts of subjects.”

As much as she wants to, Adora feels like reminding Entrapta that someone's life is on the line right now won't really help anything.

"How about tomorrow morning?" Entrapta offers. "You two can meet me at the Fright Zone at daybreak, and we can get started then."

"Thank you, Entrapta," Adora says. "That will be perfect. We'll see you then, okay?"

"Okie-dokie! Don't be late, or else I'll be forced to start without you!" Entrapta waves at Adora and Catra with one of her pigtails as they step out the tent.

"Believe me, we *won't* ," Adora says under her breath.

Judging by the lack of lightning for the past hour, the storm seems to have mostly let up, but the rain isn't showing signs of backing down. Adora and Catra hop onto their speeder again.

"Let's stay here for tonight so we don't have to drive back," Catra yells over the sound of rain and wind. "I think I've had my fill of water tonight."

"Me too," Adora agrees, and she tugs the steering rod forward.

Thankfully, it takes them less than a minute to reach their old tent, the one that they had been staying in before they moved into their new room at Bright Moon. They retreat inside and dry themselves as best as they can with a couple of extra bed sheets in the storage chest.

Adora collapses forward onto the bed once she is finished drying herself. For some reason, she feels incredibly exhausted. And judging by the soft *whump* she hears next to her, Catra feels the same way.

And despite her state of incredible exhaustion, Adora is not going to fall asleep tonight. Her mind is racing *way* too quickly for that.

Catra went through a *lot* tonight, finding out she was indirectly responsible for the loss of Glimmer's mother. And Angella… is she still alive? If she is, can they even get to her? Can they bring her back?

If they do open a portal again, how will they even *find* Angella? And if they do manage to find her, will someone else have to stay behind in her place? What if they can't even open another portal to begin with?

Adora tries her best to push those thoughts out of her mind, to clear her head and let sleep take her away. But before she knows it, an hour has passed, and she is still wide awake, tossing and turning, her brain not giving her a single break, not a single chance to breathe.

She needs to fall asleep. She needs to be her best, most rested and energized self tomorrow, so she can focus fully on finding Angella and bringing her home.

But that doesn't look like it's going to happen.

Adora, having slept with Catra at the foot of her bed for the majority of her life, knows that the absence of the rhythmic, rumbling purr that she knows so well means Catra is also awake.

So, Adora doesn't worry about rousing her when she says, "Catra, I can't sleep."

"I know," Catra whispers in response. "I can't, either."

I'm sorry," Adora breathes.

"I'm sorry, too," Catra sighs. "I just… I *really* hope she's still out there, Adora…"

"I do too."

Silence falls between them.

Adora feels hopeless. She is uncertain that they can save Angella, *if* she's alive, but there is nothing she can do about that right now. What she *should* be focusing on right now is comforting Catra, but she feels like she can't even do *that* . Catra is in a tough place at the moment, and physical touch might not be the best idea. That leaves speech as Adora's only option, and… She really can't think of what she could possibly say right now to make Catra feel better.

"Adora?" Catra asks after a minute.

"Yes?" Adora responds, determined to do anything in her power to help.

"Can you… do that thing you do? You know, with… with my hair?"

Adora's heart leaps. She is *pretty* sure she knows what Catra wants, but it can't hurt to ask, just to be sure.

"You want me to rub your hair?" she asks.

"Um… Yeah."

"Of course." Adora reaches over to run her fingers through Catra's soft hair and behind her ears, just like she likes it.

Anything she can do to help.

"Thank you, Adora," Catra says, and a purr escapes her chest.

"You can ask me anytime, Catra," Adora returns. "Anytime."

Eventually, the telltale sound that Catra has fallen asleep reaches Adora's ears, and she feels relief wash over her.

Thank goodness she was able to help Catra escape her state of restlessness. Catra has already been through enough today, and she doesn't need a sleepless night on top of all of that.

Adora continues to gently stroke Catra's hair, only stopping when the soothing sound of soft purring lulls her into a deep sleep.

*****

Entrapta is pretty sure she had said at some point that she would start the experiment without Catra and Adora if they didn't show up by daybreak. But, that promise didn't account for the event that the experiment started *before* daybreak, so technically, she's not breaking it.

How do they expect her to wait for 3.56 more hours, anyway? She had woken up extra early to get a head start on the data compilation process, so what's to stop her from getting a head start on the assembly stage?

Everything has been progressing very smoothly, which is atypical for the vast majority of Entrapta's experiments, but probably due to the fact that she has-

"Emily! I need your brain again!" Entrapta says, flipping up her visor and laying down her tool.

The round repurposed Horde bot beeps and boops excitedly, scuttling over to where Entrapta sits poised on her throne of hair.

"Can you pull up the data from Hordak's portal research again? The spreadsheet?"

Emily trills happily and displays a complicated hologram from her holographic emitter.

"That's the one!" Entrapta shifts her hair-chair into a more elevated position. "Alright, let's see…"

She mumbles to herself as she peruses the vast spreadsheet, pausing occasionally to turn back, tools in hand (and hair),

towards the four dilapidated, half-assembled metal sections of the previous successful portal attempt.

"Emily, I need a size C hex driver," Entrapta says as she closely examines a particular metal panel on one of the chunks of the portal chassis.

Emily whirrs across the sanctum and uses their opposable digit to grasp the tool in question from Entrapta's massive toolbox, and they shuffle forward and drop it into Entrapta's outstretched hand.

"Thank you!"

Despite the apparent state of disrepair that the outer casings of the parts of the portal machine are in, their internals are actually very intact. Not completely, of course, but in a much better condition than Entrapta had expected. However, that doesn't mean that they're in *good* condition just yet.

Of course, the glaring issue here is the fact that there shouldn't be four parts to this portal, but *three* .

The two bottom sections are relatively fine, but the top section was cleaved in two by… something. Something sharp, judging by how clean the cut is. Which means the top section will have to be put completely back together. And the wires inside, all *also* sliced

in two, are going to need a good soldering, as well. That will take a very long time to complete.

With her hex driver, Entrapta removes the outer panels of the left piece of the top section of the machine. Before she can get started on soldering, she needs to make sure all wires are present and accounted for.

Good thing the wires are color coded, for the most part. Any non-colored wires are going to need to be labeled.

"Emily, this is going to be *fun* !" Entrapta effuses, and Emily gives her a beep of excitement in response.

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What Will Be Lost

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra should be prepared this time around, right?

Chapter Notes

Hey y'all! I hope your day is going swimmingly :)

Welcome to chapter 15. Things are getting... fun

Enjoy!

Catra jolts awake and discovers that she is wrapped around a sleeping Adora from behind. Weird. She doesn't remember moving into this position.

Not that she's complaining, or anything.

But, as much as she wants to stay here, and close her eyes and drift off to sleep holding the love of her life, she can't. *They* can't. They have a portal to build.

And… Catra's to blame for that.

Reluctantly, she removes her arm from Adora's grip and unwraps herself from around her body. Carefully, she shakes her awake.

"Mmm…" Adora groans, rubbing her eyelids.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra says, reaching down with her thumb to gently sweep Adora’s bangs out of her face.

“Hey, Catra,” Adora replies, stifling a yawn with the palm of her hand. “Is it daybreak yet?”

“No, not yet.”

“Good. How much time do we have?”

Catra, still reluctant to leave the warmth, slogs out of bed and pokes her head out of the tent flaps. The rain is finally gone, and the dim red hue hanging over the tips of the trees of the Whispering Woods tells her that they don’t have much time until sunrise.

“It’s almost morning,” she says, turning back to face Adora. “We should probably get going.”

“Right,” Adora agrees, and she rolls out of bed.

Once Catra is dressed, she goes to her nightstand and finds Adora’s pin sitting on top of it. She fastens it to her belt, taking great care to ensure that it won’t fall off or get lost. This has

become an essential part of her morning routine ever since Adora gave her the pin.

"You ready?" Adora asks, once they are both dressed.

"Yeah," Catra replies, double checking that her pin is fastened securely. "Let's go."

As Catra steps outside and onto the speeder, she notices that Adora is uncharacteristically silent. Adora's only ever like this when she's really worried about something.

For good reason.

She's not the only one who's worried. Catra's stomach has already lurched uncomfortably in anticipation so many times this morning that she's lost count.

What if the portal doesn't work? And if it does, what if they aren't prepared to handle what they find inside of it?

What if Catra messes up her only chance to save Angella?

What if… Angella is no longer…

Catra feels a hand interlock with hers. Adora's hand. It brings her to her senses.

And Adora simply gives her a warm smile, squeezing her hand.

Catra doesn't let go. She can't afford to.

And as the speeder zips through the treeline, Catra reminds herself that she's doing this with the person she trusts more than anyone in the world, the person who has endured countless trials with her, the person who's been by her side for almost her entire life.

That thought does wonders to ease Catra's anxiety as they speed towards the Fright Zone.

At some point, however, Adora lets go of her hand, and she lets out a gasp.

"Catra?" she asks, her voice shaking.

"W-what's wrong?" Catra responds, feeling the uncomfortable dread rising within her again.

"If… if we do find Angella, how are we going to get out of the portal?"

"W-what do you mean?" Catra's heart drops. She has a good feeling that she knows exactly what Adora is about to say, but is terrified of hearing it all the same.

"Well…" Adora says, furrowing her brow. "Someone has to… to stay behind. To shut down the portal."

Catra doesn't respond. Instead, she tries, and fails, to swallow the lump in her throat.

"I mean…" Adora continues. "The entire reason Angella was trapped in there in the first place was because… she had to stop the portal."

"No…" Catra breathes. The pace of her heartbeat quickens.

"What are we going to do, Catra?" Adora asks, sounding panicked. "W-who's going to stay behind?"

"No! There *has* to be another way!" Catra says defiantly.

"I-I don't know, there's…" Adora drops her head.

There *has* to be some way to shut down the portal that doesn't involve sacrificing someone. There is *no way* Catra is going to let anybody stay behind, including herself. They are going to save Angella, and no matter what it takes, they are all going to leave *together* .

"Adora," Catra says. "How exactly was the first portal shut down?"

Adora swallows and furrows her brow. This… must be a painful memory for her. But Catra *needs* to know, she needs to know every detail so she can figure out how to do this without losing someone.

"It's…" Adora says, drawing a shaky breath before continuing. "...Angella went to the center and removed the sword, the power source. And without the power source, the portal couldn't function. I… I think that's the only way…" She gulps solemnly.

Catra's brow creases and her eyes narrow in concentration.

The sword is the power source. And the only way to stop the portal is to remove the sword from the center of it. So, how can they remove the sword without getting trapped between dimensions?

The *sword* .

If Catra remembers correctly, Adora's old sword, the one that powered the first portal, was different from the one she has now. Her *current* sword is not only thinner and more powerful, but more versatile. For example, Adora has the ability to-

"Adora!" Catra says, suddenly struck with inspiration. "Stop the speeder!"

Adora tugs backwards on the steering rod, bringing them to a halt.

"W-what's wrong, Catra?"

"Transform into She-Ra. I have an idea."

Adora obliges, thrusting her hand into the air, summoning her sword from thin air, and grasping its hilt. In a flash of light, she's She-Ra.

"Give me the sword," Catra says.

Adora looks confused, but she obeys nonetheless, handing over the sleek blade.

Catra turns around, and with a grunt of exertion, throws the sword as far as she can. It spirals away until it is completely out of sight, obscured by the thick foliage of the Whispering Woods.

" *Catra* -"

"Adora," Catra interrupts. "You can summon your sword, right?"

"What?" Adora asks, raising an eyebrow.

"Try it, Adora. Try bringing your sword back."

Suddenly, Adora's eyes widen in understanding. "C-Catra, you're-!"

She doesn't finish her sentence. Instead, she raises her hand skyward once more, furrowing her brow in concentration, and her sword appears above her. She grasps it again and gives Catra a wide grin.

"There's your answer, Adora," Catra says, returning her smile. " *Nobody's* staying behind to shut down the portal. Not when you can do *that* ."

"Catra, I-I think that might work! You're a *genius* !"

“Yeah, yeah. Tell me something I don’t know, Adora. *Oof* -!” Catra grunts as Adora, no, She-Ra, catches her in a tight hug. It reminds her of the hugs Scorpia gives, except about ten times more forceful.

But, Catra’s not complaining, especially since there’s a bicep that’s wider than a tree trunk currently being pressed to her cheek.

*****

“Yep, just as I thought,” Entrapta says, peering at the portable electronic display in front of her. “It was worth a shot, Emily, but this portal is *definitely* going to need She-Ra’s sword to function properly. Auxiliary power just won’t do.”

Emily gives a monotone beep.

“I know, such a hassle!” Entrapta agrees. “But, Adora will be here soon, and then we’ll be in for a *treat* ! Ooh, I can’t *wait* !”

“I *am* here, Entrapta,” Adora says.

“Woah!” Entrapta jolts, turning around to face Adora and Catra. “How long have you two been standing there?”

“About five seconds,” Catra responds matter-of-factly.

“Weird. I didn’t notice your entrance,” Entrapta says, and she stares at Adora and Catra expectantly. When neither of them respond, she says, “Well. That doesn’t matter. You’re here now, and that means we can *finally* open this portal up! It’s actually happening, Emily!”

Emily trills happily.

“It’s done *already* ?” Adora asks. Didn’t Entrapta say that they weren’t going to start working on the portal until sunrise? And wasn’t this portal machine destroyed?

“Yes, it will function,” Entrapta says. “But I am not entirely sure that it’s one hundred percent safe *just* yet. Well, nothing is ever truly one hundred percent safe, but the point is, with some more time, I think I could tweak it so that the chance of catastrophic failure is at *least*- ”

“Hold on,” Catra interrupts. “What do you mean by *catastrophic failure* ?”

“ *Ahem* . The portal machine undergoes an *immense* amount of stress throughout both the activation and deactivation processes,” Entrapta explains. “And that means that, during those phases of

activity, there is a chance the portal will destabilize, and judging by the simulations I ran, the outcome will be *highly* unfavorable if that happens.

"This portal machine had to be rebuilt from the broken scraps of the previous successful attempt, which means that unfortunately, there's going to be a higher chance than last time that it will fail. Like I said, it will take a good amount of time for me to reconstruct the machine and check for any misalignments or faulty connections, which would *significantly* reduce-"

"We don't *have* time," Catra asserts. "We need to hurry."

Entrapta cocks an eyebrow. "Didn't I already tell you that *hurrying* is a good way to mess up an experiment? There's a heightened chance of failure when you rush results!"

"That's a chance we're willing to take," Adora chimes in, stepping forward. "Catra's right. We're against the clock here. Please, Entrapta," she says, throwing her hand into the air, summoning her sword, and transforming into She-Ra, "we need to activate the portal *right now* ."

"You're right, Adora," Entrapta agrees, to Adora's surprise. "Failure is a fundamental aspect of experimentation, and to be afraid of it is to disregard the nature of *science* !!"

That's not *exactly* the point Adora was trying to get across, but it's fine. As long as Entrapta is on board and willing to activate the portal, she'll go with it.

"Exactly, Entrapta," she says, giving her a smile that she hopes is encouraging. "Now, let's do this."

" *Whew* ! Wow. Okay. It's actually happening!!" Entrapta effuses, her eyes sparkling. "Okay, Adora, put the sword on this pedestal!"

Adora moves forward, closer to the device that Entrapta is gesturing to. As she approaches the pedestal, she feels a pull on her sword, as if it is magnetically attracted to it. She releases it, and it flies forward and snaps into place, floating inches above the device.

"Alright! The red switch on the side of the portal will activate it. So whenever you're ready, go ahead!" Entrapta says, bouncing on her heels from excitement.

Adora starts forward towards the switch, but is halted in place when she feels Catra grab her arm. She turns to face her.

"Adora," Catra says. "Let me be the one to activate the portal. I… feel like I need to. To… to set things right."

Adora gives her a smile. "Okay, Catra. Go ahead."

Catra walks forward purposefully, stopping in front of the large red switch and turning to face Adora and Entrapta, who are both watching intently.

"Entrapta. Can you leave the room? I don't want you to get caught up in the portal."

"L-leave? *What* ?" Entrapta protests. "When I'm about to witness a scientific *miracle* ?? You can't expect me to-"

"Please," Catra says. "I don't want to risk you getting hurt. You said it yourself; this portal is dangerous. So- *please* leave before I activate it."

Entrapta gulps, looking around to Adora and Emily for support.

Emily beeps somberly.

"Yeah," Entrapta says, apparently understanding the robot. "You're right, Emily. Let's go. I wouldn't want you to get hurt, either."

With that, Entrapta shuffles dejectedly out of the room with Emily scuttling at her heels, who also looks somehow disappointed despite their lack of facial features.

When the door shuts, Catra locks eyes with Adora.

"You ready, Adora?" she asks.

"Yeah, I'm ready," Adora responds.

She's as ready as she'll ever be. She pushes any lingering doubts out of her mind, and focuses entirely on their objective.

Save Angella. Bring her back home.

After taking a deep, steadying breath, Catra closes her fingers around the switch and pulls it downward.

This is it.

Bolts of blue-green electricity lash outward in all directions as the three portal fragments levitate upward, locking into a tight formation around Adora's sword. And then, the entire room is filled with a blinding, light-purple light.

The last thing Adora sees are Catra's brilliant gold and blue eyes, and then there's nothing.

*****

Adora is blanking. What on Etheria is she supposed to be saying right now? She knows it's something important, judging by the fact that she's standing in a tent in front of the commanding officers of the Princess Alliance, and they are all looking at her expectantly.

Oh. Yeah. *Duh* . The briefing. The one she's been giving for the past fifteen minutes.

Adora clears her throat. "As I was saying, the assault on the Fright Zone must be swift and decisive. If we strike quickly enough, the Horde won't have time to mobilize its armies, and we can cripple them before they even have a chance to fight back. But of course, you all know that it isn't going to be that easy. Their leader, Catra-"

When that name escapes Adora's lips, she feels a pang of… *something* in her chest. Anger? Regret?

...Longing?

Focus .

"...Their *leader* is bold and cunning, and, unlike the previous leader of the Horde, she's not afraid to fight on the front lines. She's dangerous, but she has a glaring weakness. One that Mermista will be able to exploit. She hates water, and coming into contact with it will compromise her physical capabilities.

"Mermista, you will assume control of a special squad of 5 whose mission will be solely to take down Ca- the leader of the Horde. You will skate the perimeter of the battle, and once you find her, engage her, and *only* her. Bringing her down will take the wind out of the Horde's sails."

Another pang in Adora's chest. She never wanted it to come to this. To the point where she has to… where Catra will end up…

No. She's already had this conversation with herself enough already. Catra is beyond redemption. The only option left is to silence her, once and for all.

They've been preparing for this attack for weeks, and she is *not* going to get cold feet the day before it starts.

"I know you all already know this, but let me go over it once again," Adora continues. "There will be a total of 9 squads, each containing around twenty personnel. Squad 1 is going to be led by myself, Squad 2 by Glimmer, Squad 3 by Bow, Squad 4 by Frosta, Squad 5 by Perfuma, Squad 6 by Netossa, Squad 7 by Spinarella, Squad 8 by Seakawk, and the 9th and final Squad, led by Mermista, will have five members instead of twenty. Each squad

leader has specific instructions as to which position to assume during our assault on the Fright Zone. Any questions?”

“Yes, commander. What about Micah?” Frosta asks.

How did Frosta remember to call Adora commander, but not bother to refer to Micah, who *outranks* Adora, as King?

“ *King* Micah?” Adora corrects. “He can’t go into battle. The Horde may allow *their* leader to fight on the front lines, but the Princess Alliance will not.” A scoff escapes her lips. “Any other questions?”

“Um, yeah. When is the assault, again?” Mermista asks.

“We leave tomorrow at sunrise,” Adora responds, suppressing the urge to smack her hand to her forehead because she’s said this a million times. “But all of you need to be ready to march at least an hour beforehand. Remember, we have roll call before we leave in the center of camp.”

“Ughhhhh,” Mermista groans. “Why so *early* ?”

“To catch the Horde off guard. We’ve been in a stalemate with them for a month, and they won’t be expecting an attack,” Adora explains, and she can’t stop herself, “we’ve been *over* this, Lieutenant. Did you sleep through the entire past *week* ?”

"No, I'm just in *denial…* "

Well, *hopefully* Mermista wakes up on time. Adora's going to have some strong words with her if she has to drag her out of bed and get her going. Though every squad will play an important role, Mermista's squad's mission is going to be *especially* critical to the success of the operation as a whole.

And her squad's success means Catra's…

Adora shudders. She can't even bring herself to *think* about that. For some reason.

Catra is the enemy , she reminds herself. *She won't show mercy, so why should I?*

"What's wrong, Commander?" Bow's voice brings Adora back to reality, so she just shakes those thoughts out of her head.

"Nothing's wrong, Bow," she deflects. "Um… Everybody, you know your job, and you know that you need to do it well tomorrow. Dismissed."

The Princesses, Bow, and Seakawk shuffle out of the tent, leaving Adora alone with her thoughts. She already knows that if she

stays here pondering, her mind will take her down a dark path, so she figures she should head back to her own tent and try to get some sleep, even though it's barely evening and the sun's still out.

Yeah, that's a good idea. Sleep it off, and worry about it in the morning.

But as Adora starts towards the tent flaps, a weird, brief flash of light fills her vision. She shields her eyes, and when she opens them again, she's facing… a bed? Weird.

Why is there suddenly a bed in the war room?

Wait… she's not in the war room. As she checks her surroundings more closely, she realizes that she's in her own tent. How did she get *here* ? And when did she hang up her jacket and remove her hair tie??

She pokes her head out of the tent flaps. Is it just her imagination, or is it a little darker outside as well?

That was… strange. Maybe Adora was so tired from all of the war preparations that she drifted off in the war room and sleep-walked back to her tent?

And sleep-hung up her jacket and sleep-removed her hair tie?

Yeah, seems pretty unlikely. And Adora's never sleep-walked before. Not that she knows of, at least.

So, how did she *get* here? And what was that weird flash of light?

Adora shakes her head to clear her mind and flops down on the bed. She doesn't bother trying to remove her shoes because, well. They are already off. *Somehow* .

She tries not to think about that as she closes her eyes. Instead, thoughts about the battle tomorrow drift into her head, thoughts about Catra, about victory, and about… defeat.

Of course, defeat is not at *all* desirable, because that means that Adora loses her comrades, her friends, her *people* .

But… victory will mean… losing Catra. And not just her, but many of Adora's old Horde comrades, the ones she grew up beside and fought beside before she defected.

Either way this battle goes, one side, or both, will lose something. And that's…

Terrifying.

If only there was a way to resolve this peacefully. But, it’s the Horde. Peace is not, and never will be, an option for them.

Adora’s sheer exhaustion overrides her racing mind, and she manages to drift off to sleep in just under an hour.

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Recall

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra must remember.

Chapter Notes

Hey, y'all!! Welcome to another chapter!

I had a fun time writing this one. Enjoy!

When Adora wakes to her alarm, she feels like she didn’t sleep a wink, as if she laid down, closed her eyes, and it was somehow morning in an instant. It takes an incredible amount of effort for her to push herself into an upright position and start getting ready for the march to the Fright Zone.

As planned, once she is done dressing, she heads to the center of camp where she will be doing a roll call. When she arrives, Bow and Glimmer are there already, but nobody else. That’s fine; the others aren’t required to be present for another ten minutes.

“Morning, Adora,” Bow says somberly. He isn’t his usual cheerful self this morning. But, that’s to be expected, considering the situation.

The battle ahead of them is going to decide so much about the future of Etheria. To say that there’s a lot riding on the success of the Alliance would be a *vast* understatement.

And it’s not like they are fighting an army of unthinking robots like they have countless times before. They’re fighting people, *real* people, who have *feelings* , who have *families* .

Adora has been fortunate enough to have never taken a life before, but that… might change today. And the thought that she is going to have to live with that for the rest of her life is downright *horrifying* .

She shudders.

Even though it’s to protect her friends, her *own* family, none of this is any easier to come to terms with.

“Morning, Captain,” Adora responds, and Bow gives her a smile that doesn’t reach his eyes.

Silence follows this basic interaction, as there’s really not much to say. The impending battle hangs over their heads like a stormcloud, flooding their minds with stinging apprehension.

Adora feels sick to her stomach, despite the fact that she hasn’t eaten anything this morning. In just half an hour, she, and almost everyone she knows and has ever known, will be engaged in active combat.

Almost everyone that has ever entered Adora's life will be on the battlefield today.

That's…

Adora shakes her head.

She is the Alliance's *commander* . She can't afford to be hesitant. She must be vigilant and decisive on the battlefront; she must be bold enough to make the decisions that will help them *win* . Because that's what truly matters right now, more than anything else. The fall of the Horde, which will mean peace for the future to come.

Right. Adora must look past her doubts and focus on the greater good. She will… no. *They* will march to the Fright Zone without hesitation and destroy it, just like they have planned for the past two weeks.

Suddenly, another weird flash of light catches Adora off guard, so much so that she actually trips.

Wait, trips? Why'd she *trip* ? She's standing still!

Or, was. When she raises her head from out of the dead leaves below her and looks around, she's no longer in camp. In fact,

she's somewhere that is surrounded by trees, and what looks like the entire Alliance army is behind her, marching forward.

"Adora, you good?" Bow's voice comes from Adora's right, and she turns her head to see him offering her a hand.

"Yeah, I'm alright, but… what just *happened* ??" Adora says. She would ask 'where are we,' but she recognizes this forest. It's the Whispering Woods.

"What do you mean?" Bow asks, shouldering his weapon and hoisting Adora to her feet. They continue forward. "I think you just got caught up on that root."

"No, no, I mean, how did we-" Adora pauses and her brow furrows. Come to think of it, she's definitely seen that weird flash of light before. Earlier this… morning? "Bow, what day is it?"

Bow cocks an eyebrow. "O-kay, did you hit your head, commander? With all due respect, you're acting a bit… *weird* right now. Maybe you aren't… um. In the right… *mindset* to-"

"I'm *fine* , Captain," Adora interrupts, throwing up a hand dismissively. "I'm fine. Just…" Her mind is racing at a million miles an hour. Just 30 seconds ago, they were in the center of camp, waiting for everyone to show up so Adora could do a roll call. So… how on *Etheria* did they get here?? None of this makes any sense.

“Alright, if you say so,” Bow says. “Let’s just… keep moving, alright? We’re almost there, commander.”

Adora shuts her eyes, taking a deep breath and running her hand down her face and over her jaw.

Right.

How could she have let herself become distracted? She has a job. No, a *duty.* A duty to lead the people behind her into battle, to take down the atrocious Horde once and for all. She can’t let *whatever* is happening with her mind right now distract her from what’s important.

And this is the last time she’s reminding herself to get it together. From now on, it’s time to focus completely. After all, how focused she is on the task at hand could very well be the difference between life and death.

Vigilance. Decisiveness. She needs to have both, and *continue* to have both until the job is done. Until…

It’s over.

Until the dust settles and the Horde is gone for good. Because that's what *will* happen today. Adora has no intention of losing this battle. She has to win for the sake of Etheria, for the sake of her friends, for the sake of *everyone* .

As the Alliance army marches forward, the only sounds in the air are the crunching of leaves and sticks beneath hundreds of pairs of boots and the clanking of weapons and equipment. Nobody is talking.

Adora strains her ears for *something* to listen to, some random conversation in the back of the pack, or perhaps a sound made by some wild animal, because the silence is way too eerie. It leaves her alone in her thoughts, leaves her alone and vulnerable to anxiety that she has tried so desperately to suppress for the past two days.

Suddenly, her ears latch onto something in the distance, something that she can't quite identify, but sounds incredibly familiar.

It's a whistle-like sound. She feels like she's heard it before, but if she has, then it has definitely been a while. What *is* that?

What is that *sound*?

And then, it clicks. They are in *danger* .

“TAKE COVER!!” she yells to the soldiers behind her, and she dives behind the nearest tree just in time. An explosion tears through the air behind her, sending up a plume of dirt and foliage right where she was standing just moments prior.

As she scrambles to her feet, another explosion rings out to her right, and another to her left, and *another* , they’re all around her, too many to count-

That’s what the sound was. Horde artillery shells. But- how? They haven’t even reached the Fright Zone yet!

She pokes her head out from behind her tree to scan the area for the source of the bombardment. Ahead of her, she spots it, several orange streaks of smoke slicing through the air as countless more shells are launched upward and towards the Alliance army.

The artillery units appear to be concealed behind a rocky ridge just outside of the edge of the Whispering Woods.

But *why* ?? How did they get there? The Fright Zone is still several miles away, so what are artillery units doing out this far? And- how are they all perfectly aimed at this position already?

That doesn’t matter right now. The alliance needs to focus on survival. Adora checks her immediate surroundings. In front of her is a body, one of someone she feels like she knows, but can’t quite identify-

Another shell explodes to Adora’s left, and she feels shrapnel rip through her left shoulder like a knife through paper. She hits the ground way too late, landing flat on her back and coughing up the last of the air in her lungs.

As she regains her breath, she begins to examine her wound. It doesn't look too bad; it’s not anything that She-Ra won’t be able to heal.

Right. *She-Ra* . How could Adora have forgotten??

Thankfully, the shells seemed to have stopped coming for now, but she doesn’t know how long that will last. Regardless, this seems like her best opportunity to strike back.

Adora stands and throws her hand into the air, but before the sword has a chance to materialize above her, she feels some object collide with the side of her face, sending stars into her eyes. Her mouth fills with dirt as she faceplants into the ground, and before she can properly regain her footing, she hears a voice. A very *familiar* voice.

“Not today, *Adora* .”

Adora feels her heart drop. She pushes herself upward and spits out a mouthful of dirt before turning to face her adversary.

" *Catra* ," she growls. "I'm surprised you left your comfortable little *throne* to get your hands dirty."

Of course, this is a lie, because Adora knew full well that Catra would be on the battlefield today. But, she also knows that when Catra's angry, she isn't as good as a fighter. Getting under her skin is going to be an essential tactic for Adora if she's going to win this fight.

"You'll find that I'm full of surprises, Adora," Catra jeers, apparently unfazed, and she starts to strut towards Adora. "You, however, are not. I knew every single one of your pathetic moves a week before you even made them. You can thank my loyal scouts for that," she says, examining a fingernail, as if the current conversation is nothing more than small talk. " *Wonderful* plan, by the way. I'm simply *taken* by your tactical prowess."

Adora grinds her teeth. She feels the familiar anger that normally accompanies her interactions with Catra bubbling up inside of her, but this time it's more potent than ever.

They were ambushed, and weeks of preparation were *wasted* . How could they have been so careless??

No matter. She can adapt, she can change up the plan. And, Adora's not the only one who made a mistake.

Catra is overextending. And as long as Adora can incapacitate her here and now, the Horde will not be able to win this fight. Without their beloved *lord* , the Horde will crumble.

Once again, Adora thrusts her hand above her head, and just barely catches a glimpse of light at the tips of her fingers before she's on the ground again, this time with Catra on top of her, pinning her down.

"What did I tell you, Adora?! You are *not* turning into She-Ra today. Or *ever* again," Catra hisses, raising a deadly, razor-sharp claw overhead. "Not after I'm done with you."

Adora lets out a shout of anger and drives her knee into the side of Catra's rib cage as hard as she can, sending the Horde Lord tumbling to the forest floor and coughing for breath.

Adora stands up, dusts herself off, and approaches her enemy.

"I expected a bit more of a fight, if I'm being honest," she says nonchalantly, hoping to provoke a reaction.

But Catra doesn't scream in anger, like Adora expected she would. Instead, she cuts to the chase and pounces forward recklessly,

seemingly out of desperation.

Even better. She's no doubt losing her edge.

Adora easily reacts to Catra's *way* too obvious punch, pulling her fists inward and swerving to the right to dodge. She pivots her body out of the path of a clumsy kick.

But as she prepares a right-handed uppercut to counter, Catra does something Adora isn't ready for. She quickly sweeps the top of her foot through Adora's knee with incredible speed, and Adora feels it break like a toothpick.

She gasps in pain, her eyes streaming, and she collapses sideways as her left leg cannot support anymore weight.

"Works every time," Catra croons. "You really are *way* too predictable, Adora."

"Catra, *you* -" Adora tries, but she is cut off by Catra's knee being driven violently into her throat, rendering her unable to speak, causing more tears to well up in her eyes.

And as she tries to gasp for air, Catra raises her hand once again, claws extended, ready to strike. But… she doesn't. She's smiling like she's won already, but she doesn't bring her claw down. She doesn't finish Adora off.

Her mistake.

Adora doesn't waste another second. Suddenly, in a flash of light, she's She-Ra, and the pain in her shoulder and in her knee is completely gone.

Catra's eyes widen and she scrambles backwards off of Adora, stumbling over a tree root as she tries to retreat.

"What's wrong, Catra?" Adora asks, lunging forward and catching Catra by the ankle. "Didn't think I could transform without my *sword* ?"

Catra tries desperately to escape, but Adora easily overpowers her. She pulls Catra closer and grabs her around the neck, hoisting her off the ground and slamming her against a tree.

Catra gasps for air, slashing at Adora's forearm, but her claws are useless against Adora's golden vambrace. Adora tightens her grip.

She has the power to end it now. She can choke the life out of the leader of the Horde, end the war, and return home a hero.

But she simply can't bring herself to end the life of the girl she grew up with. The girl who was her closest friend, the girl who

was always there by her side when she needed her most, the girl she… loved. She *loved* Catra.

There has to be another way. Maybe she can imprison Catra in Bright Moon, use her as a bargaining chip, call for the end of the war, and negotiate for peace, *somehow* .

The odds are slim, but that's the only option, or at least the only option that Adora's willing to take. She's *not* a killer, and Catra doesn't deserve to die.

Nobody does.

Adora releases Catra, and she crumples to the ground, gasping and coughing for breath.

"You…" Catra rasps, pushing herself slowly to her feet. "You should have finished me off when you had the *chance* ."

Her voice is poisonous, dangerous, full of unbridled malice. It sends a terrible chill down Adora's spine. But as she is preparing herself for Catra's inevitable counterattack, she spots something that makes her do a double take.

The golden glint of a small object on Catra's belt, an object that Adora recognizes.

It's… her pin?? Why does *Catra* have it? Sure enough, when Adora checks her own belt for the pin, she can't find it.

Suddenly, something clicks in Adora's mind, *something* that she can't quite identify. Whatever it is, it's telling her to stop the fight *right now* .

"Catra, *wait* !" she yells as Catra lunges forward. But Catra doesn't seem to be interested in backing down. She lashes furiously at Adora, who just barely manages to dodge the onslaught, using her dual vambraces to deflect countless powerful blows.

Adora manages to find an opening and uses it defensively, shoving Catra backward and putting a good amount of distance between them.

"Stop!" she pleads, reverting out of her She-Ra form and throwing her hands outward in a ceasing gesture. "Listen! I don't want to *fight* you!"

Catra falters, her eyes widening in confusion.

"Catra, why do you have my pin?" Adora continues.

"What are you *talking* about??" Catra snaps, her anger still bleeding through to her voice.

"On your belt! That's my pin! How'd it- how'd you- *none* of this makes any *sense* !"

Catra looks just as surprised as Adora to discover a small, golden, single-winged pin fastened to her belt. She runs her fingers over it as if she can't believe it's there.

Realization hits Adora, and she gasps in surprise.

"Catra," she says, stepping forward cautiously. "Do you remember *anything* before yesterday?"

"I…" Catra responds, the pin still clutched in her fingers, the bite behind her voice fading. "N-no, I don't."

"I do," Adora says. "I- I just remembered. *None* of this is real."

"W-What do you mean??"

"Did you have any… weird time slips recently? Like, one moment you're somewhere, and another moment you're somewhere completely different, like you skipped forward somehow?"

Catra's eyes widen. " *Yeah* , I did. It… it happened twice. Once yesterday, and once today."

"Right! The same thing happened to me!" Adora exclaims, taking another, more confident step forward. "It's because we're in a fake reality! I've seen this before. *You've* seen this before. Remember, Catra, *please* . We went through a portal to-"

"To find Angella," Catra interrupts, and understanding fills her expression. "To save her. I-I remember now. Adora, I remember!"

"Yes! This is all fake! *All* of it! The Horde is gone, remember?" Adora says, breaking into a smile. "A-and… I-I love you Catra!"

"Adora…" Catra says, tears welling up in her eyes. She runs forward, only letting go of her pin to throw her arms around Adora's body. "I love you too, Adora. I- I love you so *much* . I *knew* something was off in this reality, like when I was fighting you, I-" she pauses to swallow, and she removes herself from Adora's embrace, crossing her arms over her body. "I-I'm sorry Adora, I- your *knee* , i-it's broken, isn't it?"

"No, don't do this Catra," Adora says defiantly. "It was *not* your fault. This reality is messing with my head as well. And-" she stomps her left foot firmly into the ground, "my knee is fine. She-Ra healed me."

Catra breaks into a warm smile. “You know, I really had no idea you could do that, Adora.”

“Um…” Adora raises an eyebrow. “Do what?”

“I didn’t know you could transform without your *sword* !”

Oh, well,” Adora chuckles. “Yeah. I can do that. I totally forgot I could.”

“Wait, Adora,” Catra says, her tone suddenly warning. “If you transform again, do *not* summon your sword. Remember, if you do, this reality collapses.”

Oh yeah. *Woah* . Catra’s *completely* right. If Adora summons her sword, she will remove the portal’s power source, thereby collapsing the portal and compromising the entire mission.

Thank goodness she was stopped when she tried to summon it earlier, when she tried *twice* . That would have been a disaster if it worked.

Of course, they would have simply been returned to the *real* reality, probably unharmed, but there’s no telling if they would be able to reactivate the portal, or if they would be able to overcome their memory loss again if they tried to enter an alternate reality for a *third* time.

“You’re right, Catra,” Adora says. “Thanks for the reminder.”

“No problem,” Catra responds. “Just… hold off on summoning it until we find Angella, alright?”

“Alright. Let’s bring her home, Catra.”

But Adora’s confident smile fades as the realization hits her. The realization that she has *no idea* how to access the space between dimensions. And- she doesn’t even know where to *start* .

“Adora?” Catra asks. “Where… Do we go? T-to find her?” She seems to be thinking the same thing.

“I- I don’t know,” Adora responds, dropping her head.

“Well… How’d you do it last time?” Catra tries. “You’ve gotten there before. How?”

Adora *did* get there before. The fact that they are still alive on this planet right now is proof of that. But *how did she do it* ??

She racks her brain for the answer, but comes up empty. She retraces the steps she took in the previous portal reality, from getting captured in Bright Moon, to falling through the fake floor, to arriving in Dryl, to talking with-

"Entrapta!" she exclaims. "Catra, we need to find Entrapta and ask her how to access the center."

"You're right," Catra agrees. "She knows more about this alternate reality stuff than anyone."

"Where is she, Catra? Do you know?"

"No, but I saw some stuff that belongs to her in the Fright Zone yesterday before we set out for battle. Well, *portal* yesterday. I don't know if a day has *actually* passed in real life, or if we're just frozen in-" Catra cuts herself off. "Anyway. Let's go to the Fright Zone and check if she's there, yeah?"

"That seems like our best option right now," Adora agrees, and she scans the area for an escape route from the battle. There don't seem to be any clear paths out of the chaos. Explosions are still ringing out in the distance, and the Alliance soldiers are still pinned behind the trees. Getting out of here isn't going to be easy.

But… they *have* to get out. They *have* to find Entrapta and ask her how to access the center. It is crucial that they find a way to

get to the Fright Zone as soon as possible, or else they risk-

Suddenly, there's another flash of light, And Adora finds herself standing not in the Whispering woods surrounded by a raging battle, but in front of one of the side entrances to the barracks in the Fright Zone.

" *Woah* ," Catra exclaims, and Adora turns to face her. "Did *you* do that?"

"Uhh…" Adora says, scratching her head. "No? Did you?"

" *Definitely* not."

"Huh. Weird."

"Yeah."

"Um…" Adora says, and she shakes her head to clear her mind and focus on their objective. "A-anyway, let's move."

"Right," Catra agrees, and she steps forward and unlocks the door to the barracks with a keycard.

They both sneak in silently, passing by several empty bunk beds as they cross the room to the door leading to the hallway.

"Which way?" Adora whispers. The hallway ahead goes two different directions.

"I don't know," Catra responds, scanning the hallway attentively with her mismatched eyes. "Both?"

"Both? We need to choose one."

"No, I mean, we should probably split up," Catra explains. "So we can find Entrapta more quickly. We don't know how much time we have. I don't like it, but I think it's our best option right now."

"Split up," Adora repeats, and she shakes her head. "I-I don't know, Catra, I-"

"You know what, Adora? I've got an idea. Follow me," Catra says, and she starts down the hallway, turning right at the nearest door and unlocking it with her keycard, and they enter into what looks like a locker room.

She extends a claw and slashes the lock clean off the third locker from the left, and she tears it open and rummages around its contents until she finds a small, greenish-yellow badge. Adora recognizes it immediately as a Force Captain's badge.

“Force Captain Grizzlor isn’t fighting today. He’s in medical. Pretty bad accident last week, apparently,” Catra says. “Anyway, take this.” She tosses the badge to Adora, who catches it and pins it to her jacket.

“Um… why?” Adora asks.

“To communicate, dummy. Just press on the badge and you can talk to anyone who has one. Make sure you only talk to me, or you’ll risk blowing our cover.”

“Right,” Adora says, furrowing her brow. “D-does this mean that we’re splitting up now?”

“Only if you’re okay with it,” Catra responds.

Adora sighs. “You’re right, Catra. Splitting up is a good idea. You go right, I’ll go left?”

“Um, maybe *I* should go left, considering that way is a *lot* less dangerous for a Horde Lord,” Catra suggests. “You go right. It’ll be a lot safer that way.”

“Okay, um. Good luck,” Adora says, and she gives Catra a smile, turning on her heel to start down her side of the hallway.

However, she stops in her tracks when she feels Catra's hand close around her wrist.

"Wait, Adora," Catra says, and Adora turns to face her. "Um…" Catra's face goes slightly red. Before Adora can comprehend what's going on, Catra moves her face forward and catches her in a kiss.

"Mmh!" Adora moans out of surprise. Her heart flutters and her eyes widen, her chest igniting with an intense flame. But it doesn't last long, as Catra pulls away after only a couple of seconds, leaving Adora dumbfounded where she stands.

"Be careful, alright?" Catra says, and she turns and runs down the hallway.

"Y-you too!" Adora calls after her, and she tears her eyes away from Catra to focus on her half of the mission.

*****

Shadow Weaver floats towards the electronic display in the corner of the communication room. She extends a thin, grey finger and presses the button to activate it. Several white dots and a detailed map of the ongoing battle materialize onto the display.

“Curious…” she glowers, narrowing her eyes at one particular dot that is not at all where it is supposed to be. “A deserter. I wonder who you could be.”

She presses her finger to the small dot and a data table appears beside it, complete with a picture of a certain someone with mismatched eyes and pointed ears.

“Home so soon, Catra?” she growls, and she shuts off the display with more force than is necessary.

She picks up a smaller device from the table and activates it, and the screen recreates a map displaying the layout of the Fright Zone. A small, white dot is moving across the surface, heading for the Sanctum.

“There you *are* ,” Shadow Weaver scoffs, and she floats out of the room, the heavy door sliding shut with a clank behind her.

*****

Shattered World

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra meet some resistance.

Chapter Notes

Yo, super long chapter today!!

Enjoy!!

Entrapta has *got* to be in the Sanctum.

This alternate portal reality, though completely warped, is still fundamentally based off of the events of *actual* reality, which means that Entrapta is most likely working for the Horde at this point, given that Adora didn't report her among the ranks of the Alliance Army.

Either she's here in the Fright Zone, or she's in her castle at Dryl. Hopefully the former situation is the case, for that would make things a *lot* easier.

Catra doesn't really know anything specific about this reality, only that she's somehow the leader of the Horde. And *that* means that Hordak is probably gone. Maybe he was sent to Beast Island, or something.

Either way, as long as Entrapta is still here, they need to find her as quickly as possible and ask her how to access the space

between dimensions.

As Catra is sprinting silently through the halls, she hears a door slide open to her right, and she quickly hides herself in a nearby entryway, straining her ears for the sound of footsteps so she can determine which direction this person is travelling and avoid them accordingly.

However, there is no sound of footsteps. Instead, an eerie silence and a familiar chilling sensation in the air, one that Catra hasn't felt since-

"Come on out, Catra. I know you're back there." Shadow Weaver's cold voice rings through the hall, and Catra's stomach lurches uncomfortably.

Right. In this reality, things are different. *Very* different…

Catra's brow furrows in anger and she steps out into the hallway to face her enemy.

"I couldn't help but *notice* , Catra," Weaver seethes, "that you have returned home *very* early. I seem to recall you having a… *battle* to win?"

Catra suppresses a growl in her chest and puts on a facade of indifference. She needs to seem convincing enough for Weaver to

let her be on her way, because she does *not* have the time to deal with her right now. She has *way* more important things to do.

"Battle's over, in case you didn't notice," she says, trying her best to keep her voice steady. "The Alliance was a joke. Adora's dead, along with the rest of those rebels. They walked right into our trap."

Shadow Weaver's expression is unreadable as always, but Catra can tell that she is machinating underneath that stone mask.

"How *amusing* ," Weaver says after a moment. "My reports tell me that the battle with the Alliance is in fact still underway, and that *you* were spotted fraternizing with the enemy. Fraternizing with *Adora* , a disgrace to the Horde!"

"Oh, *please* ," Catra scoffs. "Whatever your precious report told you is wrong. Adora is gone. I killed her with my own two hands, and I've got her prized pin to *prove* it." She reaches down to her belt and removes the small golden pin that Adora gave to her, holding it up for Weaver to see. "Remember this, Weaver? Yeah? *This* is Adora's. Or, it was, until I pried it off of her dead body."

Catra's jaw clenches. That was incredibly hard to say.

Weaver is silent, her tendrils writhing beneath her menacingly. She floats slowly forward towards Catra, and Catra forces herself

to stay rooted to where she stands, as to not give Weaver any indication that she's willing to back down.

Weaver stops in front of where Catra is standing and slowly extends a hand towards the pin in Catra's outstretched hand.

Catra reacts off of instinct and she recoils backwards, clasping her fist around the pin and tearing it away from Weaver's reach.

Nobody will touch her pin, especially not *Weaver* . Adora gave it to her, and *only* her, and she is *not* going to let anyone lay their hands on it. The pin means more to Catra than anyone will ever know. It's a symbol of Adora's love for Catra, of the unbreakable connection they share, a symbol of the future that they will create together.

"You're *lying* ," Weaver hisses, and she activates the small handheld device she is holding and holds it up for Catra to see. The screen recreates a map of the battle, with several white dots flashing into position. "The battle is far from over. Every single one of my able bodied Force Captains are currently engaging the Alliance army on the edge of the Whispering Woods," she says, and Catra swears she can see her eyes narrow through her mask. "Except for *you* ."

" *Your* Force Captains??" Catra says in disbelief. At this point, she doesn't even care that her cover is blown. "I *outrank* you, Weaver. Did you forget who is actually in charge here?"

“Your rank is of no concern, *traitor* !” Shadow Weaver spits, and she swells upwards, her dark tendrils creeping along the floor and up the walls, shrouding the hallway in darkness. “I always *knew* you were never loyal to the Horde.”

“Yeah?” Catra shoots back, her anger boiling to a breaking point. She extends her claws. “Why don’t you *do* something about it, then? Go ahead, *Shadow Weaver* . Put me in my *place.* ”

Shadow Weaver lets out a yell of rage and shoots her tendrils forward. Catra dodges easily and turns around, running down the hallway to put distance between herself and Weaver.

“Running will not help you!” Weaver yells, and Catra smirks as she takes cover in the intersection between two hallways.

She unclenches her fist that was closed around her pin and stashes it carefully away in her most secure pocket. Now that her pin is safe, she can fight.

“I could *easily* outrun you, Weaver,” Catra asserts, stepping out from her cover. “But right now, you’re in my way. I need to get to the Sanctum, so I’ll give you two options. It’s either you step aside, or I *make* you.”

“You will never step foot in there again!” Shadow Weaver yells. “You are not worthy to lead the Horde! You *never* were!”

“Option two it is, then,” Catra says, the corner of her mouth curling up into a tenuous smile. “Shame we couldn’t come to an *agreement* .”

Catra springs forward, slashing away a dark tendril that whips in her direction. This hallway doesn’t have much cover, but it doesn’t matter. She’s fought Shadow Weaver before, and she knows how to win. Cover or not, she *will* come out on top.

A blast of dark-purple lightning shoots Catra’s way, and she dodges to the right.

“Insolent *wench* !” Shadow Weaver throws another round of lightning. Catra dodges under this time, flattening herself against the floor and springing back upward in one smooth motion.

“Is that all you’ve got?” Catra taunts. She smiles to herself. This is going just as she planned. She will continue to dodge Weaver’s onslaught of weaker attacks to get under her skin, to get her impatient. Any second now, Weaver will reach her limit and throw out a reckless attack.

Any second now.

“You are a *disgrace* to the Horde!” Shadow Weaver yells. Her next attack is stronger and Catra has a harder time dodging, but

succeeds all the same. As the attacks keep getting stronger, they keep getting slower, something that Catra will use to her advantage.

"Sorry, did you say something? I was thinking about how *hot* that traitor Adora is," she drawls. That seems to do the trick, as it earns her a scream from Weaver, as well as a very powerful blast of purple lightning. Her eyes widen as it bolts towards her, and she just barely manages to avoid it by diving out of the way and rolling over her shoulder.

As she brings herself back up, she notices that Shadow Weaver is backing up, holding both hands over her head. A large ball of dark magic is forming above her, growing larger by the second.

This is her opening. Catra doesn't waste a second. She sprints forward, eyes locked on Shadow Weaver's stone mask, until she closes the distance and slashes a claw clean through it. The mask breaks into pieces and tumbles to the ground.

" *Augh* !" Shadow Weaver screeches, and she reaches downward to gather up the remnants of her shattered mask.

Before Weaver can get her hands on it, Catra kicks away the blood red jewel that she knows is the source of Weaver's connection to the Black Garnet and drives a heel into the sorcerer's chest.

“Ack!” Shadow Weaver grunts, and she falls to the ground, clutching at the spot Catra just kicked.

“Don’t move,” Catra commands, and she moves over to where the small red jewel is and holds it up for Shadow Weaver to see. “Or I’ll break this.”

“ *No* ! You can’t-!”

“Silence!” Catra snarls, holding the jewel up higher, threatening to slam it into the ground and smash it. “I don’t have time to deal with you. So stay here and rot. If you get in my way, I *swear* I will throw this thing on the ground.”

That seemed to get Shadow Weaver to shut up. Good. Catra pockets the jewel and starts forward. She’s done here.

“You’re *welcome* ?? Who do you think you *are* ?!” Catra yells suddenly, surprising herself. Weaver’s now exposed face contorts with confusion.

She has no idea what Catra is talking about. Catra knows this, but she doesn’t care. She just needs to get this off her chest.

“I’ll *never* forgive you for what you did to me and Adora! How you *treated* us!” she continues, taking a defiant step forward. “You can ‘sacrifice’ yourself as many times as you want; sacrifice yourself a

million times, because it will never, *never* be enough! You-deserve- *nothing*!!" Catra screams the last word. Her chest is heaving at this point. She hasn't felt this angry in a long time, but finally, for the *first time*, she feels like it's for the right reason.

She doesn't say another word. Instead, she leaves Shadow Weaver dumbfounded where she lays and passes her to resume her route down the hallway and towards the Sanctum.

*****

"Entrapta?!" Adora calls out, for the twentieth time, and again, to no avail. She lets out a huff of irritation.

At least the Fright Zone is basically empty, because Adora would have definitely been found out a long time ago if it weren't. She has had to finesse her way around a couple of soldiers and guards, but none of them seemed to notice her. Her presence here is unknown to the Horde, and she'd like to keep it that way.

She pokes her head inside another random vent, because Entrapta could be anywhere in this place. *Anywhere* !

The vent is empty, just like she'd expected. Unfortunate, but Adora will find her eventually.

Hopefully. What if Entrapta is not even in the Fright Zone? What if she's off somewhere completely different, and Adora and Catra are wasting their time trying to find her here?

Then again, do they actually *need* Entrapta to access the center? Well, *no* , but… She'd be a big help. Last time Adora was in the portal reality, Entrapta was really the only person who was able to provide information about the center.

But *how* did Adora access it? If she remembers correctly, Entrapta didn't tell her anything about how to actually *get* to the center, only that she had to go there and remove her sword, the power source, from it to stop the world from ending. So, Adora set out for the center, and she… somehow ended up there?

Somehow ended up there ? That sounds familiar. That sounds *exactly* like what has been happening to her for the past few days. First in the war room after her briefing, second in camp just before roll call, and third in the Whispering Woods right after fighting Catra and coming to her senses.

And in each instance, there was a weird flash of light before Adora found herself in a completely different location, like time *slipped* or something. And she has seen these weird time slips before, in the first portal reality.

"Wing D-7, got it." Someone's voice is coming from further down the hallway. "An intruder? Oh, I thought you said- ahem. M-my apologies, I'm on it. O-okay, it will be done."

Adora freezes in place, scanning around her for somewhere to hide. There's an open door to her left, and a closed one to her right. She goes for the open one.

She crosses the hallway on her tiptoes and slides into the room. She reaches for the door to close it, but her heart drops when she realizes that there *is* no door. And she just walked into a dead end.

The footsteps sound much closer now. Adora hides herself behind a couple of boxes in the corner of the dingy room. Whoever is looking for her seems to be alone. She can easily deal with one person, *if* they find her.

The footsteps draw ever closer, and Adora holds her breath as the beam of a flashlight shines into the doorway and the person steps inside. They cross the room to where Adora is hiding, and it's just a matter of time before-

Adora can deal with this, she reminds herself. It's just one person.

"Hey, could you do me a *huge* favor?" she says, popping up from her hiding place, and the guard shines the light directly into her eyes. Ow. "Could you tell the stocking crew that we're running low on… uh… boxes?"

Wow, that was bad. It sounded a *lot* better in Adora's head.

"Identify yourself immediately," the guard commands.

"I'm the uh, the um…" As she rambles on, Adora carefully steps out from behind all of the boxes, closing the distance between herself and the guard. Just a couple more steps, and-

The guard presses a button on the side of their helmet. "Intruder alert!" they yell, backing out of the room. "Wing D-7, near the maintenance hall!"

"Ugh..." Adora transforms into She-Ra, lunges forward, and punches the guard directly in the center of their chestplate, sending them flying across the hallway. They slam against the wall and crumple to the ground.

This is not good. Someone most *definitely* heard that Guard's transmission, and they are probably on their way to Adora's location already. She needs to leave this room and find somewhere to escape to.

If Adora gets captured, Catra will have to make it to the center and save Angella without her. Catra can make it to the center. She's done it before.

Yeah, that's right. Catra was with Adora last time she went to the center of the portal reality. Well, she was *fighting* Adora, but still. The point is she can make it.

Wait…

Adora remembers the moment she accessed the center of the last portal reality. It was when Catra told her that she 'broke the world,' and that it's 'all her fault.' And right after that, Adora shoved her backward and told her, 'I didn't break the world, but I am going to fix it,' or something like that, and that's when she noticed she was suddenly in the center of the portal reality. She had time-slipped there.

Adora hears radio chatter from behind her, and she silently sprints to the nearest source of cover. She has completely lost track of where she is going, but that doesn't matter, as long as it is away from her pursuers.

What *does* matter is figuring out how to get to the center of the portal reality.

Can she time-slip there again? Because she's almost certain that's what happened last time. But… Did she just get lucky?

No. There's a… *pattern* to the time slips. They didn't happen randomly. The first one, which happened yesterday, was after her briefing when all she wanted to do was head back to her tent and

go to sleep. And suddenly, *conveniently* , she was back at her tent.

The second one happened today while she was waiting for everyone to show up for roll call, when all that was on her mind was her determination to march to the Fright Zone. And suddenly, she was marching to the Fright Zone.

The third slip happened when she and Catra were discussing their options for finding Angella, and they agreed that going to the Fright Zone to consult Entrapta was their best option. Suddenly, she was at the Fright Zone. She time-slipped there.

And she had time-slipped to the center of the last portal reality when her mind was dead set on finding the sword and removing it from the portal.

I didn't break the world, but I am going to fix it!

It feels like a long shot, but Adora has a feeling that if she focuses completely on arriving at the center of the portal reality again, she just might arrive there.

And with the sounds of several Horde guards approaching from behind her, it seems like her best option right now.

But before she can try that, she needs to find Catra. Adora presses her finger to her Force Captain badge.

"Catra?" she shout-whispers, concealing herself behind a large metal pillar. "Are you there? Come in, Catra!"

"Adora?" To Adora's relief, Catra's voice comes through her badge. "Oh, it's *so* good to hear your voice. Did you find Entrapta yet?"

"No, not yet," Adora replies, carefully peeking her head out from her hiding place to scan the hallway for guards. "But I think I remember how to get to the center, and we don't need Entrapta to do it. Let's meet up as soon as possible; I've got some guards looking for me."

"Wait- hold on. You know how to get to the center? *How* ?"

"I can't really talk right now. Where are you? We need to hurry and meet up."

"Okay…" Catra breathes out. "Do you know how to get to the mess hall from wherever you are?"

Mess hall. Adora steps out from behind the pillar and starts down the hallway to her left. It shouldn't be too far from here, if she remembers correctly.

“Yeah,” she replies. “Meet there?”

“On my way,” Catra says. “Talk to me if you run into trouble.”

“Alright.”

Adora moves as silently as she can through the hallways, occasionally stopping and hiding to let a group of guards pass before continuing on her way. When she approaches the mess hall, she hears voices, and her heart drops. The guards sure aren’t going to make this easy.

“The orders come from the detention level, m-my Lord.”

Adora stops in her tracks. That voice sounded *very* close. As she holds her breath and slowly backs up, a familiar voice reaches her ears.

“So what you’re *telling* me,” Catra’s voice! “...is that the detention level has more authority than me?”

“N-no, my Lord, that’s not what I was- ahem. W-we will call off the search immediately, as you wish.”

“Good,” Catra responds, and Adora can hear her voice getting closer as she crosses the room towards the exit. “I will deal with the intruder myself. Now, get lost, all of you. That’s an *order* !”

Adora tries to back up as quickly as she can, but her heels hit the wall behind her; there’s nowhere to go, nowhere to hide, and the door to the mess hall is sliding open-

Suddenly, she is face-to-face with a group of five guards, as well as a very smug-looking Catra.

“Found you,” Catra drawls, and she nods her head towards the guards behind her. “Surround her.”

The five guards all activate their stun batons and form a semicircle around Adora, trapping her against the wall.

“I surrender!” Adora pleads, throwing up her hands in submission.

Without breaking eye contact with Adora, Catra moves forward and holds out her hand expectantly to one of the guards, who lets out a nervous squeak and fumbles around in their utility belt before producing a pair of handcuffs. Catra snatches them up.

“Turn around,” she commands. “Hands behind your back. And don’t try anything *brave* .”

Adora obeys, turning herself around and facing the wall. She feels Catra get *very* close to her and fasten the cuffs around her wrists.

"I will take the prisoner to the detention level myself. This one's *personal* ," she hears Catra say. "You! Inform the detention level that I have the intruder under control, and tell them to call off all search parties. The rest of you are dismissed."

"Yes, my Lord!" the five guards chant in unison, and they shuffle awkwardly backward before turning the corner and disappearing from sight.

"Phew. That was hard," Catra sighs, unlocking Adora's cuffs and tossing them to the ground with a dull *clunk* .

"What was hard?" Adora asks.

"Pretending to be my old self again. It's very… *draining* ."

"Oh," Adora replies simply, dropping her head.

"Anyway," Catra changes the subject, "you said you know how to get to the center?"

“Yeah! I remember!” Adora beams. “I-I think. It’ll probably work.”

Hopefully.

“Well, how do we do it?” Catra asks, scanning quickly behind her in case there are more guards.

Adora doesn’t respond. Instead, she closes her eyes and takes a deep breath to clear her mind, focusing all of her willpower on arriving at the center of the portal reality.

They will travel to the space between dimensions and find Angella. They *will* bring her home.

That’s right. There’s nothing stopping Adora from completing this mission, nothing holding her back from the center.

She *will* travel there and set things right.

Adora hears a familiar noise, and when she opens her eyes again, she isn’t in the Fright Zone anymore. Bright purple light surrounds her on all sides, and beneath her feet is a large, expansive floating rock formation.

This place is the center. There's no doubt about it. She knows because she's been here before.

"Adora, what did you just *do* ?" Catra says in disbelief, and Adora wheels around to face her.

"Um…" Adora starts, but she isn't sure how to answer. *She* didn't really do anything. It was all her mind. Or- the portal. She can't say.

"Where's Angella?" Catra asks before Adora can respond.

"She should be here," Adora says, scanning the entire surface area of the rocky floor below her, to no avail. "R-right? She's… she *has* to be…"

"Adora," Catra says, pointing to a spot somewhere behind Adora. "What about over there?"

Adora turns around to find another rock formation surrounded by a much darker purple aura floating nearby. A bright white light emanates from the center.

That *must* be the space between dimensions.

“I think that’s it!” Adora exclaims.

“Are you sure?” Catra asks, sounding apprehensive.

Adora steps forward until the tips of her boots are hanging off the edge of the rock formation below her. “It has to be.” She takes a couple of steps backward and readies herself to jump to the smaller rock.

“Wait!” Catra says, stepping forward. “What if you get *trapped* ?”

“Let me try something, Catra,” Adora returns, and she grits her teeth, sprints forward, and jumps the gap. She brings herself to a stop just outside of what looks like the barrier between the portal reality and the space between dimensions.

She turns to face Catra.

“What… w-what now?” Catra asks, her voice full of uncertainty, her brow furrowed.

“I’m going in,” Adora says determinedly.

“Wait, please! What if you-!” Catra cuts herself off with a gasp as Adora reaches out and plunges her hand through the dark purple

barrier.

It feels… normal? Adora had expected to feel some sort of odd magicky sensation, but that is not the case. She doesn't feel *anything* . She removes her hand from the barrier.

"If my hand can leave, I can leave," she points out, turning back to face Catra.

"A-are you sure?"

"No," Adora says, letting out a sigh. "I'm not. But… We've come this far, Catra! We can't just give up now!"

Catra gulps and nods curtly, her words seemingly failing her.

Adora gives her a smile that she hopes is encouraging. With a deep breath, she turns and steps completely through the barrier.

The first thing Adora notices is the bright light ahead of her, one that is being created by what appears to be her sword. She shields her eyes from its brilliance as she walks forward.

Below the sword, there's the outline of a very tall woman with long, unkempt pink-purple hair. That *has* to be Angella!

Adora sprints over to kneel beside the unconscious woman and immediately feels for a pulse.

Please be alive, please be okay…

Tears of joy well up in Adora's eyes as the feeling of a beating heart reaches her fingertips.

" *Yes…* " she breathes out.

Angella looks to be in terrible shape. She's horribly thin, and her face is paler than ever. Her cheekbones are showing through the taut skin covering her face.

She doesn't seem to be injured in any way, and other than looking very starved and dehydrated, she appears to be completely fine.

Adora transforms into She-Ra and cradles Angella in her arms. Quickly and carefully, she stands and heads towards the purple barrier ahead of her.

She made it in. Now, it's time to leave.

Adora is met with no resistance as she passes easily through the barrier and jumps to the other, larger floating rock formation.

"A-Angella!" Catra exclaims, sprinting forward, tears sliding down her face.

"She's alive, Catra! She's *alive* !" Adora says, smiling broadly, and she carefully lays Angella down on the ground in front of her.

Catra chokes back her tears and breaks into a smile of her own. She moves forward, throws her arms around Angella, and buries her face in her shoulder.

Adora doesn't waste another second. She throws her hand up into the air and her sword materializes from thin air. As she grasps its hilt, her vision is flooded with a bright purple light and her ears are filled with a rushing noise, getting louder and louder-

And then...

All sound stops. Only for a fraction of a second, however, and Adora barely catches a glimpse of her surroundings before her ears are filled with a deafening *boom* . She feels herself being thrown forward by the blast, and she falls onto Angella's body.

Her ears ringing, she reverts out of her She-Ra form and checks for Angella's pulse again.

She lets out a sigh of relief. Angella is still alive. Thank *goodness* .

"Adora? Did- did we make it?"

"Catra!" Adora wheels around at the sound of the voice. Laying on the ground amongst countless shards of what looks like the remains of the completely destroyed portal machine is Catra, and she's…

Adora's stomach lurches. She sprints over to Catra and kneels by her side, grasping her hand.

"A-Adora…" Catra breathes.

"Hold on, Catra, I-I'm-"Adora's voice fails her, her heart twisting violently at the sight of blood soaking through every inch of what is left of Catra's charred shirt, pooling onto the ground below her.

Catra gives her a weak smile. "Speak up, dummy. I can barely hear you."

"I-It's okay, Cat, j-just hold on…" Adora rips her gaze away from Catra's destroyed body and throws her hand into the air, fighting back the tears welling up in her eyes, fighting back the urge to

scream, focusing every ounce of her willpower on making her sword appear above her.

In a small flash of light, a portion of the blade appears, but no hilt just yet, just a bit longer, and it will-

"A-Adora?"

Adora's blood turns to ice.

The panic, the sheer terror behind Catra's voice sends a wave of deep, piercing dread straight into Adora's heart. The sword flickers weakly above her hand.

No, no, NO!

Adora needs She-Ra, *Catra* needs She-Ra, now more than ever. Adora tries desperately to push the pounding, pulsating fear out of her mind, to cling onto the wavering hope that Catra is going to be okay, that she is going to *live* , that Adora will summon She-Ra and heal her, that everything will work out, and they will return to-

"Adora? W-where'd you go? P-please don't leave…"

Eerie silence follows these words, chilling Adora to her core, and she feels Catra's hand lose its grip on hers.

All evidence of pain and contortion disappears from Catra's face. Her head rolls limply to the side.

"C-Catra?" Adora breathes.

Cata doesn't respond. Her mismatched eyes are staring blankly forward, fixated on nothing.

S-she's sleeping. She's…

"Catra?" Adora repeats, her voice breaking. "C-Cat, say something…"

Please… anything…

Adora *has* to heal her.

She steels her mind and focuses her gaze determinedly upward, throwing her hand up into the air. She *will* transform, she *will* heal Catra, and it will all be okay; she's done it before, and she can do it again.

Thank *everything* ; Adora feels her heart jump as her sword starts to reappear above her. She grasps the hilt as soon as it is solid, transforming into She-Ra, and she immediately places her hands on Catra, pleading with every cell in her body to heal her, they need to heal Catra, they *have* to heal Catra, before she…

No.

Adora shoves every one of those horrible thoughts out of her mind, repeating the same words over and over again in her head to fill the terrifying silence;

It's okay, it's okay, it's okay, it's okay…

It's gonna be okay…

It works, and she begins to glow a pure, brilliant white.

Slowly, methodically, the countless gashes covering Catra's body start to close up, weaving themselves together as if they had never existed in the first place.

Adora rasps out a shaky sigh of relief and reaches down to cradle Catra in her arms, a healed-up Catra, a *healthy* Catra.

Any second now, she’s going to wake up. She’s going to look into my eyes and tease me, then she’ll laugh at me for taking too long to heal her…

Catra doesn't move.

Yes, any second now… just a little bit longer, and I’ll see her smile…

I love her smile…

Catra doesn’t move.

Why… isn’t she moving…

Slowly, Adora lowers her ear to Catra’s chest in a movement that takes an eternity, an eternity plagued by the horrible thought that she may not hear anything.

She makes contact with Catra’s chest. She strains her hearing for the faint thump that means Catra is alive, that means Catra will wake up from this nightmare…

There is no such sound. Instead, a hollow, horrific silence.

The world slows to a halt.

Adora lets out a guttural scream that tears her vocal cords in two, and she collapses onto Catra’s cold body, sobbing violently into the tattered remains of her bloodstained shirt.

*****

Cost

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Everything's over. There's nothing left.

Nothing.

Nothing.

...Nothing.

Adora doesn't move. Her tears long exhausted, she simply exists, never to make a sound again, never to raise her head again, for she has no reason to.

Everything

is gone.

"I thought I made it *clear* , Adora," Shadow Weaver says, holding Adora back with her arm. "You are not to enter this room, under *any* circumstance."

"Sorry, Shadow Weaver," Adora says, but only to make Shadow Weaver happy, because Adora wants to go back to the room. That room has got her friend in it. She's never had a friend before.

"Run along, now, child. And if I see you anywhere near here again, there will be more *extreme* consequences. You don't want that, do you?"

“No, not really,” Adora replies, but she wants to go back anyway. She wants to go into the room and see her friend. Nobody will take her friend.

“Good girl.” Shadow Weaver kneels down to pat Adora on the head, and she turns Adora around and gives her a push forward, away from the room.

Adora walks away feeling very hopeful. When she goes to bed that night, she makes sure everyone is asleep before she climbs out of her bed to go back to the room and see her friend.

The hallway is dark and scary, but she doesn’t want to let that stop her. She braves the dark corridor and reaches the door, and-

No Shadow Weaver here. Adora is happy about that!

She skips forward and jumps up to grab the door handle, pulling it down with all of her weight, but the door doesn’t open.

No!

Adora looks around for the key. Maybe Shadow Weaver dropped it by accident.

But suddenly, she sees something that will work better than a key! A vent!

She goes over to the vent and tugs on the cover as hard as she can. She is strong! The cover cannot stop her strongness, so it falls off. She climbs through the vent and into the room.

Inside, there are no lights, but there is a window. Thankfully, the shiny moon is helping Adora out tonight, and she can see her friend!

She has really floofy hair. One yellow eye, and one blue eye. They are glowing like little lights.

“Cat,” Adora says, sitting down and pointing at her friend.

Her friend hisses and runs away to the corner. Is she mad at Adora?

“Sorry,” Adora says, slowly scooting forward closer to Cat.

Cat doesn’t talk back or move from her spot. She instead hides under her blanket.

“I won’t do it again,” Adora tells her, promising to herself not to make Cat mad again. Because they're friends, and that's not what friends do.

“What?” Cat says from under her blanket.

She’s talking! Adora is happy!

“I’m sorry for making you mad,” she tells her.

Cat peeks her head out, her shiny eyes looking right at Adora.

“I’m not mad at you.”

“Y-you’re not?”

“No.”

“Are you sure?” Adora asks.

“Yes. I’m pos-i-tev.”

Adora doesn't know that one.

"What's that mean?"

"Pos-i-tev?"

"Yeah!"

Cat sits up and lets her blanket fall from her shoulders.

"It means I'm really really sure."

"I never knew that word," Adora says, letting out a laugh. Cat smiles at her laugh! That makes Adora happy.

"Now you do," Cat tells her.

Adora scoots closer. "I'm glad you're not mad at me."

"I'm mad at the red lady," Cat says, crossing her arms. " *Really* mad."

“I-” Adora speaks really quietly so only Cat can hear, “I’m mad at her too.”

“You- you are?” Cat asks, moving closer, her pretty, bright eyes getting a lot bigger.

“Mhmm. Yup. She doesn’t like me, I don’t think.”

“She keeps hurting me,” Cat says, speaking very very softly. Adora barely hears her.

“I-”

She’s interrupted- the door opens, and Shadow Weaver comes in.

“Adora, you *know* better! I told you not to come back here!” she snarls.

Adora jumps forward to get to Cat before Shadow Weaver can.

“Don’t hurt Cat!” she yells, clinging onto her friend.

“Adora, you get away from that *thing* at once!”

“No! I won’t! She’s my friend!”

“ *Adora*- !” Shadow Weaver sounds very angry. But Adora doesn’t care, as long as nobody hurts Cat.

“A-do-ra?” Cat says. “Is that your name?”

Everyone is silent, waiting for an answer. Adora gives it.

“Yup! My name is Adora. Nice-ta meet you, Cat!”

“That’s not my name,” Cat says.

“Then, what is it?” Adora asks, but Cat doesn't tell her. Adora turns around to ask Shadow Weaver. Maybe she knows.

But… Shadow Weaver isn’t here? Where did she go? Adora hears her laugh from somewhere outside, like she does when she’s making one of her big smart plans, and then her voice is gone.

Adora turns back to Cat.

“I don’t know my name,” Cat tells her.

“Oh,” Adora responds. “H-how do I… What do I call you?”

“I don’t know.”

Adora wants to find out a name for Cat, so she can be happy.
“Can I call you kitty?”

Cat makes a gross face. “I don’t like that.”

“Oh,” Adora says, feeling a little sad. “...Sorry.”

“Your name is cool,” Cat tells her. “I wish I had *your* name.”

“Y-you do?”

“Yeah. A-do- *ra* . I like it.”

Adora’s tummy has bugs in it for some reason. Cat likes her name!
And… if Cat doesn’t have a name, maybe Adora can give her one.
One like hers!

“Cat-ra,” she says, and Cat’s eyes get big again. “Can I call you Cat-ra?

Cat takes a long time to speak.

“Yes, I like that name, A-Adora.”

“Yay!” Adora is really happy! Her friend has a name now! Cat-ra!

Cat-ra laughs, and it’s the first time Adora hears it. She really likes Cat-ra’s laugh. She wants to make her laugh some more so she can hear it again.

“Hey, did you mean it?” Cat-ra asks after a moment.

“Hmm? What did I mean?” Adora says.

“Did you… really mean it?” Cat-ra comes closer. “...That I’m your friend?

Adora smiles and puts a hand on her arm. “Yes. I’m pos-i-tev.”

They will be friends forever.

Adora raises her face out of the grass below her. The details of her surroundings slowly slide into focus. Standing ahead of her is a bright, glowing golden-white figure, one she recognizes as the form of She-Ra.

“HEAL HER!” Adora yells at the figure. “ *PLEASE* !

The figure doesn’t respond. Instead, it looks at Adora with an expressionless, featureless face, telling her nothing, *nothing* .

“TAKE ME INSTEAD!” Adora pleads, tears blurring her vision. “Please, *give her my life* …”

Thankfully, the figure seems to understand, and it moves forward. Adora feels some sort of relief wash over her, perhaps because she wants, no, *has* to believe that the figure will do something to help Catra, or that it *can* do something to help Catra, please, just *anything* to help her…

However, the figure simply throws down it's pure-white sword and turns to walk away.

" *NO* !!!" Adora screams, her voice breaking, her vocal cords straining. "COME BACK!!"

The figure continues to walk away.

"Come *back…* " Adora laments, losing hope. She claws and inches her way forward through the grass, lacking the energy to stand, trying with all her might to reach the figure.

Suddenly, the figure dissipates away, filling Adora's vision with a bright light, and she feels a strange draining sensation overcome her.

And then… she feels the body below her. It's…

...Catra…

Nothing matters anymore. Nothing.

Nothing.

Adora goes completely limp on top of the body of the woman she loved, not even bothering to breathe. She mourns in silence, her mind void of every emotion except deep, consuming, wrenching, empty despair.

But then-

There’s a feeble sound below. Did she imagine it? No- she *couldn't* have- she tenses up, freezing in place, straining her ears for the sound to return, for it sounded like-

A *cough*. Another one sounds from below, and she quickly raises herself off of Catra’s body.

And Catra… *opens her eyes* . Her beautiful, unmistakable mismatched eyes.

Adora stares in disbelief.

“Hey, Adora. You’re back,” Catra says softly, breaking into the smile Adora loves so much, the smile she thought she had lost.

Adora cannot respond. Tears flood her vision as she is completely overwhelmed with emotion. She falls forward onto Catra, holding

onto her, clinging onto her as tight as she can, feeling her heartbeat against the side of her head, a feeling that she is so *incredibly* grateful for right now that she can't even begin to describe it.

"Hey- Adora, you're gonna squeeze me to death," Catra says, wriggling around in Adora's grasp.

"I-I thought I *l-lost* you, Catra… Oh, *Catra…* " Adora sobs, her face buried in the crook of Catra's neck.

"What? What're you talking about, Adora?" Catra asks. "And- why are you crying?"

"W-we made it, Catra," Adora says through her sobs, her words shaking. "We *made it* …"

And Catra is here, Catra is *alive* , thank *goodness* …

Adora feels her warmth. She feels her every movement. She can hear every breath she takes, feel her chest rising and falling as she takes them...

Catra is alive. She's here, and she's *alive*.

Adora's lip trembles as she clings onto Catra. She can't let go.

“Um, Adora?" Catra says. “Was I… asleep just now? I feel… weird.

“Let’s just… get Angella back,” Adora replies, wiping her eyes on her sleeve and giving Catra a warm smile. She can fill Catra in later.

“Good idea. Let’s be quick,” Catra responds, standing up. *Standing up* . Seeing her simply being able to stand is almost enough to bring Adora to tears again.

She's *alive*.

*****

After what feels like an hour, probably due to their wrenching anticipation, Bow barges out of the door to the infirmary.

“Guess what, guys??” he says excitedly, grinning wider than ever. “She’s gonna be okay! The doctors say she’ll make a full recovery in no more than a *week* !”

“That’s *wonderful* !” Adora exclaims, standing and pulling Bow into a hug.

Catra lets out the puff of air that she was holding. “That’s great to hear,” she says, smiling.

“Get in here, Catra.” Adora removes half of herself from Bow and gestures for Catra to join her in a group hug.

“Ugh, *fine* ,” Catra mock-complains, and she wastes no time in letting herself be swept up by Adora and Bow’s arms.

“You guys…” Bow says mid-hug, “I really don’t know what to say. I just *can’t* believe Angella is here! Wait ‘till Glimmer hears about this! And King Micah!”

They did it.

Catra and Adora *did it* .

Angella, Glimmer’s mother who was presumed *dead* , is back at Bright Moon, safe and sound, making a strong recovery in the infirmary.

Catra can barely comprehend all of the powerful emotions flowing through her mind right now, relief, happiness, triumph, gratitude, *closure* .

Her past self, that abhorrent incarnation of hate, malice, and indifference, has never felt so *far away* . It's like saving Angella dealt a final, critical blow to it, destroying every last shred of it, separating Catra completely from her haunting past that has been clinging onto her like a disease for as long as she can remember.

For the first time, she can finally look at herself and say with full confidence that she's *free* .

"Bow, we'll explain everything after; let's go get Glimmer!" Adora says excitedly.

"I'm on it! You two stay here, alright?" Bow tells them. His brow furrows. "Glimmer isn't really… Um. I'll just go get her." He turns the corner out of the infirmary.

*****

"Glimmer?" Bow calls, knocking on the door to their room. "Are you in there?"

If Glimmer is in there, she isn't answering. She's been like this since last night, and Bow has been respecting this and giving her the space that she needs.

He still doesn’t know what is bothering her, but whatever it is, seeing her mother again is *sure* to cheer her up.

“I’m coming in,” he warns, and he pushes the door open. Inside, Glimmer is nowhere to be found.

He checks the closet and washroom, to no avail, and lets out a sigh.

As he turns to leave the room and head back to the infirmary, he gets an idea as to where Glimmer might be.

He crosses the room over to the window, opens it, and carefully steps out onto the small windowsill.

“Glimmer?” he yells upward, hoping that if she’s in their secret spot on the roof, she’ll hear him. “Come down here, I need to show you something!”

No response. Either she’s ignoring him, or she isn’t up there. Just as Bow is about to try again and call her name once more, he hears the familiar sound of teleportation behind him.

“Hey,” he says softly, turning to face Glimmer. She still looks upset. Her eyes are not leaving the floor, and her arms are limp by her sides. Bow figures it's a good idea to maintain his distance.

“Thanks for coming down. I didn’t want to bother you, but this is really important. It’s about… Angella.”

That gets Glimmer’s attention. She brings her gaze upwards, brow furrowed. “W-what?” she asks in a small voice.

Bow reaches outward, offering a hand. “Will you teleport us down to the infirmary?”

“The… infirmary?” Glimmer croaks, her eyes widening. “Why? What’s- who-”

“C’mon, I’ll show you,” Bow offers, smiling and extending his hand further. Glimmer gulps solemnly and takes it, teleporting them away.

“Glimmer!” Adora shoots up from her seat as soon as they appear in the waiting room.

Catra avoids eye contact and her ears fold backward along her head.

“Hey,” Bow soothes, his hand finding Glimmer’s shoulder as her breathing starts to pick up at the sight of Catra.

What could have happened between them?

"Hey, Sparkles," Catra says, finally meeting her eyes. She gives a warm smile.

"Catra, I-I'm- I'm *sorry* -"

"No, it's okay!" Catra, now standing, moves forward cautiously. "It's okay."

Glimmer's eyes are watering now, and Bow couldn't be any more confused.

She takes a small step backwards as Catra approaches her, as if Catra is seeking to hurt her. Bow almost steps between them, acting on pure instinct, but stops himself when Catra reaches Glimer and pulls her into a gentle hug.

Now Glimmer is full on sobbing, using Catra's shoulder as a sponge to soak up her tears.

Bow gives Adora a confused look, who gives him a smile that doesn't really tell him anything.

“C’mon, let’s go inside,” Catra whispers carefully, guiding Glimmer towards the door to Angella’s ward.

Bow’s heart leaps as he and Adora follow them inside. Glimmer is about to discover that her mom is alive. Unconscious for now, but *alive* !

The second she turns the corner, Glimmer gasps and instantly teleports over to Angella’s cot.

“ *Mom* !” she cries, throwing her arms around Angella and burying her face in her shoulder.

“She’s gonna be okay, Glimmer,” Bow assures. Glimmer now has one of Angella’s hands in her own, grasping onto it as if letting go would end the world. Bow kneels beside her, running a hand over her back as she weeps.

He almost tears up himself at the way Glimmer is clinging onto her mother, wailing into her shoulder. It’s nothing short of gut-wrenching.

But what does send the tears sliding down Bow’s face is the fact that Angella is back, *somehow* , and that Glimmer gets to be with her again after so long, after they all thought she was gone.

They’re tears of joy, of indescribable gratitude for whatever miracle brought Angella back.

“How…” Glimmer sniffles, almost too quiet for Bow to hear.

“What? What’d you say?”

“H-How?” Glimmer’s voice is slightly louder now, mostly understandable, but still muffled, as she still isn’t raising her head from its spot on Angella’s shoulder. Bow opens and closes his mouth in response, unsure of what to say, for right now, he could ask the exact same question. He turns to Adora and Catra for help.

“It’s kind of a long story,” Adora tells him.

“It’d probably be better if we told you later,” Catra adds.

“Yeah. Let’s give Glimmer some more time,” Adora offers.

“Okay,” Bow breathes. As much as he wants to know how in the world Angella is back, Adora is right. Glimmer needs time to sort her emotions out. That takes priority here, and Bow is not going to leave her side until she’s ready.

"I-Is she okay?" Glimmer asks.

"Yes," Bow responds, slightly taken aback by the sudden strength behind Glimmer's words. He strokes along the base of her neck with his thumb. "The doctors say she'll be better in a week at most."

"Oh, Mom… I *missed* you…"

Well, that got another tear from Bow. And apparently, Adora as well. Catra isn't crying, but Bow hasn't ever seen her cry, so that's not really a surprise.

"Should I go get Micah?" Adora asks. Bow gives her a nod, and she smiles and turns the corner.

*****

"So, let me get this straight," Micah says, staring forward at Catra and Adora like they are members of some sort of extraterrestrial species. "You went into some magic portal and somehow managed to find my wife?"

"Yeah, pretty much," Adora replies, sparing him the details.

Keeping the details to a minimum is probably for the best, because Catra isn't even sure if Micah even knows about the first portal, about how Angella was lost to begin with. From what she understands, Micah was informed that Angella was simply lost to the war, and nothing more.

"Okay, yeah," Micah breathes. He scratches the side of his head, looking completely dazed. Catra finds it kind of strange that his facial expression hasn't changed at all since they all started talking about this.

" *You* did that?" Glimmer asks, as if she still can't believe it.

"Well- yeah. Me and *Catra* ," Adora clarifies, turning to give Catra a smile. "She helped out a lot. I mean- it was her idea in the first place."

"It… It was?" Glimmer's eyebrows raise. She moves forward, as if in a trance, and wraps her arms around Catra. "Thank you… *Thank you* …"

Catra simply returns Glimmer's hug. It still feels weird hugging anyone who isn't Adora. She'll have to keep getting used to it.

"Angie…" she hears to her right. She turns to see Micah, who has tears streaking down his face now, moving towards Angella. He reaches down to hold his wife's hand, bringing it upwards to place a gentle kiss on the back of it.

And then, he breaks down into heaving sobs.

Catra gulps. To see Micah in this state, the most cheerful guy on the planet next to Bow… It's kind of hard to watch.

"Hey, Catra? Can I talk to you outside?" Adora whispers.

"Sure," Catra says, tearing her eyes away from the solemn King.

Adora takes a deep breath as soon as they are out of the room, out of earshot of everyone in the infirmary.

"I wanted to say this as soon as we got back, but, well…"

"What is it?"

Adora doesn't respond for a couple of seconds. It appears as though she's thinking very carefully about what to say.

"...Do you remember what happened after we left the portal reality?"

All Catra can recall is Adora summoning her sword, a bright purple light flooding her vision, and then Adora, who had tears falling from her face, looking down at Catra, who was laying on the ground for some reason.

They talked about something, something Catra can't really recall, and then… She remembers a weird warming sensation taking over her entire body. She opened her eyes, feeling sleepy for some reason. Adora was laying silently on top of her, and when she raised her head, she started crying again and hugging Catra.

She's definitely missing something here, because these details don't add up.

"Yeah. You started crying," Catra tells her. "But why? When I asked, you… didn't tell me."

"That's because…" Adora swallows and buries her face in her hands. "S-sorry, this is… this is k-kind of hard to say," she stutters, her voice muffled.

Catra furrows her brow and lays a hand on Adora's shoulder. "Hey, what's wrong, Adora? A-are you okay?"

What is going on? What is Adora so upset about?

“Yeah, I’m alright. It’s just that you-” Adora pauses, and she looks like she is having a very hard time saying whatever she is about to say.

Was it something Catra did? Is Adora upset at her for her actions in the portal reality? Catra didn’t have control, she didn’t *know* , she thought that they were still fighting in the war; it wasn’t her fault…

...Right?

“You were gone,” Adora finally says, and Catra stares at her. She isn’t sure if she’s confused, curious, horrified, or all three.

“I… *what* ?”

“On the way back, you asked me why there was blood on your shirt, and… I just couldn’t tell you. I’m sorry,” Adora explains. “It’s because… you were caught up in the explosion.”

“The explosion?” Catra raises an eyebrow. “What *explosion* ?”

“The portal machine- it… I-it blew up when we got out, and you were right next to it, and you- y-you-” Adora screws her eyes shut and takes another deep, shuddering breath.

Okay, Catra is *completely* lost now. She has about a million questions to ask right now, but seeing Adora in this state makes her want to hold them all in, as prying might just upset Adora even more.

So, Catra does what her instincts are telling her to do, and pulls Adora into her chest, placing a hand gently on the back of her head.

She hears Adora sniffle into her shoulder, and feels arms wrap around her body. She carefully starts to run her hand through Adora's hair, which seems to do a good job of calming her down. Thank *goodness* .

Eventually, Adora stops crying and pulls away from Catra's embrace.

And then, she states, "you were dead, Catra."

That catches Catra so off guard that she actually flinches backward in surprise, *completely* taken aback by what she thought she just heard Adora say.

"I was- I was *what* ?"

"Dead," Adora repeats in monotone. "I… I checked your heartbeat after you were caught up in the portal explosion, and… there

wasn’t one. You were… gone.”

Catra stares at Adora in disbelief. She has no idea what to say in response to that. Her mind spins as she tries to understand how that could be even *remotely* possible.

“W-What do you mean? I was… *dead* ?” she falters. Adora doesn’t even have to answer the question. Her facial expression is telling enough.

Suddenly, Adora moves forward and clings onto Catra again, hugging her like they’d be separated forever if she lets go.

“I t-thought I lost you… Oh, I thought I *lost* you, Catra…”

“Hey, It’s okay!” Catra tries. “I-I’m here now. I’m *okay* !” Whatever happened to her after the portal reality doesn’t matter. She is fine now, and she will make sure she stays that way. “I’m not going *anywhere* ,” she adds firmly.

Following this, Adora lets go of Catra, but keeps a firm hold on her shoulders.

Then, she moves her head forward and meets Catra’s lips with hers. And though it doesn’t last very long, it’s a kiss that somehow means more than every one they’ve shared in the past. It’s a solidification of their unbreakable love for each other, a

commemoration of their endurance together through adversity, through countless trials that have shaped them, made them stronger, ripped them apart, and brought them together.

“I love you so much,” Catra assures Adora. And the smile she gets in response tells her that Adora understands. Adora is so good at that, at understanding Catra. And for that, and countless more things, she has Catra’s undying love.

*****

Chapter End Notes

Hey y'all. Thanks for reading, as always. It truly warms my heart.

Insatiable Destiny

Chapter Summary

Adora reflects. Micah tells his story.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It kind of feels like a part of Adora is gone, in a way. But at the same time, it's also like she is finally *free* from that 'part of her,' that warrior side of her that knew only destruction and chaos.

Losing the ability to transform into She-Ra is not something Adora ever thought she would have to deal with.

She had her suspicions that She-Ra was gone ever since they saved Angella, specifically after Catra was revived from the portal explosion. The lack of She-Ra's presence within her was something that she could literally *feel* .

And yet, she told herself that she was imagining things, that she could still feel She-Ra within her. And that worked great up until yesterday, when she paid a visit to the library with the Best Friend Squad.

"Oh *no* , I can't reach this book!" Bow had said. "If *only* we had some sort of way to grow a couple feet taller!"

Of course, he was just joking around, and Adora knew that. But she's never been the type to back down from a challenge, no matter how seemingly trivial.

"Leave it to me," she replied, with way too much confidence. Perhaps her vastly overblown confidence was her way of trying to convince herself that she had imagined She-Ra's powers leaving her, like if she believed hard enough it would somehow miraculously make them come back.

It was… embarrassing, to say the least. Even though she knew full well that she wouldn't be able to summon She-Ra in that moment, she still dug herself into a hole in the hope that maybe she was wrong.

The hugs of support she got from all three members of the Best Friend Squad were very nice, and cheered her up significantly. Glimmer ended up simply teleporting a couple of feet into the air and nabbing the book from the shelf.

"Why can't you transform, Adora?" Catra had asked. Her question has been on and off in Adora's mind ever since yesterday. "What *happened* ?"

But Adora finally thinks she has the answer.

After Catra lost her life, She-Ra's energy left Adora's body and assimilated itself into Catra to bring her back.

It's just a theory, but it makes *way* too much sense not to be true. The shining white figure in the portal walking away and leaving Adora, the weird sensation of magic escaping her body when she returned to reality, the fact that she felt the lack of She-Ra's power the moment after Catra came back to life…

It all adds up.

The thing is, she doesn't really miss it, which is… *weird* . She acquired She-Ra's power during the war, and lost it essentially right after the war ended. The part of her that everyone was always *expecting* something from, the part of her that she hated at times because it felt like a burden, or an insatiable destiny, is finally *gone* .

Although… Adora does kind of miss She-Ra's healing ability. That otherworldly power has saved a great many lives, including Catra's. *Twice* . Having the power to help people in such a powerful way was something that Adora loved about herself.

But… it wasn't really *herself* , was it? It was She-Ra…

All along…

Adora lets out a melancholy sigh and wraps herself more snugly around the back of Catra, who is still fast asleep in her arms. The

simple reminder that Catra is with her right now is plenty enough to put her mind at ease.

For the past week, Adora has been consistently getting the best sleep she's ever gotten in her entire life. Sleeping while holding Catra (or the other way around; she can't decide which position she enjoys more) is so… It's so- *ugh* . It's *so* nice. She'll never grow tired of it.

"Nn… A-Adora… *please* …"

Catra's voice rumbles in Adora's ears. She sounds like she's desperate, or distressed. Her body is twitching. Is she having a nightmare?

"Catra!" Adora says firmly, shaking the girl awake.

"Agh!" Catra squeaks, and she jolts into consciousness, her wide eyes vigilantly scanning the bedroom, the hair on her tail fluffed outwards in all directions. Her gaze meets Adora's and her brow drops. "Adora? What's going on?"

Oh no, oh *no* , was she having a nightmare? Was Adora unable to keep them away?

No, no, no-!

“Adora?” Catra repeats, sitting up now. “Are you okay? What’s-”

“I’m fine,” Adora interrupts. That’s not the issue right now . “W-Were you having a nightmare?”

Catra cocks an eyebrow. “What? Uh- no? Of course not.”

“Oh,” Adora breathes out. She feels significantly relieved. “ *Good* .”

Catra smiles. “Why would I? I haven’t had a nightmare since that one night back in those tents. All thanks to you,” she says warmly, nudging Adora on the shoulder.

“Thank goodness.” Adora takes another deep breath. *Wow,* she was freaking out. But for good reason. If Catra’s nightmares had returned… She shakes her head. “You were talking in your sleep, so I thought it was another nightmare.”

“It wasn’t. I was actually having… a *really* good dream for once,” Catra says, her voice breathier than normal.

Now Adora is curious. “Really? What was it about?”

"Well…" Catra blushes. The tip of her tail rises and falls rhythmically on the sheets behind her. "There was this girl… She was *super* hot." She looks straight at Adora, her eyes half-lidded and her expression dreamy. "She had these really pretty blue eyes."

Adora's heart does at least five consecutive somersaults.

"I would be mad at you for waking me up from such a *fantastic* dream," Catra continues, coming closer, "but the real thing is *way* better." With that, she wraps her arms around Adora and they slowly descend back onto the bed. Once horizontal, Catra tangles her legs with Adora's and fits her head perfectly into the space beneath Adora's chin.

"Still sleepy?" Adora asks, one of her hands finding Catra's back, the other cradling her head. It feels so natural, so *right* for them to have their bodies pressed against each other like this.

"Yeah," Catra replies, and she closes her eyes. "Just a little longer…"

"Mmm…" Adora sighs, settling her face more snugly into Catra's hair. If there were a way to get any closer, a way to wrap her arms somehow more thoroughly around Catra's body, she would do it in a heartbeat.

I… I want to spend the rest of my life with you…

*****

"You have to tell me *everything* , Angie!"

"Oh, Micah, my dear. There's nothing *to* tell! Really, I would prefer to hear about your story. Mine is terribly dull. Not much goes on in a collapsed portal dimension." Angella smiles. "Now tell me, how did you survive for so long on Beast Island?"

Micah shifts to a more comfortable position in his chair in preparation for his story. For the past four hours, he has been in the infirmary. Ever since his wife Angella unexpectedly returned unconscious to Bright Moon, he had been spending most of his hours of daylight here. Books borrowed from the library are piled several feet high in the corner, papers full of random sketches and drabbles are strewn across the desk that Micah had borrowed from his office, the card game that he and Glimmer were playing to pass the time is still left out on the nightstand, and there would definitely be a temporary wardrobe in here if it weren't for the rules that the infirmary has in place against "living in a ward." But, the only time Micah left this ward was to use the restroom or return to his room to go to sleep. He was basically *already* living here, so why couldn't they just bend the rules a bit and let him stay overnight?

It had been a long, sometimes awfully boring week of sitting around waiting for Angella to wake up. Thankfully, however, Angella got visitors very frequently. Glimmer visited without fail multiple times a day, as well as her friends Bow, Adora and Catra (who doesn't seem to be very much of a talker).

But now, Angella is awake, and Micah is the only person in Bright Moon that knows. Except the doctors, of course. He will spread the wonderful news soon, but now is the time to catch up with his dear wife.

"You don't give up, do you?" Micah teases.

"You know me, Micah. I'm as stubborn as ever. A couple of months trapped in a portal didn't change that about me." Angella gives her husband a warm smile.

"Alright," Micah caves. "If you insist. But strap in, because this one is *exciting* ! Well, not really."

"Oh, stop stalling, dear," Angella chuckles.

"Yeah, okay." Micah takes a deep breath and begins. "The first thing I remember after the battle was waking up on a Horde dropship. I don't remember too many details, but I think they gave me some sort of drug to numb my body. I could barely even move, so magic was out of the question. They had me tied up, as well. I tried to escape, but I was too weak. I don't remember much more after that. The next time I woke up, I was being thrown out of the ship, and then it took off. They didn't even bother to untie me.

“At first, I was terrified. As far as I was concerned, that dropship leaving me on that island was my death warrant. I didn’t even expect to survive until nightfall. So, I ran. From anything and everything. But there was nowhere to go. I felt like some sort of caged *animal* .”

“Oh, Micah…” Angella places a gentle hand on his forearm.

“But eventually,” Micah continues. “I realized that the island wasn’t impossible to beat like they’d always told us. I realized that survival was *realistic* . Once I stopped fearing the island, I started to think clearly. I started to do things that made *sense* instead of acting off of impulse. I managed to get the ropes off and I started to build a shelter for the night. I had to eat bugs for food. It was hard, but I managed. I was able to fight off most of the creatures on that island with magic. I ran from the ones I couldn’t. Honestly, that’s all there is to it. The days kind of blur together from there.”

“Dear…” Angella squeezes Micah’s forearm.

“In the back of my mind, I knew that all I wanted to do was get home and see you and my daughter,” Micah says. “You and Glimmer were the only things that kept me going. I kept telling myself that I would get out of there, that I’d see you two again. And… I did!”

After a moment of silence, Angella says, “Adora and Bow saved you, correct?”

“Yes! And Entrapta helped,” Micah beams. “I couldn’t have escaped without them. Make sure you thank them!”

“Oh, I will,” Angella assures him. “I'll be *sure* to.”

Micah pulls her wife into a hug, much to the dismay of the doctor who just re-entered the ward (“she’s still recovering!”).

But Micah and Angella aren’t going to let that stop them from hugging each other for the first time in fifteen years.

*****

Catra has never felt more alive.

Simply put, this is the happiest she’s ever been in her entire life.

And as she looks down from her balcony into the lush, sun-lit valley below, she can’t help but feel fortunate. Because even in her darkest hour, in her most desperate moments of fear and anger, deep down, this is what she truly wanted. Not to rule Etheria, not to take down the Princesses, not to *win* …

No.

She wanted people to care for her. She wanted someone to tell her she mattered. She wanted someone to look at her for once not with expectation and disappointment in their eyes, but kindness. Empathy. Trust.

She wanted…

To be loved.

And now…

Catra feels a pair of hands close softly around her waist and a warm body press gently against her back. A head on her shoulder.

"Morning, Catra." Adora's soft voice reaches her ear.

"Hey, Adora," she purrs in response, leaning her head back into the warmth and allowing her weight to shift into Adora's embrace.

This is what she wanted. What she *wants* .

“Scorpia told me that you like tea,” Adora says, finding Catra’s hand in hers and stroking it with her thumb. “She told me your favorite flavor.”

Catra chuckles. “Did she tell you that I’ve only had tea once in my entire life and I barely even remember how it tastes?”

“What? She didn’t say *that* ,” Adora huffs. “Well, it was worth a try, I guess.”

“What was?”

“Well,” Adora sighs. She gently unfurls herself from around Catra’s body. “I made some tea.”

“You did?” Catra’s ears perk up. Her heart does a little flip. “For me?”

“Yup! It’s on your nightstand if you want it. You slept *forever* , so it’s probably cold by now.” Adora lets go of Catra’s hand and crosses the room towards the door. “Well, I’ve gotta get going, or I’ll be late. I told Bow I’d hang out with him this morning.”

“Have fun!” Catra says brightly.

It’s so weird. In the past, she would have been horrified at the prospect of Adora spending time with someone other than her.

So much has changed.

“Love you!” Adora calls, giving Catra one last glance, and she opens the door and steps outside.

“I love you more!” Catra shouts back.

She immediately goes over to her dresser, dresses, and moves to her nightstand. She pins Adora’s pin onto her shirt, like she does every morning. Now that her most valuable possession has been taken care of, she takes a sip from the mug sitting on top of her nightstand.

Woah .

Adora was right; this tea is relatively cold. But the *flavor* …

The flavor of the tea more than makes up for its lack of heat. It’s a delicate blend; Catra can taste apple, lemon, cinnamon (she’s only known that cinnamon has existed for about a month, but she *loves* it), and some other flavors she really enjoys, but can’t quite identify.

This is so different from the tea that Scorpia gave her that one time in the Fright Zone. Of course, Scorpia's tea was pretty good (even if Catra was too stubborn at the time to admit it), but this tea, *Adora's* tea…

Adora's is different. Its sweetness and bitterness are perfectly balanced. It has just the right amount of sour as well. It tastes like it was brewed specifically to Catra's taste, like Adora had studied what flavors Catra enjoys and used that knowledge to create something she'd find irresistible.

And Adora, selfless as always, had brushed this off as no big deal, like this is just a normal morning thing to do.

"Thanks, Adora," Catra says, even though she knows Adora won't hear it. She'll make sure to thank Adora for real as soon as she sees her next.

Unable to stop smiling, she moves back outside and takes a seat in a chair on the balcony, sipping her delicious tea and drinking in the view.

How on Etheria did Adora manage to make Catra's entire day within ten minutes of her waking up?

Well, the answer to that is actually pretty obvious. Adora is a *cheater* . Somehow, she always knows what will make Catra happy.

Always .

*****

“I still can’t believe it, mom! That you’re finally *back* !”

“I can’t believe I finally have my family back, Glimmer. My daughter.”

“Oh, I love you, mom!”

“I love you too, Glimmer. And I missed you. So *much* .”

They’re getting closer. Catra holds her breath. Her hands close around her pin.

She doesn’t know why, but her body went on autopilot as soon as she heard Glimmer say the word ‘mom,’ and she is now hiding behind a pillar, trying to remain out of sight.

Her heart pounds in anticipation.

“Ooh, I’m gonna go get Bow!” Glimer says eagerly. “I bet he’ll be so happy to see you!”

“I’ve always liked that boy,” Angella replies. “What about Adora? Is she around?”

“Oh yeah! I’ll find her as well. And Catra! I’ll be right back!”

“...Catra?” Angella asks, sounding uneasy.

The sound of Glimmer teleporting echoes throughout the hall.

Angella is walking forward again; Catra can hear her footsteps- they're growing nearer. She has nowhere to run, nowhere else to hide, it’s only a matter of time before she is found out, unless she can do something…

Angella enters Catra’s line of sight, her focus drawn to a large statue in front of her. A statue of herself.

She pauses, looking up at the statue, standing completely still with her hands clasped neatly in front of her.

Catra sees her chance, and slinks away as silently as she can. There’s a room down the hall, and she knows it’s not a dead end,

maybe she can reach it before Angella notices her, just a couple more feet-

"You!" Angella says firmly, and Catra's heart drops like a brick. She gulps and turns around.

"I know your face," Angella continues, walking menacingly in Catra's direction, her wings spreading dangerously outward. "What are *you* doing here?"

"I-I'm- I was-" Catra stammers, taking a step backward. Her ears flatten against her head. "I-I can *explain* , I-"

"Explain *what* ?" Angella demands. Catra staggers backward. "Explain why you ravaged our lands, *burned* our cities-"

"Angie!" Micah's firm voice fills the hall, silencing Angella. He strides towards Catra and puts a hand on her shoulder. "It's okay. She's part of the family now."

Catra's eyes widen.

" *What* ?" Angella retorts. "What do you mean, dear?"

“Catra,” Micah squeezes Catra’s shoulder, “is one of us. She joined the alliance, helped us fight against Horde P- *well* -” He chuckles slightly. “That’ll take some explaining.”

Angella blinks several times in surprise.

“Angella,” Micah continues. “Catra saved your *life* .”

“You… *You* ?” Angella’s eyebrows fly upward.

“Yes,” Catra asserts, her confidence returning. “Adora and I.”

“Adora… and you?”

“You don’t remember, Angie,” Micah explains. “You weren’t conscious.”

“...How?” Angella breathes.

“Why don’t we go find a place to sit down?” Micah suggests, moving forward and taking both of Angella’s hands in his. “There’s a *lot* to catch you up on.”

Catra feels a strong warmth towards Micah blossom in her heart. He has shown her nothing but kindness from the moment they met, despite her background, despite what she did in the past, despite *everything* .

Did Micah know that Catra was the reason that Angella was trapped in the portal? Did he show Catra compassion regardless?

How??

"...tra? Catra."

"Y-yes, King Micah?" Catra kneels instinctively.

"Do you wanna come?" Micah asks. "You don't have to."

Catra smiles, taking the King's hand and rising to her feet. "Yes. I do."

*****

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter, 2 oc's make an appearance :0

Revelations

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra reminisce.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hey, Adora! Good morning! How'd you sleep?" Bow says brightly as he opens the door.

"Morning, Bow! I slept *amazing,* " Adora replies.

"Good! Come on in," Bow offers, gesturing inside.

"Actually, did you want to go on a walk this time?" Adora wrings her hands. "I… need advice again."

"Pfft," Bow snickers. Adora cocks an eyebrow. "I'd love to take a walk, but…" Bow passes Adora and they start down the third floor hallway towards the stairwell. "You know Catra way better than I do. The only advice I could give you is to follow your heart. Do what *you* think is right, not what I-"

"No, no, it's not about *Catra* ," Adora interrupts. "Well- it *kind* of is…" She takes a deep sigh. It's only logical for Bow to assume that Adora is seeking out advice about Catra, considering that Catra is pretty much all Adora has talked about for the past two

weeks. “So, um, this is kind of off topic, but…” Adora sighs again. The question is harder to put into words than she anticipated.

“What’s up?” Bow tries.

“How do I… okay. Netossa and Spinarella. They talked about how they were…” Adora furrows her brow, for the word she has been trying to remember ever since she heard it continues to evade her. “T-they called each other something. What was it? I-I don’t remember, but…”

“Uhhh…” Bow settles his chin between his thumb and forefinger in an expression of complete confusion. Of course he is confused. Adora is being cryptic at best with her questions.

“They were- It’s like they had some sort of special word to call each other. Did they make it up? Was it something-”

“ *Wife* ?” Bow says incredulously, his expression transforming into one of understanding. “Do you mean wife?”

“Yes!” Adora confirms, pointing excitedly at Bow like he just cracked an enigma. “That’s *it* ! You’re a genius!”

“A-alright!” Bow smile-grimaces, clearly still confused. “Glad I could… help?”

“What does that… What does it mean? That word?” Adora clarifies, stepping out into Bright Moon courtyard. It’s a sunny morning, not a cloud in the sky.

“Ohhh!” Bow sounds like he just came to a revelation of some sort. “You don’t know that word!” He furrows his brow. “ *Man* , the Horde sucks.”

“That’s the truth,” Adora agrees.

“Okay,” Bow starts. He holds his hands out in front of him like he’s about to explain an elaborate Ice Ball play. “Netossa and Spinarella use the word ‘wife’ to describe each other because they are *married* .”

“M-married?” Adora breathes out, her eyes sparkling adventurously. What does *that* mean? What are they not telling Adora?? Why does that sound so *nice* ?!

“Marriage is a formal union between two willing partners,” Bow elaborates, taking a seat on the edge of the fountain in the middle of the courtyard. “It’s basically a fancy ceremony that recognizes two romantic partners as officially ‘together.’” He laces his fingers together as he says that last word.

"Whu- I wanna… I wanna get married!" Adora blurts breathlessly. "I-I wanna marry Catra!!"

Why is her heart suddenly pounding? Why does she want this so much?? *Why has nobody ever told her about this* ??

"Woah, slow down there, Adora!" Bow holds his palms outwards towards her. "You've gotta *talk* to her about this first. It doesn't just happen overnight."

"But, *But…* Y-yeah. You're right," Adora admits, cooling down. As much as she wants to tear back upstairs, burst into her room, and ask Catra to marry her, that would be a terrible idea, considering that Catra probably doesn't even know what marriage is either.

"Maybe you could have a conversation with her about this later?"

"Yeah, I think I will," Adora smiles. As always, Bow's advice is the best.

But…

Suddenly, Adora's heart sinks. How can she ask Catra to marry her when Adora hasn't even asked to be her *girlfriend* yet?

“I think it’ll work out for you,” Bow tells her.

“Bow?” Adora gulps, wringing her hands again. “You’re totally right. I can’t rush this, and I should have a conversation with her first. But… She’s not even my *girlfriend* yet.”

“She- She’s not?” Bow raises an eyebrow quizzically. “I thought for *sure* she was.”

“No, she’s not…” Adora admits, dropping her shoulders.

“Well, then maybe you could start there,” Bow advises. “Ask her to be your girlfriend. That’ll make asking her to be your wife a lot easier, I bet.”

Adora grins. “Bow, what would I do without you?” Her heart leaps.

“Oh, it’s nothing,” Bow dismisses, putting a hand on the back of his head and going slightly red.

Suddenly, Glimmer appears beside them.

“ *There* you are!” she says excitedly. “Guess what??”

“Hey, Glim, what’s up?” Bow asks.

“ *My mom’s awake* !!” Before Adora or Bow can respond, Glimmer grabs onto each of their arms and teleports them away.

*****

There is something so complex about the state of being that Adora is in right now. She’s literally just sitting on a bench next to Catra, watching the sun recede behind the blood red clouds just over the tips of the trees in the distance, and yet, the seemingly simple experience has such an incorporeal, impossible-to-pin-down feeling associated with it.

The quiet sounds of the evening- the fountain in the center of the courtyard, the distant chatter of kids running around, getting in a last few minutes of play before their bedtimes, the sound of the waterfalls in the distance- all culminate to form an experience that Adora has never had before, or never had the *chance* to have before.

For once, she’s just sitting there with nothing more to it. Not because she has to for Horde shift work, or for a lecture on personal defense, or for a force captain orientation- no, because she chooses to be here right now, by Catra’s side, holding onto *her* hand, sharing this beautiful evening with her. Together.

Now that Angella is awake (and on board with everything and no longer calling Catra an enemy), their work finally feels complete. Not that saving Angella was a job, or some sort of *obligation,* but still. They're finally *done* .

Now, for the first time, Catra and Adora can walk forward together, towards a future *they* want. They'll support each other every step of the way, without fail, without hesitation. Adora knows it, and she knows Catra does too.

"Hey, no fair!" The sound of a kid's voice reaches their ears. Two kids, no doubt no older than ten, burst out of the bushes behind the bench and make a beeline towards the fountain.

"You got a head start!" The shorter kid, who is lagging behind what appears to be his friend, perhaps brother, tries to catch up with what looks like incredible effort given how short his little legs are.

"I win!" the first, taller kid says triumphantly, hopping up on the edge of the fountain and posing pompously. His dirty-blonde, almost-shoulder length hair dances peacefully in the pleasant evening breeze.

Another voice, much closer, comes from Adora's right.

"Those kids remind me of us. When we were younger."

Adora smiles and turns to face Catra. “They do, don’t they?”

The corner of Catra’s mouth curls upward into a fond smile as she continues looking forward, her soft gaze locked on those two little boys, who are now play-fighting with some tree branches. It’s a reminiscent gaze, full of longing for what Adora knows are *those* days. Those simple days where everything wasn’t so complicated, where Catra and Adora had nothing to worry about in the world but each other. Well, and perhaps-

“-Shadow Weaver! *Hide* !” Catra hissed. She grabbed Adora’s arm and piloted her behind some nearby metal crates.

Adora didn’t sense Shadow Weaver, but she wasn’t about to question her friend. She knew that Catra was serious by the tone of her voice. And by the fact that she was much better at seeing, hearing, and smelling than Adora, and was normally the first out of the two of them to sense danger.

Being caught out this late would most likely get them in pretty serious trouble, or at least land them with a good week or two of doubled-up chores. They both stuffed their bedsheets with extra

pillows before they snuck outside to make it look like they were sleeping and minimize their chances of being caught up past curfew. So, if they were going to get caught, it wasn't going to be because somebody was looking for them.

That eased Adora's mind a little bit as Shadow Weaver passed by. She knew Shadow Weaver was passing from the way the searchlights got ominously dimmer. It was night outside, so the effect was very noticeable.

As for why Shadow Weaver was out here so late, Adora had no idea. But thankfully, she didn't seem to be looking for Catra or Adora, because after a few seconds, the searchlights came back on, sweeping the floor in the pattern that Adora knew like the back of her hand.

"Let's go," Catra whispered once they were in the clear.

She and Adora moved quickly, efficiently, through the searchlights. Though they had a lot of experience dodging the searchlights, they didn't risk going past them often. Only for special occasions. So, whatever Catra was leading Adora to this time had to be good.

"Over here," Catra instructed, taking a left and turning herself sideways to fit between two large metal storage canisters. Adora followed suit, and they emerged into a sizable hidden cavity surrounded on all sides by sheets of dilapidated metal. Through the holes in the sides and top of the structure shone beams of light from the floodlights outside, which provided enough light to

see actually pretty well considering they were basically indoors at that point. Small pools of water were covering the floor, and a large wire, severed at the bottom, was hanging from the ceiling just above the water. Not the best combination. But given the broken-down state of this place, the wire probably wasn't live, so there wasn't any electrocution to worry about.

"What is this place?" Adora asked, stepping forward. The sound of her voice and combat boots echoed very profoundly off of the metallic walls.

"Check this out!" Catra said, grabbing the wire in the center of the room and climbing expertly up a broken structure lining the left-most wall. Once she got to the top, she gave Adora a smirk, hooked her foot through a small loop at the end of the wire, and jumped off.

Catra soared across the room and over the puddles of water below her so gracefully, so *freely* . Adora cheered for her and let out a laugh as she reached the other side, lost momentum, and swung backwards to where she started, sticking the landing effortlessly.

"That was *awesome* , Catra!" Adora said excitedly, bouncing on the balls of her feet.

"Keep your voice down, or we might get caught," Catra reminded her. She jumped down from the platform and landed softly next to Adora with a mischievous smile. "Do you wanna try?"

“ *Yes* !” Adora shout-whispered.

Adora had a harder time climbing up to the platform, or at least it sure seemed like she did, given how effortless Catra made it look. But she made it without incident, and without getting nicked by the sharp-looking pieces of metal sticking out of the structure at every angle.

“Okay, just put one of your feet through this loop,” Catra explained. But she must have seen the apprehension on Adora’s face, because she added, “don’t worry, I tied it myself. It’s unbreakable!”

“This is a granny knot,” Adora pointed out.

“Shut up,” Catra retorted, but in her lighthearted way that never failed to put a smile on Adora’s face.

She put her steady hands on Adora’s hips as Adora stepped into the loop and allowed herself to be suspended almost entirely by the wire.

Adora trusted Catra. Her hands guiding her were so careful, so gentle, and yet so reassuring at the same time. They melted the last of Adora’s apprehension away, leaving room only for excitement.

“You ready?” Catra asked.

“You *bet* ,” Adora told her, and she felt Catra’s hand leave her hips. She inched forward slowly but surely. The foot that she held herself in place with was losing its grip as her center of gravity shifted away, until-

It was like she was flying. Her stomach rose to her chest. Every nerve in her body was tingling with exhilaration as she swung. She whooped in excitement as her body missed the ground by mere inches at the lowest point in the arc, and then she rose back upward until she slowed down and stopped completely, suspended in place like time had stopped, before gravity returned and she fell down again in the opposite direction.

She craned her head backwards to try and get a view of the platform, to little avail. As she reached it, she threw her foot out blindly, and thankfully, it came into contact with something. But her relief was short lived, as she could tell that she wasn’t going to have enough leverage to hold herself in place.

“Uh-oh,” she groaned.

As she prepared herself to fall back downward and make another swing, she felt a hand around her forearm. And then another hand around the other. Catra pulled her upward, back onto the platform, and into her arms.

Adora was giggling like crazy, holding onto her best friend, who was laughing just as hard as she was.

"That- was- *Amazing* !" Adora said, stepping back and placing her hands on Catra's shoulders.

"I know, right??" Catra replied. She moved towards the edge and put her foot into the loop again. "Hey, Adora, push me!"

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah!"

Adora placed her hands carefully on Catra's back.

"Okay, on three," Catra told her. "One, two, *three* !"

Adora sent her forward with a decent amount of her strength. Catra let out a yell of excitement as she swung, completely disregarding the whole 'voices down' thing.

"Harder!" Catra said as she came back. Adora pushed a little bit harder. "Harder!" Catra repeated as she made another cycle.

Adora couldn’t stop laughing. She pushed with almost her full strength, sending Catra hurtling downward, setting a speed record-

Then- Catra let out a yelp as she collided with the opposite wall. She fell back down, her foot slipped out of the loop, and she hit the ground, tumbling over and over through the puddles.

Adora’s heart clenched. She immediately jumped down from the platform, hurting her feet when she landed, but she didn’t care-

“Oww- *ouch* …” Catra groaned, clutching her sides. Adora ran over to her and kneeled beside her.

“I’m *sorry* , Catra I-”

“-I didn’t mean to!” the shorter kid says, kneeling over his crying friend. “D-does it hurt?”

Adora shoots up from the bench, striding purposefully towards the shorter kid.

“Owie…” the shorter kid groans, holding onto his knee, tears falling down his dark face.

“Are you okay? What happened?” Adora asks as soon as she reaches him.

“C-Colt pushed me off t-the f-fountain!” the little kid cries through shaky breaths. “Oww, it *hurts…* ”

“Benny, I’m so sorry, it was by accident!” Colt laments, standing timidly over Benny with his hands clasped over his front.

“You meanie,” Benny complains.

“Um- Benny? Can I see it? Can you show me your knee?” Adora asks as soothingly as possible.

Benny nods and shakily removes his hands from the wound. Adora’s heart twists at the sight of it. It’s not serious, but the impact was enough to get through his blue jeans and draw blood. She looks to Catra for help, but Catra shrugs. She looks like she wants to help as much as Adora, but also at a loss for what to do.

"L-look," Adora tries, taking one of Benny's small hands. "Benny, can you stand up? Can you try?"

"I don't know…" Benny sniffles. He starts to push himself upward, and with a little encouragement from Adora, manages to fully stand up.

"There you go!" Adora congratulates him. "Look how *strong* you are! We'll get you some bandages and your knee will be healed up in no time!"

Benny gives Adora a smile, but the pain is still visible in his brown eyes. If only Adora could help him…

In a moment of powerful realization, she knows exactly what to do. This familiar gripping conviction arises within her, one she's felt many times before, one that has saved lives in the past. The powerful, almost electric sensation she knows so well spreads throughout her body as far as her fingertips.

I want you to feel better.

She gently pulls Benny into a hug, and miraculously, they both begin to glow a bright golden-white.

"A-Adora!" Catra says in disbelief.

After a couple of seconds, Adora stops glowing. She looks down to see if Benny's scrape is healed, and sure enough, there is no trace of it, as if it had never been there to begin with.

A solid five seconds of silence passes.

"You're *amazing* , miss!!" Benny exclaims, running his hand over his newly healed knee.

"How'd you do that??" Colt demands, his green eyes the size of dinner plates and sparkling like gemstones.

"This kid is asking the right questions," Catra chimes in. Her mismatched eyes are just as wide as Colt's.

"I-I don't *know* ," Adora breathes out, staring at her hands, trying to find evidence within them that points to the existence of She-Ra within her still, or maybe just a part of She-Ra...?

No, that can't be right- Adora doesn't feel her at *all* .

"Can you do it again??" Benny asks.

“Yeah! I wanna see it again!” Colt adds.

“Yeah! Yeah!”

“Hold on, um…” Adora starts, and immediately the two children fall silent, giving her their undivided attention. “I can uh… Only do it once per day! And I get *really* tired when I do it.”

“So… *Awesome* !” Colt says, his voice something between a whisper and a yell.

“Oh, you think *that’s* awesome?” Adora smirks. “Wait until you see my *fire magic* !!” She throws her hands up dramatically in front of her.

“You have *fire magic* ??” the two kids both say in unison.

“I’m just kidding, I don’t have fire magic,” Adora laughs.

“You even had me for a second there, Adora, with what you just pulled,” Catra admits, her eyes still wide. She looks like she has a million questions to ask right now.

Adora winks at her and kneels so that she is level with the two boys.

“Listen, Benny, Colt, I’m gonna head to sleep soon. You two should probably head home as well and get to bed before it gets too dark. A good night’s sleep is important!”

“Aww… okay,” Colt complains, turning to face Benny. “Benny, let’s go back home.”

“Aw man.” Benny hangs his head slightly before bringing his gaze back up to meet Adora’s. “Well, good night, miss! Have a good rest!”

“Yeah! We’ll see you!” Colt adds.

“Be safe!” Adora waves at them until they disappear from the courtyard.

“Adora,” Catra says as soon as the two boys are gone, and Adora knows exactly what she’s thinking.

“I have no *idea* how I did that,” she supplies.

No… She had no idea she *could* do that. Because somehow, she knows she can replicate the process right here and now if she had someone to heal.

“Was it She-Ra?” Catra asks.

“No,” Adora confirms with full confidence. That magic wasn’t She-Ra, “It was *me* .”

And maybe it was her all along. Not She-Ra, not the weapon she had a ‘destiny’ to carry, not the mythical alter-ego that everyone always told her she was fated to bear- no. It was *her* .

“It was *you* ,” Catra says, a realization rather than a question.

“Yeah,” Adora replies simply. She gives Catra a smile. “It was *always* me.”

That statement was a fact. Adora just *knows* it. It was never She-Ra, the warrior. The only purpose She-Ra served, outside of giving her the temporary ability to transform into an eight foot tall super-warrior, was to give her a reason to learn how to utilize the magic that has always been a part of her from the beginning.

They always told her that She-Ra had the ability to heal. That one of She-Ra’s ‘primary functions’ was to heal.

Was that a lie? Was it just another manipulation tactic employed by Light Hope to convince Adora that she needed She-Ra to

access her magic? That she needed She-Ra to be *useful* ?

Maybe. It could just be a coincidence. She-Ra very well could have had a built in healing function, but somehow, Adora is confident that if it *did* exist, she never once used it.

Every single magical ability that Adora had access to when she still had She-Ra- weapon transformation, light blades, energy blasts- were all channeled through her sword. Every single one- *except* healing. Healing was the only magical ability that she controlled with her hands, with her body, with *herself* .

The power of healing- the power of She-Ra- was never supposed to be the sword, the destructive potential, the *warrior* .

Not that she doesn't give the sword any credit. After all, it was the whole reason she sought to optimize her magical abilities in the first place. In a way, the sword taught her *how* to heal. Or- it taught her how to do it *consistently* , because she is almost certain she was able to use her healing ability before she even *knew* about the sword.

But the sword also taught her that she couldn't access her magic unless she was She-Ra. It taught her to fear being herself, that she was useless without the sword.

In many ways, She-Ra helped. In countless others, she simply held Adora back.

Because She-Ra was never meant to be a weapon. She-Ra was *healing* , before the First Ones came around and perverted its form into a destructive warrior, before the First Ones created the sword, the *shackles* binding every She-Ra to a destiny full of violence.

Adora finally feels free from the cycle.

"I didn't know you were so good with kids," Catra says fondly, taking a seat on the edge of the fountain and crossing one leg over the other. The tip of her tail flicks upward in what Adora knows is approval.

"Yeah, well, I've been around my fair share of children. I have *plenty* of experience," Adora grimaces, not because she doesn't *like* being around children, in fact, quite the opposite, but because… They sure can be a handful sometimes when they keep constantly asking her to perform more magic, or do something cool again, or solve the mysteries of the universe-

"So what you're saying is that kids basically love you. That's understandable. Who wouldn't?" Catra asks. Adora blushes and sweeps her hair behind her ear. "That was sneaky, by the way."

"What was?" Adora asks, claiming the spot next to Catra.

“The way you got those two kids to head back home.”

Adora raises an eyebrow. “...What was so sneaky about it?”

Catra smirks. “You lied about how you’re ‘about to go to bed.’”

“Actually,” Adora shoots back. “Yes, I am. The word ‘soon’ can mean in five minutes or in a couple of hours. I just didn’t specify.”

“Sneaky,” Catra affirms. “Well, I *hope* you aren’t planning on going to sleep in five minutes. We’re still busy.”

“What do you mean? I’m not busy.”

“You’re about to be,” Catra responds. She turns to face Adora, her gaze fixated on her lips with that *look* in her eyes. Adora knows what she wants.

And Adora wants it too.

She smiles and moves her head forward to meet Catra’s lips, but it’s brief, barely lasting a second. Her eyes shoot open in a mixture of surprise and disappointment at how short that kiss was.

"Maybe this isn't the *best* spot," Catra points out, running her hand along the smooth, stony surface of the fountain. "Let's go to our room."

Adora is slightly taken aback by how candid Catra just was with her request, but grateful all the same. And- now that Catra pointed it out, she agrees completely; there are *much* better places to kiss her girlfriend. Or… soon-to-be girlfriend.

I still need to talk with her about that…

She can worry about that later. For now…

"Okay," she replies.

"Quit stalling; we don't have all night," Catra teases, standing up, taking Adora's hand, and fast-walking towards the palace.

"Yeah we do," Adora points out.

Catra turns to face her and simply rolls her eyes. As she returns her gaze forward, her tail moves upward and brushes along Adora's cheek.

Adora’s heart starts beating noticeably more quickly. Tonight is going to be *incredible* .

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Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is essentially one gigantic love scene, so uhhh yeah see y'all then

Something More

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra love each other.

Chapter Notes

Welcome to copious amounts of spice

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Click .

As soon as they are both inside their room, Catra locks the door. Adora, who had taken a seat on the edge of the bed, feels her heart jump out of her chest.

And Catra, always so calm, always so *composed* , simply pockets her key and struts over to where Adora sits absolutely frozen in place.

Adora can't seem to find her words. She tries, with great difficulty, to match Catra's intense gaze, and surprises herself when she somehow manages to succeed. She knows she's blushing, but also knows she's unable to do anything about it.

Catra doesn't speak. Instead, she simply reaches forward and places her pointer finger on Adora's forehead, giving it a gentle push. Adora complies, lowering herself backward onto the bed. Catra follows her down and straddles her thighs.

Apparently, Adora has forgotten how to speak. And it doesn't help that Catra is now lowering her head down so close that Adora can feel her soft breath against the side of her face.

"I want you, Adora," Catra purrs, her lips brushing ever so slightly against Adora's ear.

Adora's heart rate shifts into overdrive. She puts her hand impulsively on the back of Catra's head, running her fingers through her hair to hold her in place.

"You can have me," she responds, trying to sound as smooth as possible.

But all smoothness is thrown out of the window when she feels Catra's tongue make contact with the base of her jaw and slide all the way up to her temple.

Woah. That was… new. New in a good way. A *very* good way.

"Yeah? How much?" Catra asks, and it takes Adora a good few seconds to remember what she's talking about.

Composure, Adora. Breathe. Answer the question.

Her mind concludes that she should answer the question, but her body seems to be on a different page. Her leg wraps around Catra's waist, and with a good amount of lateral pressure, she flips Catra's body beneath her own.

"You can have *all* of me," she growls, her hands finding Catra's wrists. She pins them to the bed.

Adora doesn't exactly know where *that* came from. And apparently, Catra doesn't know either, judging by how wide her eyes are.

"Uhh-" Adora accidentally croaks, because apparently her brain feels the need to stall for time for whatever reason.

Or maybe it's because she wasn't expecting Catra to show so much… compliance. She was sure she'd hear some sort of teasing remark or a taunt in response to her weird improvisational maneuver.

But… Catra seems to have lost the capacity to do so. Her pupils are dilated and every breath she takes is shaky.

Well, now what? Adora has Catra in the ideal position below her body, and she has to do *something* . Maybe she should have gone

into this with a plan, and not acted on whatever random impulse her body threw at her.

Or , maybe she's overthinking this.

Just kiss her, idiot.

Adora bridges the gap between them with a kiss, a slow, sensual contact that turns her insides to mush, that slows down everything around her. All that matters right now is exploring Catra's soft lips with her own, and she's got all the time in the world to do it.

First, it's a tiny flick, so quick and stealthy that Adora almost doesn't notice it.

But then, it happens again. There's no mistaking it this time, the feeling of a tongue in her mouth, one that isn't her own. It sends a wonderful electric shock through her body, and she closes her eyes and lets out a soft moan, basking in the pleasure, not even remotely realizing that all of her motor skills have temporarily been put on hold.

Catra pushes her advantage, and before Adora can react, she's on her back, staring upward into two beautiful, mismatched eyes, eyes that are alight with an intense flame.

" *Woah* , U-uhm…" is all she can manage.

Catra smirks. "You let your guard down, Adora."

And before Adora can sputter out a response, Catra's lips are against hers again. But this time, it's something completely different.

Catra's tongue is in her mouth, brushing deliciously against her own. Adora's heart flares up with intense passion, and she arches up into Catra's body, allowing herself to infiltrate Catra's mouth with her own tongue.

It's indescribable. Adora's chest- no, her entire body- is burning. There are sounds escaping her that she never even knew she could make.

Catra pulls her head back, allowing a moment of repose.

"You…" Adora pants. "You're *amazing* , Catra."

"What's wrong, Princess? Out of breath already?" Catra complains, one of her fangs poking very cutely out of the corner of her mouth.

“Pfft,” Adora scoffs, regaining some vocal confidence. “You were the one who stopped.”

“Yeah, I know. I wanted to ask you something.”

“Uh-” Adora raises an eyebrow. What in the *world* is relevant enough to warrant interrupting such an extraordinary interaction? Catra is probably just going to joke about something, come up with a distraction to catch Adora off guard again, or- maybe she is plotting to-

“Why are we still dressed?” Catra asks suddenly, and Adora’s brain shuts down. Fragments of words seem to be escaping her mouth, but nothing coherent.

And of course, Catra smirks. “It just doesn’t seem *practical* ,” she continues, her tail flicking mischievously behind her. “Don’t you agree?”

“I- I- y-yeah,” Adora stammers, her eyes locked on Catra’s hands, which are crossing over each other and closing around the cloth at the base of her shirt.

Catra wastes no time pulling off her top, exposing her slender body. Adora quickly (clumsily) follows suit, and soon, they have both cast every garment of their outer clothing carelessly off of the side of the bed.

“Um…” Catra blushes, playing with the strap on her shoulder, her voice changing from her teasing one to a more soft, kindhearted one. “Wanna go together?”

Adora just nods, for her words continue to betray her, and moves her hands behind her back.

They are in a standoff, eyes locked, each silently daring the other to move first, because everything has to be some sort of *game* between them for some reason. It takes every ounce of Adora’s concentration not to do a false start, not to fall for the slight movements that Catra keeps trying to trick her with.

But then, Catra makes a movement that *can’t* be fake. Adora’s heart leaps and she follows her lead, letting the last of what was covering her chest fall to the bed below her. Catra’s falls at the same time, and Adora is unable to suppress her gasp.

Woah . Catra looks *incredible* , better than she’d ever imagined. And she had imagined a *lot* .

“I-” Catra starts, but seems to be just as flustered as Adora. “I’m-gonna stare at you, o-okay?”

“S-sure,” Adora breathes out, like she isn’t also doing exactly that.

After several seconds of ogling stupidly at each other, Catra moves forward and wraps her arms around Adora's neck.

"Sorry for the interruption, Adora," she smirks, her voice regaining its characteristic confidence. "Would you like to continue?"

"Uh-huh! Yeah, I-I'd like that," Adora replies, and she feels Catra pull her downward over her body, and they return to a more favorable horizontal position. Adora stares downward into Catra's eyes, her hands pressed to the bed next to the sides of Catra's head.

"I still can't believe this is real," Catra says. Adora wasn't really expecting that.

"What's real?" she asks, cocking her eyebrow.

"Well, *you* ," Catra chuckles. " *This* ." She gestures to Adora's body above hers. "I would be lying if I said I haven't fantasized about this before."

"You've… *fantasized* about me?" Adora stammers, redness creeping up her chest and filling her cheeks.

“Pfft. Are you kidding, Adora? Of *course* . All the time. I think it would be easier to count the days that I *didn’t* think about - ” Catra cuts herself off, her eyes flicking to the side and her ears pulling back from embarrassment.

So, Adora is freaking out. Catra basically just admitted that she’s been pining for Adora for the majority of her life. That’s a *big* deal.

“I did too,” she almost-whispers, like it’s an admission of guilt. “You know, um. Fantasize. A-About you. Yeah.” The redness has now passed her eyebrows up to her hairline, and she wouldn’t be surprised if it is covering her entire body at this point.

In the past, she would have given up anything in the world to be in the exact position she’s in at this moment.

But now, she’s here, *Catra’s* here, and there is nothing between them anymore, no war, no reconstruction, no confusion, no, well, *anything* .

“Wow, we suck at this, don’t we?” Catra grumbles, still avoiding eye contact. “If I would’ve known we could’ve been doing *this* two weeks ago, there’s no *telling* how much I’d-” She pauses again and her brow furrows into an apologetic expression, full of complete sincerity. “S-sorry, Adora, it’s not your *fault* or anything; I-I didn’t mean to make it sound like-”

“No, it’s alright, Catra.” Adora’s hand landing softly on the side of Catra’s face brings her gaze back upward. “You’re totally right.” She sighs. “And- I should’ve just *asked* you. There were so many times that I wanted to-”

“Adora,” Catra interrupts firmly, “you said it yourself. We’re here now. None of that matters anymore. Let’s just… forget about it and move on?”

“Yeah. You’re right.”

Catra gives Adora a lascivious smile, which is probably her cue to continue. She lowers herself further downward until her face is inches from Catra’s and their bodies are touching, like, *actually touching* , skin on fur, for the first time ever. The heat radiating off the both of them is probably enough to start some sort of wildfire.

Unable to hold herself back anymore, Adora moves her face downward, kissing Catra again, and it’s somehow even more incredible than the last. Every time they kiss, it’s like they are getting more and more comfortable with each other, more passionate.

And they *understand* each other. Nobody else in the world could understand Adora this well, share with her such a *sensual* kiss.

Catra pulls away, a hungry look in her eyes.

“I want you to touch me, Adora,” she purrs, in such an incredibly seductive way that it gives Adora goosebumps all over and makes her brain temporarily unable to string words together in a comprehensible manner.

“Uhm-” she gulps. That escalated particularly quickly. “You want- I- *um* -”

Suddenly, Catra’s expression hardens and she moves her hands off of Adora’s back as if contact with it would burn her fingers. “Adora- I-I didn't mean to… I mean, i-if you don’t want this-”

“N-no, no, I’m just-” Adora stammers, and she takes a breath to regain her composure. “I *do* want this. I want *you* .” She is surprised she was able to get that out, considering all of her short-circuiting from earlier.

“You mean it?” Catra asks, looking hopeful.

“Yes, I do. *Promise* .”

“Okay,” Catra smiles. “If you get uncomfortable at all, just tell me, alright?”

“I will. I don’t think that’ll happen, though,” Adora says, smirking, and hoping that Catra rids herself of all doubt that Adora wants to be here with her.

Because she *does* . Adora doesn't want anything else in the world right now.

Her heart rate speeds up even more as she slides back into focus. Catra is looking at her curiously, as if she is trying to predict her next move. Adora tries to move her hands and start something, but they seem to be firmly adhered to their spots on the bed. Great. Now Catra is *really* going to think that Adora doesn’t want to do this.

“Um… where do I… where do you want me to…”

“Everywhere, Adora,” Catra tells her.

As much as Adora loved to hear that just then, it didn’t really answer her question, or help quell her internal freak out.

“Sorry,” she breathes out. “I don’t- I don’t really know what to *do-* ” There are so many *options* , which means the possibility of screwing this up is *very* high, and- what if she’s not good enough in the first place? She just wants to do what’s best for Catra, whatever will make her happy-

“That’s okay,” Catra says, to Adora’s surprise. “I’m nervous, as well.” She lets out a small, high pitched laugh. “Like, *really* nervous. I have the most beautiful, amazing girl in the world right here in the same *bed* as me. How can I *not* be nervous?”

Adora’s mouth opens slightly.

“I might not show it,” Catra continues. “But, I am *freaking out* right now. Here-”

“ *Oh-!* ” Adora gasps as Catra grabs one of her hands and places it to her chest, her *naked* chest.

“You feel that? My heart?” Catra asks, her breathing speeding up and her pupils dilating.

Yes, Adora definitely feels *something.* Beneath her hand is the most soft, smooth surface she’s ever touched. And- sure enough, she can feel the rapid *thump thump* of Catra’s heart beneath her fingertips, beating no doubt as fast as her own. That makes her feel a lot better about her own nerves, about her current state of constant freak out.

“You know why, Adora?” Catra continues, and Adora meets her eyes. “It’s because you’re… you’re *you* .”

Adora feels almost overwhelmed by her attraction to the girl below her body.

"I… I *love* you, Catra!" she says breathlessly, like it's a revelation, and she catches Catra in a kiss before she has a chance to respond, determined to show her that she is loved more than anything in the world.

*****

Catra isn't sure that anything this universe has to offer can ever top what was just the most *incredible* half hour of her entire life. At first, Adora was a little hesitant, but once she started to get into it, she *really* got into it, like a snowball effect.

Of course, it took some experimentation and figuring-out on both sides, because neither of them actually really knew what they were doing. But that's what made it fun. They figured it out *together* .

After a while, their curious exploration of each other's bodies blossomed into fiery intimacy, and that's when it got *really* fun. Adora made Catra feel so good that she probably won't ever be able to move herself into an upright position again.

Going into this whole thing, Catra was afraid that Adora didn't want her like she wanted Adora, but *wow* , she couldn't have been more wrong.

It’s like a dream. Catra is laying half-on top of Adora’s soft, naked body, completely wrapped around her in every way imaginable, tail, thighs, arms…

It still feels like this situation that Catra is in is something that is too good to *possibly* exist, something that can’t even begin to be *imagined* , and yet, it’s happening. Catra is cuddling with the girl that, just a year ago, she thought she could only have in her most outlandish, unattainable fantasy.

Catra has never felt so fulfilled in her life. The hole in her chest that she kept falling into every time she convinced herself that she could never have Adora finally feels like it’s been filled.

Adora’s body on hers is the most warm, safe, wonderful feeling ever, and Catra is so incredibly grateful to be able to experience the sensation, to have such an amazing person by her side.

And as for why they waited an entire week to do this… Catra can’t say for sure. Perhaps Angella’s return to consciousness finally gave them that sense of completion that they’ve been seeking for so long. Perhaps they were too involved with her recovery process to even think about it. They *were* pretty occupied with visiting her every day and helping out in the ward, after all.

Either way, they’re here now. Catra and Adora have crossed into new territory, *exciting* territory, and it can only get better from here.

“Hey, Catra?” Adora asks. Catra feels the vibration of her words against her hair.

“Yeah?”

“I’ve been thinking about this for a while, but what can I…” Adora sighs, not in the way she does when she’s upset, but more a contemplative sigh. “What do I call you?”

Catra blinks a couple of times. What on Etheria is *that* supposed to mean? “What do you mean, Adora?”

“Well, I just feel like the word ‘friend’ isn’t really- you know,” Adora trails off. Catra almost facepalms; she would’ve if both of her hands were not in their highly favorable positions on Adora’s body at the moment. “Can… Can I call you my girlfriend?”

“Adora,” Catra chuckles in disbelief. “We just had *sex* . Don’t you think that’s kind of a given?”

“Well,” Adora breathes out, and Catra can practically hear her blushing. “Yeah, good point.”

“But, yes.” Catra places a kiss on the closest spot to her lips, which happens to be the side of Adora’s neck. “You can call me

whatever you like.” Her heart leaps, and she can’t help but smile. Adora is now, officially, her *girlfriend* .

Sparkles is going to have a field day once she finds out.

“Okay,” Adora giggles, a careful hand finding and stroking along Catra’s lower back, near the base of her tail, just the way she likes it. “You’re *mine* now.”

Catra’s eyebrows shoot to the top of her forehead.

She’s… she…

Woah.

That statement was something that Catra wasn’t at *all* expecting to hear, but is *so* glad that she did. Adora calling Catra hers is something Catra didn’t know she needed so much until she heard it.

“I’m… I’m yours?” she breathes, surprising herself with the almost desperate quality of her tone.

“Yup. You’re all mine, Catra,” Adora confirms, her hand gently travelling all the way up Catra’s back and to her hair. “And not in a

possessive way, or anything, I just-”

“Yeah, I know,” Catra grins, because she knows that Adora is way too kind of a person to be saying that in a selfish way. “You’re mine as well, Adora. I won’t let *anyone* else have you,” she affirms, tracing circles on Adora’s belly with her index finger, hoping her touch feels even a fraction as incredible as Adora’s does.

“Oh *no* , I’m in for it now,” Adora teases, now playing with the tip of Catra’s ear.

“ *Hey*- !” Catra protests, scrunching her nose and flicking her ear away. “That *tickles* .”

“I know,” Adora says mischievously, going in for another devious touch.

“Nope!” Catra asserts, grabbing Adora’s wrist before her hand makes contact. The other hand comes shortly afterward, but Catra is prepared, and catches it as well.

Now, with both of Adora’s wrists in hand, there is only one logical course of action.

Catra rights herself on top of Adora and pins her wrists to the bed. She lowers herself downward until their faces are almost

touching.

"You'll *never* get to my ears now," she gloats.

Adora raises an eyebrow, smirking, looking wholly unimpressed, and swiftly moves her head upward and catches the end of Catra's ear between her lips. "I win!" she says through the corner of her mouth.

" *Hey* !" Catra huffs, pulling her head away, trying to ignore how much her heart just skipped. "That wasn't- *ugh* !"

"C'mon, I got you fair and square!"

"Those were some shallow tactics, Adora," Catra complains, but the corner of her mouth betrays her and creeps upward into a slight smile, which no doubt completely dissolves her facade of indignancy. She relents, slumping back down next to Adora and wrapping an arm around her midsection.

"Don't I at *least* deserve a kiss for my glorious victory?" Adora tries.

Catra gets an idea. She brings one of Adora's hands up to her face and places the tiniest peck on the very tip of her finger.

“There, are you happy now?” she says triumphantly, returning her head to its spot next to Adora’s.

“Aww, that’s all I get?” Adora mock-complains.

“You weren’t very specific,” Catra reasons.

“Well, yeah, I guess that’s true.”

As a comfortable silence falls between them, Catra finds herself sliding her hand up to Adora’s shoulder and running her fingers softly down her arm in a gentle rhythm. She is so *elated* that she can just reach out and touch Adora like this, that the remains of the walls between them constructed during the war have finally been fully erased.

“That feels good,” Adora says, an invitation for Catra to continue.

She does, of course. It’s so indescribably fulfilling knowing that she has this effect on Adora, that only *she* can provide this pleasure for her.

It doesn’t take many passes of Catra’s hand down Adora’s arm before Adora is shifting herself closer, her lips dotting the underside of Catra’s jawline and down her neck. One of her hands slides slowly down Catra’s side and along the outside of her thigh.

" *Mmnn…* " Catra hears a moan. Probably hers; she is too lost in the sudden and overwhelming influx of pleasure to know for sure.

She's addicted. Every contact Adora makes is electrifying. Everything about her touch, her warmth, her body, is so irresistible, so unreal.

How had Catra managed to exist without this for *so long*?

"Sorry," Adora breathes between kisses. "I couldn't hold back."

"Y-yeah, don't… d-don't be," Catra stammers, with great difficulty, as every breath she takes is shuddering like an earthquake. Both of her hands find their way into silky strands of golden-blonde hair. She feels Adora's mouth on her neck form into a smile.

Things are heating up again. If Adora keeps this up, Catra may just end up completely melted by morning.

No matter. That's a risk she's willing to take.

Adora's hand travels purposefully back upward along Catra's leg and settles softly on the spot right below her belly button.

“Can I?” she asks.

Of course you can .

It was wholly unnecessary for Adora to ask that question for a second time, as she probably knows beyond a shadow of a doubt that Catra’s answer will be a *million* times yes, but Catra is still infinitely grateful for her consideration.

However, she overestimates her ability to put that into words.

“P-please…” she begs, her eyes fluttering shut.

Thankfully, Adora seems to understand. And she doesn’t need to be told twice.

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Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading y'all!! Next chapter is the final official chapter, but there will be an epilogue. Stay tuned!

Sunset on Brightmoon Palace

Chapter Notes

Hey, y'all...

It's the final chapter. It's kind of a bittersweet feeling to know that this is the last one.

I'm excited to get this story completed, though, and move on to other projects. I hope you enjoy the ending!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Wildcat! Hey!”

Catra’s ears fly upward, and she immediately turns around to the sight of Scorpia striding broadly towards her. Her mood, even though already incredible, improves somehow even more at the sight of her spiky friend.

“Scorpia! Long time no see,” she smiles, and then she does something that she has never done before. As soon as she reaches Scorpia, she hugs her. It feels so *weird* to initiate a hug on Scorpia, partly due to the fact that she is a whole head shorter than her and is used to being simply picked up when hugged, but mostly because she is *never* the one to hug first. It was always Scorpia. Catra is surprised she even managed to beat her to the punch.

That just goes to show how happy I am to see her.

" *Woah*- !" Scorpia doesn't return the hug at first, no doubt because she is in shock that Catra actually hugged her, for *real* , for the first time in history. But then, she comes to her senses, and Catra feels her massive pincers wrap around her body. No picking-up this time. Catra is silently grateful for that.

"Where have you been?" she asks as soon as the admittedly extremely enjoyable hug ends. She never thought she would ever see herself referring to a hug from anyone who isn't Adora *'enjoyable* .' Maybe she's gone soft.

But… Maybe that's not such a bad thing.

"Oh, *busy* . I've been working my claws off reconstructing," Scorpia replies proudly, flexing a massive bicep. "Where are you headed this morning?"

"Breakfast. Wanna come?"

"Ooh, *yes* !" Scorpia effuses. "Where to?"

"Just down this hallway," Catra tells her, and as they start heading in that direction she asks, "why are you still working? Micah said we're done, remember?"

"Oh believe me, Catra, he made that *abundantly* clear," Scorpia sighs, shaking her head. "I almost lost hope that he'd ever let me

continue working."

"You… wanted to keep working?" Catra raises her eyebrows. "Have you been back at camp this whole time?"

"Yup!" Scorpia confirms. That explains her absence lately.

"...Why? Why keep working?"

"Oh, well…" Scorpia runs a pincer over the back of her neck. "Reconstruction is one of the few things that I'm able to use my strength for that's actually productive. And helping people always makes me feel good." She smiles. "Honestly, I kind of *enjoy* it."

Catra blinks a couple of times in surprise. "Fair enough," she says. She, for one, did not enjoy reconstruction at *all* , and would gladly never go through it again. But it's good that Scorpia found it at least somewhat enjoyable.

"But now that reconstruction is basically over, I've got nothing else to do. So, I started working on my new room!"

"Your new room?" Catra asks. They cross the threshold into the dining hall. It's relatively quiet this morning, so it will be a good place to catch up with Scorpia.

"Yeah, King Micah offered me a room here for *free* as a thank you for all of my help!" Scorpia grins.

"Really? That's *wonderful* , Scorpia!"

"I know, right??" Scorpia piles up a plate of various meats. Catra goes for a muffin and an apple, and they both sit down at some seats near the back of the dining hall. "So, yeah, that's what I'm here for today. I'm about to start working on my room. Perfuma is gonna live with me!"

"Woah. Since when?"

"Since the war ended," Scorpia replies in a tone that makes it sound like Catra should have already known this.

Catra is *very* surprised. But- for good reason. It took her and Adora, who she's known for basically her entire life, *much* longer than Scorpia did to decide that they wanted to live together. Well, to be fair, they *were* busy fighting a war for their entire lives…

But still. It seems to Catra like Scorpia and Perfuma have known each other for basically five minutes, so the fact that they are both set on moving in together could mean two things. Either they really connect with each other and are well into their relationship and fully prepared to make this decision, or they are taking things *way* too quickly. Hopefully it's the former option.

"I… *wow* ," Catra gapes. "You two are close, I take it?"

"Oh, *very* !" Scorpia makes that face where her pupils basically shapeshift into little hearts and her face almost sparkles. "We've been on a bunch of dates, and… I think she's the one, Catra!"

Well, it seems like it was indeed the former option. Catra feels pretty relieved about that.

"Good for you!" she congratulates, feeling this strange vicarious joy welling up inside her.

A comfortable silence falls between them. Smiling has to be contagious, or something, because Catra hasn't been able to stop ever since she ran into Scorpia this morning.

It's truly gratifying to hear that Scorpia is doing so well, because if anybody deserves it, it's her. She's always so kind, helpful, and supportive to everyone she meets. There is always a big smile on her face, and she always manages to brighten people's day.

And… She gives *great* hugs.

There. Catra said it. But she won't say it out loud just yet. That… will take some more time.

“How are things with Adora?” Scorpia asks, leaning forward and propping her elbows up on the table. Another thing about Scorpia: she always seems genuinely interested to know what is going on in other people’s lives. Because she’s just *that* considerate.

“They’re *amazing* ,” Catra says. She wishes she had another word to use, because ‘amazing’ frankly doesn’t cut it.

“Really? Did my advice work at all?” Scorpia leans in a little closer and drops her voice. “Were you able to ask for her touch?”

“Well… yeah,” Catra breathes out. Her face grows warmer.

“Good! So it worked?”

“That’s definitely *one* way to put it…” Catra mumbles. She adjusts her jacket upward to more thoroughly hide her neck. When she woke up this morning and looked in the mirror, she noticed a bunch of little marks all over her body that she couldn’t determine the origin of. But now that she’s more fully awake, she knows with almost one-hundred percent certainty that those marks were left by Adora’s lips.

Good thing it’s that time of year when it starts to get chilly outside, or else Catra would have no doubt been questioned about her choice to wear such a heavy jacket today.

"That was pretty much my first time giving advice to someone," Scorpia chortles, looking relieved. "So I'm glad it worked out."

'Worked out' is the understatement of the century.

"Scorpia, Adora is my girlfriend now." This statement comes semi-out of nowhere, and Catra even surprises herself with it. She hasn't told anyone this yet.

To be fair though, it has only been 'official' for about ten hours now.

Scorpia seems surprised as well. Her jaw drops and her pincers find her cheeks.

"What?! Since when?"

"Since last night," Catra tells her, blushing yet again. "We… um. We *talked* ."

Scorpia all but falls out of her seat with excitement. "Oh, *Catra* , that's- I'm so *happy* for you! Congratulations!"

“Thanks, Scorpia.”

Scorpia beams brightly, turns around to check the clock on the wall nearby, and then says, “Oh, hey, I’ve gotta get going; I told Perfuma that we’d start this morning. It was good to see you again, and we should totally hang out soon!”

“I was gonna say the same thing,” Catra agrees, flashing Scorpia a fanged smile.

“Awesome!” Scorpia almost yells, pumping a pincer into the air. With that, she says, “alright, see you later!” and turns to leave the dining hall.

Catra looks after her with fondness in her eyes, with deep gratitude that she is fortunate enough to have someone as kind as Scorpia as her friend.

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Before breakfast, Catra sometimes likes to watch the sunrise. But not today, because she ended up staying in bed and cuddling with Adora until there was no longer a sunrise, and it was basically almost midday.

Not at all a bad tradeoff. If giving up one of her minor past hobbies means being able to melt away in Adora’s embrace for

more extended periods of time, then she will *gladly* take it.

Besides, watching the sunrise alone was something she did in the Fright Zone mostly when Adora was gone, when she was looking to replace her warmth with the heat of the sun…

It's weird to think about the days back in the Fright Zone. Catra doesn't look back at them with sadness anymore like she used to, but rather a kind of empty indifference. If anything, those days just serve as a reminder of how truly incredible her life is right now.

She smiles to herself and makes a mental note to give Adora a hug and tell her that she is loved when she sees her this morning. Because Catra can just *do* that now. And because she wants Adora to hear it every day.

Speaking of Adora, that is *definitely* her voice coming from the courtyard outside. Catra recognizes those grunts and yells- is she training, or something?

Not exactly. When Catra pokes her head around one of the stone pillars of the colonnade surrounding the courtyard, a very interesting display comes into view.

Adora is engaged in combat with two kids. Well- *combat* in the sense that they are both swinging wildly at her with their sticks,

and she is making a huge deal of blocking, like it's hard for her, like she can't just fell these two children with one powerful strike.

Catra recognizes the two kids. It's Benny and Colt. Did they come back to the palace to play with Adora?

They seem to be having the time of their lives trying their very best to take Adora down, and Adora looks like she's trying very hard not to accidentally hurt them as she deflects their tiny blows.

"Die!!" Benny yells vehemently, but his squeaky voice paired with the fact that he keeps stumbling forward onto his knees as he advances makes the delivery of this line nothing short of adorable.

" *No!!* " Adora dramatizes, letting a blow from him through. It bounces harmlessly off of her thigh, but she falls to the ground with defeat, throwing her hands outward and splaying her body across the ground. "You got me…"

Catra swiftly takes action and leaps over the wall, grabbing a stick from below a tree nearby and thrusting it into the air.

"I'll avenge you, Adora!"

“Catra? What’re you-” Adora starts, eyes wide, but she’s interrupted by Colt.

“New target inbound!” he assesses, spinning his stick around in his hand like the world’s youngest swordmaster.

“Get her!” Benny cries, pointing his stick at Catra and moving in for an attack.

“You’ll never win,” Catra taunts, winking at Adora, who is still laying down, propped up on her elbows and looking at Catra like she just appeared out of nowhere. Which she kind of did.

“Hiya!!” Benny growls. His first strike is surprisingly hard for a little kid, but Catra easily blocks it.

Colt’s blow comes next, and Catra also manages to deflect it. But consistently blocking two kids’ onslaught of strikes is a lot harder than Adora made it look. But that’s probably because Adora actually has experience with a sword. Catra never really got that, so she just resorts to using her agility to dodge the majority of Benny and Colt’s attacks.

It’s *fun* . Playing with these kids and seeing their faces light up with passion as they hack away is incredibly gratifying.

“Get away from my girlfriend!” Adora yells, now back on her feet and getting back into the fray, brandishing her stick menacingly in the direction of the two boys.

Catra’s jaw drops as soon as these words leave Adora’s lips. To hear it out loud for the first time…

They’ve technically been in a relationship since yesterday, but that- the fact that she just said it out loud- in *public* - just made it feel so *real* . Even though Catra already knew it was real, that Adora truly meant it when she first said she wanted to call Catra her girlfriend.

This is *real* . Thinking about it even for the hundredth time is still enough to make Catra’s heart flutter.

“Ow!” she yelps as a stick smacks against her hip. Oh yeah. Maybe she shouldn’t have zoned out in the middle of a duel.

“Got you!” Benny says triumphantly with a toothy smile.

Catra almost starts to protest, but then she remembers that she is supposed to lose. “Ah!” she cries, clutching at her wound. She makes a big deal of falling to the ground, just like Adora did.

“No!” Adora springs forward and makes a final effort to avenge Catra, but after exchanging a few blows with the kids, she is

finally taken down by a well-placed slash in the torso from Colt. She drops to her knees, lets her stick roll from her fingers, and slumps down onto the ground next to Catra.

"Any last words?" Colt demands, brandishing his sword down at them, but he's laughing. Probably at Adora, who is clutching dramatically at her heart while doing these over-the-top and utterly hilarious groans of defeat.

For some reason, there are tears welling up in Catra's eyes. Perhaps because she was just overwhelmed with affection towards Adora for being… well, *her* . She is so *good* with these kids, and the way that she so masterfully captures their attention and draws from them the most adorable laughs is so incredibly endearing. They practically love her.

But then again, who wouldn't? And why does Catra love this part of Adora so *much* ?

"Ugh, ooh… Bleh…" Adora lets out one final groan, closes her eyes, sticks her tongue out, and lets her head roll to the side, much to Benny and Colt's delight.

"Victory!!" they both cheer triumphantly, high-fiving each other and laughing like crazy.

And even though Adora is supposed to be dead, she starts laughing as well. Of course, Catra can't help but join them.

And then Adora does something that completely stuns Catra in place. She kneels so that she is relatively level with Benny and Colt, and then reaches out with both of her hands and playfully rustles their hair while giving them such a *warm* smile.

At that moment, frozen in place with sheer awe, Catra comes to an epiphany. It's like something was just awakened in the back of her mind, the realization that she *wants* this- she wants…

A child. She wants to raise a child with Adora. One of their own.

Maybe not now, because she can say with almost pure certainty that she's not going to be ready for that yet- but definitely in the future.

Either way, she does know that she wants to spend the rest of her life with Adora. She knows that more than anything in the world.

*****

Two weeks kind of blurred together. Not because they were repetitive and boring, no, but because they were so incredibly enjoyable that time seemed to pass triple.

And time doesn't seem to feel like slowing down any time soon.

Well, at least Catra's perception of it, because every day in her life now is filled to the brim with activity, and it's like she is constantly moving from one thing to the next. Not in a bad way, of course. There's just so much to *do* .

She and Adora have fallen into a kind of routine in the morning which consists of cuddling until they feel like moving, and then brewing some tea together and taking it out to the balcony to sip away, or the courtyard, maybe even the front steps of the palace- whatever they are in the mood for.

And then they talk. About what wild plans they have scheduled in the future, about how what they did the other day was so much fun and they should totally do it again, about the past they shared together in the Fright Zone, about how nice it is that they can just sit down and enjoy a sunrise together without a world-shattering war to break their backs over.

And because they have been exerting themselves all their lives as soldiers, it doesn't feel right to go a day without any physical activity. It comes in many forms, whether it be a refreshing morning run together around the perimeter of Bright Moon lake, or perhaps taking turns on the punching bag downstairs, or even another deadly sword duel with Benny and Colt who keep insisting on visiting and slicing Adora and Catra to shreds each day- the options are limitless.

Additionally, the Best Friend Squad is together these days more than it's not. But thankfully, Bow and Glimmer seem to understand Catra and Adora's desire for privacy pretty well, and Catra only

had to endure a mild amount of puppy-dog gazes when she broke the news that she wasn't in fact very interested in having regular 'Best Friend Sleepovers.'

Glimmer, just as Catra predicted, essentially exploded when she became privy to the fact that Adora and Catra were in a relationship. Well maybe *privy* isn't the right word, because Adora and Catra weren't exactly keeping it a secret.

Well. Maybe Catra was sort of kind of trying to keep it a secret. From Glimmer in particular. Because she knew this would happen.

Of course, Catra knew Glimmer would find out eventually, and that the efforts to conceal the truth would inevitably be in vain. But regardless, it was fun dancing around her, playing a little game of cat and mouse with her over this whole thing, and to see her face- *oh* to see her face when Catra finally 'admitted' it.

It's probably for the best that Glimmer is aware of Catra and Adora's relationship now considering that she has the ability to spontaneously appear in any room within the palace at any given time. Locked doors mean nothing to magical teleportation powers. So now that she *does* know, maybe she will think twice about randomly teleporting into Catra and Adora's room.

Hopefully. She hasn't teleported in on anything just yet, and Catra is crossing her fingers that it stays that way.

*****

"I don't know about you guys, but *I'm* in the mood for some bowling."

"Pfft. Bow, you sound like Scorpia."

"Why, does she like bowling?"

"Yeah, I think. She told me a while back."

"You should invite her, Catra!" Glimmer chimes in. "We can all go bowling together! Adora, what do you think?"

Adora isn't very prepared to answer her question. Her mind has been occupied for the past five minutes by these waves of sheer joy that come from seeing Catra interacting so casually, so *easily* , with Bow and Glimmer, like they've been friends their whole lives.

"Uh- Sorry, what were you saying?"

"Bowling," Glimmer sighs, rolling her eyes melodramatically. "Yes or no?"

“Bowling? Sure, yeah, I’m fine with that.”

“Okay! That’s two votes; Catra? Bow?”

“I was the one who suggested it, Glim,” Bow chuckles.

“Oh, shut up. What about you, Catra?”

“Sure, why not. I’ll ask Scorpia if she wants to go.”

Glimmer lets out a puff of air and slumps backward onto the roof below her. “Alright, so we know what we’re doing tomorrow?”

“I think so,” Bow confirms.

“Good *job* , everybody. Only took us an hour and a half to decide.”

Catra’s remark earns her a slap on the shoulder from Glimmer, which Adora finds completely hilarious.

To her right, Bow cracks his knuckles. “You guys are going down. I’ve been bowling before, so I’ve got the experience.”

“You went bowling *without* me?” Glimmer gasps.

“Yeah, I think you were busy or something that day, I can’t really remember.”

“I’m about to throw you off this roof.”

“Please don’t.”

That would definitely be fatal. Adora already knew that Bright Moon palace was tall, but being on the roof really puts it into perspective. The ground seems so far away from up here.

But it really is a nice view, one Adora wishes she had been able to experience sooner. Apparently, however, she was lucky to even have had the *opportunity* to, given how up until now, this was supposedly Bow and Glimmer’s ‘secret spot’ and they’d never let anyone else up.

Now that a serene silence has fallen over them, Adora finds her girlfriend’s hand with her own and laces their fingers together. Catra takes this further and basically rolls onto Adora’s body until she is essentially using her as a body pillow.

“I love you, Adora.”

The tone of her voice- so smooth, so genuine- it is music to Adora's ears.

"Bow, I think Catra *loves* Adora!" Glimmer whispers as loud as she can.

"What makes you say that?" Bow shout-whispers back.

"I don't know, just… something about the way they act around each other?"

They're laying it on thick. Adora simply smiles.

Catra also seems too comfortable at the moment to bother responding. Her purring is as loud as ever, and only increases in volume as Adora runs a hand softly through her hair.

There isn't a cloud in the sky tonight, so the view of the vast array of vibrant stars above is as clear as crystal. Adora just stares, lost in this beautiful moment, barely even listening to the discussion Bow and Glimmer are having to her right about optimal bowling ball weights as she sinks into the warmth of her girlfriend beside her.

This is her life now, her perfect reality, and she won’t give it up for the world.

*****

Chapter End Notes

Wow, that was a journey. Thank you all so much for reading, leaving comments, and giving kudos!! Seeing such positive feedback is incredibly motivational, and it's really nice to see that so many people enjoyed this story!

I currently have a college AU underway, so if you're interested in seeing that, consider subscribing so you don't miss it when it drops! Also, the epilogue to this current fic is coming sometime next week, so there's that as well.

Thanks again for reading!!!

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

Hey, welcome to a short little bonus-chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The house is extra lively this morning. Normally, Adora takes it slow. She would slog out of bed, followed closely by a half-conscious Catra, start brewing up some fresh tea, and then they would sit out front as they gain their bearings and wait for the ball of energy to wake up.

And then the tea would finish, and Adora would saunter inside and emerge a few moments later, two piping mugs in hand, to watch the sunrise with her wife as she sips away.

But not this morning. They don't have the luxury of time to spare. As such, Adora is trying to be productive while still being half-awake, which doesn't normally work out too well.

"Should I bring an umbrella?" she asks, her weary brain making logical leaps by the second.

"Adora, it's indoors," her wife chuckles. "Besides, why would you bring an umbrella to a dance, anyway?"

"Yeah, that's true," Adora agrees, marking 'umbrella' off of her frighteningly cluttered mental list. "Okay, shoes, kid shoes, dress,

kid clothes- I don’t think I’m missing anything, am I?”

Catra’s eyes sparkle as she flashes Adora a gentle smile.

“You’re a mess this morning.”

“Well- I mean- I’m just- I don't wanna forget anything, you know? Have to make a trip back-” Adora rummages through her duffel bag for the umpteenth time- “Oh *jeez*- Finn? Finn, will you come in here?”

The ball of energy pokes their pointy-eared head into the living room.

“Yeah, ma?”

“Where’s your undershirt? I don’t see it in here.”

“I’ll go get it,” the kid says, and they disappear around the corner with the flick of a tail.

“We should just let them pack their own bag,” Catra proposes.

“They’re *seven* ,” Adora points out. “We’re Finn’s parents; we’re supposed to do these things for them, right?”

“Yeah, that’s true.” Catra snorts. “Nobody ever packed *my* bag when I was seven. I’m kind of jealous.”

Adora smiles.

“Got it!” Finn announces, re-entering the room and slam-dunking their white undershirt into the duffel bag.

“You’re the best!” Adora sings, kneeling down to cradle Finn’s tiny little face and press a kiss to their forehead. “Okay, I think we’re ready to go. Babe, you got everything?”

“Yeah, like we established.”

“Oh, hush. Finn, sweetie, did you brush your teeth?”

Finn proudly bears their pearly-white fangs as proof that they in fact did.

“Good, okay-” Adora zips the duffel bag closed and slings it around her shoulder, letting out a puff of air. “I think we’re ready to go.”

“Yes! Dance time!!” Finn cheers, They sprint to the door and tear it open.

“Finn- wait, honey, don’t go too far!” Adora calls after the lightning bolt that is her child. They throw her a thumbs-up.

“Well,” Catra shrugs. “Guess it’s just me and you.”

“Yeah…” Adora lets out a nostalgic sigh. Then, she finds her wife’s hand and laces their fingers together. “I guess we’ll bring up the rear?”

“I’m okay with that,” Catra smiles.

And they set off for Bright Moon, hand in hand, off to Scorpia’s first ball.

*****

Chapter End Notes

Thank's for reading, y'all. Truly.

If you are looking for something else She-Ra related to read, I recently published a ~7k word pre-canon one shot, and it would mean the world to me if you checked it out :)

Also, subscribe so you don't miss my upcoming college AU!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!